

Tracing the history of pronunciation in nineteenth-century English

Marco Wiemann

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Marco Wiemann

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For Jackie and Samira

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Part I

Context, data and methods

1 Introduction

This book studies the pronunciation of nineteenth-century English based on grammar books as sources for historical phonology. One major goal is to expand our knowledge of the phonology of a historical period that has often been neglected, namely Late Modern English (c. 1700–1900; henceforth LModE). The primary source of data consulted here is the *Collection of Nineteenth-Century Grammars* (henceforth CNG)¹ (Anderwald 2016a), a collection of 258 English grammars published in Britain, Ireland and North America. I conduct quantitative and qualitative analyses of comments on phonological features in the CNG to determine the extent to which nineteenth-century grammars provide evidence for historical sound changes. The phonological features considered are *Long Mid Diphthonging* (i.e. diphthongisation of the vowels in GOAT and FACE words)², the TRAP-BATH split, post-vocalic /r/ absence and /r/ realisations, /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, the WHICH-WITCH merger³, /v/-/w/-interchange, and realisations of *-ing*. Moreover, I assess how suitable the genre of grammars is for historical phonological analyses and whether the CNG could be fruitfully utilised for future research in LModE phonology. In addition, I consider the grammars' allegedly prescriptive character and evaluate to what extent grammars from the period were normative in their approach to phonological variation and change. The aim, however, is not to trace their potential impact on phonological change but to evaluate the extent to which they may serve as reliable and independent chronologists of the phonology of the time.

¹The collection has never been officially published as a whole. However, a list of all grammars contained in the collection can be found here: <https://www.anglistik.uni-kiel.de/de/fachgebiete/linguistik/anderwald/cng-collection-of-nineteenth-century-grammar>. Furthermore, all grammars in the collection should be available to read online without additional charges via Google Books or archive.org.

²For reference to vowels I make use of Wells' (1982) lexical sets, i.e. a collection of example words that serve as stand-in for all words having a certain vowel in standard accents. For a more detailed explanation, see Chapter 4.

³Throughout this book I use the lexical set WHALE to refer to historical <wh> words potentially affected by this change. This set was introduced for the ECEP to extend Wells' (1982) lexical sets (see Yáñez-Bouza et al. 2018). It comprises all words with initial and word-internal <wh> spellings in English, including those before <o> as *who*, *whom* and compound forms such as *somewhere*.

1 *Introduction*

In this book I show that nineteenth-century grammars offer important insights into the timeline and types of phonological variation and change in the LModE period. In contrast to present-day grammars, they provide information on the lexical distribution of phonological variants, their realisations, and regional and social information on the speakers and can thus be used to assess how and when phonological variables changed. My analysis further reveals that grammars in the CNG exhibit a considerable number of close-to-verbatim copies from other authors, and earlier orthoëpists and grammarians. At the same time, the CNG as a whole can be considered a heterogeneous collection, not least because some grammars are indeed very prescriptive, while the majority are characterised by a striking absence of prescriptive commentary, even for highly stigmatised linguistic variants. Yet, even the prescriptive grammars and those who plagiarise other authors provide valuable information on phonological change. If a grammar negatively evaluates a variant, it shows awareness of a change in progress and that the variant was likely salient. (Near-)verbatim copies reveal who the authority was on pronunciation and which variants were regarded as the standard. I thus argue that grammars can be used for research in historical phonology if caution is exercised on part of the researcher in the interpretation of the information they yield. In order to do this, it is necessary to be acquainted with the history of the grammarians' research traditions, to know their contemporaries' terminology and approaches, and to discuss this against the backdrop of the broader history of the period. It is moreover sensible to corroborate results by consulting different historical sources to find converging evidence.

This book is divided into three parts: Part I covers the historical context and provides a description of the data and methods of my analysis (Chapters 2–4). Chapter 2 contains three introductory sections and one section that is concerned with the aims and research questions of the present work. Section 2.1 provides a brief history of phonetics and illustrates types of sources for the study of historical phonology. Section 2.2 gives some socio-economic background of the period and discusses grammar and dictionary writing. Given the alleged prescriptive nature of many LModE works, Section 2.3 focusses on historical prescriptivism. These sections illustrate the three areas of research where I locate my study, namely historical phonology, grammaticography, and prescriptivism. In Section 2.4, I elaborate on the concrete aims of the present work in more depth. Chapter 3 discusses the CNG, the typical structure of nineteenth-century grammar books, and the role of phonology in these works, including those that deliberately exclude sections on pronunciation. The chapter furthermore provides an overview of common transcription conventions in LModE grammars and dictionaries. Chapter 4 outlines relevant theories of phonological change as well as the frameworks used to analyse prescriptive comments.

Part II (Chapters 5–11) contains the analysis of phonological features: Chapter 5 and Chapter 6 are concerned with the vowels and Chapters 7–11 discuss the consonant features. Every chapter in Part II of the book starts with some historical background on the respective phonological feature. This is followed by my analysis of the feature in the CNG. Here each relevant variant receives one separate section. Each chapter ends with a summary of the most important findings and a brief discussion of their implications. The chapters on the TRAP-BATH split, /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, and the WHICH-WITCH merger (Chapters 6, 8, and 9) have additional sections on frequency effects, lexical distribution, or dialectal variation.

In Part III (Chapters 12–15), I discuss my overall research questions against the backdrop of my findings and evaluate the suitability of grammars for the study of historical phonology. Chapter 12 presents a recap of my research questions. In Chapter 13, I compare comments on the phonological features in my data to previous work on LModE phonology and prescriptivism. Chapter 14 addresses questions about the originality of some authors in the CNG. It is also concerned with grammars that stand out for other reasons such as unusual detail or terminological accuracy when regarded from a twenty-first-century standpoint. Finally, in Chapter 15, I state the limits of my analysis and point to opportunities for further research in the fields of grammar writing, prescriptivism, and historical phonology.

2 Investigating LModE pronunciation in nineteenth-century prescriptive sources

2.1 Phonetics and phonology: History and sources

The nineteenth century was a time of innovation and rapid industrial and cultural change. It brought about several technological advancements relevant to the study of linguistics such as the phonograph, the gramophone record (Hickey 2017b: 562), and steam-powered printing. It saw the introduction of mandatory schooling in the British-Irish Isles and North America, increasing literacy rates (see Graff 1987; Sanderson 1995; Bandiera et al. 2019), and a more scientific treatment of pronunciation as exemplified by works such as Alexander John Ellis' (1869a) *On Early English Pronunciation* and Henry Sweet's (1877) *A Handbook of Phonetics*. It is towards the end of the century that the first phonetic laboratories started to be founded, e.g. one laboratory was established by the phonetician Abbé Rousselot in Paris at the Collège de France in 1898 (Ashby & Przedlacka 2018: 162). Indeed, the discipline of linguistics in general began to be regarded as a science "analogous to biology and geology and differentiated from 'humanities' such as history, literature and law" (Milroy & Milroy 2012: 5). These were all far from entirely independent developments, however, as one reason for supplying money to establish phonetic laboratories in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries was indeed (foreign) language teaching (Ashby & Przedlacka 2018: 161–162). Nineteenth-century developments also included a move towards more reliable sound-classification and transcription conventions, as shown by Ellis' palæotype and glossic for transcribing English (see MacMahon 1996: 835–836). Eighteenth-century pronouncing dictionaries already made use of different notations to transcribe pronunciation, such as diacritics, different fonts, and phonemic alphabets. These, however, varied in each work and are at times still hard to interpret (Beal 2023: 450). Many early nineteenth-century sound-classification attempts (including Ellis' earlier ideas) still lacked a system comparable to modern IPA. Correspondence from the 1840s between Isaac Pitman and Ellis about

a phonotypic alphabet shows that both were still working to greater and lesser degrees in the tradition of earlier elocutionists like John Walker, author of the very influential *Critical Pronouncing Dictionary* published in 1791 (see Kelly 1981). The invention and revision of different phonetic alphabets concluded with the official introduction of a unified system in 1888 (Passy 1888), which was, with the exception of few symbols, identical to the IPA used today (MacMahon 1996: 831). These developments laid down the foundation for the establishment of phonetics and phonology as we know it.

Along with the scientification of linguistics, earlier eighteenth-century efforts of codifying and implementing a standard pronunciation culminated one century later in the emergence of a supra-regional prestige accent in Britain, viz. Received Pronunciation (RP henceforth). This locality-independent but socially distinct variety was famously first described by Ellis (1869a: 23):

In the present day we may, however, recognize a received pronunciation all over the country, not widely differing in any particular locality, and admitting a certain degree of variety. It may be especially considered as the educated pronunciation of the metropolis, of the court, the pulpit, and the bar.

Renowned late eighteenth-century authors like Walker had already assigned the term *received* ‘most correct, acceptable’ to some individual variants, but it is not until Ellis that this predicate is used for an entire variety. Codification efforts were not only driven by motivations to unify the pronunciation of one nation but furthermore by economic interests and the marketability of “proper” pronunciation to aspiring social climbers (Beal 2004b: 168–189, 2010). According to McIntosh (2008: 228), speaking and writing “correctly” had almost become a “national obsession” in Britain by the early nineteenth-century. This trend was also reflected in the readership of works by elocutionists like John Walker or Thomas Sheridan. It was not the aristocracy, the upper classes or the lower classes but the middle classes who regarded it necessary (and could afford) to spend money to try and climb socially by means of pronunciation (Ranson 2012; Beal 2020, 2023). The idea, however, of one superior “standard” pronunciation goes back as far as sixteenth-century sources like Puttenham (1589) and Hart (1569), if not earlier (Beal 2010: 21; Hickey 2010: 21; see also Mugglestone 2007: 13–18; Beal 2020: 27–30).¹ On the other side of the Atlantic, American English (AmE henceforth)

¹My use of the terms “standard” and “non-standard” in the context of historical grammars is often an anachronistic one, especially since a spoken standard in England is only emerging in

was emerging in the nineteenth century as a distinct variety following the independence of the US from Britain (see Schneider 2007: 273–308; Paulsen 2022: 7–35).²

Despite these developments, the phonology of nineteenth-century varieties had not received sufficient scholarly attention by the turn of the twenty-first century. In fact, this is true of the LModE period (c. 1700–1900) as a whole and Jones (1989: 279) thus refers to the two centuries as “Cinderellas of English historical linguistic study”. Introductory works like Minkova (2014), for example, do not treat LModE as a separate period at all. This may be due to fact that some scholars have claimed that it is too similar to present-day varieties and therefore does not require equal treatment as earlier periods (see Beal 1999: 13–35 on the eighteenth century as the “Cinderella” of historical linguistics). Another reason is the (alleged) prescriptive approach of LModE dictionaries and other sources. However, Beal (1999: 181) suggests that these sources should not be ignored due to their politically incorrect character because they can provide valuable insights into the social and political relevance of linguistics. While there had been some work by the end of the 1990s which showed that LModE phonology was in fact different to present-day English (PDE henceforth) and far from uniform (e.g. Beal 1996, 1999), MacMahon (1998: 521) still called for more research in LModE pronunciation in regard to changes in style and sociolinguistic variation. With respect to eighteenth-century pronouncing dictionaries and her own analysis of those, Beal (1999: 184) pointed out that her research had only “scratch[ed] the surface in terms of the wealth of phonological evidence available in eighteenth-century pronouncing dictionaries”.

Beal (2004b) herself and Jones (2006) have made two major contributions with their books on *English in Modern Times* and *English Pronunciation in the Eighteenth and Nineteenth Centuries*, in which they consult various sources from eighteenth-century dictionaries to later nineteenth and early twentieth-century works by scholars like Walker, Sheridan, Smart and Daniel Jones (D. Jones henceforth), amongst others. Yet, Beal (2012: 22) still states under the heading “Late Modern English phonology: The Cinderella of Cinderellas?” that

the nineteenth century. According to the OED, *Standard English* is first attested in 1806 but none of the comments I have looked at in the present study use the terms to refer to either variants or varieties (OED: *Standard English*, in *standard* n., adj., & int. see also Wolf 2011 for the historical development of the notion of *Standard English* in grammar books from 1600–1900).

²I refrain from using the well-established term *General American*, which goes back to Krapp (1925), as a uniform standard spoken by the well-educated similar to RP does not exist in the US. Whenever I speak of present-day AmE pronunciation I refer, similar to Upton & Kretzschmar (2017), to younger educated speakers with no regional features, i.e. the speech of broadcast media.

the breakthrough in corpus linguistics largely benefitted other areas like pragmatics, morpho-syntax, studies on prescriptivism and historical sociolinguistics, and thus still claims that “[t]he most neglected area of LModE is phonology”. More recently, there appears to have been a change in sentiment as we have a greater number of publications on LModE phonology than twenty years ago. This we owe in part to sources such as historical grammars, dictionaries, letters, and newspapers becoming more readily available in digital form. For the eighteenth-century, two collections have been created and utilised for research in historical phonology, namely the *Eighteenth-Century English Phonology* (ECEP) and *Eighteenth-Century English Grammars* (CEGE) databases (see for instance Beal 2013; Beal et al. 2020; Yáñez-Bouza et al. 2018; Yáñez-Bouza 2020). These databases are still being expanded in terms of features that can be analysed with them (see Yáñez-Bouza & Nieves-Fernández 2023 for a discussion of methods used for making realisations of /ŋ/ in words like *thing* or *think* searchable in the ECEP). This is in fact also true of the CNG, whose compilation was made possible essentially because of large-scale digitisation by Google Books. In contrast to most present-day grammars (that focus only on morphology and syntax), LModE grammars often also treated pronunciation (see Chapter 3, Beal 2013; Yáñez-Bouza 2016a: 174). Therefore, they potentially constitute suitable sources for historical phonology, albeit yet untouched by researchers in the field.

The (re)discovery and digitisation of recordings from the first half of the twentieth century with speakers born in the second half of the nineteenth century (e.g. the *Berliner Lautarchiv*³) has furthermore enabled successful attempts at apparent time analyses of nineteenth-century pronunciation (see for instance Hay & Sudbury 2005; Trudgill & Gordon 2006; Mair 2016; Hickey 2017a; Przedlacka & Ashby 2019). Special issues on speech representation, including pronunciation based on pauper petitions, have also contributed to a more substantial understanding of the pronunciation of LModE (see Auer et al. 2023; Gardner 2023). Other sources such as pronunciation guides and magazines like *Punch* have revealed valuable information about (attitudes towards) pronunciation in the LModE period as shown for example in Mugglestone (2007) and Crystal (2017, 2018). Works like Paulsen (2022) illustrate a growing scholarly interest in the history of discursive varieties, its relation to structural varieties and the role of phonological variation in enregisterment processes (Agha 2003; Silverstein 2003; Agha 2007). Several recent publications also focus on the interface of literature and historical linguistics. Examples are attempts at reconstructing John Keats’

³See their website for more information: <https://www.lautarchiv.hu-berlin.de/en/sound-archive>.

2.1 Phonetics and phonology: History and sources

pronunciation (Sen 2025) or analyses of eye-dialect and respellings which were used to depict the dialect and social background of different fictional characters (see Hodson & Broadhead 2013). Studies of enregisterment and dialect literature further contribute to our understanding of nineteenth-century phonological variation (see Cooper 2020; Maguire 2020a). In addition, Nieves-Fernández (2023) shows how we can utilise dictionaries of individual authors to investigate historically issues of suprasegmental phonology like accent and prosody.

Evidence for nineteenth-century pronunciation therefore comes from a variety of written sources like grammars, dictionaries, style guides, or magazines. These sources have been considered direct evidence (Beal 2004b: 126) in the sense that their authors intended to provide descriptions (or prescriptions) on pronunciation. As modern phonetics was only emerging towards the end of the nineteenth century, many sources that have so far been used for reconstructing LModE pronunciation, such as those provided by Ellis, Sweet, and D. Jones, were based on the authors' auditory and production skills rather than on experimental methods. They were ear-phoneticians, not experimental phoneticians, and Sweet even openly questions the legitimacy of experiments in phonetics (Ashby & Przedlacka 2018: 161–162). Yet, they provide us with valuable insights into the pronunciation of the time, even though they were not entirely free of bias towards the emerging experimental methods. Indirect evidence (Beal 2004b: 126), on the other hand, is based on rhymes, puns or non-standard, semi-phonetic spellings which can be found in letters, poems, pauper petitions, dialect literature and literary dialect. In contrast, early recordings provide evidence that enables us to *acoustically* measure nineteenth-century variants, albeit dependent on the critical/sensitive period hypothesis which apparent time methods inevitably rely on. These are therefore not covered by Beal's (2004b) dichotomy of direct and indirect evidence as they are not written evidence. Despite the fact that acoustically measurable data appear to be the ideal type of evidence to any historical phonologist, they cannot be used to access the phonology of eighteenth and early nineteenth-century speakers for obvious reasons. Consulting earlier written sources is therefore necessary to reconstruct these stages of pronunciation and to come closer to a complete picture of LModE phonology.

It is also important to bear in mind that the further we go back in time, the more dissimilar the terminology, methods and approaches to language may become compared to our modern ways of practising phonetics and describing pronunciation. In his book-length chapter on LModE phonology, MacMahon (1998) consults the writings from authors like Sheridan, Walker, and Webster, amongst others (see MacMahon 1998: 375–381 for a more extensive list of elocutionists).

Indeed, MacMahon (1998: 376) notes that great caution is required when interpreting sources prior to Ellis. However, this should not keep us from exploring other earlier sources as Beal (2004b: 130) rightfully points to the fact that despite the prescriptive character of works like Walker's (1791) dictionary, he was a good observer who had the intention of laying down the characteristics of what he regarded as "proper" English pronunciation. This is one reason why a more detailed look into nineteenth-century written sources (before and after Ellis) may yield important insights into historical phonology.

2.2 Grammars and dictionaries: Production, motivations, and structure

Of the written sources mentioned in the previous section, grammars are currently underrepresented as a genre in terms of evidence consulted for reconstructing nineteenth-century phonology. Systematic studies of comments on pronunciation in grammars are still wanting. The grammars in the CNG too have not been subject to comprehensive scrutiny on LModE pronunciation, except in Wiemann (2023, 2024). In fact, nineteenth-century grammars have generally been disregarded by and large as evidence in historical linguistics until comparatively recently (Yáñez-Bouza 2016a: 165). According to Anderwald (2016a: 1), there is still a considerable research gap when it comes to nineteenth-century grammar writing simply because the nineteenth century is regarded as particularly prescriptive. Busse et al. (2019: 49), some of the few researchers currently working on nineteenth-century English grammars (see also Busse et al. 2016, 2021), also point to the scarcity of studies on nineteenth-century grammars with surprise. This equally applies to North American and Irish grammars of English from the nineteenth century. The only other recent studies involving nineteenth-century grammars have been conducted by Anderwald herself (2014a, 2014b, 2016a, 2016b, 2017, 2019, 2020a, 2020b, 2022). Whereas Wolf (2011) also discusses nineteenth-century grammars, his study is concerned more with the development of the notions of *Grammar* and *Standard English* from 1600 to 1900 than with a larger-scale analysis of linguistic features treated in these works. There are some contributions from the 1980s and 90s (Finegan 1980; Downey 1986, 1991; Leitner 1986; Wächtler 1986; Michael 1991, 1997; Görlach 1998), but these mostly have a bio- or bibliographical focus. Luckily, as Yáñez-Bouza (2016a: 172) remarks, the fact that these grammars can serve as sources for investigating historical English has started to be acknowledged.

The absence of studies in this area is still astonishing for several reasons: there is a wealth of material that was published in the nineteenth century and is now available in digital form. As shown in Figure 2.1, it is as early as the eighteenth century that we can see a stark increase in the production of grammars – especially in the second half of the century with more than 200 grammars compared to less than 40 in the first half (Yáñez-Bouza 2016a: 166).

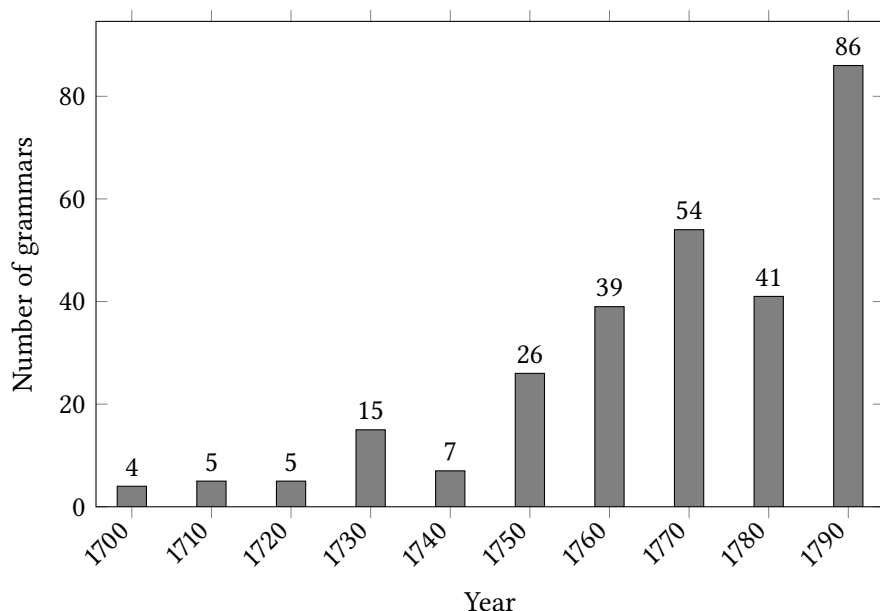


Figure 2.1: First editions of English grammars published in the eighteenth century, based on the ECEG

This trend continues as Görlach's (1998: 2) *An Annotated Bibliography of Nineteenth-Century Grammars of English* (ABiNGE) provides evidence for 1,936 English grammar books that were published in the nineteenth century. This further increase of grammars in the nineteenth century is illustrated in Figure 2.2, ordered by place of publication.⁴

In contrast to this enormous increase in grammar books, the number of original pronouncing dictionaries (not reprints or updated editions) in the nineteenth

⁴Anderwald (2016a) collates grammars published in Ireland and Scotland under the label *British/Britain*. I refer to grammars from this category as *British-Irish grammars* and furthermore use the term *British-Irish Isles* (rather than *British Isles*). In the present work, *British-Irish grammar* functions as an umbrella term of grammars comprising any part of this geographical region even if none of the grammars I discuss in a certain section were published on the island Ireland.

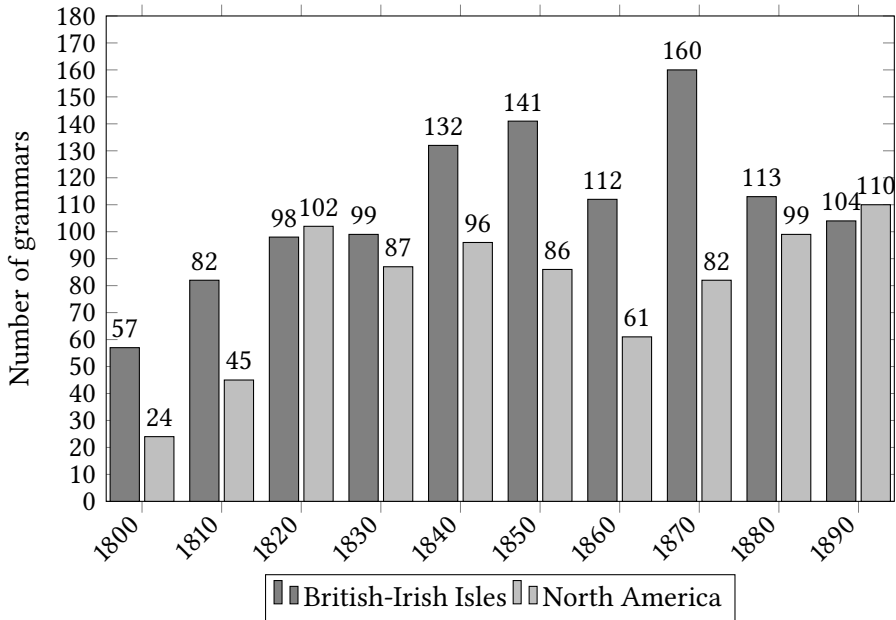


Figure 2.2: Number of grammars in Görlach (1998), based on Anderwald (2016a)

century is comparatively low. According to Collins & Mees (2009: 177), there were no new pronouncing dictionaries after Smart's (1836) *Walker Remodelled* except those from Wales designed for Welsh-speaking learners of English such as Spurrell's (1850) *Geiriadur Cynaniaethol*. Jones (2006: 273) adds Smart (1810), Knowles (1835), and Cooley (1861) to the list. However, he also points out that no new dictionaries were published in Britain between 1800 and 1850 and that the comprehensive treatment of pronunciation had gone out of fashion. This has been attributed to the major role that Walker's pronouncing dictionary played posthumously as it went through 34 editions and over 100 reprints, also in Scotland, Ireland and North America, the last being published in 1904 (Beal 2009: 149, 172). Other dictionaries such as Smart (1836) furthermore referenced Walker in the titles of their work (see Beal 2009: 172 for more dictionaries that make mention of Walker in their titles).

Together with Walker, Sheridan's (1780) *A General Dictionary of the English Language* was one of the most influential pronouncing dictionaries of the late eighteenth century (Beal 2009: 150). In fact, Sheridan's dictionary was also published and revised throughout the nineteenth century (Jones 2006: 273). Despite his popularity, Sheridan also received criticism and ridicule from his contem-

poraries because he was an Irishman. Therefore, some will undoubtedly have preferred Walker's or other dictionaries by British authors over Sheridan with respect to advice on proper pronunciation. That is not to say that Sheridan did not have supporters in Britain (see Beal 2009: 164–170 for a discussion of Sheridan's work).

In terms of dictionaries in North America, there was fierce competition between the lexicographers Joseph E. Worcester and Noah Webster. Worcester stuck closer to British norms in questions of orthography and pronunciation, while Webster was a linguistic nationalist favouring a uniform American language (Wells 1973). Webster's (1783) *The American Spelling Book* (first published 1783 as part of his *A Grammatical Institute of the English Language*) is potentially his most important work for any historical phonologist, and also one of his most successful ones; it is said to be responsible for British and American pronunciation differences and for a homogeneous speech in the US (Finegan 1980: 46). Similarly successful was his *An American Dictionary of the English Language* (Webster 1828), a precursor of the Merriam-Webster dictionary (Finegan 1980: 44). Worcester first edited Johnson's dictionary (Worcester 1828) before publishing his *A Comprehensive Pronouncing and Explanatory Dictionary of the English Language* (1830) and after several revisions the *Dictionary of the English Language* (1860) (Wells 1973: 67). These dictionaries were in fact not purely lexicographic but also featured pronunciation as illustrated by, for example, the title of Worcester's 1830 dictionary or the preface of Worcester's 1860 dictionary:

A DICTIONARY of the English language, in order to be complete, must contain all the words of the language in their correct orthography, *with their pronunciation* and etymology, and their definition, exemplified in their different meanings by citations from writers belonging to different periods of English literature; and such a Dictionary cannot be brought into a small compass. An attempt has been made to render the work which is now offered to the public as complete as possible, without being too large and too expensive for common use. (Worcester 1860: iii, my emphasis)

With respect to pronunciation, Worcester draws strongly on Walker (1791). Landau (2009: 189) states that the notational system for pronunciation Webster used in his *American Dictionary* (1828) was "far from showing an accurate pronunciation of every word included" and "was no match for Walker's popular *Critical Pronouncing Dictionary*".

Dictionaries indeed also had an influence on the way grammars treated pronunciation. Beal (2013: 175–176) suggests that the normative tone as well as some

conventions in notations employed by Walker and other elocutionists had an impact on late eighteenth-century grammars like Wright (1794). She further states that the fact that these grammars treated pronunciation in the first place was part of the zeitgeist. This also seems true of one of the most influential late eighteenth-century grammarians, namely Lindley Murray, whose grammar features a section on orthography (Murray 1795: 1–19), in which also sounds are discussed, albeit in a less detailed fashion than in Walker's (1791) dictionary. Murray was a lawyer born in the US but first published his grammar in 1795 in York, at which point he had been living in England for about ten years. Another well-known grammarian, Robert Lowth (1762), bishop and professor of poetry at Oxford, does not discuss pronunciation proper in his grammar but just provides definitions on what vowels, consonants, or diphthongs are. Fens-de Zeeuw (2018: 54) argues that Murray had the greatest popularity of all grammarians at the end of the eighteenth century and potentially throughout the entire nineteenth century. This is based on the publication history of Murray's grammar and mentions of his name in novels and popular authors.

Downey (1991: 28–29) also lists several American grammar books from the first half of the nineteenth century that were influenced by Murray and that copy his definition of grammar word for word, e.g. Kirkham (1834). According to her, the rules Americans found in Murray's grammar were already familiar to them through Lowth, whose grammar was first published in America in 1775. Therefore, these rules were immediately accepted when Murray's grammar was first published in America in 1800 (Finegan 1980: 35). Murray's view was strengthened by Goold Brown's (1823) *Institutes of English Grammar*, which was even more popular in New York than Murray, whose grammar Brown had entirely superseded in use there by the 1850s (Downey 1982: v–vi, 1991: 36–37). However, at New York public schools Kirkham's grammar was more frequently used in the 1830s and 40s and at Harvard Lowth's grammar was also in use as late as the 1840s (Finegan 1980: 35, 55).

Generally, Downey (1991: 27) states that there were two trends in nineteenth-century American grammar writing: those working in Brown's and Murray's tradition and those that followed Roswell Smith and Samuel Greene, the latter of whom being chronologically slightly after Brown and Murray. This does not mean that Brown simply copied rules verbatim from Murray like Kirkham did. Brown was on the one hand against innovation but on the other reprimanded other grammarians for their lack of originality (Finegan 1980: 56). Thus, despite being categorised as a traditional grammarian by Downey (1991: 30), Brown thought Murray "insufficiently prepared to write a grammar", while Kirkham regarded Murray as "the greatest of grammarians" (Finegan 1980: 49, 55). It is

perhaps not surprising then that, according to Finegan (1980: 49), Brown and Kirkham “hated one another’s grammatical methods and despised one another personally”. Downey (1991: 30) points out that “midcentury America was too progressive to let the works of Murray, Brown and other traditional grammarians control the field”. This is important not only for the study of grammatical features but equally for pronunciation. An aversion to traditional grammars might also lead to a departure from the traditional structure of grammars and might thus indicate a shift in the role that pronunciation played in these works (see this section below). Downey’s observation might indicate a change in the practice of copying from earlier works or at least a divergence in who was copied or referenced.

In sum, comparing the genre of English grammars and pronouncing dictionaries historically, there was a massive increase in the publication of new grammars, while the “classics” like Murray kept being reprinted and still exerted influence at least until the middle of the nineteenth century. As regards dictionaries, however, the nineteenth century was mainly dominated by new editions of Walker, whereas North America also saw the so-called dictionary wars between Worcester and Webster from 1830 to 1864 (Wells 1973: 56; Landau 2009: 195–197). Grammars and pronouncing dictionaries were not however in direct competition, as noted by Beal (2013: 176) for the late eighteenth century. In terms of grammar writing, Görlach (1999: 16) also points to Murray’s influence and cautions against mistaking the enormous quantity of publications for the influence these books had. Often grammars did not have a big reach, being only used in a single school or in a very restricted area, and Murray was indeed considerably more popular than most grammarians (Görlach 1999: 16).

Michael (1997: 39) suggests that grammars could be easily written within a few evenings by utilising other peoples’ works because the contents of other works were very well known and easily accessible. This likely accounts for unacknowledged verbatim copies as well as references to other works, which were indeed very common in codifying works in the European tradition (see for instance McLelland 2021: 270–271 for a list of genre-typical features of grammars and dictionaries). Plagiarising other works was a widespread practice in English, French and Dutch grammars from the eighteenth-century (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1996a)⁵.

⁵In contrast to Tieken-Boon van Ostade (1996a), I do not distinguish between unacknowledged copies and plagiarism because in order to do that I would have to investigate the intention of every single grammarian in the present analysis, which is not possible given the scope of this book.

Chapman (2008: 31–32) points out that the fact that many grammarians wrote grammars only because they knew the contents of other grammars does not make them a “*scholarly* discourse community”. Watts (2008), nonetheless, argues for regarding grammarians as a discourse community. This is not necessarily a contradiction as grammarians did in fact share common interests, goals and beliefs, which are Watts’ crucial criteria for defining a discourse community. These, however, do not have to be scholarly. Watts (2008: 53) suggests that four ideologies can be found in British grammars in the second half of the eighteenth century. These are the ideology of standard language, politeness, educated language, and commercial success and social improvement (Watts 2008: 53). For the US (and in part for Britain), we may add nationalist and religious ideologies. The former is exemplified in the works of Webster, whereas the religious significance of “correct” grammar plays a crucial role for grammarians like Kirkham. Finegan (1980: 54) notes that “the connection Kirkham’s books fostered between religious piety and linguistic purity gave his dicta the force of evangelical zeal, which continued to be reflected in handbooks and apparently in the public mind”. These ideologies and common interests may differ and may at times even be contradictory in the work of one and the same elocutionist.

To give two very different examples, Thomas Spence, author of the *Grand Repository of the English Language* (1775), was a Radical with a working-class background from Newcastle whose aim was to educate less advantaged speakers and provide them with the linguistic means to become political (Beal 1999: 1–12). Looking at his contemporary Thomas Sheridan’s work, we can identify contradictions between alleged aims and praxis. Sheridan proposed that his motivation was to help speakers overcome class barriers and therefore taught what was regarded as the correct “standard” pronunciation (Watts 2008: 46). However, Sheridan’s real goals were very different to Spence’s and in practice Sheridan condemned dialectal speech and was interested in making profit off of his lectures and books (see McIntosh 2008: 228; Watts 2008: 46–48; Beal 2009: 167–168). Watts (2008: 46–47) mentions statements from Sheridan’s *Course of Lectures on Elocution* (1762) that reveal openly negative attitudes to dialect speech. For instance, dialects are referred to as signs of “provincial, rustic, pedantic, or mechanic education; and therefore have some degree of disgrace annexed to them” (Sheridan 1762: 30).

Regarding the grammarians’ motivations, Anderwald (2016a: 250) also lists economic interests, increasing mass affluence, and schooling “coupled with reading books ‘to bits’” as reasons for the explosion of production and the expansion of the grammar market. Moves towards compulsory education likely also promoted the expansion of the grammar market in the nineteenth century. Similarly,

a lower middle class for whom the prospect of social advancement depended on their skills of adjusting to what was perceived of as “proper” speech likely played a role. Tieken-Boon van Ostade (2008b: 104) explains the increase of grammars in the second half of the eighteenth century in terms of a battle for market dominance and argues that the codification of grammar was in fact less important. The astonishing increase of grammars published as well as the presence of strong competition by new grammars and new editions as well as reprints of renowned works appears to have been clear to the grammarians themselves. Indeed, prefaces and introductions offer evidence that many nineteenth-century grammarians felt the need to address the question of why they were writing another grammar given the seemingly oversaturated market (Anderwald 2016a: 249).

Chapman (2008: 31–32) notes that many late eighteenth-century grammarians saw “themselves primarily as teachers, simply distilling what has already been published in grammars”. Tieken-Boon van Ostade (1996a: 92) points out that Murray, who copied verbatim from many of his sources, had truthful intentions and only intended to “promote the cause of learning and virtue” (Murray 1795: v) in his grammar and indeed regarded himself as a compiler (Murray 1795: iii; Mugglestone 1996: 148). Murray did not escape criticism for unacknowledged copying and started mentioning his sources from the fourth edition of his grammar (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1996a: 88; Mugglestone 1996: 146). A nineteenth-century example is Kirkham, who acknowledges Murray as his inspiration and source, and does not claim to have come up with the rules in his grammar himself (Finegan 1980: 49). This is also exemplified in the structure that the majority of these grammars follow. The traditional structure was fourfold and included orthography, etymology, syntax, and prosody. Some grammars also had sections on *orthoëpy*, ‘the study of the relationship between pronunciation and [...] spelling’ (OED: s.v. *orthoëpy* n. 1.), which usually came after orthography. *Etymology* most of the time concerned what we would nowadays refer to as morphology rather than etymology in our modern sense. As many grammarians were working in the Latin tradition, as evidenced also by their imposition of Latin grammatical categories onto English, their main focus lay on etymology and syntax. This structure we find in the eighteenth and for some still in the nineteenth century (see Chapter 3, Chapman 2008: 29–30; Yáñez-Bouza 2018: 36). Regardless, we should not naively assume that LModE grammarians were all a homogenous group as many followed different conventions when it comes to terminology, approach to language, and topics they deem important.

This is particularly clear in the nineteenth century, where authors appear to break this traditional structure. As we shall see in Chapter 3, some grammarians not only justified why they decided to write yet another grammar but also

addressed the question of why they deliberately excluded sections on orthography, orthoëpy, and prosody, which are those sections where we would find comments on pronunciation. This potentially points to a general trend towards a more modern understanding of grammar books in which mainly morphology and syntax find their place. Based on Bailey (1992) and Görlach (1998), Jones (2006: 273) suggests that the nineteenth century marked a change to a greater focus on morphology, syntax and vocabulary, rather than pronunciation. While the traditional fourfold structure was carried over into the nineteenth-century grammar writing tradition thanks to the popularity of Murray, Downey (1991: 28, 31) also argues that American grammarians started gradually focussing more on etymology and syntax rather than continuing to adhere to the traditional structure of grammars.

In addition to a move away from the traditional structure, the nineteenth century potentially marks a change towards more modern and descriptive approaches to language. Busse et al. (2021: 147) hypothesise that grammar writing started to become more descriptive from the second half of the nineteenth century. This they support by fewer evaluative references and a decreasing relevance of works by other authors. McLelland (2021: 268) suggests that when looking at these works diachronically, it may be sensible to regard European grammars and dictionaries as part of a discourse tradition (rather than a discourse community in Watts' 2008 sense) or a "diachronic series of works in a particular *genre* where [...] genre-typical features are expected and inherited, but are also adapted over time, and where new ones may arise". This captures their similarities and differences as well as evolving attitudes from potentially prescriptive late eighteenth- and nineteenth-century grammars to present-day linguistic works as proposed by Busse et al. (2021: 147). I pick up on this idea again in the following sections as it is central to the question of how prescriptive nineteenth-century grammars in fact were and whether they can indeed, in terms of attitudes to language, be regarded as one uniform genre that changes and eventually evolves into modern-day scholarly grammars like Quirk et al. (1985), Huddleston & Pullum (2002), or Biber et al. (2021).

2.3 Historical prescriptivism

In contrast to grammaticographic research, nineteenth-century prescriptivism has thankfully received considerable attention in recent years. Yáñez-Bouza (2022) provides an excellent overview of studies pertaining to different methodological currents in the realm of historical prescriptivism in English. Another

recent addition to the body of work in the field is a special issue on prescriptivism and language use in LModE (see Calle-Martín 2024). Some of the most valuable contributions in the area of prescriptivism and pronunciation are Mugglestone's (2007) monograph *Talking Proper* and several contributions by Beal such as Beal & Sturiale's (2012) special issue of *Language and History* on prescriptivism and pronouncing dictionaries as well as one of her most recent publications on "vulgar" pronunciations in eighteenth-century dictionaries (Beal 2023). Furthermore, papers by Trapateau (2016) and Nieves-Fernández (2022) zoom in on attitudes to pronunciation in individual authors like Walker and Sheridan, whereas Ranson (2012) looks closer at Walker's methodology and discusses his "rhetoric of prescriptivism". In the context of prescriptivism and LModE grammar writing the *Dictionary of English Normative Grammar 1700–1800* (DENG; Sundby et al. 1991) is also worth mentioning although it is not concerned with pronunciation. The number of studies and approaches listed in Yáñez-Bouza (2022) clearly show that historical prescriptivism is worth of detailed study. Reasons for this are manifold and exceed empirically investigating claims of direct impact or complete absence of prescriptive influence on usage. Regardless of the extent to which prescriptive sources like grammars and dictionaries have had an influence on actual language use, they form part of the history of the English language.

Curzan (2014: 47–49) argues for an understanding of the history of English which encompasses not only structural changes but also attitudes to language. She compares the relation between language and prescriptivism to contact between two languages or dialects. If this contact has an impact on the development of a language, then it is of course vital for the description of its history in structural terms. Irrespective of this, evaluative comments in the nineteenth century may shape the way languages, dialects or certain variants are perceived in the following centuries and how they play into the enregisterment of varieties (Anderwald 2020b: 80–83; for recent studies on historical enregisterment see Paulsen 2022; Gerwin 2023). Finegan (1980: 53, 58) argues, for example, that Kirkham's grammar has caused linguistic insecurity until today (i.e. the 1980s) and that Brown's opinions are still reflected in twentieth-century attitudes. Anderwald (2020b: 83) similarly suggests that studying historical prescriptivism may enrich our understanding of "present-day linguistic discrimination, linguistic profiling, stereotyping and the stigmatization of speakers". She furthermore contends that it is our responsibility as (historical) linguists to work against discrimination and injustice, a statement I wholeheartedly agree with. In order to do this, it is sensible to consider where present-day negative attitudes to dialects of specific regional and social groups as well as non-standard variants come from.

For the purpose of the present study, the following statement by her is highly relevant. She argues that “English and American prescriptivism in the 19th century was instrumental in shaping our present-day views (as a society) of how language usage indexes speakers socially, and that it shows how the educated elite act as gatekeepers of social and moral values” (Anderwald 2020b: 89). Curzan (2014: 5–6) also points to linguistic insecurity of PDE speakers and the perpetuation of class hierarchies resulting from the prescriptivism that emerged in the eighteenth and gathered speed during the nineteenth century. Regarding pronunciation specifically, I have noted in Section 2.1 that the idea of a superior pronunciation existed at least as early as the time of John Hart. The crucial difference however to the situation from the 1750s onwards is that sixteenth- and seventeenth-century authors like Hart and Puttenham did not yet embrace the thought of one single correct pronunciation speakers should adhere to. The emerging British pronunciation ideal in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries was one where the regional background of a speaker was undiscernible. This is reflected in Ellis’ (1869a: 23) comment on a “received pronunciation all over the country, not widely differing in any particular locality” (see Section 2.1). John Hart was certainly already aware that the speech in London was evaluated differently to, for instance, that of a dialect speaker from the North (Mugglestone 2007: 4, 13). However, as pointed out by Mugglestone (2007: 14), Hart had a relatively liberal attitude towards dialect spelling and pronunciation, as evidenced in the following excerpt:

if any one were minded at Newcastell uppon Tine, or Bodman in Cornewale, to write or print his minde there, who could iustly blame him for his Orthographie, to serue hys neyghbours according to their mother speach, yea, though he wrate so to London, to whomsoever it were, he could be no more offended to see his writing so, than if he were present to heare him speake. (Hart 1569: 21)

It is only in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries that propriety and correctness in speech start to become a “national obsession” (Mugglestone 2007: 1–5; McIntosh 2008: 228). This could, amongst several other factors, also be due to the increasing rise of nation states in Europe at the time as the “one nation-one language” principle is closely tied to this development (see Aronin 2019: 6–7). However, up until roughly the second half of the eighteenth century, it was still mainly grammatical features like multiple negation and double comparatives rather than phonological features which caused associations with provincial speech. This changes with authors like Sheridan, Walker and Smart, in whose

works the absence of variability and regional features in pronunciation becomes crucial (Mugglestone 2007: 20–21, 24). While they did not successfully implement such a uniform and invariant supra-regional pronunciation as the standard variety, their attempts at doing so did in fact pave the way for nineteenth-century developments and eventually the emergence of RP in Britain (Beal 2020: 21). Mugglestone (2007: 27) points out that an idealistic conception of what elocutionists tried to do would be one of social harmony rather than hegemony in the sense that class barriers would be overcome by one uniform pronunciation in the entire country. In reality, however, this was far from the case as the emerging middle class was willing to spend money for a pronunciation that would supposedly enable them to further move up the social hierarchy. Elocutionists such as Sheridan seized this opportunity and took advantage of a well-to-do middle class through marketing his lecture courses and dictionaries.

The independence of the US furthermore promoted nationalistic language ideologies in America as evidenced by Webster, which clearly advertise and try to enforce a one nation-one language ideal. This is paired with the naturalisation of grammar, the idea that learning grammar facilitates religious advancement, and that language is God-given. Hence, it has to be protected against further human corruption (Finegan 1980: 49, 58). Through the categories “right” and “wrong” being favoured over the actual linguistic reality of speakers, codification works as an ideology. This then becomes more impactful in terms of attitudes that speakers have about certain variants than the actual usage they encounter (Mugglestone 2007: 11–12). This potentially leads to some variants becoming more prestigious than others in certain contexts.

For instance, if we depicted the development of post-vocalic /r/ in a simplified manner, its absence, as in [kɑ:t] *cart*, was evaluated as un-American in the US outside cities of the North-East. As a whole, /r/-full pronunciations like [kɑrt] were in the process of acquiring overt prestige in nineteenth-century America (see Paulsen 2022: 403). In Britain, in contrast, it is /r/-less realisations that eventually came to be evaluated as overtly prestigious, even though they were still stigmatised in the nineteenth century (see Chapter 7, Beal 2004b: 154)⁶. Curzan (2014: 52) explains overt as well as covert prestige of linguistic variants in terms of Bourdieu’s (1991) theory of linguistic marketplace.

In Bourdieu’s (1991) framework, languages and linguistic variants may raise one’s cultural and symbolic capital. Thus, the absence of /r/ after vowels had by

⁶I use post-vocalic /r/ absence, non-rhoticity, and /r/-lessness synonymously as denoting the absence of /r/ in pre-consonantal and absolute final positions. Whenever /r/ occurs between vowels, I refer to it as intervocalic /r/.

the beginning of the twentieth century acquired means of generating high symbolic capital in Britain because it was this pronunciation that was required for well-paid and prestigious jobs, for instance at the BBC. In other words, if you did not pronounce your /r/s, your speech was more valuable in this particular linguistic market; hence overtly prestigious. However, an /r/-full pronunciation, together with other dialect features, might have carried more cultural capital in a social network of factory workers or miners in the South-West of England and was thus a covertly prestigious form of speech. What is regarded as prestigious (overt or covert) is made up of different assets and does not depend only on the realisation of one single consonant sound. In Bourdieu's theory, there are technically different markets in different regions. Therefore, several linguistic forms that might have had symbolic capital in the British-Irish Isles did not in the US. Different values of linguistic variants can also be located on the community level within these areas. This becomes even clearer when we look at indexical links that Paulsen (2022) reports whereby in the US some British overtly prestigious forms like non-rhoticity were associated with the *dude*, i.e. a person who (unsuccessfully) tries to imitate British norms. The *dude* furthermore refers to men who show "an ostentatious regard for fashion and style in regard to dress or appearance" (OED: *dude* n. 1). Features like non-rhoticity will have been more valuable in some circles in and around New England and New York, but they were evaluated as pretentious and inauthentic elsewhere; hence, less valuable in these linguistic markets. In a sense, we can imagine scholars like Walker and Sheridan or Webster and Worcester as having tried to enhance the capital of certain variants or protect the variants they themselves used from loss of value on the emerging standard English market. This, in theory at least, could have made them gatekeepers of linguistic norms and in consequence of power hierarchies.

We also have to ask the question of who in reality had access to, say, Thomas Sheridan's lecture tour or who could afford grammars or elocution lessons. This similarly boils down to the question of who had access to education. Restricted access to these linguistic variants and in turn the impossibility of acquiring speech that carries high symbolic capital leads to an unequal distribution of capital in linguistic terms. Expansion of symbolic capital may in turn also lead to the increase of one's economic capital, i.e. wealth. However, the negotiation of practices with symbolic capital take place regardless of a financial gain, albeit with a comparable logic. In Bourdieu's (1991) understanding, the linguistic markets functioned according to economic principles in a broader sense: the increase of symbolic and cultural capital generates profit in the form of honour and prestige (see part II of Thompson's introduction to Bourdieu 1991). This does not however necessarily entail that language with high capital in one particular community will have

led to financial wealth or success in society. In the example of the factory worker above, it is likely dialect speech from the region, together with a specific workers' register, that would have had high cultural capital, while RP would certainly have not. Nonetheless, it is the emerging standard pronunciation that promises social advancement and wealth, a fact that was exploited by dictionary authors and book sellers alike. This is where we can, at least hypothetically, locate codifying works such as the nineteenth-century grammars of the CNG. They attempted to dictate what is linguistically valuable in the emerging standard English markets.

It has been suggested that the prescriptive approaches to language of these codifying works evolve into more descriptive stances as the nineteenth century progresses, which results in more objective descriptions of language variation at the turn of the twentieth century (e.g. Busse et al. 2021). If we look at the treatment of pronunciation more specifically, this seems true in the works of Ellis, Sweet, and D. Jones. However, it is not necessarily the case that scholars who employ methods and terminology more like our own appear out of the blue and that prescriptivism comes to an end at the close of the nineteenth century. In fact, as I have remarked in Section 2.1, Ellis also worked in the tradition of Walker, who was, if measured by twenty-first-century standards, clearly a prescriptivist, albeit one with considerable observation skills and an intention of describing a standard pronunciation (see Beal 2004b: 130). It is perhaps sensible to regard some eighteenth and nineteenth-century grammarians and elocutionist as precursors to modern linguists, while others are forerunners of modern-day prescriptivists. Chapman (2008) makes a similar case when he points out that sentiments we find in eighteenth-century grammarians still exist in the present day. Thus, prescriptivism has not vanished in the English-speaking world, but a more descriptive tradition has emerged parallel to the world of prescriptive sources like usage guides (see Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2018) and digital (grass-roots) prescriptivism we find in blogs and new media like X (formerly Twitter), TikTok, YouTube or the like (see Lukač 2018a; Lukač & Heyd 2023). Chapman (2008: 36) remarks that “not only were they [sc. eighteenth-century grammarians] the precursors of today's usage experts, some of them can be seen to be precursors of today's language experts”. This does neither in turn mean that we should discard prescriptive sources as unworthy of study, nor that we have to agree with their judgements and actively engage in similar methods. We should place them within the emergence of modern linguistics and discuss their biographies and works by considering their historical context.

Chapman (2008: 36) further notes the same starting point for a more professional treatment of language and what he calls the “uncritical transmission of grammar”, which in turn led to the emergence of two different types of authors

discussing language: language experts and usage experts. The transitional period, the genesis of this split between language and usage experts, is covered by the CNG and therefore we may expect to find examples of both strands in it: the precursors of today's linguists and those that continue to express value judgements, insist on norms of correctness and propriety and thus attempt to perpetuate societal power structures by means of language. This calls into question the idea of a uniform discourse community and the homogeneity of the genre of grammars even further. I argue below that many of the grammars in the CNG are indeed, at least in terms of pronunciation, very similar in regards to their approach, terminology, example words and verbatim copies from other works. However, at the same time they display considerable differences if we take the collection as a whole, a fact that is discussed in Chapter 14. I suggest that this would be an argument for McLelland's (2021: 268) definition of genre or a proposal for interpreting codifying works as belonging to a *discourse tradition*.

Still, all this seems to suggest that we can make a clear cut between descriptivists and prescriptivists. However, in reality this is far more complicated, not least because of the existence of several different definitions of the term *prescriptivism*, which is usually defined in opposition to *descriptivism* (Chapman 2020: 46). Rawlins & Chapman (2020: 2) state that embracing this and similar binaries like *standard* vs. *nonstandard*, *correct* vs. *incorrect* for analysing prescriptivism discourses does not live up to their complexity. They admit that "binaries undoubtedly serve their purposes for capturing broad trends" but point to their limitations: "they prove an impediment to a better understanding of prescriptivism and the values associated with it". It has thus become common to speak of a descriptive-prescriptive continuum rather than two opposing standpoints that are mutually exclusive. Beal et al. (2023: xxiii) point out that scholars like Wolf Peter Klein even deconstructed this opposition further as he argues that solely descriptive approaches do not exist. They interpret Klein (2005) as suggesting that beyond making prescriptivism its object of study, "linguistics is in fact intrinsically and inescapably connected to prescriptivism". They also call attention to the fact that the older view of a clear-cut dichotomy between *descriptive* and *prescriptive* is still maintained in introductory textbooks in linguistics as recent as 2022 (see for instance Hejná & Walkden 2022: 62). While these dichotomies are helpful analytical tools, assuming a continuum rather than fixed, mutually exclusive categories comes closer to the reality of many grammars in the CNG.

Besides the grammars and dictionaries so far mentioned, there were of course other nineteenth-century sources with a potentially less scholarly motivation than, for instance, Walker and Sheridan. Advice for good pronunciation or value judgments of improper speech could be found in usage guides (see Jones 2006:

282–293; Straaijer 2018), magazines like *Punch* (see Crystal 2018), and newspaper columns and cartoons (see Paulsen 2022). Curzan (2014: 16) distinguishes two types of prescriptivism. The type we are dealing with in the present study she terms *institutional prescriptivism*, which is top-down: “prescriptivism that has been institutionally ‘endorsed’ through publication, adoption in schools, use as a standard for newspaper editing, [...] prescriptivism with the cultural and social power that comes with institutionalized authority”, and *individual prescriptivism*, which is essentially bottom-up: “speakers tell other speakers how they should and should not talk. These efforts often rely on community norms or personal authority”. The latter type we could also rephrase as *grassroots prescriptivism* following Lukač (2018b). While there was never an official institution in the British-Irish Isles or North America comparable to the *Académie française* or *Real Academia Española* for French and Spanish respectively, LModE dictionary and grammar authors still fall into this category. The ideas of language planning and reform, which were central to these academies, become increasingly important for English in the eighteenth century, where good language showed the presence of a good mind. Eighteenth-century grammarians such as Murray were influenced by this belief and prescriptivism in his grammar could be regarded as resulting from that (Russo 2000: 293–294).

This becomes clearer when we reconsider Bourdieu’s (1991) idea of symbolic and cultural capital and apply it to grammarians and elocutionists like Murray, Walker, Kirkham, and Brown – and those who reprinted and edited their works after their lifetime. Their market dominance not only brought about economic capital but furthermore enabled them to exercise institutional power and potentially influence which phonological and grammatical variants were to carry overt prestige and acquire validity and value in middle- and upper-class circles.

Curzan (2014: 24) furthermore defines prescriptivism based on its aims: (a) standardising, i.e. dictating the standard usage, (b) stylistic, i.e. differentiating style within the proposed standard, (c) restorative, i.e. attempting to restore older forms of usage that are no longer used, and (d) politically responsive, i.e. promoting non-discriminatory language. Aims (a)–(c) are relevant for the present study and are consulted in my analysis where applicable. This definition I describe as a broader, goal-based definition of prescriptivism, which I distinguish from a narrower, somewhat simpler, form-based definition of prescriptive utterances that simply regard statements with deontic modals like *should*, *ought to*, or *must* as *prescriptive*, whereas their negations are *proscriptive*. As I outline in Chapter 4, I embrace both a broad and a narrow definition of prescriptivism in my analysis and further discriminate between different types of judgement and evaluation used to justify phonological variants.

In terms of impact nineteenth-century prescriptive works had, an immediate influence of prescriptivism on usage or a complete absence of it have both often been naïvely assumed (Anderwald 2016a: 1). One simple reason for this could be that this is the easy way out of a question that requires taking into account a multitude of factors into one's analysis. Indeed, Anderwald (2020b: 74) points out "the question 'Did prescriptivism influence language change?' is surprisingly complex to answer". Auer (2006) distinguishes two types of evidence for the study of historical prescriptivism: first, precept evidence, i.e. (prescriptive) meta-linguistic comments, and second, usage evidence, i.e. actual linguistic practices of individual speakers or speech communities. For answering questions about the influence of prescriptivism, one method that has been suggested is to correlate which variants and constructions dictionaries and grammars prescribed (precept evidence) with data from corpora (usage evidence). Thus, having both types of evidence at hand are necessary preconditions for making claims about the impact of prescriptive works on language change (Anderwald 2020b: 74).

Finding an answer to the question of the influence of prescriptivism is even trickier in historical phonology as the line between written sources that express attitudes to pronunciation and those that present actual usage are blurry. This is the case for the simple reason that reliable usage data of phonological variables, comparable to evidence that can be gathered from corpora, only emerges in the late nineteenth century in the form of proper recording technology (see Section 2.1). Usage evidence in the form of corpora may nonetheless assist historical phonologists. For periods before the introduction of a standardised writing system, they can of course be utilised to systematically investigate spelling variation and thus aid in reconstructing earlier pronunciations by means of orthography. For LModE phonology, corpora are particularly helpful, not for reconstructing earlier stages of the phonological system, but for accessing usage frequencies of particular words and thus for helping us to trace lexical diffusion (see Trapateau 2020, Chapter 4, and Section 6.5 for examples of this). Still, one of Anderwald's (2020b: 74) prerequisites, i.e. usage data on the linguistic variables, is not available for phonology, at least not on the same level as those data available for morpho-syntax, lexis, semantics, and pragmatics. However, this at the same time makes nineteenth-century precept sources invaluable as we can access actual usage of pronunciation variants mainly through these works (see Beal's 2004b category of direct evidence mentioned above).

At this point, it is also sensible to return to a few points made above: grammars and dictionaries that Beal (2004b) includes in her category of direct evidence are not uniformly prescriptive but have descriptive elements; neither does Auer's

(2006) category of precept evidence only cover prescriptive comments: these works constitute a continuum.

Pouillon (2018: 106) finds that eighteenth-century dictionary authors reinforced social hierarchies and followed an “abstract ideal of language”. She states that authors like Walker did not prescribe the accent spoken by the elite or a norm consisting solely of artificial rules (Pouillon 2018: 122). She claims that Walker and those coming before him respected the elite’s speech but at the same time considered the prevalence of different variants in what they prescribed. They therefore disallowed variants they regarded as belonging specifically to a particular group of speakers (Pouillon 2018: 122). A similar approach we could perhaps assume for grammarians of the LModE period. Whereas taking comments in this type of evidence at face value would thus be naïve because they are evidently ideology-laden, grammarians’ mentions and evaluations of variants may still indicate structural changes in the phonology of the language or certain groups of speakers. Even if they are prescriptive, if these sources mention phonological features, this means that they were aware of them, and it has been suggested that features that are subject to change attract criticism (see Anderwald 2016a: 18). At times correlating comments in grammars with early twentieth-century recordings is possible if we utilise the apparent time construct. Considering these recordings and the time of publication and detail on similar variables in early nineteenth-century grammars may be helpful for reconstructing early stages of sound changes.

What has been found concerning the relation between precept and usage material on grammatical and lexical features may nonetheless enhance our analysis of phonological variables. Yáñez-Bouza (2016a: 169) identifies three trends in the relation between precept data and changes in language usage: comments triggering change, comments reinforcing change, and comments having only little impact on actual language change. The first two trends can either be temporal or permanent. Examples of prescriptive sources causing a permanent change she gives are the three-form verbal paradigm *write-wrote-written*, rather than a *write-wrote-wrote*, the latter of which was still common until the late eighteenth century (Oldireva Gustafsson 2002). Developments that were reinforced through proscriptions and eventually became permanent at least in standard English were the decline of periphrastic double comparatives, e.g. *more lovelier* and multiple negation, e.g. *I don’t want no milk* (González-Díaz 2008; Tieken-Boon van Ostade 2008c). The rise of the progressive passive, e.g. *the bridge is being built* instead of active variants carrying passive meaning as in *the bridge is building*, is an example of a construction that faced harsh criticism in the nineteenth century but whose increase in usage was not halted (Anderwald 2012; see Yáñez-Bouza 2016a:

178–180 for a more comprehensive list of examples). Regardless of whether we are dealing with grammatical features or with phonological features, if we want to utilise historical sources like grammars, we need to consider a potential time lag. Whenever grammarians discuss (or prescribe) a construction or variant, its potential way into the speech of their readers will take some time. In the second scenario, in which grammarians take up changes already under way, some time will have passed from its first usage to the inclusion of it in a grammar. I consider this time difference in connection to my data in Chapter 13. However, as previously mentioned, I refrain from hypothesising on the influence of grammars on actual language change.

2.4 Aims and research questions of the present work

In the previous sections, I have shown that nineteenth-century prescriptive works offer potential opportunities for expanding our knowledge in historical phonology and for evaluating the extent to which the prescriptive attitude of the nineteenth century that has been so frequently proposed was indeed a reality. I thus hope to not only fill the research gap in historical phonology, but furthermore to contribute to a better understanding of nineteenth-century grammar writing and prescriptivism. Given the proposed transition period in the genre of grammar writing, we could expect a move away from treating phonological features and a greater focus on morphology and syntax. In addition, a change from prescriptive to more descriptive approaches to pronunciation could be expected towards the end of the century. As the presence of verbatim copies from or references to other works are typical features of prescriptive works like grammars and dictionaries, the reliability of information they provide may be affected. It is thus possible that many grammarians were not independent witnesses of the linguistic features they were writing about. The present work is grammaticographic in nature as one of my primary interests lies in evaluating to what extent grammars in the nineteenth century can thus be fruitfully used as sources for studying historical phonology.

While I show that there are certainly some caveats we have to follow when working with grammars in historical phonology, I hope to further add to our understanding of sound changes as well as approaches to pronunciation. As concerns the field of prescriptivism, I investigate more systematically where these grammarians were prescriptive, how frequent ideology-motivated statements were and what they reveal about the attitudes to the phonological variants. Analysing whether grammars exerted direct influence on sound changes by

means of prescriptive commentary is incredibly difficult with the data at hand for reasons outlined in Sections 2.1 and 2.3. Thus, my aim is not to investigate the potential impact these grammars had on actual language change but rather to evaluate, based on their comments and approaches, if they were reliable observers.

In a broader sense, I locate the present work in the field of historical sociolinguistics, not least because studying prescriptivism is clearly sociolinguistic in essence: it concerns the analysis of comments that prescribe and proscribe the use of certain social, regional, gendered or ethnic variants (and in some cases even entire varieties). In my analysis, I benefit greatly from studies on metalinguistic commentary employing the framework of enregisterment (Paulsen 2022; Gerwin 2023) and believe that I can contribute some valuable results for future research into indexicality and enregisterment.

I focus on the following phonological features in my analysis: The diphthongisation of the vowels in the GOAT and FACE sets from /o:/ and /e:/ to /oʊ/ and /eɪ/ (*Long Mid Diphthonging*), the lowering and backing of the vowel in BATH from /æ/ to /ɑ:/ in some British varieties (TRAP-BATH split), realisations of /r/, post-vocalic /r/-absence as well as /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, the WHICH-WITCH merger, the interchange of /v/ and /w/ in syllable-initial position, and realisations of the *-ing* ending, including hypercorrect and velar-nasal-plus forms. These are summarised in Table 2.1, ordered by vowel and consonantal features.

Table 2.1: Phonological features to be analysed in the CNG, ordered by vowel and consonant features

vowel features	Long Mid Diphthonging TRAP-BATH split
consonant features	realisations of /r/ and post-vocalic /r/-absence /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion WHICH-WITCH merger /v/-/w/-interchange realisations of <i>-ing</i>

The main reason for analysing these features is that they reflect changes in progress and were subject to sociolinguistic variation in the LModE period (see for instance MacMahon 1998; Jones 2006). In the present analysis, I am mainly concerned with the emerging pronunciation standards and the features in question are all relevant to the development of RP and AmE pronunciation. The

change from long monophthongs to diphthongs in the FACE and GOAT sets happened in both RP and AmE pronunciation and variants with centralised onsets in GOAT now typical of RP speakers emerged only at the end of the nineteenth and beginning of the twentieth century (see for instance Wells 1982: 210–211, 237).

A long and retracted back vowel in BATH words and different in quality to the TRAP set has become a characteristic feature of RP and south-eastern British speech. Similarly, post-vocalic /r/-absence is one of the key features that distinguishes RP (and most British accents today) from AmE standard pronunciation. Both features, the TRAP-BATH split and non-rhoticity, were still clearly markers of social and regional varieties in North America in the nineteenth century (see Paulsen 2022).

/h/-dropping and /h/-insertion are relevant in this context as the list of words which were required to have an /h/ was still different in the nineteenth century compared to present-day RP and AmE pronunciation. For instance, *hospital* and *humble* were commonly pronounced without an /h/ (MacMahon 1998: 477–478). Variation in these and other words was also relevant in nineteenth-century America and continues to exist to this day in some words, e.g. *herb*. Dropping of initial /h/ in other words, including those of Germanic origin, is a traditional dialect feature and very widespread in England (Ramisch 2010).

The WHICH-WITCH merger, i.e. the merging of /hw/ and /w/ towards /w/ in words like WHALE, occurred both in the British-Irish Isles and North American varieties. However, some varieties in Ireland, Scotland and North America maintained /hw/ longer (see Jespersen 1909: 374–375). While the use of /hw/ is recessive today, some speakers in these regions still use the /h/-full realisation (Trudgill 2004: 77).

From a present-day perspective, /v/-/w/-interchange is admittedly an outlier in the list of features considered in the present study as it does not play a role in present-day variation anymore, at least not with respect to standard pronunciation in the British-Irish Isles and North America. Historically, however, this was different. Walker (1791: xii–xiii) lists it as a typical mistake Londoners and “those not always of the lower order” make. Given Walker’s comments and particularly the feature’s potential presence in non-lower-class London speakers, I decided to include it in the analysis. While /v/-/w/ interchange used to be associated with London speakers in the nineteenth century (see also Gerwin 2023), historically it was much more widespread. The feature was used in other British varieties, particularly in the South-East, and it survived the longest in Norfolk (Trudgill 2021: 85–86; Trudgill et al. 2003). In an American context, Webster (1789) provides evidence for the presence of this feature in Boston and Philadelphia (see Krapp 1925: 241–244; MacMahon 1998: 485). Furthermore, variation in /v/ and

/w/ was still attested in the twentieth century in Pennsylvania, presumably due to an influence from Pennsylvania Dutch (see Huffines 1980; Raith 1981). There is furthermore evidence in Irish and Indian English varieties (Kallen 2013: 49–50, 214–215, 221; Sharma 2012: 2086). A merger of /v/ and /w/ has been suggested for several less-widely spoken Englishes such as Tristan da Cunha or Pitcairn English (see Trudgill et al. 2003).

At first glance, realisations of *-ing* other than a velar nasal also do not appear particularly important for the emergence of standard pronunciation if regarded from a PDE perspective. However, while today alveolar realisations are typical in less formal contexts, regional varieties or the speech of the working classes, they used to be commonly employed by the British aristocracy (Beal 2004b: 161). Velar nasal plus realisations were associated with the North-West (Smart 1836: xxxii), and are today mainly used in the West Midlands and North-West of England, also in monomorphemic words (see Hughes et al. 2012: 68; Bailey 2019). In early twentieth-century America, Krapp (1919: 114–115) ascribes velar nasal plus variants like /ŋk/ mainly to “larger cities and in speakers of foreign birth or tradition”.

This should by no means suggest that these are the only phonological features relevant to variation and change in the nineteenth century. There is a plethora of other vowel and consonant changes in LModE, for instance the development of unstressed vowels, the contrast between the BEAT/BIT sets, happy-tensing, raising of CATCH, centralisation of the onset in PRICE, fronting of MOUTH, YOD-coalescence and YOD-dropping, /t/-glottalisation, or /l/-vocalisation, to name only a few (see MacMahon 1998; Beal 2004a; Jones 2006 for a more comprehensive list). I cannot provide a complete analysis of comments from the CNG on all these changes in the present study. I decided to focus on those illustrated in Table 2.1 for reasons outlined above. Furthermore, the fact that they are reported to vary and change in the nineteenth century makes them vulnerable to stigmatisation. Many variants like [æ] and [ɑ:] for BATH words, non-rhotic pronunciations, /h/-dropping (including in WHALE words), or alveolar realisations of *-ing* were stigmatised throughout the LModE period (see Beal 2004b, 2023; Mugglestone 2007). Hence, they also lend themselves very well for investigating prescriptivism. Given the fact that the majority of features above showed variation in North America and the British-Irish Isles to some extent, they equally offer opportunities for investigating the influence British-Irish sources might have exerted on North American grammars at the beginning of the nineteenth century and for looking at differing attitudes between the regions.

A more detailed description of the history and specific research questions concerning individual features is provided in the respective chapters of Part II. The

overall research questions for the present work are illustrated in i–v. I approach all questions from a qualitative and, where the data allow for it, quantitative point of view. This means that I always consider how many and which grammars provide evidence for my research questions but also look into the terminology and wordings they use to comment on the features outlined in Table 2.1:

- i To what extent are the features mentioned in Table 2.1 discussed by the grammarians?
- ii To what extent do comments in the CNG align with the current state of research on phonological variation in the nineteenth century? Do the grammars in the CNG diverge from the established timeline or realisation for certain variants?
- iii Are certain phonological variants stigmatised in the grammars? If so, how prescriptive are the grammarians and does the degree of stigmatisation depend on the feature in question?
- iv To what extent do grammars contain verbatim copies from other LModE codifying works?
- v To what extent can grammars in the nineteenth century be regarded as a homogenous genre?

Overarching research question:

To what extent can nineteenth-century grammars be taken as historical evidence for sound changes and sociolinguistic variation?

In the next two chapters of Part I, I outline my method and provide information on the *Collection of Nineteenth-Century Grammars*. As a first step, I assess whether there is a pattern in terms of which types of grammars treat pronunciation, how many grammars treat pronunciation, to what extent they explicitly argue against including pronunciation, and how their use of terminology has changed. LModE transcription conventions are also briefly discussed in this context (Chapter 3). In Chapter 4, I describe the annotation process and present a framework for the analysis of prescriptive comments and historical sound changes.

3 Analysing the CNG: Pronunciation and grammars

The main source used for the analysis in this book is the CNG, which is a collection of 258 grammars originally published between 1800 and 1900. It was compiled by Anderwald (2016a) between 2007 and 2011 by searching Google Books for various terms such as “English grammar”. In the process of creating the CNG, Anderwald (2016a) tried to ensure a balanced collection and thus included 125 North American and 133 British-Irish grammars. The former category further contains one Canadian grammar, whereas four Irish and ten Scottish grammars are included as part of the latter category. Distinguishing between North American and British-Irish grammars has been mainly done on the basis of places of publication. Reasons for this were the sheer number of grammars, which still only constitutes a fraction of publications in the nineteenth century (see Görlach 1998), and the scarcity of biographical information available for many grammarians.¹ When there was more than one place of publication, the first place mentioned, or (where available) the country in which the edition was originally published was counted. Mulligan’s (1868) grammar for instance was initially published in Britain; hence it was categorised with the British-Irish grammars. The other two exceptions are William Cobbett’s (1818) and Edwin A. Abbott’s (1885) grammars. While Cobbett was living in the US when he wrote and published his grammar, he was an Englishman (Dyck 2004). Similarly, Abbot’s grammar was published in the US but he himself was English. In line with Anderwald (2016a), both are thus classified with the British-Irish grammars.

To the best of my knowledge, all grammars in the CNG were written by native speakers of English and were designed mostly for teaching in schools, private students and self-study. This is based on the biographical details available, the authors’ names, information given in the grammars (especially the prefaces), and Anderwald’s previous work on the collection. They have, with the exception of 15

¹In addition to consulting Görlach’s (1998) annotated bibliography, Anderwald checked *The Concise Dictionary of National Biography* for author details, albeit with little success. Thus, the place of publication, together with the limited biographical information available, had to serve as a basis for the categorisation of grammars into different regions.

3 Analysing the CNG: Pronunciation and grammars

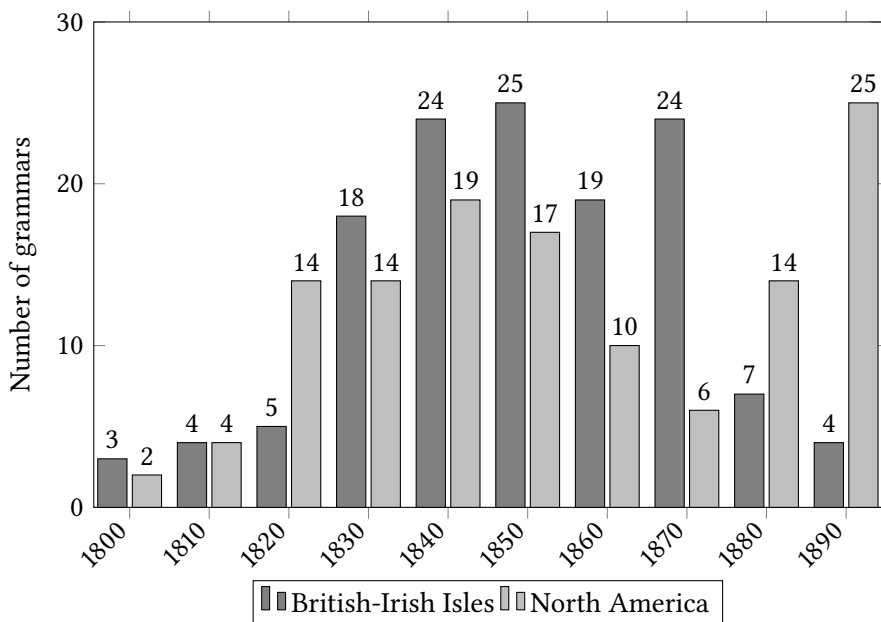


Figure 3.1: Number of grammars (first editions) in the CNG per decade, based on Anderwald (2016a: 12)

works, exclusively male authors. These 15 grammars are either solely written by women (6 grammars), co-written with women (3 grammars) or have anonymous authors (6 grammars). Any grammars intended for foreign language teaching were excluded, and a distinction between scholarly and school grammars was not made due to practical difficulties in implementing such a distinction. Moreover, where available, first editions were used (173 of 258 grammars) (Anderwald 2016a: 10–15).

In terms of publication date, Figure 3.1 illustrates their distribution throughout the nineteenth century. This figure is based on the year of publication of the grammars' first edition. As previously mentioned, the first edition was not always available and sometimes later editions have been used in the analysis of the present book. Figure 2.2 in Section 2.2 above, in comparison, shows the publication dates of all grammars published in the nineteenth century, ordered per decade based on Görlach (1998). Both figures show a stark increase of grammar books after the 1810s, which marks a continuation of a trend that started in the eighteenth century. Some grammarians in the CNG are aware of the massive numbers at which grammars on English were being published in the nineteenth century. One example of this is Bingham (1867: 3–5), who claims in the preface

Table 3.1: Overview of the traditional structure of grammars in the CNG, including typical contents of its sections

sections	typical contents of the section
introduction/preface	goals, motivation, sources, comments on other grammarians, anecdotes
orthography (and orthoëpy)	letters, spelling, sounds, syllable structure
etymology	~ morphology
syntax (including at times “false syntax”)	~ syntax, typical mistakes
prosody	~ suprasegmental phonology, instructions for poetry
(common errors)	lists of common mistakes or “vulgarisms”
(appendix)	various, sounds of the letters

to his grammar that “[m]ore than five hundred works on English Grammar have been published in this country, the great majority of which have never found their way beyond the publishers’ shelves”. Despite this awareness, he provides a 207-pages long work on English grammar. He ends his preface with the following statement and shows what we could perhaps describe as a blending of “academic” humility and implicitly expecting praise for his work: “[w]ith much distrust of his own ability to achieve success in an undertaking in which so many have failed, the author sends forth the following pages, in the hope that he has accomplished *some good*, both for teachers and learners”.²

In terms of how the grammars in the CNG are structured, many display the order of sections illustrated in Table 3.1. This means that they essentially follow the

²Whenever I quote grammars from the CNG, I keep the capitalisation and italicisation as in the original text. This in turn means, for example, that example words in quotes are not always italicised as is customary in modern linguistic works. I do this to be as faithful as possible to the original and show readers that linguistic conventions were far from standardised in the nineteenth century. Changes I have made to the format of the citation are always indicated after the quote in brackets.

3 Analysing the CNG: Pronunciation and grammars

traditional distinctions of grammar books (see Section 2.2 & Yáñez-Bouza 2018: 36). Important sections for the analysis of phonological variation are the introduction and preface, orthography and orthoëpy, appendices, or separate sections on phonology or the sounds of letters, which are not present in all grammars. Figure 3.2 shows an example taken from Swett (1844). This illustrates well which sections are crucial for investigating pronunciation in traditional grammars, as he writes: “[o]rthography treats of the form and sound of letters, the combination of letters into syllables, and of syllables into words” (Swett 1844: 11).

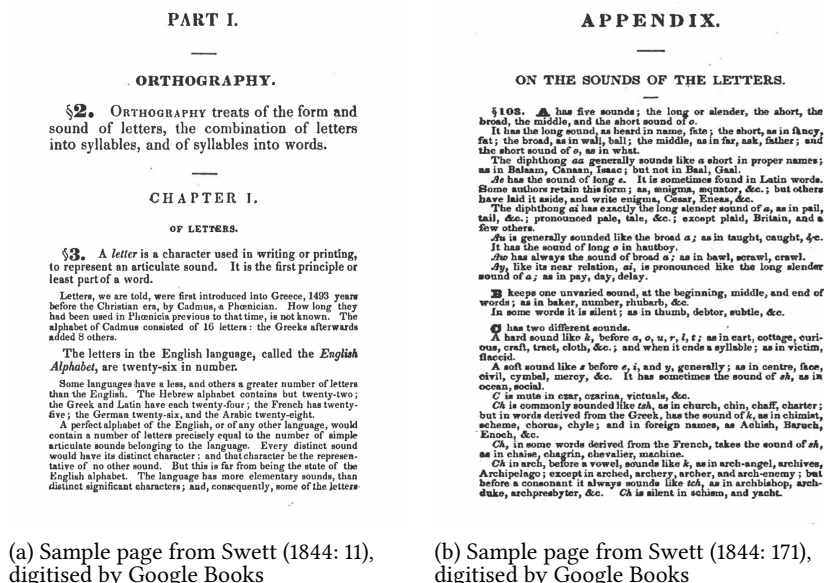


Figure 3.2: Sample pages from Swett (1844)

While Swett (1844) is admittedly based on Murray (1795), the treatment of sounds under *orthography* pervades the grammars in the CNG. This is perhaps contrary to a present-day interpretation of the term as we would expect only spelling variation to be part of such a section. In addition to orthography, in some works there are sections titled *orthoëpy*, which comes from ancient Greek *ὀρθοέπεια* ‘correctness of diction’ (OED: s.v. *orthoepy* n. ii.), which frequently treat sounds.

Nonetheless, a clear-cut distinction between sound and spelling is still absent in the majority of sources in the CNG as evidenced by Swett’s (1844) appendix. He treats every possible combination of letters in alphabetical order. For instance,

Figure 3.2 provides evidence that for him the words *far*, *ask*, and *father*, have the same vowel, which is relevant for the analysis in Chapter 6: “A has five sounds: [...] the middle, as in *far*, *ask*, *father*” (Swett 1844: 171). This way of elaborating on the sounds of English was customary already in authors like Sheridan (1780), Walker (1791), Murray (1795) and to a certain degree also Webster (1790), who all proceeded in a similar fashion. While there seems very little awareness of this in the grammars of the CNG, a few note that spelling and pronunciation are frequently confounded. Murray (1847: 5-6) for instance comments on other grammarians’ confusion of orthography and pronunciation: “[w]e do not wonder that grammarians, who overlook this difference [...] should differ in opinion and draw absurd conclusions” (see also Lennie 1863 below on the distinction between orthoëpy and orthography). The prefaces less frequently give information on the realisation or stigmatisation of specific variants. There are, however, instances in which this is the case and sometimes it indeed already foreshadows the tone which we can expect the rest of the grammar to have. For instance, in Leigh’s (1840) grammar, which is supposed to be comical as indicated by its name *Comic English Grammar*, we can find the following passage in the preface:

Few persons there are, whose ears are so extremely obtuse, as not to be frequently annoyed at the violations of Grammar by which they are so often assailed. It is really painful to be forced, in walking along the streets, to hear such phrases as, “That ’ere homnibus”. “Where’ve you *bin*”. “*Vot’s* the hodd’s?” and the like. Very dreadful expressions are also used by draymen and others in addressing their horses. (Leigh 1840: xi)

This reveals several non-standard features as /h/-dropping (’ere), /h/-insertion (*honnibus* & *hodd’s*), /v/-/w/-interchange (*Vot’s*), and a potentially shorter or lax realisation of the vowel in *been*. The passage clearly shows a negative evaluation and an association with working-class occupations who the readers are invited to laugh at.

The first step before analysing these grammars for comments on phonological variation was, naturally, to determine which of them offer sections that treat pronunciation in the first place. This was done by manually searching the grammars for the respective sections several times. The first time served the purpose of checking in which grammars there are sections such as orthography, orthoëpy, or prosody. This was done by means of a combination of manual and OCR (optical character recognition) searches. In contrast to Anderwald (2016a), I decided to use OCR software to some extent, which was helpful for a few key terms such as “orthography” and “orthoëpy” and in the later analyses also for example

words employed by the grammarians for certain phonological variants (e.g. for /r/, see Chapter 7). OCR was also helpful when it came to identifying those grammars that actually acknowledge their sources as it enabled key word searches for prominent authors of the time such as Murray, Walker, or Webster. Other search terms I used were “pronounce”, “pronunciation”, “sound(s)”, and words like “vulgar”, “improper”, “barbarous”³, the latter of which were typical evaluative terms in LModE times (see for instance Mugglestone 2007: 95–134; Trapateau 2016; Beal 2023). Nonetheless, manual searches still constituted my main method as this was inevitable to gather reliable data from the grammars. It is especially the bad quality of some scans that made it necessary to manually read through the grammars several times.

After this, I started with manual searches in which I noted down if these sections treated pronunciation, to what extent there were other sections that could be described as discussing pronunciation, what the respective sections were titled, and which phonological features were discussed. I thus categorised grammars into treating pronunciation and not treating pronunciation. My criteria for including grammars in the former, which is the important category for the present study, were the following:

1. the grammar has a section on orthography, orthoëpy, phonology or a comparable topic, or features dedicated pronunciation exercises
2. the sections or exercises yield more than simple definitions of vowels and consonants
3. the sections or exercises provide some evidence on the realisation or lexical distribution of at least one phonological variable

Based on these criteria, I have found that 166 of 258 grammars (64%) treat pronunciation to a degree that makes them suitable for tackling the research questions outlined in Section 2.4. Grammars in which comments on phonological variation is only added as a note to syntactic or morphological processes, e.g. the presence or absence of /h/ under the section on indefinite articles, were not included. Yet, I show in Section 8.3 that even those works may be fruitfully used to some extent. Furthermore, grammars that only provide a definition of terms like

³In the present work I use quotation marks to refer to terminology and evaluative terms used by grammarians to highlight that these are not my own words and because they are not in accordance with present-day linguistic terminology. Yet, as is customary in present-day linguistics, example words grammarians provide are italicised in the running text.

syllable, vowel or consonant but do not elaborate on this any further were categorised as not treating pronunciation (see the example of Lowth's 1762 grammar mentioned in Section 2.2). However, if they give a definition of monophthongs and diphthongs⁴ with example words so that information about the diphthong system of English as a whole may be derived, I classed them as treating pronunciation. Example words of diphthongs are helpful for the analysis in Chapter 5, even though grammarians often do not provide detailed articulatory information. Grammars like Smith (1872), to give one example of a grammar that was not included, mainly provide definitions. In his case, while the grammar does give an example of what he regards as a diphthong, he does not include enough information to derive anything about the distribution, quality, or the diphthong system as a whole: "When two vowels are joined together in one sound—as *oi* in *voice*, *oo* in *book*, *ow* in *cow*—the two vowels so taken together are called a Diphthong—that is, double-sound" (Smith 1872: 8).

As I show in Chapter 5, LModE sources often use "diphthong" synonymously with what we would refer to as digraph. This convention and the lack of additional information in Smith's example make it impossible to determine whether the words he describes as containing diphthongs were indeed diphthongs or simply digraphs. Many grammars distinguish between "improper diphthongs" 'monophthongs represented by digraphs', and "proper diphthongs" 'diphthongs in our modern sense'. Even in those grammars that mainly provide simple definitions, their example word for "improper diphthongs" was often *boat*. Therefore, they provided information on the realisation of GOAT words (see Section 5.4 for a more detailed discussion) and were thus included under grammars treating pronunciation.

Of the 166 grammars, 100 were published in the British-Irish Isles and 66 in North America. Therefore, in the CNG generally more British-Irish grammars treat pronunciation (100 of 133 grammars, i.e. 75%) than North American grammars 66 of 125, i.e. 53%). The category of British-Irish grammars include two grammars solely from Dublin (Edwardes 1877; McArthur 1836), two published in Dublin and other regions (Speers 1880; Sullivan 1855), and eight grammars that were either published only in a Scottish city or in Scotland and London (Burnet 1838; Coghlan 1868; Collier 1866; Connell 1843; Cannon 1845; Macintosh 1852; M'Culloch 1834; Wood 1857). The category North American grammars includes

⁴They use a variety of terms to refer to what in modern terminology would be monophthongs and diphthongs, e.g. "pure sound", "simple vowel", and "improper diphthong" for the former and words like "compound sound" for the latter. Those that use the term "monophthong" and "diphthong" do not always do so in a similar way to our modern use and often argue based on spelling (see Chapter 5 for a more detailed analysis).

3 Analysing the CNG: Pronunciation and grammars

one Canadian grammar (Davies 1869). Of the 166 grammars I used for analysing phonological variation, only one grammar was written by a woman, namely Hyde (1895). Her grammar does not feature a dedicated pronunciation section but pronunciation exercises that are scattered through the grammar. Five of the grammars I analysed were written by anonymous authors, namely (Anonymous 1848, 1853, 1877, 1885, 1888). The distribution of these grammars is illustrated in Figure 3.3. It shows that until the 1870s between 62% and 75% of grammars contain information on pronunciation. Throughout the nineteenth century, grammars including pronunciation show a significant decrease ($\tau = -0.52$, $p < 0.05$), with the first drop below 60% in the 1880s. Except one statistical outlier the same trend can be seen in North American and British-Irish grammars if regarded separately.

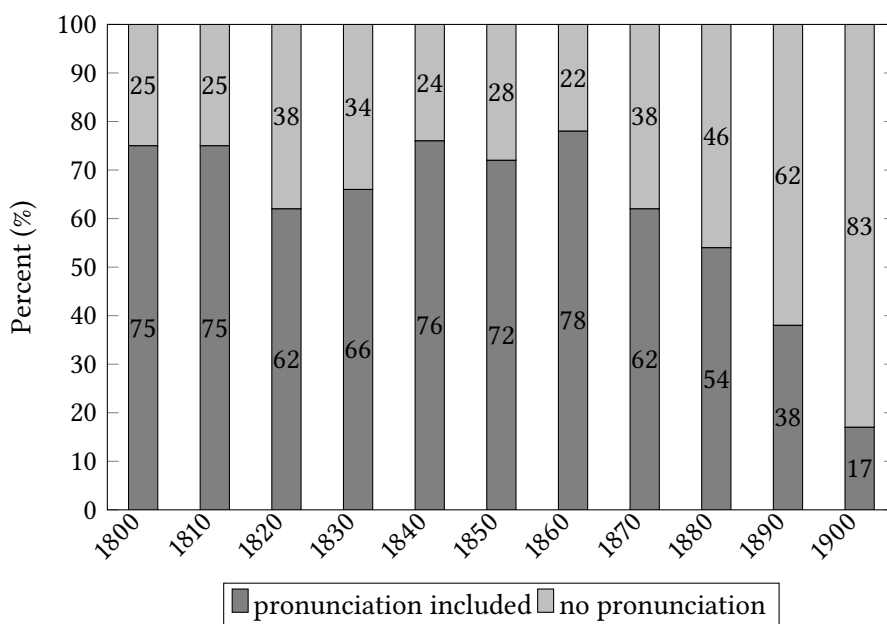


Figure 3.3: Grammars in the CNG that include pronunciation in relation to those that do not

In Chapter 8, I sometimes make reference to grammars in the CNG not included in the 166 grammars that treat pronunciation. This is due to the fact that some information on /h/-full words or variation of /h/ in WHALE words can be gathered from the sections dealing with indefinite article allomorphy and relative pronouns respectively even though these grammars do not otherwise treat

pronunciation. An example of this is Tidmarsh (1882: 163), who states the following under relative pronouns “in modern English the wh of the relatives is sounded hw”. Whenever I discuss cases like this in my analysis, I indicate this in the respective section.

Scans were unfortunately missing the relevant pages in two grammars, namely Greene (1830) and Jenkins (1836). From the pages that were present in the scans, these, however, looked like the standard make-up of those grammars that only provide definitions on orthography and orthoëpy but do not give examples or elaborate on them any further. They were therefore counted as not treating pronunciation. In the final step, I went back to passages in the grammars I had previously marked as containing comments on the features outlined in Table 2.1 in Section 2.4 above. I categorised these grammars according to the different variants they suggest, how prescriptive they are and how much information they reveal about the variants.

Grammars that do not treat pronunciation at times comment on why they deliberately kept sections on sounds, orthography or orthoëpy very brief or excluded them altogether (25 grammars, see Table A.1 in the Appendix for a list of grammars with abridged titles that do so). With the exception of two grammars, namely, Weedon (1848) and Tidmarsh (1882), all the grammars that contain such comments were published in North America. Thus, at least in the grammars of the CNG, British-Irish grammars are not only more likely to include information on pronunciation but those that do not treat pronunciation are also less likely to provide reasons for its exclusion. As regards Table A.1, North American grammars are marked with an asterisk to more easily differentiate between places of publication. This is a convention I adopt in all tables throughout this book. Whenever a table includes references to grammars, an asterisk was added to North American grammars, whereas British-Irish grammars remain unmarked.

Reasons given for the absence of sections that treat orthography or orthoëpy are various. They indicate an emerging division of labour between dictionaries, phonetic works and grammars. Some give negative evaluations of grammars that discuss pronunciation, some criticise the inclusion of pronunciation but include it themselves, and some direct their readers to other works, general as well as specific. Yet, as we shall see later, there are some late nineteenth-century grammars that very thoroughly discuss pronunciation.

An interesting example can be found in Cobbett (1818: 14–15):

Orthography means neither more nor less than the very humble business of putting *Letters* together properly, so that they shall form *Words*. This is so very childish a concern, that I will not appear to suppose it necessary for

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me to dwell upon it. [...] I will here for form's sake, just observe, that the letters A, E, I, O, and U, are *Vowels*. Y, in certain cases, is also a *Vowel*. All the rest of the letters of the alphabet are *Consonants*.

It is curious that he dismisses orthography as “humble business” and “very childish a concern”. This is especially the case since spelling and sound-spelling correspondence in LModE, similar to PDE, was indeed not very straightforward. Many other grammars clearly also provide evidence for this when they talk their readers through pages-long lists of different combinations of letters. However, Cobbet's statement certainly shows a shift in the text type of grammar writing very well.

Others like Felton (1843: 7) show the emerging division of tasks between grammars and other works like dictionaries and spelling books. He refers his readers to spelling books and generally other works for rules on sounds, spelling and letters:

ENGLISH GRAMMAR [...] is divided into four parts; viz. ORTHOGRAPHY, ETYMOLOGY, SYNTAX and PROSODY. [...] ORTHOGRAPHY treats of the different sounds of the letters, and the proper method of spelling words. NOTE. As this part of grammar is usually learned from Spellingbooks, it will not be repeated here. (Felton 1843: 7)

Felton follows the structure of traditional grammars in which orthography occupies the first position. In addition to spelling, orthography also concerns sounds in his definition. However, he does not regard it as belonging into a grammar book but in spelling books. The quote also illustrates a traditional conception of grammar (in the sense of system of rules of a language not a grammar book), which in fact includes also sounds and spellings. In contrast, Harvey (1851: xxxi) argues against orthography occupying the first rank of grammar as grammar exists independently of orthography and thus he excludes the section: “But were it otherwise, I should scruple to teach any pupil, that the first division of Grammar was Orthography, when it is obvious that it could not be the first [...] that Grammar must exist though Orthography never existed”. Pinneo (1854: 159) uses the absence of orthography and prosody sections in his grammar to advertise some of his other works as he suggests “[f]or further explanation of Orthography, see the author's ANALYTICAL GRAMMAR”. Grammars like M'Chesney (1822) and Lynde (1821) in contrast, do not provide a reason for the exclusion of Orthography and simply state that “ETYMOLOGY and SYNTAX being the two principal parts of Grammar, will be made the particular objects of attention in this work”

(M'Chesney 1822: 3) and “the only parts treated, are a part of etymology and syntax” (Lynde 1821: 9). Webster (1807: 13) similarly does not provide a reason but excludes orthography from the subjects that are treated in his grammars. Others again tell their students that Orthography, “the first part of grammar, teaches the nature and powers of letters, and the just method of spelling words”, can be omitted “because we believe you are already acquainted with it” (Hull 1828: 5). Arguments like this could have a didactic motivation as teaching time might have been better used for grammar in the sense of syntax and morphology. Yet another grammar, namely Morris (1858: 3), makes explicit reference to the term *orthoëpy* and argues that “pronunciation” would be a much better word instead and claims that “[p]ronunciation can be better learned from professed works on this subject, or from dictionaries, than from any or all the English Grammars that have ever been written”. He continues with the rhetorical questions “[w]ho would think of turning to a grammar to learn the pronunciation of a word?” and “[w]hy, then, should grammars promise to impart this information, if their pretensions are untrue?”. This statement hints at a more present-day understanding of grammar books.

Pue (1841: 19) puts forward some less coherent argument for the omission of orthography and prosody: “[y]ou will need to be told nothing more about Orthography and Prosody; the first meaning spelling, and the last pronunciation. If you never had to write, you would have no use for Orthography; and if you never had to speak, you would have no use for Prosody”. Tidmarsh (1882: 2) is the only grammar that states that orthography is discussed only briefly, which in reality means that his grammar has five sentences on orthography. These are essentially a list of the English vowels, semi-vowels, and consonants. Weedon (1848: 3) in contrast does have a section on orthography but leaves out sounds on purpose as “to commence with a long dissertation on the nice variations of sound, as some Grammars begin, is not only useless to an Englishman, it confuses him”. His use of “nice” and his reference to the “uselessness” of this approach shows his critical and perhaps even condescending attitude to grammars that discuss pronunciation. However, not all grammars that omit sections on orthography or *orthoëpy* draw attention to their omission or provide reasons. These examples also show that grammars may include sections on orthography but at the same time do not treat pronunciation.

Moreover, grammars that have been counted as treating pronunciation because they provide sufficient information may refer to other works for more extensive discussions on pronunciation. One example is Cardell (1827: 42), who writes that “[a]n extended illustration of Orthography, with the meaning of syllables found in modern words, is to be given in an other [sic!] work”. Another

grammar may even suggest that teachers can skip the section on orthography if they regard it sensible to do so. Bullions (1851: 2) for example writes: “[y]et as the whole subject [i.e. orthography] is treated more fully in the spelling-book or dictionary, a brief synopsis of its principles only is here given [...]. The teacher may, therefore, if he thinks proper, pass over this part for the present, and begin with PART II”. There are several similar examples which suggest that at least for some grammarians the traditional structure of grammars and with that the relevance of orthography and orthoëpy was decreasing. Lennie (1863: iii) admits in his preface that “[o]rthography is mentioned rather for the sake of order, than from a conviction of its utility; for, in my opinion, to occupy thirty or forty pages of a grammar in defining the sounds of the alphabet is quite preposterous”. In contrast, Lowres (1863: 50) appears to make a case for the inclusion of orthoëpy and highlights its difference to orthography:

In many English grammars orthoëpy is entirely omitted, in others it is supposed to form a part of orthography, but this supposition is a manifest mistake; for if the real nature of each be attentively considered, it will appear evident that orthoëpy and orthography are totally different subjects, and equally entitled to a separate classification.

There are grammarians in the CNG who explicitly refer to the works of other scholars they regard as authority in terms of pronunciation and spelling. Fleay (1884: 83), for instance, claims the following after introducing orthography and orthoëpy: “[t]hose students who desire accurate statements on this matter must not have recourse to the current English Grammars, but to the writings of Mr. A. J. Ellis and Mr. Guest [...]”. While he does not specify whom he means with “Mr. Guest”, he likely refers to nineteenth-century philologist Edwin Guest, who was a leading founder of the Philological Society and author of *A History of English Rhythms* (1838a, 1838b). We can find similar comments even in grammars that are comparatively thorough in their discussion of sounds, e.g. in Fowler (1855) or Ramsey (1892). Fowler (1855: 152) states that his own statements regarding the sounds of English “are sufficiently exact for the purpose in hand” but adds that “[t]hose who wish to pursue it further can consult DR. RUSH’s admirable work, ‘The Philosophy of the Human Voice’”. His statement refers to Dr James Rush, who was an American physician but also published on various other topics including language (e.g. Rush 1827). Ramsey (1892: 145) notes, after introducing his transcription system, that “[t]his is but a rough scale of sounds easily distinguished. Those who have made a life-study of orthoëpy discover a great number of intermediate shades that elude the common sense and sometimes perplex the

professional ear”. As an example he quotes Ellis, whom he calls “[t]he most laborious investigator”. However, Ramsey (1892: 131) also accuses Ellis’ paleotype and Karl Richard Lepsius’ (a German Egyptologist and linguist) Standard Alphabet of being inaccessible: “Both [sc. systems of writing] are chargeable with excessive refinement and hair-splitting, and neither of them has been made at all intelligible to the general reader”. Ramsey informs his readers: “I shall not try to introduce either [sc. Ellis’ or Lepsius’ writing systems] in this place, although aware that it is very annoying for a reader to find his page filled with marks to which he has no key” (Ramsey 1892: 131).

West (1898: 40) is of the opinion that a detailed description of articulation does not belong into grammars: “[a]ll this is interesting, no doubt, to us as physiologists, but it is no concern of ours as grammarians”. He continues to delineate which part of describing sounds in fact belongs into grammar books and which does not: “[...] whether we stop our breath or only squeeze it, whether we vibrate our vocal chords or do something with our larynx or pharynx. This is physiology, not grammar. Our business is to distinguish the sounds when produced, not to determine the mode of their production”. West’s statements somewhat reflect the present-day difference we make between phonetics and phonology. Furthermore, Carpenter (1902: 2) also notes that orthoëpy is treated in dictionaries but adds in a footnote that “[t]o one branch of Orthoëpy, however, the pupil’s attention should be particularly called, i.e., Phonology, which deals with the classification of spoken sounds”. A section titled “Phonology” is indeed discussed in the appendix to his grammar.

As noted in Section 2.1, LModE terminology and transcription systems were vastly different to those used in the present day and extremely heterogeneous; nineteenth-century grammars were no different in that respect. While the nineteenth century saw a move more towards current conventions, which is also partially reflected in the CNG, a note on different LModE transcription practices is sensible at this point.

Discussions about spellings based on what sounds they reflect, mostly in alphabetical order, are very common in the grammars of the CNG and very much follow previous traditions. As the IPA was introduced only in 1888, we find a variety of different ways to refer to sounds in dictionaries and grammars from the LModE period. Diacritics such as “˘, ˘, ^, ´, ˝”, or italicisation were used on the regular orthography of words to indicate length, tenseness, stress, and simply to distinguish between different phonetic realisations of the same grapheme. In Perry’s (1775) system, for instance, italics are used for silent or indistinct sounds, “-” to indicate a long/tense vowel, “˘” for short/lax vowels and “^” (as well as “˘” and “˝”) to distinguish different short vowels of the same spelling. To give an

example, *duke* has a long vowel “ū”, *duck* a short one “ŭ” and *bush* a short vowel of a different quality “û”. To differentiate between sounds of <O>, Perry makes use of all options outlined above: *note* has “ō”, *not* “ö” or “o”, *prove* “ô”, *wolf* “ò”, and *done* “ó”. In contrast “˘”, and “˙” inserted between letters indicate “sharp and quickly accented syllables” and “flat and slowly accented syllables” respectively (Perry 1775: liii). Note, however, that the use of a macron does not refer solely to length but may indicate a diphthongal character. In Perry (1775: viii, 39), the word *bite* is transcribed with “ī” and said to be realised with a diphthong.

Different ligatures can also be found, for example in Spence (1775), for vowels as well as consonants such as ligatures joining <A> and <U>, and <N> and <G> to refer to the vowel in *wall* and a velar nasal respectively (Beal 1999: 82; Yáñez-Bouza & Nieves-Fernández 2023: 56). In Sheridan’s (1780: 4) dictionary, we can find the use of superscript numbers to refer to different realisations of sounds, e.g. “a¹” for the vowel in *hat*, “a²” in *hate*, and “a³” in *hall*, which was another widespread type of indicating different pronunciations (see Beal 2009 for a detailed discussion of dictionaries from the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries). There were also several established terms in LModE dictionaries and grammars such as “Italian *a*” (likely [a:]), “rough *r*” (likely a form of trill), “improper diphthong” (a digraph with monophthongal pronunciation), “ringing sound” (a velar nasal), and others that are discussed in more detail in the relevant chapters of my analysis.

As regards late nineteenth-century sources, Ellis’ works feature several different types of notation such as his Palaeotype and Glossic systems. His notations are comprised of symbols and ligatures such as “e” or “æ” (referring to [ɣ] and [æ] respectively), consonant combinations to indicate different single consonant sounds (e.g. “kh” to refer to [x]), the doubling of symbols to indicate a quantitative difference (“e” translates into [e] while “ee” stands for [e:]), diacritics (“˘” indicating lowering) as well as italics to distinguish phonetic quality (“e” is [e] whereas “e” refers to [ɛ]) (MacMahon 1996: 835–837).

In sum, some common ways of transcribing and indicating the distribution of sounds in LModE sources are:

- diacritics for length, quality or stress
- italics for silent letters or quality
- ligatures or separate letter combinations to refer to a single sound
- superscript numbers for quality or length

- fixed terms for a specific vowel or consonant, e.g. “Italian *a*”
- IPA in late nineteenth-century sources

Of course, these are not the only types of phonetic notation that can be found in LModE sources but these are the main ways of describing pronunciation that are relevant to the analysis of the CNG. Giving a comprehensive overview of all LModE transcription systems would exceed the scope of the present work (see MacMahon 1996, 1998; Jones 2006; Beal 2009 for more detail on LModE transcription systems).

The general use of the terms *phonetics* and *phonology* is also worth considering in this context. The first mention of *phonology* in the OED comes from 1798, whereas the first attestation of *phonetics* is from 1841 (OED: s.v. *phonology* n.; *phonetics* n.). The adjective *phonetic* is documented from 1802 (OED: s.v. *phonetic* adj.). In the CNG, the earliest example of *phonetic(s)* is from Balch (1841) but he uses it only with reference to Egyptian and Indian scripts, and Brown (1851) only uses it as part of two quotes. Bullen & Heycock (1853) employ it in the context of a spelling reformation, but the earliest uses to actually describe the pronunciation of English come from Barnes (1854) and Fowler (1855) in the CNG. For the term *phonology* the earliest examples can be found in Kenyon (1849) and Brown (1849). Yet, they still often use it alongside traditional terminology and also still focus very much on the spelling. For example, for Barnes (1854) and Brown (1849) the phonetic alphabet and phonology respectively are still part of orthography. For a full list of grammars from the CNG that contain the terms *phonetic(s)* and *phonology/phonological*, see Table A.2 in the Appendix. The excerpts discussed in this chapter show that grammarians were to a certain extent aware that the genre of grammar books was changing, in terms of terminology and structure, and who was to be consulted in matters of pronunciation. This is something we shall see more specifically with respect to certain phonological features in Part II of this book.

4 Framework(s) for analysing phonological change and prescriptive comments

Similar to Anderwald (2020a: 75), following Labov's (1972: 72) *principle of accountability*, I also noted down which grammars did not discuss any or only some of the phonological features outlined in Table 2.1 in Section 2.4. Moreover, I not only consider the number of variants, phonetic quality and timeline but furthermore example words grammarians provide. With this information I intend to trace the potential development of variants in a more fine-grained fashion. By considering example words, comments on the quality and quantity of variants as well as social information the grammars provide, I hope to shed more light on the processes of phonological change themselves instead of looking simply at the proposed starting and end points of change. Indeed, Bybee (2015: 39) notes that the lexical diffusion of sound changes "has been ignored in many studies, or assumed to be uninteresting". Thus, the approach taken here, as far as the data permit it, is based on the assumption that "all sound changes have to diffuse through the lexicon in some way or another, gradually or abruptly, reaching completion or not" (Bybee 2015: 39).

I therefore differentiate between phonetically and lexically gradual and abrupt changes in my discussion (see also McMahon 1994). To put it simply, phonetically gradual changes involve qualitative and quantitative intermediate stages in the change of sounds. This is illustrated by the assumption that before becoming [ɑ:] in the South of England, the vowel in BATH words likely moved from [æ] through different stages like [a], [aː], or [ɑ:]. Regarding this as a phonetically abrupt change would preclude the possibility of intermediate stages and would postulate a direct shift in usage from [æ] to [ɑ:]. This is an unlikely scenario for the vowel in all BATH words, but applies well to the development of /h/-dropping (see Paulsen 2022: 133–141 and Chapter 6 for a detailed discussion on the development of the vowel in BATH).

Lexically gradual changes analogously involve a diffusion of innovative phonetic variants through a set of lexemes that have this phoneme. Thus, a change

happens in some words first while others are affected at a later stage in the process, if they are at all affected. The usage-frequency of words potentially plays a role in this scenario. High frequency words may be affected first as they are more entrenched (in Schmid's 2020 sense). While of course more than one factor is relevant for the diffusion of sound changes, Bybee (2015: 41) notes that "the role of frequency and repetition is to move the change forward". Phillips (2015: 360–363) also points to frequency effects but notes that high as well as low frequency words may be affected first, regardless of whether we are dealing with phonetically gradual or abrupt changes. She furthermore notes that phonetic similarity between words plays a role in the spread of innovative variants (see Trapateau 2020 for a critical discussion concerning the role of high frequency words in the change of Middle English /a/). Moreover, it has been suggested that wholesale sound change, in contrast to constructional change, happens in words irrespective of their word-class or syntactic contexts (Hilpert 2013: 13). To illustrate his point, Hilpert jokingly invites us to imagine a sound change that affects an entire language save for subordinate clauses. In contrast to lexically gradual changes, in abrupt changes all relevant words are altered at the same point in time.

These two opposing ideas of diffusion of sound change through the lexicon versus abrupt and regular changes can be traced back to different theoretical concepts, namely the discussion between lexical diffusion and Neogrammarian sound change. This issue is still controversial and there are some misconceptions about both approaches that persist. One of those is that lexical diffusion is random and irregular. However, as previously noted, frequency effects have been shown to play a role in the spread of sound changes through the lexicon (see Phillips 2015). Furthermore, both approaches are not necessarily mutually exclusive. According to Hale (2003: 344–345), the hypothesis put forth by Neogrammarians concerns constraints on change and thus the conditioning factors of possible changes. If and how a phonological change spreads in a community, i.e. the constraints on diffusion, is a different matter.

When we are talking about nineteenth-century grammar books, we should note that example words grammarians use only reflect frequencies in as much as we assume that they used their own intuition to come up with these examples and therefore accessed words which are more entrenched, or those words and only those which they actually heard speakers pronounce with a certain variant. This presupposes also that they were independent witnesses, which, as I shall show, some of them likely were not. Lists of example words in grammars are likely to be incomplete, or simply copied from other earlier authors. In the latter case, however, example words can be beneficial in order to determine the extent to which grammarians plagiarised each other (see Chapter 14). Given the scope

of this book and the number of grammars scrutinised here, a full scale comparison of example words with usage frequencies in various corpora, dictionaries and other sources from different time periods, as done by Trapateau (2020), is not possible. Nevertheless, where the data suggest a clear pattern in example words, additional evidence from corpora – *A Representative Corpus of Historical English Registers* (ARCHER) and the *Corpus of Historical American English* (COHA; Davies 2010) – has been consulted as far as possible (Chapter 6).

Sound changes may be gradual or abrupt also in terms how the innovative variant spreads through each speech community. How feasible answering questions about intermediate phonetic stages as well as different communities is highly depends on how much phonetic and sociolinguistic information grammarians include. The region assigned to the grammars might reveal some information about the spread of the variants. I thus examine the regional variation of variants in two ways. First of all, based on the place publication of the grammar and following the assumption that grammarians describe and prescribe what they consider the standard of their specific region. Second of all, I use comments on regional variation by the grammarians themselves. Concerning the year of publication of the respective grammars, it is also crucial to bear in mind that it does not reveal anything about the age of the grammarian. If we assume that grammarians were influenced by their own usage in which variants they describe (or prescribe), or which example words they use for the variants, this is vital for the analysis of lexical diffusion. For this reason, considering the dates of birth of grammarians might be more sensible and could yield a different outcome, as Beal (1999: 104–105) and Trapateau (2020: 539) point out. However, since detailed biographical information is absent for most of the authors in the CNG and can not be included as a variable in the analysis, the year of publication is the main point of reference available.

In my phonological analyses, I use Wells' (1982) lexical sets to make reference to vowels. A lexical set, e.g. the GOAT set, is a stand-in example word of a category of lexemes that have the same vowel in a given accent. So, whenever I speak of the vowel in GOAT words, I mean the vowel in *boat*, *know*, *so*, *old*, etc. Each example word “stands for a large number of words which behave the same way in respect of the incidence of vowels in different accents” (Wells 1982: 120). This way of referring to vowel distributions has become customary in the European tradition of English phonology and sociolinguistics. A list of all lexical sets distinguished by Wells, including more examples of words that belong to the respective sets can be found in Wells (1982: 127–168).

I furthermore complement my results with data from the ECEP. The ECEP is an online database that contains data from 11 British eighteenth-century pronounc-

ing dictionaries, all interpreted and transcribed into modern IPA. It is a very helpful resource, especially due to the idiosyncratic notational systems found in LModE dictionaries (and grammars for that matter), which are given in their IPA equivalents in the database. The ECEP contains in total “1,959 example words for each of the 11 dictionaries consulted to date, including 1,395 example words for vowel sets across 27 different lexical sets and 564 items across 6 consonant lexical sets” (ECEP: title page). The dictionaries cover a time span from 1757 to 1798 (in terms of years of publication), which is an ideal point of departure for my analysis. For more information regarding the make-up of the database, see Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018), and Yáñez-Bouza (2020).

Regarding prescriptivism in grammar writing, I also include neutral and positive evaluations in addition to comments that display stigmatisation of variants, which should enable a more comprehensive picture of the grammars and their metalinguistic behaviour. The framework I utilise for categorising prescriptive comments in the CNG is taken from Anderwald (2017), who distinguishes different categories of evaluation for comments on linguistic features in the grammars. I generally distinguish three types of evaluations of features: first, neutral evaluations, which are simple descriptions that do not contain any form of judgement or prescriptions. Second, positive evaluations as we can see for instance in Higginson’s (1864: 9) comment on different /r/ variants: “[t]he distinct but not excessive *trill* of the *r* is a great characteristic of good articulation”. These are, however, generally less frequent than neutral or negative evaluations. Passages are counted as negative evaluations if they contain prescriptions, proscriptions, explicit negative judgments on correctness, social values, aesthetics, or a combination of these. Therefore, if a grammarian argues along the lines of “this variant should be used”, “this variant should not be used”, or “the use of this variant is a vulgarity”, I count these instances as negative. Statements with *should*, *should not* or comparable expressions are regarded as negative because they clearly aim at reducing or completely disallowing variation. With respect to these categorisations, I focus especially on the form of the metalinguistic comment, i.e. the presence of deontic modals and their negations for prescriptions and proscriptions and the use of terms like “vulgar”, “improper”, “feeble”, and its derivatives for value judgements. For the initial categorisation I embrace a narrow form-based approach as outlined in Section 2.3. Value judgements are in accordance with Anderwald (2017) further distinguished into the categories Aesthetics, Education, Logic, Mistake, Nature, and Social Evaluation. Examples taken from the CNG are presented in Table 4.1. These overlap to a certain extent with Curzan’s (2014) list of justifications for good rules under stylistic prescriptivism, which includes logic, avoidance of ambiguity, necessity, aesthetics and education. Ranson

(2012: 19) observes partially similar ideas in Walker’s dictionary, namely “authority, correctness, the social status of the speaker, aesthetic pronunciation, obligation, and guilt”.

Table 4.1: Evaluative categories and examples from the CNG

categories	terms
Aesthetics	dreadful, marred in its pronunciation
Education	ill-educated persons
Logic/Avoiding ambiguity	confounding two words
Mistake	defect, error, fault
Nature	degradation, disposition
Social Evaluation	Cockneyism, feeble, improper, vulgar(ism)

Aesthetics generally contains arguments that refer to the beauty (or rather its absence) of linguistic variants. While evaluative terms like “ill-educated persons” are technically also a social evaluation, I still introduce the category Education as some grammarians explicitly refer to the educational status of speakers using certain variants, which is a different level of socially-based value judgments than for instance “improper” or “Cockneyism”. In the nineteenth century, “Cockney(ism)” was not only applied to the speech of working-class Londoners but also more generally as a value judgment like “vulgar”, as argued by Sen (2025: 11). The category Logic is expanded to refer to instances where grammarians argue based on homophony or potential ambiguity rather than in purely logical terms. Anderwald (2017, 2020b) for example shows that multiple negation and unmarked adverbs are often regarded as illogical in the grammars of the CNG. For nineteenth-century grammarians two negatives ought to make a positive and adverbs without *-ly* cause confusion since they allegedly create ambiguity due to the formal identity to their adjective-counterparts. This kind of argument is similar to grammars suggesting that certain phonological features such as /w/ instead of /hw/ in <wh> words create confusion between words like *whet* and *wet*. Those arguments we find for instance in Walker (1791: xiii). Mistake includes comments in which a feature is simply evaluated as a fault. Nature comprises comments and terms that ascribe the use of certain linguistic features to a natural reason, for example a speech impairment or a disposition. The final category, Social Evaluation, contains terms such as “vulgar” or explicit value judgements of different types of speakers or dialects such as “Londoners”, “Kentish”, and specific working-class occupations.

Where the data allow for it, I furthermore incorporate what I have called a broader differentiation of prescriptive comments into standardising, stylistic and restorative goals into my discussion (along the lines of Curzan 2014, see Section 2.3). While the CNG offers only few examples of what we might regard restorative prescriptivism in Curzan’s (2014) sense, the majority of metalinguistic comments I deal with in Part II fit into the category of standardising prescriptivism. Many clearly represent the aim of disallowing for variation and of raising variants used by one particular group of people (usually educated speakers) to the level of the standard while vehemently railing against those variants found in other speakers. To a certain degree I utilise oppositions like negative vs. neutral/positive, or prescriptive vs. descriptive as analytic terms for obtaining an idea of the general trends in the metalinguistic commentary in the CNG (see my discussion in Section 2.3). This I deem sensible as the majority of these grammars has not been analysed in detail. However, I complement these general observations by detailed quantitative and qualitative analyses of comments and grammars so as to eventually place them on a prescriptive-descriptive continuum. In sum, my analyses aim at examining the grammars for the points outlined in Table 4.2 in the realms of historical phonology and prescriptivism.

Table 4.2: Points to be analysed in the CNG in regard to historical phonology and prescriptivism

phonology	number of different variants per variable
	frequency and timeline of innovative variants
	phonetic quality of different variants
	gradualness of changes
	lexical distribution of variants based on example words
	regional differences in the distribution of variants
prescriptivism	frequency of criticism
	categories from Table 4.1 that capture the criticism best
	categories of restorative, standardising, or stylistic prescriptivism
	place of grammars on a descriptive-prescriptive continuum

As will become apparent in Part II, the grammars in the CNG do not always contain sufficient information on the features in the present analysis to successfully address all of the points shown in Table 4.2.

The following Chapters 5–11 present my analysis of the phonological features illustrated in Section 2.4.¹ Chapters 5 and 6 cover the vowels and Chapters 7–11 concern the consonants. The features are discussed separately and all receive dedicated chapters. Every chapter begins with the historical background on the feature in question. This has the purpose of giving sufficient information on the state of research to follow my analysis. Moreover, it is a prerequisite for answering the research questions listed under i and ii in Section 2.4: To what extent are the features discussed by the grammarians? To what extent do comments in the CNG align with the current state of research on phonological variation in the nineteenth century? Do the grammars in the CNG diverge from the established timeline or realisation for certain variants?

Following the historical background, I present my analysis, which always starts with an overview on the regional and temporal distribution of variants in quantitative terms in the CNG. I then discuss several examples from a qualitative point of view and show which phonetic values can be derived from grammar books. I scrutinise how the information provided by grammarians can be interpreted in phonetic terms and which types of comments are reliable and warrant conclusions on the phonetic quality of variants. All sections are ordered by the different variants I have been able to find for the respective variables.

This qualitative part is followed by an examination on prescriptions and variation found in the grammars. This constitutes the analysis of the research questions listed under iii in Section 2.4: Are certain phonological variants stigmatised in the grammars? If so, how prescriptive are the grammarians and does the degree of stigmatisation depend on the feature in question? The degree of stigmatisation is not always treated in separate sections, simply because of the make-up of the data, and is treated sometimes alongside other aspects of the qualitative analysis. Furthermore, all consonantal features treated in Chapters 7–11, except realisations of *-ing*, were identified by Walker (1791) as typical mistakes of Londoners. Thus, in addition to tracing the development of features which eventually acquire overt prestige and evaluating the degree to which they were still stigmatised in the nineteenth century, I touch on the extent to which they were considered to be typical London features.

Discussions on the extent to which grammars contain verbatim copies (research question iv in Section 2.4) do not receive dedicated sections but are examined alongside the phonological analyses in the sections on the different variants. Every chapter on the respective features ends with a short summary of my analysis.

¹Parts of the sections on the GOAT vowel, /r/, and /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in Chapters 5, 7, and 8 have already been published elsewhere (see Wiemann 2023, 2024)

In addition to this general structure, some chapters feature additional sections. Chapter 6 has sections on frequency effects and diffusion (Section 6.5) and prescriptions and dialectal variation (Section 6.6). Chapter 8 contains sections on accepted /h/-dropping and its lexical distribution (Section 8.3) and prescriptions and proscriptions (Section 8.4). Chapter 9 has additional sections on dialectal variation, etymological arguments, and prescriptions (Section 9.4) and the relation of WHALE realisations to /h/-dropping (Section 9.5). These additional sections have been added to live up to the complexity and heterogeneity of the data.

Part II

Analysis

5 Long Mid Diphthonging

5.1 FACE and GOAT: Historical background

The development of eighteenth-century long mid monophthongs /e:/ and /o:/ into diphthongs during the nineteenth century is often referred to as *Long Mid Diphthonging*. According to Jones (2006: 303), the earliest possible point for the establishment of diphthongal variants in words collated under the FACE and GOAT sets in prestige speech is the middle of the nineteenth century. RP and AmE pronunciation both have diphthongal variants today resulting from *Long Mid Diphthonging*. Traditional RP and AmE have [oʊ] and [eɪ ~ ɛɪ], while realisations with centralised onsets like [əʊ] in GOAT words are now typical of modern RP (sometimes also referred to as Standard Southern British or General British pronunciation, see Lindsey 2019: 4). These centralised qualities were first noted towards the end of the nineteenth century, but became established as the standard variant in British prestige speech only during the twentieth century (Wells 1982: 237; MacMahon 1998: 460–461; Beal 2004b: 138). For regional accents in the UK, Trudgill (2004: 52–57) shows, based on Ellis (1889), that the diphthongisation of FACE and GOAT was only in its early stages of development in the nineteenth century. Many regional dialects of the British-Irish Isles and North America as well as several World Englishes in fact have monophthongal variants in these sets today, either categorically or at least variably (see for instance Gargesh 2004 for Indian English; Gut 2004 for Nigerian English). In some cases, these constitute historical retentions of earlier distributions, in others potential L2 influence or contact-induced change (see for instance Paulasto et al. 2021: 53–55 on Welsh English). Furthermore, in pre-lateral environments laxer realisations or even mergers with corresponding short vowel phonemes are common in present-day varieties, e.g. in several US accents (Gordon 2004a: 287, 2004b: 345; Thomas 2004: 316; Hickey 2023: 67). These, however, appear to be recent phenomena (Gordon 2004b: 345).

The vowel historically present in the FACE set is also known by its traditional name “long a”. It was found in the following spellings: <a, aCe, ai, ay, ei, ey, aig(h), eig(h), ea> as in the letter *A*, *mate*, *wait*, *day*, *veil*, *they*, *straight*, *eight* and *break*.¹

¹The spellings <aigh> and <eigh> are listed here in addition to <ai> and <ei> as <gh> represents historical, dorsal fricatives in the pronunciation of words like *eight*. It is thus important to differentiate between these spellings as they constitute a different phonological environment.

5 Long Mid Diphthonging

In rhotic varieties similar spellings also belonged to this category when they appeared before <r>, for example in *air* or *care* (Wells 1982: 141–142, 155–157). In terms of Wells' lexical sets, we would refer to words where the vowel in question occurs in pre-/r/ position as SQUARE words. In RP, SQUARE words have a centring diphthong, namely [eə ~ εə], resulting from post-vocalic /r/-loss (see Chapter 7), whereas in AmE many speakers have maintained both monophthongs and post-vocalic /r/.² Some words like *gaol* 'jail' and *gauge* have <ao> or <au> spellings for the same vowel.

Words now collated under the sets FACE and SQUARE have three different origins, ME /a:/ for <a> and <aCe> spellings, /ei ~ æi ~ ai/ for all digraphs involving <e> and <a> plus <i> or <y>, and ME /ɛ:/ in <ea> spellings. As with FACE words, the most common source for SQUARE words is ME /a:/ or /ai/ (Wells 1982: 156). Before *Long Mid Diphthonging*, these three categories merged as part of the Great Vowel Shift in what is called the *Long Mid Merger*. In the case of <ea> spellings, some words had merged with <ee> spellings around 1700, as homophones like *meat* and *meet* show (Wells 1982: 141–142, 192–196).

As for eighteenth-century /o:/, i.e. traditional "long o", it is important to note that Wells' (1982) GOAT and FORCE sets both historically contained this vowel and were thus often regarded as the same category by LModE writers. The GOAT set comprises the following spellings: <o, oCe, oa, oe, ow, ou>, and <o, ou> before <l> in the words such as *no*, *note*, *boat*, *toe*, *know*, *dough*, *roll* and *soul*. Similar to the examples *gaol* and *gauge*, there are some exceptions in the GOAT set, e.g. *brooch*, *beau*, *gauche*, *yeoman*, and *sew*. Affected pre-/r/ spellings are <or, ore, oar, oor> and <our>, which can be found in words like *sport*, *fore*, *coarse*, *door*, and *four* (see Wells 1982: 146–147, 160–162). Furthermore, the vowel in GOAT words has two different sources, namely late ME /ɔ:/ and /ɔu/. The former was used in words like *no*, while the latter occurred in <ow, ou, ol(C), oul> spellings in words like *know*, *toll* and *shoulder*. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries /ɔu/ then monophthongised and merged with /ɔ:/ and became /o:/, again as part of the *Long Mid Merger* (Lass 1999: 93). In fact, the same development can be observed in diphthongs in words like *daze* and *days* respectively. Both merged and later raised to /e:/ and were part of the *Long Mid Merger*. This merger results in the nineteenth-century starting values of /e:/ and /o:/. In twentieth-century dialects of England, there was still considerable variation, with some monophthongal and some diphthongal realisations in the FACE and GOAT sets, including the tra-

²In twenty-first-century Standard Southern British pronunciation, the centring element is increasingly dropped, which leads to long monophthongs like /ɛ:/ with no traces of historical /r/ (see Lindsey 2019: 48–49).

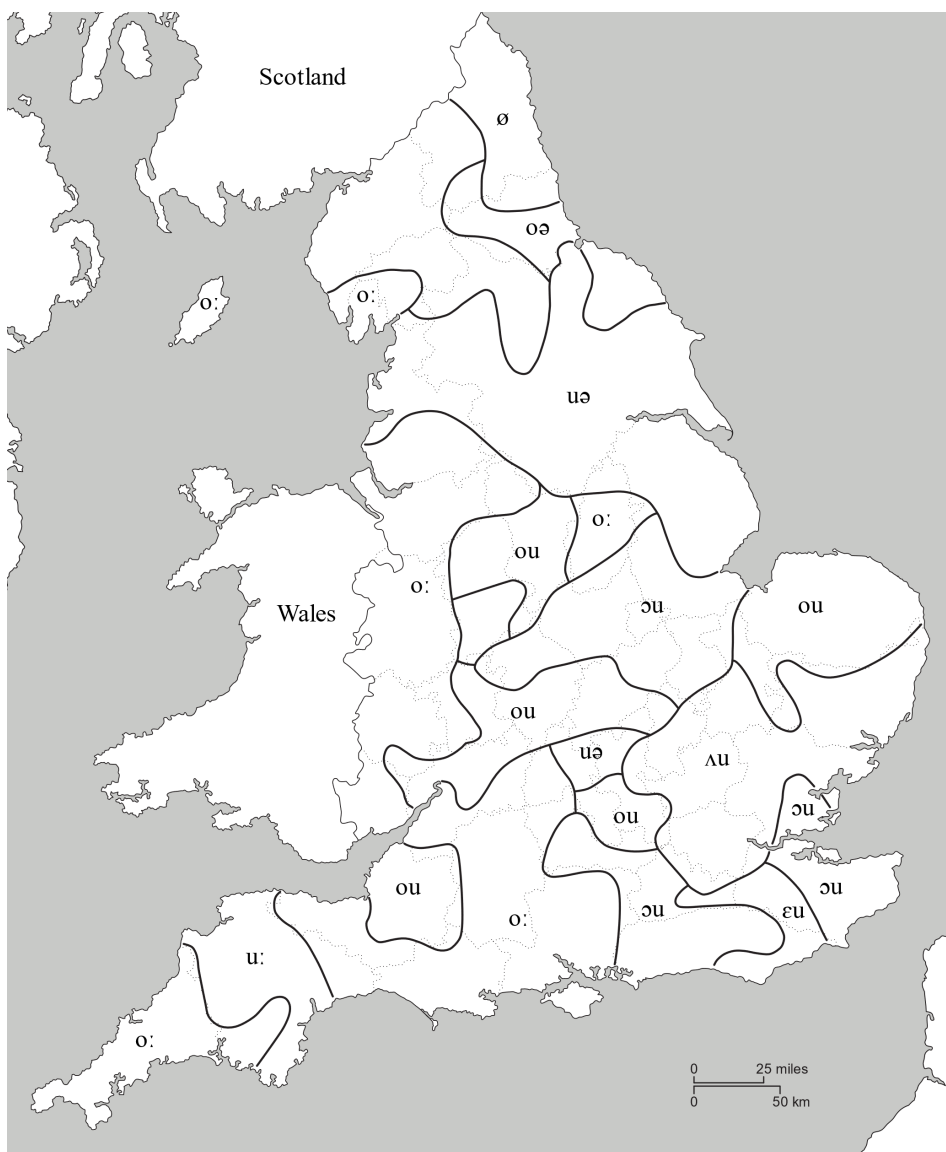


Figure 5.2: Map showing the distribution of vowel realisations in the word *loaf* in twentieth-century dialects in England, recreated based on Orton et al. (1978)

5.1 FACE and GOAT: Historical background

The ME distinctions between *daze* and *days* and *no* and *know* were maintained in many nineteenth-century accents (Trudgill 2004: 55). Furthermore, while recessive, they are still present in some regional varieties of English today, e.g. East Anglia (see Trudgill 2021: 70–71, 75–77). These historical retentions are important for the present study as the spelling and phonological environment of example words may reveal whether grammarians prescribe an older distinction between monophthongs and diphthongs or if they are indeed witnesses of *Long Mid Diphthonging* in progress.

Yáñez-Bouza (2016b) shows that 98% of GOAT words and 97% of FACE words are given monophthongs by eighteenth-century dictionary authors in the ECEP; hence resembling the outcome of the *Long Mid Merger*. Using the ECEP, Maguire (2020b: 582–583) finds that some eighteenth-century dictionary authors still discuss diphthongal variants like [aʊ ~ ɒʊ ~ ɔʊ] in ME /ɔu/ words like *mould* and *old*. Yet, as a whole monophthongs of the quality [e:] and [o:] are the prescribed standard variants in FACE, SQUARE, GOAT, and FORCE words in the ECEP.

In order to be able to consider the potential influence of pre-merger values in the nineteenth century, I follow the conventions adopted in the ECEP. I use different subsets of the FACE and GOAT sets based on historical origins and corresponding to further categorisations Wells (1982) makes for these lexical sets. FACE_a is used for spellings originating from ME /a:/, FACE_b for those going back to ME /ɛi ~ æi ~ ai/ and FACE_c in case of <ea> spellings like *break*. For GOAT words a similar distinction is applied. Those historically related to ME /ɔu/ are referred to as the GOAT_b subset and all other contexts as GOAT_a. These lexical subsets, their spellings, example words, their ME origin as well as the processes *Long Mid Merger* and *Long Mid Diphthonging* are summarised in Figure 5.3.

set	spelling	examples	origin	1700	1900
FACE_a	<a, aCe>	<i>mate, daze</i>	ME /a:/	} /e:/ >	RP & AmE /et/
FACE_b	<ai, ay, ei, ey>	<i>wait, days</i>	ME /ai/		
FACE_c	<ea>	<i>break, great</i>	ME /ɛ:/		
GOAT_a	<o, oCe, oa>	<i>no, note, boat</i>	ME /ɔ:/	} /o:/ >	Long Mid Merger
GOAT_b	<ow, ou, ol(C), oul>	<i>know, toll</i>	ME /ɔu/		Long Mid Diphthonging

Figure 5.3: Long Mid Merger and Long Mid Diphthonging summarised

Regarding the vowel used in the FACE set, MacMahon (1998: 450) gives as the first possible source of diphthongisation Wallis' (1653) *Grammatica Linguae Anglicanae* from 1653. This suggestion is based on Zettersten (1974)'s interpretation

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of Gildon & Brightland (1711). However, the quotation from Wallis (1653) that MacMahon (1998: 450) discusses only contains the digraphs <ai, ay, ei, ey> and could either indicate an argument based simply on spelling or a description of the FACE_b set, whose ME diphthongal variants have been maintained even to the present day in some areas, as mentioned above. Since Beal (2004b: 137) voices a similar suspicion about MacMahon's interpretation, I decided to revisit the Latin original from Wallis, which reads:

Diphthongi, quæ vocantur, *ai, ei, oi, au, eu, ou*, vel, *ay, ey, oy, aw, ew, ow*, recte pronunciata, componuntur ex Vocalibus Præpositivis, & Consonantibus *y* & *w*, quæ tamen pro Vocalibus Subjunctivis vulgo habentur. (Wallis 1653: 11)

'The diphthongs, which are called *ai, ei, oi, au, eu, ou*, or, *ay, ey, oy, aw, ew, ow*, rightly pronounced, are composed of the preceding vowels and the consonants *y* & *w*, which are indeed generally regarded as subjunctive vowels.' (my translation)

This passage does indeed suggest diphthongal values but only for digraphs with ME diphthongs. With respect to the graphemes <ea, oa, ee, oo>, Wallis (1653: 12) furthermore notes the following: "quanquam duplicibus characteribus scribantur, sunt tamen (saltem prout nunc dierum pronunciari solent) soni simplices"; 'despite the fact that they are written as double characters, they are in fact (at least as they are nowadays commonly pronounced) simple sounds' (my translation). He therefore also seems generally aware of the difference between digraphs and diphthongs. Thus, I argue that this passage is neither evidence of early *Long Mid Diphthonging* nor of an argument based on spelling, but potentially of a historical retention of earlier ME diphthongal values in Wallis' perceived standard, as has also been suggested by Beal (2004b: 137) for Gildon & Brightland (1711). Yet, the parenthesis "recte pronunciata" indicates variation, perhaps between older diphthongal variants and post-merger monophthongs (see Figure 5.3). This is equally noted by MacMahon (1998: 450).

In terms of late eighteenth-century descriptions of the developments of the vowels in these sets, Walker (1791: 10) calls the vowel in FACE words "long slender *a*". For him, this sound is the long equivalent to the vowel in words like *met*, i.e. the DRESS set. He furthermore seems to suggest that the vowel is "perhaps, somewhat longer" (Walker 1791: 10) in words like *haste* if compared with *hate* or *change*. Walker also lists SQUARE words like *bear* and *where* and the example *gaol* as having this sound. As for the quality, he says that "it exactly corresponds to

the sound of the French *e* in the beginning of the words *être* and *tête*” (Walker 1791: 10). Earlier in his dictionary he gives the French words *fée* and *épée* as examples of the vowel in the English words *fate* and *paper*. In French the former examples would have [ɛ:], whereas the latter have [e:]. Walker’s comments thus appear somewhat contradictory in terms of the quality of the vowel. We must thus assume values around [e: ~ ɛ:] for the FACE set based on Walker. MacMahon (1998: 449–450) states that Walker’s contradicting French examples and his reference to the vowel in *met* suggest a long vowel slightly lower than CV2, i.e. [ɛ:]. The words *gape* and *bade*, according to Walker (1791: 10), however, do not have this sound.

Most sources before the nineteenth century suggest a monophthongal realisation for FACE words, and in the description of this sound, similarities to other languages like French, German and Italian are frequently evoked (MacMahon 1998: 449). Jones (2006: 303) suggests that a passage in Walker’s second edition (1797) could be evidence for diphthongs in <eigh> spellings as in *eight* and *weight*. Jones (2006: 303) notes that this would be lexically restricted to pre-<gh> spellings and, most importantly, could again simply constitute a case of diphthong retention. I have not been able to find the comment mentioned by Jones in Walker’s second (1797) or third edition (1798) for that matter, but in his fourth London edition (Walker 1806: 47). However, in Walker’s first edition he already points out a potential homophony between *height* and *eight* and *weight* (Walker 1791), indicating a diphthongal quality but an overlap with words from the PRICE set.

Ranson (2012: 19) points out Walker’s (1791: 30) comments on the pronunciation of words like *great* as *greet*, which he observes in “people of education, and almost universally in Ireland”. This realisation he calls “affected pronunciation” and “contrary to the fixed and settled practice in England” and notices the same vowel, likely a high monophthong, in the word *break*.

In Murray (1795: 6), all FACE subsets as well as pre-/r/-environments as in words like *bear* are pronounced with his “long and slender *a*”. This is a term that we can also find in Walker (see the discussion above) and which has been interpreted in the ECEP as [e:]. Murray (1797: 10) still maintains this opinion in his third edition, which had substantially been changed in other areas compared to the first edition (see for instance Chapter 11). In both editions, he lists a few exceptions to <ai> spellings like *Britain* or *fountain*, which of course are unstressed syllables and would be reduced to schwa in present-day varieties. Only two of his exceptions should concern us here, namely *again* and *raillery*. As for the first one, this simply suggests that <ai> here, as in the majority of present-day varieties, is a vowel different to that in the FACE set. What is more, the word *raillery* would be expected to belong to his class of “long or slender *a*”. As he gives no

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explanation as to why these words are exceptions, this list does not reveal any information on the quality of the vowel. However, in the early twentieth century, Krapp (1919: 66) still notes that “for *raillery* both [ˈre:ləri] and [ˈræləri] are heard, with academic authority in favor of the former” (my emphasis). Thus, we could explain Murray’s exception as belonging to his “short or open A” in this example (Murray 1795: 4–5).

Webster (1790: 11) shows in his spelling book that he understands the term “diphthong” in a similar way to how we would use it nowadays as he writes:

Whenever a sound can be begun and completed with the same position of the organs, it is a simple sound. A diphthong is a union of two simple sounds, pronounced at one breath. To form a diphthong [sic!] there are necessarily required two different positions of the organs of speech.

This is important to note because many LModE grammarians often apply the term “diphthong” to what would properly be regarded as a digraph containing two vowel graphemes, as previously noted. From his description of the letters <y, i>, and <u>, it becomes apparent that Webster regards *die* and *defy* as containing diphthongs, but not the <i> in *fight*, which would equally be realised as a diphthong “if it were not prevented by the following consonant” (Webster 1790: 12). From this passage, however, it remains unclear what the realisation of the vowel in *fight* is supposed to be. As was common in LModE sources, he further regards initial YOD-environments as containing an [i]-like vowel and thus considers the initial sound of words like *union* a diphthong. For him, the sound in *late* is a “long simple sound”, the short equivalent of which is the vowel in *let* (Webster 1790: 13). At least for <a> spellings, the pronunciation is clearly a monophthong, potentially with a quality of [e: ~ ε:]. As concerns his diphthong system, he suggests that “oi, oy, ou and ow, are diphthongs [sic!]” (Webster 1790: 14). It appears that the only diphthongs he suggests are in the PRICE (except pre-<ght> environments), CHOICE, MOUTH sets, as well as <y> plus high back vowels. Unfortunately, after his description of <oi, oy, ou>, and <ow> he adds, quite unsatisfactorily from a historical phonologist’s perspective, the following statement: “the other diphthongs [sic!] in the language are attended with no difficulty, as a just pronunciation of them naturally results from the customary sounds of the letters that compose them”. This conforms with the assumption that it is not until the nineteenth century that diphthongal forms start to be noticed and accurately described. I think, however, that we should be cautious not to categorically exclude the possibility of diphthongal forms before that time as their use might

have been below the level of speakers' conscious awareness. We should also generally consider a potential time lag between first emergence and first description. According to Beal (2004b: 137), it is Batchelor (1809) who is usually given as the earliest observer providing reliable evidence of diphthongs in the FACE set as for instance by Jones (1989), Chomsky & Halle (1968), and, the examples Wallis (1653) and Gildon & Brightland (1711) aside, MacMahon (1998).

MacMahon (1998: 450) shows that Batchelor's transcriptions of the words *bail* and *wade*, i.e. "beyl" and "weyd", and his comments concerning the simplicity of long vowels, indicate diphthongs (Batchelor 1809: 53–54). However, Batchelor himself notes that these diphthongal values may be beyond speakers' and grammarians' awareness: "[t]he motions of the tongue can neither be seen nor felt, in some cases, without more attention than grammarians generally think proper to devote to that purpose" (Batchelor 1809: 53 cited in MacMahon 1998: 450). Based on Beal (2004b: 137), further evidence for diphthongs comes from British sources like Smart (1836), Sweet (1877), and American works like Rush (1827) and Whitney (1874). To this we can add Ellis' (1869a, 1869b, 1871, 1874, 1889) very comprehensive multi-volume treatment of English pronunciation. Jones (2006: 306) shows that Ellis was also noticing a change in progress towards diphthongal variants in southern British speech, potentially led by the lower classes:

[a]t the present moment the (*ee*, *oo*) of the South of England are actually changing into (*ei*, *ou*), and these sounds have been developed by the less educated, and therefore more advanced speakers, the more educated and therefore less advanced having only reached (*eei*, *oou*) although many of them are not conscious of saying anything by (*ee*, *oo*). (Ellis 1869a: 294)

Ellis (1874: 1111) claims that in his own usage the only contexts where he may use a diphthong are before pauses, and before [t, d] and [n]. Except the word *plate*, all example words he gives for his own potential use of diphthongs are <ay, ai> or <eigh> spellings and thus mostly belong to the FACE_b subset. According to Ellis (1874: 1109), the renowned lexicographer James Murray (and chief editor of the OED) contends that Ellis himself uses diphthongal pronunciations in *name*, *aid*, *age*, *always*, *praise*, *gates*, *take*, and *make*. Yet, Ellis (1874: 1111) claims that "[s]o far as I have yet observed, my usage is much the same as that of other educated speakers, from whom I rarely hear anything like real (*éei*)". Ellis notes that full diphthongs, i.e. (*eei*) in his notation, are used in London. Only some speakers use a full vowel and solely do so in pre-pausal contexts (Jones 2006: 306). Jones hypothesises that Ellis was unwilling to acknowledge the widespread use of diphthongs due to his perception of increasing use of diphthongal variants as

a change led by “less educated” speakers. Whether this is plausible can certainly be questioned since elsewhere when Ellis discusses social variation, he does seem to be very accurate and objective. Furthermore, of course, when it comes to his own pronunciation, it is unlikely that his descriptions are entirely free of bias.

By the time of D. Jones, the vowel in FACE is clearly regarded as diphthongal with qualities like [ɛi ~ ɛə]. Opener onsets below CV3 also exist, but are regarded as typical of London or the East Counties (see Jones 1928: xxii, 1964 [1918]: 100–101). Krapp (1919: 66–67), nonetheless, seems to still describe monophthongs for AmE standard phonology, in which clear diphthongs are variant realisations that are favoured in monosyllabic words, open syllables, e.g. in *day*, or checked syllables with voiced codas as in *raid*, *phase*, or *wave*. However, generally this variation appears to bear little importance to him as he implies that not many speakers use diphthongs and that the differences between monophthongal and diphthongal variants are hard to recognise:

But with many speakers the diphthongal quality, if present at all, is so slight as not to be appreciated by the ear. For such speakers the sound is to be recorded simply as [e:]. No questions of propriety in usage are raised by the variation between [e:] and [eɪ], the difference being so slight that it does not attract attention to itself. (Krapp 1919: 67)

With respect to the pronunciations of GOAT words, we can observe that Walker (1791: 21, 34–38) describes this sound as the “long open sound” of the letter *O*, which occurs in words such as *no*, *goat*, *toe*, *door*, *though*, *know*. He therefore proposes a monophthong, i.e. [o:], and still includes the FORCE set. Beal (2004b: 138) points out that his use of the word “open” is characterised by relative openness in contrast to Walker’s (1791) “slender o”, i.e. [u:]. Moreover, the sound in words like *coat* and *crow* are labelled “improper diphthong” by Walker (1791: 26). Murray (1795: 4) similarly contends that “[a]n improper diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded; as, *ea* in *eagle*, *oa* in *boat*”. Again, it is important to bear in mind that what is commonly referred to in these sources as “improper diphthong” is a monophthong with two vowel letters. In Webster (1790: 13), the word *note* is described as containing “long o” and is not listed under those vowels he considers diphthongs.

MacMahon (1998: 459) names the Scottish scholar William Smith (1795) as the first author to explicitly mention diphthongal GOAT realisations. Smart (1836: v) remarks that in London the sound of “ō” (long o) is “not always quite simple, but is apt to contract toward the end, finishing almost as oo in *too*” and thus records diphthongal variants in London speech. Mostly similar to Walker (1791),

in Worcester (1859: 14–16) we find [o:] still described as the traditional “long o” in a variety of different spellings comprising GOAT and FORCE words like *no*, *goat*, *door*, *court*, *though*, and *know*. In contrast to Walker (1791), he does not list any <oe> spellings. MacMahon (1998: 411–412) points out that Ellis (1869b: 602) noticed a difference in some speakers between *no* and *know*, with the former containing monophthongal forms and the latter having diphthongal realisations. Furthermore, Ellis observes in his own phonology that <ow> spellings like in *know* regularly have a diphthong, and that for <o> spellings in unchecked syllables like *no*, he often uses diphthongs (Ellis 1874: 1152). The quality of these diphthongs is [o:] plus what he calls “a labial modification” of [w] (Ellis 1869a: 9).³ What Ellis describes here could represent the history of the vowels in <o> and <ow> spellings in the GOAT_a and GOAT_b sets (MacMahon 1998: 412). However, Ellis (1874: 1152) states that the vowel is most likely to diphthongise before a pause, and before /p/ and /k/ and least likely preceding the alveolar plosives /t/ and /d/. As regards diphthongal pronunciations of the word *boat*, Ellis (1874: 1152) claims that [ou] “is not only strange to me but disagreeable to my ear and troublesome for my tongue” and adds that even a diphthong of the quality [o:w] in *boat*, i.e. one with a longer onset, “sounds strange”. He further argues that a consistent use of diphthongal forms in the FACE and GOAT sets “as the only received pronunciation thoroughly disagrees with my own observations” (see also MacMahon’s 1998: 411–412, 459–461 discussion of Ellis’ comments on /ou/). In contrast to the vowel /ei/ in FACE words, Jones (1964 [1918]: 103) notes that “[t]he English vowel o occasionally appears without a following u, but only in unstressed syllables and before another vowel” as in words like *obey* or *November*. Moreover, he notices that many speakers do not seem aware of the diphthongal quality in open syllables like *so* and *home* (see Jones 1964 [1918]: 102). For Krapp (1919: 37), the vowel in GOAT has a long monophthong before voiceless consonants such as *note* and *boat*, but diphthongal variants with the value [ou] before voiced consonants and in open syllables as in *road*, *toe*, *know*, *though* and others. He does, however, add that the latter environments and words like *oath* “are often pronounced simply with [o:]” (Krapp 1919: 94). Before consonants, the diphthongal quality is described as “less marked”, while Krapp (1919: 73, 81) also notes that “a slight glide [ə] [...] is sometimes present” in words like *stole*. FORCE words have a number of possible realisations for Krapp (1919: 85, 88), namely [ɔ:], [ɔ̃], [ɔ:ə], [ɔ̃ə], [o:], [õ], and [o]. The more raised variants, nevertheless, are identified as older and as restricted to <or> spellings.

³I have translated Ellis’ transcription system into modern IPA here. For an overview of the symbols he uses throughout his work, see Ellis (1869a: 3–13).

In addition to the questions and aims outlined in Section 2.4, I am particularly interested in how frequent descriptions of diphthongs are, when comments on diphthongal realisations first appear, and if there is a difference between FACE and GOAT in the time of first description. In terms of lexical diffusion and the development of the phonology as a whole, questions concerning the categorisation of pre-/r/ environments and potential evidence for a historical retention between subsets are highly relevant. Finally, given comments by Ellis (1869a), Batchelor (1809), Jones (1964 [1918]) and Krapp (1919) on the unrecognisability and quality of diphthongs, we might hypothesise either fewer descriptions of this vowel change or at least less stigmatisation. Similarly their comments suggest phonetic diphthongs had been in use but that they had not reached phonemic status yet; hence a long monophthong constituted the underlying form, with some diphthongs on the realisational level.⁴

5.2 FACE in the CNG: overview

Concerning comments on FACE words in the CNG, in total there are 80 grammars (48% of grammars that treat pronunciation) that at least allow for determining if the sound is regarded as a monophthong or diphthong by grammarians. 20 of these grammars provide evidence for diphthongs, albeit in varying degrees of detail (13 British-Irish and 7 North American). The remaining 60 grammars suggest only monophthongs (30 British-Irish and 30 North American). Regarding the regional distribution, in relative terms fewer British-Irish grammars provide information on the extent to which FACE words have a monophthong or diphthong (43% vs 56%). In both absolute and relative terms, British-Irish grammars contain evidence for diphthongs more frequently. The distribution of variants is illustrated in Table 5.1 and in the corresponding spineplot (Figure 5.4). In the spineplot, N stands for the total number of grammars that treat pronunciation. The x-axis of the plot shows the absolute number of grammars that contain comments on pronunciation based on the region they are from. The bar for British-Irish grammars is wider as they constitute 100 of 166 grammars; thus the bar for North American grammars is narrower as it covers the remaining 66. The y-axis illustrates the percentage of FACE variants mentioned in relation to N. The lightest shade of grey indicates grammars without sufficient information to deduce any distribution or quality. The medium grey shade represents monophthongs.

⁴I thank Raymond Hickey for his input on the phoneme status of diphthongs in FACE and GOAT words in LModE sources.

The darkest shade of grey refers to diphthongs and others, which covers grammars that mention diphthongs only, monophthongs and diphthongs, or use other terms like “triphthong” to refer to the vowel in question. Similar plots are used for giving an overview on the distribution of variants in the other analysis chapters of this book.

Table 5.1: Quantitative distribution of FACE variants in the CNG

	British-Irish	North American	all
pronunciation treated	100	66	166
FACE (and SQUARE) total	43 (43% of 100)	37 (56% of 66)	80 (48% of 166)
monophthongs	30 (30% of 100)	30 (45% of 66)	60 (36% of 166)
diphthongs or both	13 (13% of 100)	7 (11% of 66)	20 (12% of 166)
insufficient information	57	29	86

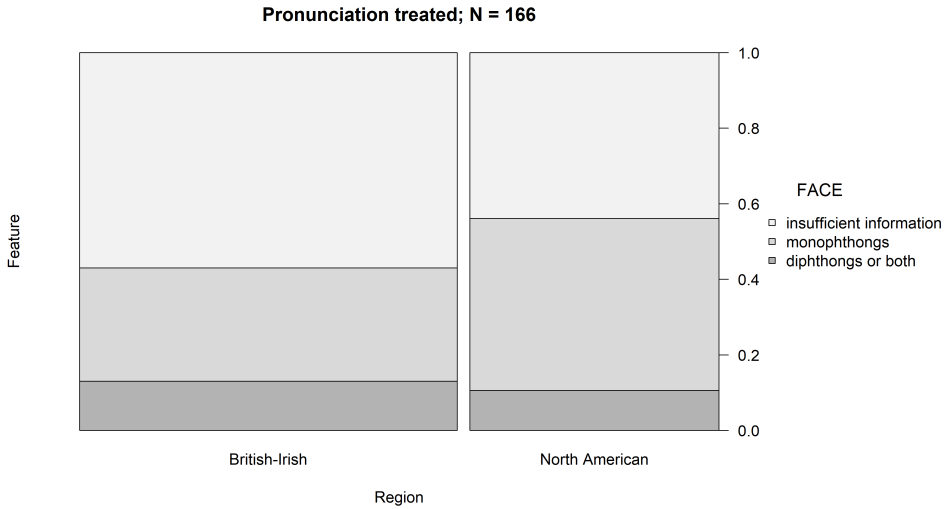


Figure 5.4: Evidence of FACE variants in the CNG

While some grammars provide extensive lists of examples, especially those that solely mention monophthongs, this is unfortunately not always the case and often we have to content ourselves with few example words. In addition, those grammars subsumed under monophthongs contain works that do not sufficiently discuss realisations of FACE but simply give a list of English diphthongs

which lacks any FACE words. This constitutes implicit evidence of monophthongal realisations. The earliest British-Irish grammar that mentions diphthongs in any of the FACE subsets is Andrew (1817), whereas the first North American grammar comes from Morgan (1814). None of the grammars that offer information on diphthongal variants were published in Scotland, Ireland or Canada.

Of the grammars suggesting monophthongs, one was published in Toronto, namely Davies (1869), and identifies the vowel as a “pure vowel”, i.e. monophthong. Sullivan (1855: 23) is the only grammar that was published in Ireland (and England and Scotland) and offers evidence for FACE, although implicitly. The only “proper diphthongs” he identifies are “*eu, oi, ou*; as in *feud, boil, found*”. There are two more grammars that were published in Scotland and suggest monophthongs, namely Connell (1843) and Macintosh (1852). Besides these four grammars, all grammars discussed with respect to the vowel in FACE were published either in Great Britain or the US.

As concerns pre-/r/ environments, 30 grammars offer insights into the extent to which SQUARE words were still regarded as the same category as FACE. Indeed, only 11 grammarians consider SQUARE to be a different category, while four others note variation; hence 15 grammars (5 British-Irish and 10 North American) provide evidence for a phoneme-split between the vowels FACE and SQUARE. Two of these are from the first half of the nineteenth century, the earliest being Webber (1832). The rest are from the second half of the nineteenth century and in fact mostly from the late 1860s and later. In Webber (1832: 8, 10), SQUARE words like *bear* and *there* belong into the same category as TRAP words, probably due to the higher position of the vowel in the TRAP set (see Purnell et al. 2017; Hickey 2017c). Another option would be lowering of the vowel before /r/. There are two grammarians who provide diphthongs in SQUARE words, namely Alexander (1835: 18) and King (1854: 3). Their comments could indicate weakening of /r/ and thus centring diphthongs or pre-/r/ breaking. In Alexander’s grammar the words *fair*, *heir*, and *bay* are “proper” diphthongs. In contrast, King only gives *fair* but no FACE words as examples. Thus, I included Alexander in my analysis but not King. Alexander’s comments are represented in Table 5.2 and Figure 5.4 under “diphthongs or both”. Furthermore, I have not been able to find any comments or patterns in FACE example words that would suggest phonological conditioning before lateral approximants in the grammars of the CNG. There are examples of diphthongs as well as monophthongs before /l/ across and within grammars and no grammar features a dedicated category for pre-lateral realisations.

As the CNG offers a much greater number of monophthongal descriptions, I only give four short examples here to illustrate what passages may look like. What we find in terms of terminology is often (16 grammars) the use of “improper

diphthong” for FACE_b words. Other terms used regardless of spelling are for instance “pure vowel” or “simple vowel”. Three examples of “improper diphthongs” are given in (1)–(3). The only example of an application of the term to the FACE_c subset is shown in (3):

- (1) An improper diphthong is that in which only one of its vowels are sounded; as *ai*, in *aid*; *ea* in *eagle*. (Connell 1843: 4)
- (2) If one of the vowels be silent, the union of the vowels is an improper diphthong, as *ai* in *laid*; the letter *i* in that word merely denoting the long or natural sound of *a*. (Munsell Jr. 1851: 6)
- (3) Two vowels, used together, are called a *Diphthong* or *Digraph* [...] When they express a single vocal sound, they are called an *Improper* Diphthong; as, [...] *ea* in *great*, an *improper* Diphthong. (Cruttenden 1870: 388)

Another interesting case is the following, which exemplifies that references to other languages, as mentioned by MacMahon (1998: 449), occur also in monolingual English grammars designed solely to teach English, as depicted in (4):

- (4) The third sound [sc. of <a> in *fate*] is that of the German *ae*, and is supposed to be the same with the *ae* of the Latins; not a diphthong, but a true vowel. This sound is also marked by *ai*, or *ay*; (Booth 1837: 12)

Booth indicates that the vowel in *fate* is to be realised as [ɛ:], analogous to the German short front vowel [ɛ]. The English vowel is likely long as he states concerning the vowel in *met* and *bed* that it “is merely a shortened enunciation of the vowel *a*, as heard in *bade*, *mate*” (Booth 1837: 43). A similar example is discussed in the section on diphthongs in GOAT below. While these grammars rarely provide much detail, values roughly similar to their sources may be assumed. Nonetheless, as this would be mere speculation, I now turn to evidence for diphthongal variants in the CNG.

5.3 FACE diphthongs

In the following section, I focus on passages that indicate the presence of diphthongs either in prestige speech or in dialects. The quality of the diphthong is discussed whenever the grammars offer sufficient information, which is unfortunately rarely the case. Two grammars, namely Fowler (1855) and Ramsey (1892),

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give clues to dialectal realisations. A summary of grammars that suggest diphthongal values, including example words they employ and their lexical sets, are given in Table 5.2. Asterisks in the table indicate North American grammars, whereas unmarked grammars are British-Irish. Nesfield (1900: 298) and York

Table 5.2: Evidence of FACE diphthongs in the CNG

grammar	spellings	phonological environment	example words	lexical sets
Morgan (1814)*	<ai>	closed	/d/, /l/	<i>laid, quail</i> FACE_b
Andrew (1817)	<ai, ay, ei, ey>	open, closed	/l/, /n/	<i>fail, day, vein, bey</i> FACE_b
Oliver (1825)	<ai, ay, ey>	—	—	FACE_b
Pinnock (1830)	<ai>	closed	/d/	<i>maid</i> FACE_b
Alexander (1835)	<air, ay, ei, ey>	open, closed	/r/	<i>fair, heir, bay, prey, they, embay</i> FACE_b, SQUARE
Cramp (1838)	<ai>	closed	/n/	<i>again, against, pain, gain, main</i> FACE_b
Crane (1843)	<ai>	closed	/d/	<i>paid</i> FACE_b
Frazee (1845)*	<aCe>	closed	/l/, /t/	<i>sale, late</i> FACE_a
Brown (1851)*	<aCe, ay>	open, closed	/l/, /p/	<i>day, ale, shape</i> FACE_a, FACE_b
Bullen & Heycock (1853)	<ay, ey>	open	—	<i>gay, say, honey</i> FACE_b, happy
Fowler (1855)*	<aCe>	closed	/l/	<i>ale</i> FACE_a
York (1862)*	<aCe>	closed	/t/	<i>States, gate, lade</i> FACE_a
Gostwick (1878)	<eigh>	open	—	<i>(weigh)</i> (FACE_b)
Tancock (1878)	<ay>	open	—	<i>day</i> FACE_b

Kelke (1885)	<ay>	open	—	<i>day</i>	FACE_b
Hall & Son- nenschein (1889)	<aCe>	closed	/t/	<i>fate</i>	FACE_a
Ramsey (1892)*	<a, aCe, ai, ey>	open, closed	/n/, /l/, /s/, /k/, (/f, v/)	<i>fane, fain, ale, face, able, bake, pain, they, (alley, valley, pulley), (thief, believe)</i>	FACE_a, FACE_b, happy
Gow (1892)	<ai>	open	—	<i>bait</i>	FACE_b
Nesfield (1900)	<a, ao, au, aCe, ai, ay, ê, ei, ey>	open, closed	/t, d/, /n, m/, /k, g/, /l/	<i>late, vein, they, name, a, fate, pain, great, weigh, stake, fête, gaol, gauge, champagne, campaign, straight, feign, eight, played, obeyed, weighed, trait, halfpenny</i>	FACE_a, FACE_b, FACE_c
Carpenter (1902)*	<ay>	open	—	<i>day</i>	FACE_b

(1862: 213–215) add a number of French words which are excluded from this table. Moreover, Brown (1851) and Gostwick (1878) argue against diphthongs, but therefore their grammars at the same time show awareness and evidence of diphthongisation.

It is important to note that this overview only lists those example words grammarians provide for purposes of their explanation of the sound or which they list in the context of their description. This does not, of course, exclude the pos-

sibility that other spellings and words would have belonged to the category of diphthongs in their proposed system of the English language. And as we shall see, it is only in the later grammars that a categorical shift to diphthongal variants may be assumed based on their comments. Table 5.2 is intended to visualise the evidence from the CNG in a simple fashion to complement the qualitative analysis below. The following part of this section is structured chronologically as there is, at least to some extent, a pattern in those grammars that mention diphthongal values in FACE. As illustrated in Table 5.2, in the first half of the century we find evidence almost exclusively for diphthongs in FACE_b spellings and thus for vowels originating from ME diphthongs. Examples that potentially suggest the twentieth-century situation of RP and AmE, i.e. categorical diphthongs, only really start to occur in the late 1880s. Furthermore, with the exception of Morgan (1814), Cramp (1838), Brown (1851), and to a certain degree we could argue Gostwick (1878), the grammars display no prescriptive or proscriptive comments or value judgments towards FACE variants. Concerning the phonological environment, there is no pattern in the example words given: nine examples of diphthongs are of closed syllables, six are open and five grammars mention words with both open and closed syllables. Occurrences of diphthongs before final /t/ or /d/ are more frequent in the given example words than in the other environments (7 grammars), which would conform to Ellis' observation of his own diphthongs. However, as absolute numbers are generally low, it is certainly debatable if this constitutes a position which might favour diphthongisation. What is safe to say, however, is that the majority of example words are from the FACE_b set and I argue below that this could be an indication of historical retentions.

In total, there are eight grammars that provide some form of evidence for diphthongs in the FACE set before 1850. Except Morgan (1814) and Frazee (1845), these were all published in the British-Irish Isles. However, save Frazee (1845), grammars from the first half of the century provide examples of diphthongal variants in the FACE_b set and may either constitute arguments for a historical retention of an older variant or a categorisation based on spelling. A case of the former can be found in the earliest mention of diphthongal forms in the CNG, namely Morgan (1814: 5), who prescribes diphthongs in the word *laid*. What we find in his grammar is not an example of early *Long Mid Diphthonging*, but an attempt at reintroducing ME diphthongs in the FACE_b set. In fact, he seems to notice the results of ME and EModE sound changes as well as realisational variation, and thus argues against monophthongs: “[a] modern corruption of pronunciation has rendered some of the pure diphthongs impure in some words: as *ai* in *laid*, *ou* in *through*; *oi* in *oil*” (Morgan 1814: 5). This is a clear case of what Curzan (2014) terms restorative prescriptivism as it is based on the reflection of

historical vowel qualities in the spelling. Morgan (1814: 5) continues: “[i]f public speakers and teachers would pay attention to this part of our language, as to be fully sensible of their harmony and elegance, they would all soon be restored”.

In addition, this shows that he suggests some aesthetic superiority of the “original” ME diphthongal values here. Morgan appears to call for a whole-sale top-down restoration reform of historical pronunciations: “[o]ur universities and academies must begin and perfect the reformation, or it will never be done. And *aa* was formerly two syllables, and ought still to be” Morgan (1814: 5).⁵ The use of the term “corrupt” and the reference to purity moreover point to his idea that some previous stage of the language was better than the current state which was allegedly ruined by variation in usage, and therefore shows a social evaluation. We also find the word *quail* under his category of “pure triphthongs”, i.e. those in which all vowels are realised. However, in the rest of his grammar, several FACE_a, FACE_b, and SQUARE words with <e> and <ea> spellings, including *lay*, are identified as “long simple vowels”, i.e. monophthongs. The <ai> sequence in *quail* is also identified as “a long”. It could be the case that he prescribes older forms and still designs the rest of his grammar according to actual usage. Nonetheless, what is more likely, and might be indicated by the make-up of his *Section 2 Of the Sounds of the LETTERS*, is that he copied passages from other grammarians for some (but not all) parts of his grammar and hence contradicts himself.

In Andrew’s (1817: 3–4) overview and descriptions of sounds, the vowels in the words *fail*, *day*, *vein*, and *bey* are listed as “proper diphthongs”. His description furthermore seems to suggest that the words *name* and *fatal* have a “Vowel, or Monophthong”, which is “a letter that makes a full and perfect sound by itself”. Additionally, *gaol* is identified as an “improper diphthong” as is the vowel in *boat* (see below), i.e. also as a monophthong. Oliver (1825: 293, 295–296) describes diphthongs in the FACE_b set, save for, for some reason that he makes not entirely clear, <ei> spellings. He writes: “Ay, like its near relation *ai*, has the quantity of long *a*, incorporated with the sound of *y*”. On <ey> spellings he states: “Ey has two quantities, that of long *a* and that of long *e*, like its kindred diphthong *ei*, but of different prevalence: it has ever a certain liquefied sound of *y* incorporated with *e*”. Apart from <a> and <ai> spellings, all pre-/r/ spellings, i.e. <e> as in *where*, <ea> as in *bear*, <ei> as in *heir* are described as belonging to the same category as FACE_a words like *made* or *lade*. Pinnock (1830: 15, 17) tells his readers

⁵His problems with the pronunciation of <ou> and <oi> concern influence from Norman French on the phonetic realisations of <ou> spellings and the merging of <oi> words with what we could call the PRICE set (Morgan 1814: 22–23).

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that the word *fate* has the “natural or proper sound of A”, which unfortunately he does not elaborate on any further. Nevertheless, what he does reveal is that the vowels in *meat* and *maid* are diphthongs: “[a] proper diphthong is that in which both the vowels are sounded; as *ea* in *meat*, *ai* in *maid*”. Alexander’s (1835: 18) poetic description of “double vowels” or “diphthongs” includes only the FACE_b subset of FACE words:

OF DOUBLE VOWELS, OR DIPHTHONGS.

When of two vowels the compounded sound

Completely in one syllable is found,

Of both partaking, yet distinct from all,

This we a proper double vowel call;

But if the sound of one be heard alone,

’Tis then improperly so called, we own,

Though of the proper it before were one.

Sev’n proper double vowels we allow,

(At th’ end of words place *ay*, *ey*, *oy*, and *ow*)

These are *ai*, *au*, *ee*, *ei*, *oi*, *oo*, and *ou*,

Thus, *fair*, *laud*, *feed*, *heir*, *voice*, *house*, *bay*, and *boy*,

Prey, *they*, *snow*, *know*, *below*, *embay*, *decoy*.

Improper diphthongs ten we have in view;

Aa, *ea*, *eo*, *ei*, *ie*, *oa*, *oe*, *ue*, *ui*, *eu*.

These ev’ry youth may easily discern,

Especially if he’s inclin’d to learn.

They are identified as diphthongs in our sense of the word here. However, the fact that it is only FACE_b spellings we find could also be due to them being digraphs. As a matter of fact, many grammarians, even when they describe “proper diphthongs”, are to a certain degree led by spelling. It appears as if pre-/r/ environments as in *fair* are also considered diphthongs. Here we would historically expect a monophthong plus /r/ and this could refer to pre-/r/-breaking or a centring diphthong resulting from /r/ vocalisation. Alexander’s (1835: 17) description of words like *bate* or *cane* does not give away much about the vowel except that the “a is long”. The term “long sound” in the CNG was in fact applied to sounds

regardless of whether they were diphthongs or monophthongs. Thus, this does not tell us much about the quality of FACE_a words. Nonetheless, the name given to the letter *a* by Alexander (1835: 16) is “ay”, which would indicate a diphthong. The letter *o*, in contrast, is simply called “o”. While this could potentially mark the earliest evidence of diphthongs in the FACE_a subset in the CNG, this has to be taken with a grain of salt. I did not include this as evidence of FACE_a diphthongs in Table 5.2.

Cramp (1838: 10–11) complains about the so called “arbiters of polite pronunciation”, who “appear to delight in unmeaning deviations from correct and well established usage”. The forms which are divergent from what he considers correct are called “anomalies and defects” by him. They are said to “render the acquirement of the English language so difficult”, but are nonetheless “held sacred”. He furthermore criticises that “the most unwarrantable violations in orthography and diction are tolerated because ‘fashion will have it so.’” As an example he states that

[w]e are told *again* and *against* should be pronounced *agen* and *agenst* [...] and many similar alterations are recommended in the works of modern orthoepists. It might be urged, in answer to these innovations, that the diphthongs [sic!] *ai* and *au* are what grammarians call proper diphthongs [sic!], in which both the vowel sounds should be heard, as in *pain*, *gain*, *main*, *laudable*. (Cramp 1838: 10)

From this passage we can draw that <ai> spellings are regarded as diphthongs by Cramp. In the entry for diphthongs in the index of his grammar, he gives the word *pain* under “proper diphthongs”. The passage these lines are quoted from contains important points on his view on pronunciation and language more generally. Concerning the lack of correspondence between sound and spelling, Cramp (1838: 11) proposes, in parts similar to Morgan (1814: 5) mentioned above, that “these improprieties might be obviated, either by new modelling the words, or by restoring the original sound to the letters”. This is partially a case of restorative prescriptivism in the sense that Cramp calls for restoring earlier vowel qualities, or a spelling reform. However, he further accuses “our modern critics” of promoting what they regard as “reputable usage” despite the fact that they are aware of differences between orthography and pronunciation. In consequence, Cramp (1838: 11) states “the orthography and pronunciation of the English language is becoming daily more fluctuating, incongruous and defective”. This passage contains several terms and statements which identify monophthongs as mistakes, e.g. “deviations from correct usage”, “anomalies”, “violations”, or “defects”,

as well as those that are social evaluations, e.g. “arbiters of polite pronunciation”, or “improprieties”.

Crane (1843: 3) provides *paid* as one example in his definition of diphthongs: “[w]hen two vowels are so combined in a sole articulation, that, though forming but one syllable, they may each be heard, they constitute what is called a DIPHTHONG, as, ‘oi’ in *coin*, or ‘ai’ in *paid*”. All the earlier grammars discussed so far are British-Irish grammars. In the first North American grammar to mention FACE diphthongs by Frazee (1845: 10–11, 14–15) generally many vowels seem to have a diphthongal quality. His description of what he considers diphthongs clearly fits a modern understanding of the term: “[t]he diphthongal sounds differ from the vowel sounds, in requiring the position of the organs to be *changed*, but without closing them, during their utterance; by which they are known *not* to be *simple*, but compound sounds”. According to him, the vowels “A, and u, are always diphthongs”. In fact, under the heading “DIPHTHONGAL SOUNDS” he places “[l]ong a, as in *sale*, *late*”. In addition, he provides some vague clues as to the quality of the diphthong: “[t]he first part of the sound of *a* is the nominal sound of this letter, and the last part is the sound of *e*, heard in *me*, and there is the difference of a tone between them, through which the voice rises by a concrete movement”. Frazee (1845) therefore provides the earliest proper piece of evidence of diphthongal variants outside of the FACE_b subset. None of the examples above provide sufficient information to derive the phonetic realisation of the vowel. He also references his contemporary Rush (1827) who, as noted in Section 5.1, provides evidence for *Long Mid Diphthonging*. Frazee (1845: 15) also makes use of Rush’s terminology “radical”, i.e. the onset of the diphthongs, and “vanish” i.e. second element of the diphthong.

Evidence for diphthongs in FACE_a words furthermore comes from the American Brown (1851), although he argues that all words we would categorise as FACE words should be monophthongs, including pre-/r/ environments as in *bear* and *care*. However, Brown also discusses his fellow American Rush (1827): “he [sc. Dr. Rush] begins by confounding all distinction between diphthongs and simple vowels [...]. But in the *a* of *ale*, he hears *ā’-ee* [...] in the *o* of *old*, *ō’-oo*” (Brown 1851: 152). Brown continues by calling Rush’s descriptions “mysteries” and eventually ends his treatment of Rush’s vowel system with a sarcastic comment: “[m]y opinion of this scheme of the alphabet the reader will have anticipated” (Brown 1851: 152). He thus shows a clearly disapproving attitude towards diphthongal variants. Bullen & Heycock (1853: 3) suggest the absence of monophthongs only in the FACE_b subset. They imply [j] in <ai> spellings as in *gay* or *say* and in word-final position for <ey> as in *honey*: “[o]bserve, y is often employed as a consonant,

as when it begins a word or syllable, as yet, yellow, young, or when it ends a syllable or word, preceded by a vowel as gay, say, boy, boyish, royal, honey, & c. In all other situations it is a Vowel, as in pony, holy, & c”.

As noted in Chapter 3 above, Fowler (1855), whose grammar was published in North America, recommends to his students that they consult Rush (1827). Fowler (1855: 145) describes Rush’s classification of sounds and thus a diphthong in the word *ale*. However, he notes directly after presenting Rush’s scheme that “[t]his classification, though distinguished by great analytical ingenuity and talent, is not so well adapted to the purpose of this work as the one adopted”. Indeed, in the remainder of his grammar we can only find “proper diphthongs” or “compound sounds” in words like *fine*, *rude*, *house* and *voice* and therefore in PRICE, YOD + /u/, MOUTH and CHOICE.⁶ SQUARE words in part belong to the same category as FACE words for Fowler (1855: 204–205, 211): words with <a> spellings as in *care*, *dare* are modified by /r/, whereas the word *there* has his long *a*, i.e. the same vowel as in FACE words. He unfortunately does not specify what the modification undergone by these vowels in pre-/r/ environments entails. Nonetheless, at the end of his section on “compound sounds” and after he has recommended Rush’s “admirable work”, Fowler (1855: 152) still adds that Rush “contends that several of the vowels are diphthongal; as, for instance, that *a* in *ale*, which, upon being prolonged, he asserts, resolves itself into the two sounds of *a* and *e*”. It is not clear why he refrains from fully embracing Rush’s classification. One possibility is that he believes that it is too complicated and that a larger number of diphthongs and additional terminology might be overwhelming for readers and students. It is also likely that diphthongs were not fully established yet and that Fowler is cautious to adopt the description. However, comparing this to Brown’s (1851) evaluation of Rush, it is clear that Fowler appears much more open towards this incoming diphthongal variant. Together with Ramsey (1892), Fowler (1855) is also the only grammarian who points to different dialect realisations of FACE words in his chapter “DIALECTS AND PROVINCIALISMS”. While his grammar was published in North America, he sees value in investigating regional dialects to ascertain information about the history of the language as he states:

[a]n examination of the dialects of the English language is indispensable in order to understand its present condition, and also to learn historically how it came to its present condition. [...] we discover many beautiful archaisms [...] These provincial modes of speech [...] have actually preserved for us the

⁶It is very common in the grammars of the CNG to regard the vowel in words like *rude* as a “proper diphthong”.

origin of English phraseology, and enlightened the philologist in his efforts to walk in paths hitherto unexplored. (Fowler 1855: 109)

A statement in his section on American dialects also suggests that he himself was American as he refers to a “distinguished English scholar” who told “the writer that the peculiarities attributed to the people of New England were constantly met with in Suffolk, where he was bred and born” (Fowler 1855: 123). In terms of dialect features, that chapter is rather unsystematic but reveals some interesting points. According to Fowler (1855: 113), the word “day is pronounced *daie*” by Kentish speakers, which could indicate a diphthong in FACE_b words. For Cumberland speakers, he gives “*tak*’ for take” (Fowler 1855: 111), which could imply a short open realisation. This conforms with the SED data, as Orton et al. (1978) observe that *make* and *take* “also still exhibit traces of historical Northern forms, but both have characteristic short vowels in the upper half of the country, namely /a/ and /ɛ/”. This realisation, however, seems exclusive to the two lexemes in his transcription of the Cumberland dialect, namely *take* and, interestingly, *away*. Cooper (2020: 137) calls this variant “short FACE”, and shows that it was likely enregistered as a Yorkshire feature in the nineteenth century. He finds it for all dialects areas in Yorkshire that he investigated. Gardner (2023: 506, 510) also finds monophthongised FACE words in pauper petitions from Dorset, represented by <e>, <ea>, or <a> in words like *labour*, *trade*, and *they*, thus also suggesting values like [ɛ] or [a] even in open syllables like *they*.

York (1862: 66–68, 70), another one of the North American grammars, follows Comstock’s scheme and identifies the vowel in *States* and *gate* as diphthong or triphthong. Similar to Rush, Andrew Comstock, who is referenced here by York, was an American physician and elocutionist. Comstock in fact bases some of his principles on Rush; hence he employs some of the same examples, e.g. *ale*, and terminology, namely the use of “radical” and “vanish” for the first and second elements of diphthongs (see for instance Comstock 1830: xiii–xix). York himself does not provide much additional information to this classification. Yet, while he does not indicate which of Comstock’s works he consulted, York follows him closely in terminology and argument. A closer look at Comstock’s work however helps to understand York’s comments. Comstock (1843: 19–23) notes a diphthong in the word *ale*, *day* and *fate*, which “has a characteristic sound for its radical”, i.e. onset of the diphthong. The “vanish”, i.e. the offset of the diphthong, is the vowel also found in words like *in* and *pin*. He further remarks that “[t]hese diphthongs, under certain circumstances (for instance, when they are carried through a wide range of pitch, as in interrogation with surprise), are converted into triphthongs” (Comstock 1843: 19–23). The third sound in this “triphthong” is the one Comstock

lists for words *eve*, *see*, and *deed*, and so we could assume, is potentially a more tense vowel.

Gostwick (1878: 19) provides only little evidence for diphthongs except that, after identifying the vowels in the words *eye*, *boy*, *ewe*, and *house* as the only “proper diphthongs”, he claims: “[t]here are no diphthongs in the words *pair*, *fear*, *weigh*, *sew*, *glow*. There are no *triphthongs* in English”. The fact that he feels the need to mention this could be interpreted as a sign for diphthongs in some speakers – in the case of the first two words potentially through /r/-loss or pre-/r/-breaking. However, he does not comment on this any further and clearly favours monophthongs. Tancock (1878) and Kelke (1885) both seem to suggest some kind of glide in FACE_b words with <ay> spellings based on the word *day*. Both seem to evoke an argument grounded in its OE counterpart *dæg*. Tancock (1878: 34) identifies the vowel in *day* as an “improper diphthong”, which usually indicates a monophthong. He also writes the following about the letter *W*:

[i]t is never really a vowel, but in such words as *draw* is like *y* in *day*, little more than a breathing, a slight remnant of a guttural or hard consonant, which was at one time distinctly pronounced. This may be seen by comparison of the forms *draw*, *drag*; *day*, *daeg*.

What Tancock (1878: 34–35) seems to suggest here in the case of the word *day* is that it has some form of palatalised consonant which used to be “a guttural or hard consonant”, i.e. either [k] or [g] following his classifications. His comment on the “aspirated guttural sound” being “the old sound of GH, as in *lough*” implies that dorsal fricatives (likely [x ~ χ] given the vowel in his example) are covered by his term “guttural” as well. It is generally agreed upon that already in the OE singular stem *dæg*- ‘day’, the final consonant was palatalised and realised as [j], whereas the final consonant in the plural stem *dag*- was fully realised as voiced velar plosive.⁷ Thus, while not a “proper diphthong” for Tancock, this could suggest realisations like [ej ~ eʲ] for *day*. Similarly, Kelke (1885: 30) first claims: “[c]ombinations of signs which appear to the eye alone as double sounds are called False diphthongs; as in *meat*, *broad*, *hail*, *sieve*”. Nonetheless, he writes about glides that “[c]ertain consonants are so termed when final and almost imperceptible. The chief English Glides are *r*, *h*, *w*, *y*; as in [...] *day* for O.E. *dag*” (Kelke 1885: 37). Again, as with many instances from the first half of the century given above, this is only an example of a small subset of FACE words.

⁷In modern editions of OE manuscripts this is often indicated by inserting diacritics above <g>. Thus [j] is usually represented as <ġ>, while [g] stays <g> (for a discussion about why cases like OE *dæg* are regarded as vowel + glide rather than a diphthong see Hogg 1992a: 289–290).

5 Long Mid Diphthonging

In terms of descriptions that illustrate a wholesale shift to diphthongal variants across all FACE subsets, the first example is the grammar by Hall & Sonnenschein (1889: 214, 216). While their category “Diphthongs” does not comprise any FACE words, they append a footnote to the “simple vowel sounds” in the words *fate*, *pain*, *pay*, *great*, *vein* and *prey*, which reads: “[l]ong Vowels in Mod. Engl. are rarely pure (i.e. uniform) vowel sounds, but have mostly become diphthongal in character: [...] Thus the *a* in ‘fate’ ends with a faint *ee* [i] sound; the *o* of ‘no’ ends in faint *oo* [u] sound”. That the final sound is described as faint could indicate a more lax vowel such as [ɪ] or potentially a glide [j]. Gow (1892: 11, 13) does not include the vowel in question under diphthongs either but simply under long vowels. He too notes that “[l]ong vowels, in ordinary English pronunciation, are seldom quite pure: e.g. people say *bai-it* for *bait*, *boa-wt* for *boat*, *fau-wl* for *fall*, thus adding a slight diphthong, or glide, at the end of the long vowel”. Similar to Hall and Sonnenschein, this implies a lax vowel, an approximant [j], or potentially a short realisation relative to the first element of the vowel.

Ramsey (1892: 144) employs the notation “(ai)” for the vowel in *fain* and *fane*, thus suggesting a diphthong. Although this looks at first sight like modern IPA /ai/, his notation for PRICE words is “ii” or “ī”. As the term “long a” is common in nineteenth-century sources for the vowel in FACE words, it is perhaps not surprising that we find the notation (ai) in Ramsey. His notation “(ai)” is, together with the vowel also found in *meet* and *receive*, one variant used in final <ey> spellings: “[a]s a termination *ey* is equivalent to *y* and fluctuates between (ai) and (ee), as in *alley*, *valley*, *pulley*” (Ramsey 1892: 158). However, as he does not explain his notational system any further and since it is not his goal to provide a phonetically precise description, the exact quality is impossible to determine. For the vowel in SQUARE words as in *care*, *fair*, *there* he uses the notation “(ae)”. This notational difference is the result of the following /r/ as he explicitly comments on later in his grammar: “[a]s *r* is so nearly allied to the vowels, it has generally the effect of prolonging or modifying a preceding vowel, which will be perceived by comparing [...] *fane* [with] *fare*” (Ramsey 1892: 169). His description of the development from ME /a:/, which equals his realisation of *arm* as “(aa)”, to the value it has in his day shows that he has a correct understanding of the timeline of the Great Vowel Shift (GVS):

[o]ne of the greatest changes has been the extensive reduction of *a* from (aa) to (ai), begun about the close of the sixteenth century, and brought to nearly its present point in the eighteenth century [...]. In the middle of the sixteenth century *ale* was pronounced (aal), *face* (faas), *able* (aab'l), *bake* (baak); and we see what they have come to now (Ramsey 1892: 149–150).

The issue with this is that Ramsey unfortunately does not properly illustrate “what they have come to now”. This is presumably because he assumes it to be evident to his readers. As noted in Chapter 3, he points out that his classification is “but a rough scale of sounds easily distinguished” (Ramsey 1892: 145) and refers his readers to Ellis for further reading on the subject. This shows that Ramsey does not appear to have aspirations for giving a more detailed account of sounds. Discussing the history of <ei> spellings he states: “[t]he sound then began to pass into (ae’ee), somewhat as we should pronounce *they*, in attempting to give each vowel distinctly” (Ramsey 1892: 156). This transcription might thus suggest that the onset of the diphthong in *they* is to be pronounced differently to that *fain* and *fane*. However, he does not elaborate on this any further and it is impossible to tell from his grammar why this should be the case in *they*. Finally, Ramsey (1892) is, in addition to Fowler (1855) discussed above, the only grammarian that reveals some information on dialectal variation of some FACE words. What he notices is an Irish English feature that Kallen (2013: 63) refers to as “one of the most salient features of traditional dialect”, namely the use of /e:/ in words like *meat*, which have in most other varieties merged with the FLEECE set and are realised as /i:/: “whoever listens to an intelligent Irishman fresh from the sod may haply hear some of the following illustrations of the Elizabethan era: preach Irish praich, receive Irish resaiv, mean Irish main, supreme Irish shupraim” (Ramsey 1892: 155). While the realisation is unclear in Ramsey, he describes the feature by using his (ai)-notation. Depending on how we approach his work, this could of course also be evidence of “(ai)” referring to monophthongs [e: ~ ε:].

Interestingly, he also notes the reverse phenomenon, whereby the post-merger vowel in the FLEECE set /i:/ is used in FACE and SQUARE words: “[a] chair was commonly pronounced *cheer*; a steak, *steek*; great, *greet*; and oblige, *obleej*; some of which may perhaps still be heard from old persons”. It is not clear, nonetheless, if he regards the latter feature as a historical feature more generally or one exclusive to his Irish contemporaries. In any case, this conforms with Walker’s (1791: 30) observation that in words like *great* and *break* some educated speakers and generally the Irish use the vowel normally found in *greet*, i.e. [i:]. A similar observation, namely that *chair* is pronounced like *cheer*, can however be found in Cobbin (1864: 82) for Londoners. This is likely a form of hypercorrection where speakers avoid the dialectal use of /e:/ in FLEECE words and try to correctly employ /i:/ but overextend the rule to words that would have /e:/ in non-dialectal speech. Kallen (2013: 46–47) mentions comments on this hypercorrection as early as the beginning of the nineteenth century.

Nesfield (1900: 278–279) describes an allophony of FACE realisations, with diphthongs occurring in checked syllables and monophthongs in open syllables: “[i]n a syllable like *late*, that ends with a consonant, there is, in our present sounding of it, a glide or slight after-sound expressed by *i*”. The notation he uses, “(ei)”, he borrowed from Sweet’s and Skeat’s works.⁸ Nesfield (1900: 282) calls the vowels in words like *late* and *note* partly diphthongal “because when they end the syllable, as in *fa*-tal, *no*-ble, they are Simple”.⁹ Moreover, the quality of the second element plays a role in his characterisation as in examples corresponding to Wells’ (1982) PRICE, CHOICE, MOUTH sets as well as YOD plus /u/, we find “not a mere glide or semi-vowel, but a fully sounded vowel” (Nesfield 1900: 282). His allophonic rule appears, however, to apply only to either the FACE_a subset or to polysyllabic words as the word *they* is clearly identified as containing a diphthong, analogous to the example *vein*: “*ei* in *vein* is a diphthong [...] such as is heard at the end of the word *they*, in which it is denoted by the final *y*” (Nesfield 1900: 457). In terms of quality he describes the first sound of the diphthong as Anglo-Saxon <é> or like French <é> in the word *été*. He moreover states that “*a* in *name* is really a diphthong, such as in French is composed of the Latin *e*, followed by a glide which may be represented by a short *i*. Hence, in phonetic writing, the sound is represented by (ei)” (Nesfield 1900: 458). Hence, we could transcribe the diphthong as ranging somewhere between these values: [e^j ~ e^j ~ e:^j]. However, he cautions his readers not to confuse the vowel with the vowel in *Mary* – which is distinct from *marry* for Nesfield (1900: 278). This remark could concern the height of the initial vowel but potentially also the second element as he notes diphthongs and triphthongs ending in schwa in the words *care*, *deer*, *drawer*, *mower*, *poor*, *fire*, *pure*, *destroyer*, *power* (Nesfield 1900: 282–283). Thus, what he suggests is that readers must not confuse are [e: ~ e^j ~ e:^j] with realisations that have more open onsets or centralised offsets. According to the North American grammar by Carpenter (1902: 228), “some of our long vowel sounds are, in the pronunciation of many people, real diphthongs (*a* in *day* = *ě* + *ĩ*; *o* in *no* = *o* + *ōō*; [...])”. In terms of vowel quality, his grammar only reveals that the vowel in *station* is a front vowel, that “*ě*” is used in the word *pen* and that

⁸Unfortunately, Nesfield does not give a proper reference to the works he used in this context but simply names Sweet and Skeat. Concerning Walter William Skeat, one of the footnotes on the previous page states “The system of Mod. Eng. sounds adopted in this book is that described by Professor Skeat in the Note printed (with his permission) in Appendix V”, which can indeed be found at the end of Nesfield’s grammar.

⁹These words could be considered ambisyllabic from a present-day perspective because syllable-initial /t/ is often realised with aspiration whereas final /t/ is not. Wells (2008: 300) regards the /t/ in words like *fatal* as constituting the coda of the first syllable.

“ɪ” is used in *pin*. He does nonetheless state that the vowel in the word *station* is between that of *pin* and *pen* (Carpenter 1902: 227). Therefore, we could perhaps transcribe the diphthong as [eɪ ~ ɛɪ].

5.4 GOAT in the CNG: Overview

As regards GOAT words in the CNG, 101 grammars (61% of grammars in CNG that treat pronunciation)¹⁰ either allow us to deduce a quality for the vowel in GOAT words or explicitly mention it. Similar to comments on the vowel in FACE, these thus include grammars that explicitly refer to the vowel in GOAT words as “simple vowel”, “pure sound”, “improper diphthong”, or the like, but also those that provide a list of diphthongs of the English language that lacks any GOAT spellings. The latter grammars are thus implicit evidence of monophthongs as we can often only derive this information based on the absence of GOAT words in the grammarians’ lists of English diphthongs. 88 grammars in the CNG indicate monophthongs (44 each British-Irish and North American). These include four Irish, four Scottish and one Canadian grammar.¹¹ Evidence for diphthongal variants can be found in 13 grammars in total (7 British-Irish and 6 North

¹⁰Upon revisiting my data for the present study, I realised that I had missed crucial passages in Alexander (1835) and Gostwick (1878) in Wiemann (2023). Burnet (1838), whose grammar identifies a GOAT_a word as a monophthong, has furthermore been missed in the previous analysis and was added to the present study. Moreover, the source *Comstock’s elocution* referred to in Wiemann (2023) was not published in 1808 but 1868. It is falsely dated 1808 on Google Books. The correct source is Comstock (1868), which has been replaced with earlier works by Comstock in the discussion of the present study. Numbers and figures have been adjusted accordingly.

¹¹The Irish grammars are McArthur (1836), Sullivan (1855), Edwardes (1877), and Speers (1880). Burnet (1838), Macintosh (1852), Collier (1866), and Coghlan (1868) were published in Scotland. The Canadian grammar is Davies (1869).

Table 5.3: Quantitative distribution of GOAT variants in the CNG

	British-Irish	North American	all
pronunciation treated	100	66	166
GOAT (and FORCE) total	51 (51% of 100)	50 (76% of 66)	101 (61% of 166)
monophthong	44 (44% of 100)	44 (67% of 66)	88 (53% of 166)
diphthong or both	7 (7% of 100)	6 (9% of 66)	13 (8% of 166)
insufficient information	49	16	65

5 Long Mid Diphthonging

American). If we consider that fewer North American grammars treat pronunciation to begin with, relatively speaking slightly fewer British-Irish grammars provide information on diphthongs in GOAT words, as illustrated in Table 5.3 and the corresponding spineplot (Figure 5.5). However, this minor difference of 2 percentage points may be disregarded, also given the low absolute numbers. In absolute terms, the overall results are more or less regionally balanced.



Figure 5.5: Evidence of GOAT variants in the CNG

Of the grammars suggesting diphthongal variants only one was published outside of England and the US, namely Speers (1880), published in Dublin, London and Melbourne. The first British-Irish grammar that provides evidence for diphthongal realisations in any GOAT subset is Alexander (1835). The earliest North American grammar was published in 1845, namely Frazee (1845).

It is worth noting that not all of these grammars consider every possible spelling. In fact, <oa> spellings are by far the most prominent words that are treated in connection to the vowel in GOAT words. However, this is mostly due to the fact that <oa> spellings appear to be the prime examples of “improper diphthongs” for many grammarians in the CNG. Therefore, even if a grammar does not feature a lengthy treatment of pronunciation but merely gives definitions on different types of sounds under the heading “orthography”, <oa> spellings are mentioned.

Half of the grammars that propose monophthongs for the vowel in GOAT identify them as “improper diphthongs”. Six grammars of these criticise the term

“improper diphthong” as it is based on the spelling of the word rather than the actual pronunciation (Crombie 1809: xvi; Fisk 1822: 37; Barnes 1854: 8; Hart 1864: 9; Mulligan 1868: 56–57; Lowres 1863: 53–54). It is in 41 of these grammars that <oa> spellings, and often exclusively the word *boat*, are used as example of “improper diphthongs”. As shown for FACE in the previous section, the grammarians’ arguments are often similar to Walker (1791), as shown in (5). They suggest that the affected words contain two graphemes representing vowels of which only one is actually realised in speech; hence, they are treated as “improper”:

- (5) Q. 20. Diphthongs are of two kinds, *proper* and *improper*. Can you define them? A. A Proper Diphthong has both the vowels sounded; as, *oi* in *voice*, *ou* in *sound*. An Improper Diphthong has only one of the vowels sounded; as, *oa* in *boat*, *ea* in *bread*. (Caldwell 1859: 18–19)

Furthermore, there are nine cases that constitute (near-)verbatim copies from Murray (1795), as shown in Table 5.4. These are exclusively North American grammars (as indicated by the asterisks) and, as we shall see, many of them copy passages on other phonological variables from Murray and are openly based on Murray’s grammar, e.g. Fisk (1822), Kirkham (1834), or Swett (1844). All the other grammars in the CNG that make use of the term “improper diphthong” and employ *boat* as an example to illustrate this are very close in wording and argument to what we find in Murray and Walker. Table 5.4 merely illustrates those examples that at most deviate in one word or one example from Murray.

Turner (1840) also describes the vowel as an “improper diphthong” and calls it “open *o*”. In his grammar, FORCE words are part of the same category, as words like *court* and *four* are said to also contain this sound and are named in the same instant as *dough* and *though*. 24 of the grammars (27%) that propose monophthongs also include spellings from the FORCE set in the same category. Grammars similar to Turner (1840) are usually very thorough as they alphabetically walk their readers through every possible spelling of vowels and consonants and consistently employ the same terms, e.g. “improper diphthong” and “long *o*” or “open *o*”.

5.5 GOAT diphthongs

As concerns the timespan of diphthongal variants of any GOAT subset in the CNG, the earliest grammar is Alexander (1835), two grammars are from 1845 (Atkin 1845; Frazee 1845) and three from the 1850s and early 60s (Brown 1851; Fowler 1855; York 1862). The remaining seven instances are found in grammars

from the close of the century, published between 1878 and 1902 (Gostwick 1878; Speers 1880; Hall & Sonnenschein 1889; Gow 1892; Ramsey 1892; Nesfield 1900; Carpenter 1902). Save for Atkin (1845), all of these grammars also mention diphthongal variants in FACE words. Speers (1880), published in Dublin, London and Melbourne, does not give any information on FACE diphthongs but on GOAT and therefore has not been treated in the previous section. As can be seen in the smaller number of GOAT diphthongal descriptions, there are several grammars in the CNG that treat diphthongs in FACE words but not those in GOAT. Regarding centralised variants of the vowel in GOAT, the CNG provides no evidence. Analogous to Table 5.2, Table 5.5 provides an overview of all the evidence of diphthongisation in my data, sorted chronologically, and including information on the spelling and the phonological environment in which diphthongs are de-

Table 5.4: Examples of (near-)verbatim copies from Murray for the definition of “improper diphthongs” with *boat* as example word, ordered chronologically

grammar	passage
Murray (1795: 4)	An improper diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded; as, <i>ea</i> in <i>eagle</i> , <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i>
Picket (1815: 6)*	An <i>improper</i> diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded; as, <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> , <i>ea</i> in <i>reason</i> .
Fisk (1822: 11)*	An <i>improper</i> diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded; as, <i>ea</i> in <i>eagle</i> , <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> .
Ingersoll (1824: 19)*	An improper diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded: as, <i>ea</i> in <i>eagle</i> , <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> .
Kirkham (1834: 20)*	An <i>improper</i> diphthong has only <i>one</i> of the vowels sounded; as, <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> .
Adams (1838: 6)*	An improper diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded, as <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> .
Smith (1841: 118)*	An improper diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded as, <i>ea</i> in <i>eagle</i> , <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> .
Swett (1844: 14)*	An <i>improper</i> diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded; as, <i>ea</i> in <i>eagle</i> , <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i>
Spear (1845: 39)*	An <i>improper</i> diphthong has but one of the vowels sounded; as, <i>ea</i> in <i>eagle</i> , <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> .
Caldwell (1859: 19)*	An Improper Diphthong has only one of the vowels sounded; as, <i>oa</i> in <i>boat</i> , <i>ea</i> in <i>bread</i> .

Table 5.5: Evidence of GOAT (and FORCE) diphthongs in the CNG

grammar	spellings	phonological environment		example words	lexical sets
Alexander (1835)	<ow>	open	—	<i>snow, know, below</i>	GOAT_b
Atkin (1845)	<oa>	closed	/t/	<i>coat</i>	GOAT_a
Frazer (1845)*	<oCe>	closed	/t, d/, /p/	<i>vote, hope, ode</i>	GOAT_a
Brown (1851)*		closed	/l/	<i>old</i>	GOAT_b
Fowler (1855)*		closed	/l/	<i>old</i>	GOAT_b
York (1862)*	<ore>	closed	/l/, /r/	<i>old, more</i>	GOAT_b, FORCE
Gostwick (1878)	<ow, ew>	open	—	(<i>sew, glow</i>)	GOAT_b
Speers (1880)	<ow>	open	—	<i>flow</i>	GOAT_b
Hall & Sonnenschein (1889)	<o>	open	—	<i>no</i>	GOAT_a
Gow (1892)	<oa>	closed	/t/	<i>boat</i>	GOAT_a
Ramsey (1892)*	<o, ow, oul>	open, closed	/l/	<i>no, know, soul</i>	GOAT_a, GOAT_b
Nesfield (1900)	<o, ow, oul, oCe>	open, closed	/t/, /l/	<i>O (the letter), so, know, note, soul</i>	GOAT_a, GOAT_b
Carpenter (1902)*	<o>	open	—	<i>no</i>	GOAT_a

scribed. As in previous tables, asterisks identify North American grammars and British-Irish grammars are left unmarked. The table moreover shows the example words used by the grammarians to illustrate the sounds, and the lexical subsets to which they pertain. As with FACE, the spellings mentioned only serve as examples for the grammarians and it is possible that diphthongs may have been used

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in other contexts. Table 5.5 shows that the most favourable phonological environments for diphthongal GOAT variants were open syllables as in *no* or *know*, before /l/ as in *soul* or *old* and before voiceless stops as in *coat* or *note*. Thus, there is a great number of examples from the GOAT_b set but also some from GOAT_a. At first glance the presence of diphthongs in *soul* and *old* might not be surprising due to common pre-lateral diphthongisation to [aʊ ~ ɒʊ ~ ɔʊ] in these environments (see Maguire 2020b: 582–583; Hickey 2023: 80 and Section 5.1). The grammarians' and their sources', e.g. Comstock (1843), descriptions of the vowel and the lexical distribution (including GOAT_a words) suggest that we are dealing with more than simply pre-lateral diphthonging. I argue below that diphthongs in words of the FACE_b and GOAT_b sets may be regarded as historical retentions.

For GOAT words, Alexander (1835) provides the earliest evidence of diphthongisation. As shown in the discussion of FACE in the previous section, he identifies diphthongs in the words *snow*, *know*, and *below*. In Atkin (1845: 6), which is one of the catechism grammars (like Caldwell 1859 illustrated above) the teacher asks the student to provide examples of “proper” and “improper diphthongs” and give an explanation as to why that is the case. The student answers that <oa> in the word *coat* is a “proper diphthong”. Their reasoning is that if it were only the *a* that was pronounced, the word in question would be *cat* – without the *a* it would be *cot*; hence the explanation is based on orthography. This is clearly a phonologically and historically implausible argument for a diphthongal realisation. Based on that reasoning every digraph that stands for a vowel would have to be realised as a diphthong. Amongst the “improper diphthongs” we can find words such as *crow*. For Atkin (1845: 6), <oa> spellings before a voiceless plosive are thus treated as diphthongal, while <ow> spellings are not.

Frazer (1845: 11) from the same year uses the vowel in the word *boat* as an example of a digraph, i.e. one vowel represented by two graphemes. Since he does not list <oa> spellings as examples of “compound sounds” but of digraphs, we can confidently contend that this vowel is supposed to be a monophthong for him. Interestingly, three pages further into his grammar he provides a list of “monophthongs or vowels” and one of “diphthongal sounds”, of which the latter category contains “long o, as in *vote*, *hope*” (Frazer 1845: 14). He elaborates, using Rush's (1827) terminology, that the *O* in the word *ode* “has its own peculiar radical, and its vanish is the sound of *oo* in *ooze*” (Frazer 1845: 15). Therefore, he suggests a diphthong ending in [u] for <oCe> spellings, while <oa> spellings in *boat* are regarded as monophthongs.

Brown (1851: 152, 169) provides *loaf* as an example of “improper diphthongs”, but remarks that his contemporary Rush (1827) suggests the *o* in *old* to be diphthongal. However, as noted above, Brown (1851: 152) does not seem to approve

of this classification. In the appendix of his grammar, he furthermore identifies every possible GOAT and FORCE spelling as “open or long o” (Brown 1851: 1006). While he thus proposes monophthongs for the two lexical sets, he still provides evidence for the presence of diphthongisation in his contemporaries’ phonology in the GOAT_b set. Fowler (1855: 145–146) lists the word *note* under vowel sounds, whereas, as noted above, the vowels found in *fine*, *rude*, *house*, and *voice* are collated in the category “compound vowel sounds”. Discussing different representations of the same sounds, he contends that all possible spellings have the long monophthong also found in *note* (Fowler 1855: 212). The only evidence for the existence of diphthongal variants that Fowler (1855: 145) provides is when he illustrates Rush’s classification, where *old* is described as a diphthong. York (1862: 66–70) mentions a diphthongal variant for *more* and *old*, which he in fact calls a triphthong in both. As with FACE, he embraces terminology that is based on one of Comstock’s works, namely the use of “radical” and “vanish” for the first and second element of a diphthong respectively. He moreover adds the “median”; which makes this a triphthong. In Comstock’s (1843: 19) system this vowel is also found in *old* and *no*. York’s (1862) scheme suggests that the “radical” and “median” are the same sound, namely “ō” and that the “vanish” is “w”. However, his symbol for the triphthong itself is “ō̄”. Thus, his description is circular.¹² For Comstock (1843: 19, 21) the first sound of this triphthong is “a sound characteristic of this element” and the second and third element is the diphthong he describes for *lose*, *too* and *move*. The different elements of the triphthong involve “gradual diminution of the aperture of the mouth” (Comstock 1843: 23). Based on their descriptions, I suggest a quality somewhat like [ou^w].

As for the late nineteenth-century sources, Speers (1880: 7) claims that the vowel in the word *cloak* is an “improper diphthong”. However, he states that the letter <w> “is a vowel when it is united with another vowel going before, as in *cow*, *flow*” and therefore suggests that the vowel in *flow* is a diphthong, analogous to the word *cow*, about which he writes: “[n]otice that w = u in *cow*, which would be pronounced quite the same if spelt *cou*”. This could be a claim based on spelling analogy to <ow> MOUTH words or relate to the historical difference between the vowel in GOAT_a and GOAT_b sets. Hall & Sonnenschein (1889: 60) categorise the GOAT words *no*, *boat*, *toe*, *crow*, *soul* and *sew* as “simple vowel sounds” as opposed to diphthongs and transcribe them as “o”. FORCE words, on the other hand, are listed separately and transcribed as “ɔ̄”. However, as previously noted, they add a general remark, stating that long vowels, like the one in *no*, are “rarely pure”

¹²My assumption is that he is either inconsistent in the use of symbols or made some mistakes in the process of copying from Comstock.

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and give the vowel “faint oo [u]” as second element of the resulting diphthong (Hall & Sonnenschein 1889: 214). Gow (1892: 6, 11) and Carpenter (1902: 228) describe diphthongal variants in a similar fashion, as noted in the section on FACE diphthongs above.

Ramsey (1892: 149) provides evidence for a less marked diphthong than [oʊ] in the word *know*, which we could perhaps transcribe as [o^u]. He writes about the letter <w> that “[a]fter *o* it either forms a perfect diphthong, as in *now*, or is very faintly heard, as in *know*”. In <ou> spellings before /l/ such as the word *soul*, Ramsey (1892: 167) also describes a diphthong, likely similar to that in *know* as his use of the word *faint* suggests: “[i]t [sc. the spelling <ou>] was next employed to express the sound of *o* in *soul*, in which some think they hear both vowels—a distinct *o*, followed by a very faint (*u*)”. Based on Ellis, he also suggests that the vowel in *no* is diphthongal (Ramsey 1892: 164). He furthermore notes that words like *glory* are increasingly pronounced as if spelt *glawry* in England as opposed to the US (Ramsey 1892: 164). Thus, he implies a lowered and distinct vowel in FORCE words in England.

Nesfield (1900) is by far the most thorough grammar with respect to the distribution of GOAT diphthongs in the CNG. In words like *obey* he admits a shortened variant of the long *o*, i.e. [o], or [ə]. Nesfield (1900: 280) observes that “a man will at one moment say *o’bey* and at another *əbey*”. However, word-final reduction to schwa in words like *fellow* he regards as “vulgarism”. He further claims that the vowel in *obey* “does not, however, make a perfect pair with the *o* in *note*; for in this and other syllables that end in a consonant, the sound of *o* is followed by a glide or slight after-sound expressed by *u*” (Nesfield 1900: 280). Thereby, he describes a diphthong in words like *note*. The vowel quality in *so*, Nesfield (1900: 458) observes, is “in fact impure; for it not only expresses the German *o*, but is followed by a slight after-sound, like a faint utterance of the Eng. *u* in *full*. This after-sound is expressed by *w* in the case of the word *know*, pronounced as (nou)”. This vowel quality he also suggests for *soul* and *know*. Therefore, we could perhaps transcribe it as [o^ʊ ~ o^u]. Nevertheless, as with the vowel in FACE words, he categorises this vowel only as partly diphthongal because not all words collated under this vowel category are always diphthongs. Indeed, he claims that vowels that end a syllable, like *noble* and *poet*, are monophthongal.¹³ His choice of example words for the illustration of the vowel quality suggests, however, that this does not apply to its occurrence in open syllables of monosyllabic words such

¹³As with the word *fatal* in the previous section, note that some twenty-first century authors may also interpret the first syllable of *noble* as checked, with the coda being /b/ (see Wells 2008: 544).

as *so*, *know*, or the name of the letter *O*. Moreover, FORCE words are described as having the “*au* sound”, and are thus treated as distinct from GOAT by Nesfield (1900: 288).

5.6 FACE and GOAT: Summary

For both FACE and GOAT words, monophthongs are by far the majority variant that grammarians proposed throughout the nineteenth century. The pervasive use of terms like “improper diphthong” to refer to monophthongs and the example word *boat* as well as (near-)verbatim copies from authors like Murray may partially account for this, at least for GOAT words. Overall, these grammars appear to be linguistically conservative in regard to the vowels in FACE and GOAT words as the innovative variants are clearly the minority.

Generally speaking, diphthongal descriptions of the FACE set are slightly more frequent and occur earlier than those for GOAT. All example words of diphthongs for either set before 1845 belong to the category of FACE_b or GOAT_b words and thus originate from ME diphthongs. These are likely to constitute examples indicating historically older, or perhaps even dialectal values. As shown in Figure 5.6, these occur as early as the 1810s, the earliest being Morgan (1814). FACE_c words are only mentioned in the context of diphthongs in one grammar, namely Nesfield (1900).

There is a small difference between British-Irish and North American grammars in the relative number of mentions of FACE diphthongs where British-Irish grammars provide slightly more evidence both in absolute terms and in relation to the number of grammars that treat pronunciation from the respective region. For GOAT words, the number of grammars that provide evidence for diphthongs is larger by one British-Irish grammar. In relative terms, treatment of diphthongal variants is however slightly higher (2 percentage points) in North American grammars. As previously stated, this is so small a difference that it may be disregarded in the interpretation of the overall results. Moreover, all North American grammars except Ramsey (1892) and Carpenter (1902) refer to or discuss diphthongal values described in either of their American contemporaries Rush and Comstock. Brown (1851) is critical of Rush; Fowler (1855) has a more neutral attitude towards Rush but does not fully adopt his scheme of vowels either. York (1862), in contrast, follows Comstock, who himself bases some of his principles on Rush. This suggests that their works must have been widespread and influential. The absence of a striking difference between grammars from both regions could indeed point to an independent development of diphthongs in Britain and

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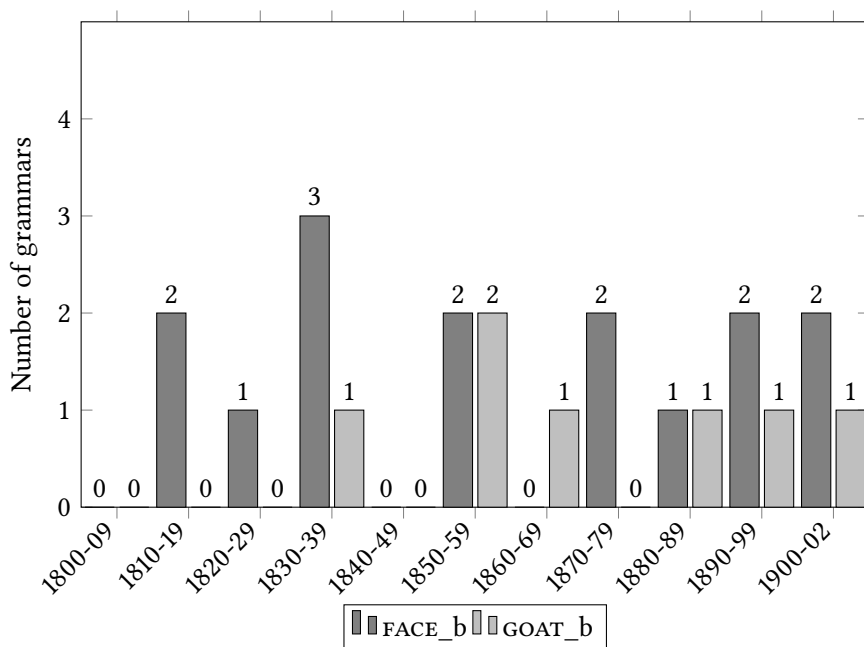


Figure 5.6: Evidence of FACE_b and GOAT_b diphthongal realisations in the CNG

North America. The fact that the first proper evidence of the change comes from the very end of the eighteenth and beginning of the nineteenth century (see Section 5.1) supports this claim.

Prescriptive comments are very rare for either lexical set. In two instances grammarians even argue in favour of diphthongs for <ai> spellings (Morgan 1814; Cramp 1838). These, I have argued, constitute examples of restorative prescriptivism in the sense that they attempt to restore earlier vowel qualities, as opposed to comments on incoming diphthongal variants as part of *Long Mid Diphthonging*. Monophthongal pronunciations are negatively evaluated socially, as a mistake, and in aesthetics terms (see the categories outlined in Chapter 4) in the two cases of Morgan (1814) and Cramp (1838). In addition, one grammar simply proscribes diphthongal variants in FACE_b and GOAT_b without further value judgements (Gostwick 1878) and one grammar exhibits strong disapproval of diphthongs in FACE_b and GOAT_b words described in his contemporary Rush (1827), namely Brown (1851).

In terms of FACE_a and GOAT_a example words, i.e. those that we can regard as evidence for *Long Mid Diphthonging* proper rather than those proposed in the

context of the vowels' history or spelling, the first mentions of diphthongal variants are from 1845 in both sets. The temporal distribution is shown in Figure 5.7.

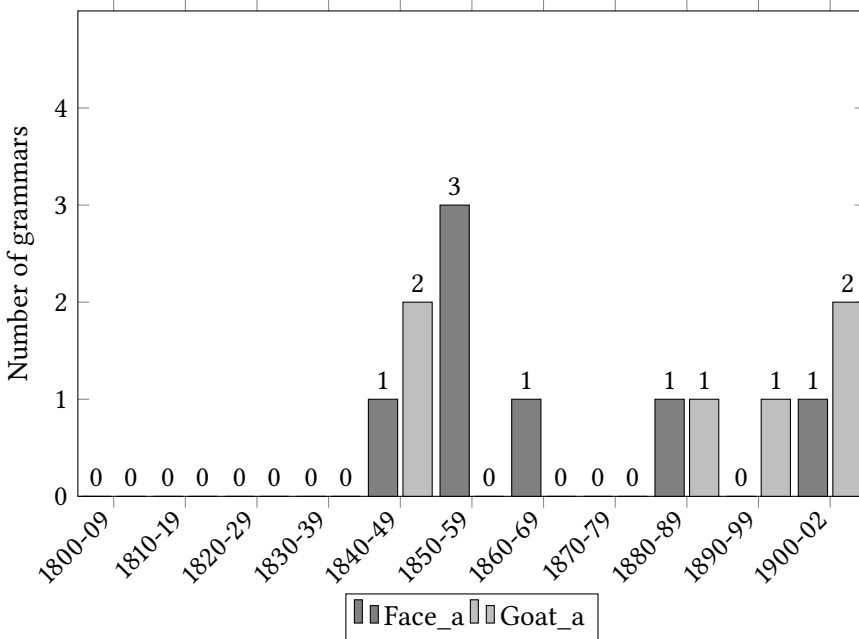


Figure 5.7: Evidence of FACE_a and GOAT_a diphthongal realisations in the CNG

Regarding the quality of realisations, the majority of grammars do not reveal any information. Those that do seem to be hesitant to consider the vowels in question “proper diphthongs”, as they would those in lexical sets like MOUTH, PRICE, CHOICE or YOD + /u/. Still, even in the later grammars, e.g. Gow (1892: 11) or Nesfield (1900: 282), we can observe comments that make reference to “glides”, “faint sounds”, “slight diphthongs”, “after-sounds”, or remnants of a hard consonant or the like. Indeed, we still find these comments as late as Krapp (1919: 67), as observed earlier: “[b]ut with many speakers the diphthongal quality, if present at all, is so slight as not to be appreciated by the ear”.

This might point to some linguistic insecurity on behalf of the grammarians, either reflected in the accuracy of their descriptions or in their attitudes towards their own realisations (see Ellis’ comments on his own pronunciation discussed above). The outcome of *Long Mid Diphthonging* had not been fully accepted and was likely happening below the level of conscious awareness for many speakers, as noted by Batchelor, Ellis, Krapp and D. Jones (see Section 5.1). I argue that

diphthongal variants had not yet become phonemic at the very end of the nineteenth century. In other words, in the nineteenth century the underlying form was still a long monophthong with some phonetically and lexically conditioned exceptions, whereas this situation reversed during the first half of the twentieth century and the diphthong came to represent the phoneme.

My results furthermore point to a phonetically gradual development, perhaps from a long monophthong to a long monophthong with an offglide and eventually to a diphthong in *FACE*, e.g. [e: > e:^j > e:ɪ > eɪ]. For *GOAT*, some labialised intermediate forms are possible, e.g. [o: > o:^w > o:ʊ > oʊ]. There seems to be a pattern regarding the categories of example words over time, i.e. *FACE_a* and *GOAT_a* words are used as diphthongal examples only from 1845, while *FACE_b* and *GOAT_b* occur earlier. However, the detail with which these grammarians discuss diphthongal variants varies greatly. Furthermore, numbers of diphthongal descriptions are comparatively low, given the fact that 166 grammars have been consulted. Both these points have to be considered when interpreting the results against the backdrop of the development of other variables.

6 The TRAP-BATH split

6.1 TRAP and BATH: Historical background

What is commonly referred to as TRAP-BATH split is the historical process by which words like *bath*, *laugh*, *aunt* or *grass* acquired a different vowel to words like *trap*, *bat*, or *pan* in the LModE period. For RP, they are usually given the phonemic transcriptions /ɑ:/ in the former group, namely BATH words, and /æ/ in TRAP words. Vowels now found in words collated under the TRAP and BATH sets both go back to ME /a/ (usually written <a>), and ME /au/ as in *aunt*, *laugh*, *dance* (see ME spellings *dawnce*, *daunse*; OED: s.v. *dance* n.) and ME /ai/ *master* (see ME spellings *maistir*, *meistir*; OED: s.v. *master* n.1 & adj.). Some words that had ME /au, ai/ merged with those originating from ME /a/ by means of monophthongisation. For vowels going back to ME /au/, there was variation with rounded variants like [ɔ:] in LModE, as there is in many present-day dialects (Beal 1999: 105; Trapateau 2020: 528). The monophthong resulting from ME /au, ai/, and /a/ words merging then split into two phonemes between the seventeenth and twentieth centuries: a short front vowel in the TRAP set, and a lengthened, lowered, and retracted vowel in the BATH set. The new vowel only developed before nasals, e.g. *dance*, and before voiceless fricatives, e.g. *bath*, except for /ʃ/ (see words like *mash*, which have uniformly retained /æ/). The words in the BATH set now pattern together with the vowels in the START and PALM sets, the latter two of which are treated separately by Wells (1982: 142–144, 157–158). The START set comprises of words in which the vowel occurs before /r/, while the PALM set contains former pre-/lm/ environments like *calm*, and words like *father*, which have acquired a distinct vowel from TRAP even in varieties in which the split has not occurred.

In terms of the history of the split, the following points are clear: it happened in many varieties of English in varying degrees of completeness, there is no variety in which all words of the category in question have undergone the change, and it was lexically (and likely also phonetically) gradual (see Hickey 2020; Trapateau 2020). The split occurred most notably in the South of England. This can be seen also in twentieth-century dialects in Figure 6.1 for the word *last*, where mostly the South-East and northern East Anglia have a long retracted vowel.

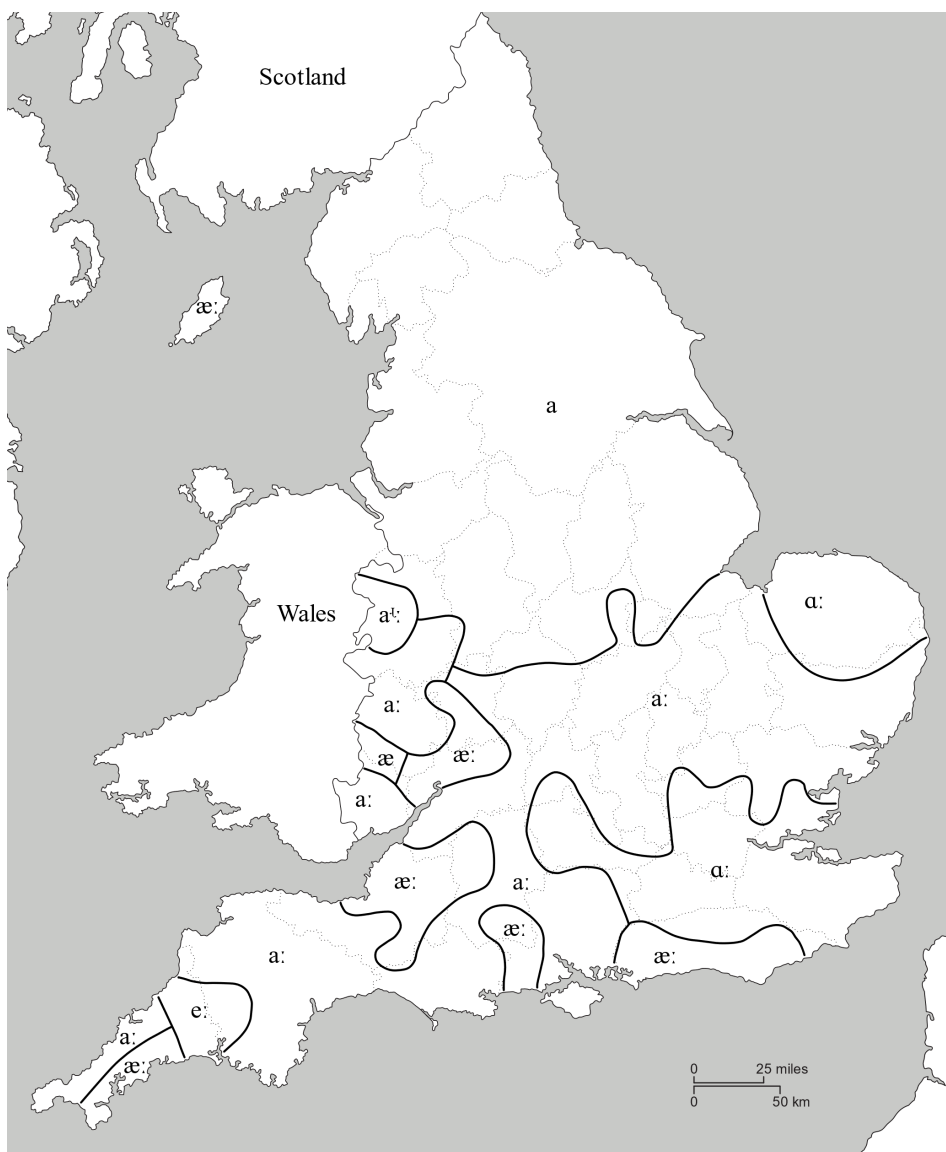


Figure 6.1: Map showing the distribution of vowel realisations in the word *last* in twentieth-century dialects in England, recreated based on Orton et al. (1978)

However, southern hemisphere Englishes and some varieties in Wales, Ireland, the Caribbean, and on the east coast of North America also have the split. In terms of lexical incidence, the split is less advanced in these varieties than in southern British pronunciation (see Hughes et al. 2012: 61; Trapateau 2020: 529). In present-day AmE pronunciation it is only in the START and PALM sets that speakers use the back vowel [ɑ]. Every word that belongs to the BATH set in RP has the same category as TRAP in AmE pronunciation. Table 6.1 illustrates the situation for present-day RP, AmE, and AusE pronunciation. I use the notation [ɐ:] for AusE because this more accurately represents its realisation and that its difference to the vowel in STRUT is merely one of length, with vowels in both sets occupying the low central area of vowel space (see Cox & Fletcher 2017: 64–65, 69–70).

Table 6.1: Phonological distribution of BATH, and PALM words in RP, AmE, and AusE, based on Wells (1982), Cox & Fletcher (2017), Upton & Kretzschmar (2017), and Trapateau (2020)

example word	environment	lexical set	RP	AmE	AusE
<i>father</i>	<i>father</i>	PALM	ɑ:	ɑ	ɐ:
<i>palm</i>	l-loss + _m	PALM	ɑ:	ɑ	ɐ:
<i>half</i>	l-loss + _f	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>master</i>	<i>master</i>	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>laugh</i>	ME /au/ + _f	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>draught</i>	ME /au/ + _ft	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>bath</i>	_θ	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>raft</i>	_ft	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>staff</i>	_f	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>fast</i>	_st	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>glass</i>	_s	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>ask</i>	_sk	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>disaster</i>	_stə(r)	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>fasten</i>	_sən	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>rather</i>	_ðə(r)	BATH	ɑ:	æ	ɐ:
<i>grasp</i>	_sp	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ
<i>castle</i>	_səl	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ
<i>demand</i>	_nd	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ
<i>aunt</i>	_nt	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ
<i>branch</i>	_nf	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ
<i>example</i>	_mpl	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ
<i>dance</i>	_ns	BATH	ɑ:	æ	variably æ

Upton & Kretzschmar (2017: xix) remark that eastern New England speakers have the back vowel [ɑ] also in words like *ask* and *aunt*, which is rarely heard in other areas of the US and may by some of them be regarded as prestigious pronunciation. Stanford (2020: 50) states that [ɑ:] is the traditional New England variant, but that this is recessive in modern New England speech. Thus, the phoneme inventory of present-day American speakers mostly represents the pre-split situation. Today's situation shows a complex distribution in the American (North)-East, not only with some speakers maintaining retracted vowels in the BATH set but also with the so called nasal short-*a* split. This split describes the use of tenser realisations of /æ/ before nasals, which results in a distinction between the BAN and BAT sets (Stanford 2020: 51–52, 275–279). In AusE pronunciation the long vowel is variable in pre-nasal BATH words and some other environments as in *grasp* or *castle*.

That the change is incomplete is perhaps best illustrated by the fact that even in varieties in which it is most advanced, namely in the South of England and RP, words like *pant*, *romance*, *mansion*, *band*, *camp* still contain /æ/, whereas *plant*, *dance*, *branch*, *demand*, *example* have /ɑ:/ (Hughes et al. 2012: 61; see Wells 1982: 232–233 for more examples, also in pre-fricative environments). It is mostly the category of pre-nasal environments in which the split is less advanced in AusE, as shown in Table 6.1. According to Wells (1982: 233), the TRAP-BATH split “represents the ossification of a half-completed sound change, which seems to have come to a stop well before completing its lexical diffusion through the vocabulary”. It is a phoneme-split and not a wholesale shift of one and the same phoneme. Thus, a categorisation that distinguishes the short front vowel category from the lengthened and retracted phoneme becomes necessary in the first place.

The first proper documentation of the split comes from the seventeenth century (Cooper 1687), when /æ/ started to be lengthened before consonant clusters starting with a voiceless fricative (Lass 1999: 104–106). Slightly earlier evidence from Cooper (1685) also indicates that vowels before clusters like /ft/, /st/ as in for instance *craft*, *passed* were affected before those preceding single fricatives as in *staff* or *pass* (Trapateau 2020: 539). The lowering and backing of the vowel, however, is said to have occurred in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries.

According to MacMahon (1998: 438), the time from the 1790s to 1820 was crucial for the change. Yet, the present-day distribution is still far from straightforward, and we find a considerable deal of variation. Thus, variation must have surely existed as early as the LModE period. Indeed, Lass (1999: 106) points out that it “is hard to find two eighteenth-century sources in full agreement about which words have the new vowel”. Lass (1999: 106) suggests however that there

was agreement on the quality. The sound was often referred to as “long Italian *a*”, which he interprets as [a:].

Table 6.2: Potential timeline of /a/ lengthening based on the ECEP (Hickey 2020: 559)

	input	later realisation	examples
1.	/_alm/	/a:m/	<i>palm, calm</i>
2.	/_alf/	/a:f/	<i>calf, half</i>
3.	/_ar/	/a:r/	<i>star, bar</i>
4.	/_and/	/a:nd/	<i>command, demand</i>
5.	/_ant/	/a:nt/	<i>plant, grant</i>
6.	/_ans/	/a:ns/	<i>dance, glance</i>
7.	/_af, s, θ/	/a:f, s, θ/	<i>staff, pass, bath</i>

As concerns the process by which the vowel was lengthened, Hickey (2020: 559) reconstructs a potential chronology of lengthening based on prescriptive sources from the ECEP. The phonological distribution of lengthening is illustrated in Table 6.2 (see also Trapateau 2020: 537–538 for a more detailed overview on the distribution of environments favouring lengthening based on the ECEP). The table suggests that lengthening occurred first before liquids and nasals and then before fricatives, contrary to what the data from Cooper (1685, 1687) suggest. Hickey (2020: 564) furthermore argues that lengthening preceding liquids and nasals conforms more with natural processes of sound change due to their similarity with vowels in sonority, whereas voiceless fricatives do not usually trigger lengthening of preceding vowels. We could thus regard this as an argument for pre-nasal lengthening occurring first, while lengthening before fricatives could have taken place by means of analogy with now lengthened words. The North American Webster (1790: 13) includes *ask* and *father* in the same category, which is his second “long *a*”, with its corresponding short sound in *hat*. He nonetheless does not provide a list of example words and he only reveals that there must have been lengthening before fricatives. This is somewhat striking as we would expect him to suggest values dissimilar to eighteenth-century British sources. His categorisation is indeed different to Walker (1791), and Webster (1790) seems more progressive here as he allows for a long vowel in words like *ask*, while Walker does not. However, there are several dictionaries in the ECEP that permit long vowels in /_sk/ environments (see for instance Trapateau 2020: 537). Murray’s (1795: 4) grammar is comparatively conservative in this respect as it

has the same short sound in *father*, *fancy* and *glass*, and thus shows no sign of any lengthening.

In contrast to Hickey, Trudgill (2004: 62–63) argues, based on nineteenth-century British and southern hemisphere evidence (e.g. Ellis 1889 and the ONZE project), that lengthening before nasals took place after lengthening before fricatives. This possibility has also been pointed out by Wells (1982: 233). It thus seems that data from eighteenth-century dictionaries provide contradictory evidence to early seventeenth-century accounts and nineteenth-century dialectal sources. Trapateau (2020: 540) also notices this and suggests that the AusE system was inherited from a system where lengthening before nasals was in the process of being reversed due to sociolinguistic pressure. In fact, Walker (1791: 11) seems to provide evidence for this reversal. Walker (1791: 10) allows for long realisations in the START and PALM sets and in BATH words like *half*, and in *bath*, *glass*, or *last*. This sound he calls the “the long sound of the middle or Italian *a*” (Walker 1791: 10). Hickey (2020: 559) interprets Walker’s “long Italian *a*” as /a:/. Walker considers the use of this vowel in words like *after*, *answer*, *basket*, *plant* and *mast* as bordering “very closely on vulgarity” (Walker 1791: 11) and prescribes his “short Italian *a*”, i.e. /æ/ in these words. He writes about the sound of long “Italian *a*” that it “was formerly more than at present sound before the nasal liquid *n*, especially when succeeded by *t* or *c*, as *grant*, *dance*, *glance*, *lance*, *France*, *chance*, *prance*, & c.” (Walker 1791: 10). However, this reversal he also suggests for *glass*, *grass*, *last*, and *fast* of which he writes: “but this pronunciation of *a* seems to have been for some years advancing to the short sound of this letter, as heard in *hand*, *land*, *grand* & c.” (Walker 1791: 10). Walker’s dictionary therefore only partially provides proof for Trapateau’s (2020: 540) hypothesis as it is in more environments than before nasals that he describes a reversal from /a:/ to /æ/.

There are nineteenth-century sources which comment in similar fashion on the environment before nasals. For instance, for Cooley (1861) the “Italian *a*”, i.e. his long sound of the letter *a*, is used before /lC, r, θ/, and ME /au/ words as in *calm*, *half*, *far*, *bath*, *father*, *aunt*, and *launch*. For pre-/n/ environments, however, he notices that the same vowel used to be employed in words like *dance*, *glance*, *lance*, *chant*, *grant*, *plant*, *slander*, and *command*. Pronouncing these with a long vowel he now (i.e. in 1861) considers vulgar. For pre-/nd/ like *command* he notes variation between the short and long sound (Jones 2006: 315). One comment on a potential reversal can also be found in the CNG, although not before nasals (see Section 6.3).

Thus, regarding the phonological environments favouring the spread of lengthening, evidence suggests two contradictory trajectories: either lengthening preceding nasals pre-dates that of fricatives or the vowel was lengthened

first before fricatives. Moreover, there is the possibility of early pre-nasal lengthening and a reversal of this process through prescriptive pressure.

This seemingly conflicting evidence could, at least in part, also be due to the sources it is based on. Hickey (2020: 554–555) views the sources in the ECEP critically and this criticism can similarly be applied to other LModE sources. Hickey notices, for instance, that, while Walker permits the use of a long vowel in the words *bath*, *path*, *lath* in his introduction, in the respective dictionary entries they are transcribed with his short sound, i.e. the vowel in words like *man*, or *hat*. Hickey (2020: 554) moreover states that eighteenth-century pronouncing dictionaries do not clearly reveal if the presence of long vowels (/a:/ in the case of Walker 1791 and Nares 1784) in some words accurately represent that the words were actually realised as such. Admitting the vowel in some words and not in others could have been the orthoëpists' way of partially acknowledging the change without fully accepting it. This and other potentially ideological reasons underlying the descriptions that dictionaries and grammars provide indeed always have to be considered (see my discussion of sources in Sections 2.2 and 2.3). This does not of course preclude the possibility that the dictionary entries may to a certain degree still indicate the lexical diffusion of the vowel through the set of BATH words.

In addition to phonological environment, we should also consider frequency effects in the spread of innovative phonetic variants as more frequent words usually inhibit change (see Chapter 4). In terms of such frequency effects, Trapateau (2020: 539–540) argues based on the ECEP data that word frequency is not vital in the spread of long back vowels in the BATH set. Instead, he considers certain “lead words” to be the key to the spread of the change. According to him, these are mostly words going back to ME /au/ and /ai/ like *laugh*, *draught* or *master* where the long vowel is the result of monophthongisation. The word *father* also belongs to this list, which is a sensible assumption also given that even present-day AmE speakers whose speech otherwise does not suggest any split have a lengthened and/or retracted realisation in that word. Moreover, Stanford (2020: 262–263) shows that *laugh* is the word which still most frequently receives an [a:] pronunciation in contemporary New England speakers, who otherwise use a short front vowel in this set.¹ We could thus hypothesise that Trapateau's “lead words” are also the words to change last in varieties where a long or retracted vowel is on its way out of the phonological system of a variety.

Most sources discussed so far show a two-way distinction of long versus short vowels, with BATH words patterning with either. Further nineteenth-century and

¹Whereas their data in this case contain only few tokens, they note that their findings on *laugh* are corroborated by earlier work, namely Madan (2010).

early twentieth-century evidence suggests a middle category between a short front vowel and what is likely a back vowel. In fact, Smart (1810: 97) describes a change away from his “a³”, in words like *slander*, *plant*, *brass*, *grass*, *mass*, *glass*, and *fast*; hence indicating a reversal of the backing of the vowel (Jones 2006: 314). The “broader a³” sound is, according to Jones (2006: 313), “perhaps some kind of [ɑ]”. Smart (1836: v) suggests an intermediate sound between “broad a³”, heard in *far*, and a short sound “narrower” than the one in *at* in words like *pass*, *path*, and, interestingly also *father*. Smart accuses Walker of bigotry for not acknowledging this intermediate value:

[a]mong speakers of the old school, this is yet the mode of sounding *a* in such situations; but metropolitan usage among educated people has for a long time inclined to change a practice, where the orthography of the words manifestly does not warrant; and as, of two opinions or tastes, it was necessary to embrace the one, the author of this dictionary takes, with Walker, the side of regularity. But Walker is a bigot; he allows of no compromise between the broad a³, with which a vulgar mouth pronounces *ass*, and the sound, narrower, if possible, than *a* in *at*, with which an affected speaker minces the same word. Surely, in a case like this, there can be no harm in avoiding the censure of both parties by shunning the extreme that offends the taste of each (Smart 1836: v)

What he identifies as the variant used “among speakers of the old school” is his “a³” in words like *graft*, *glass*, *plant*. This moved towards the medium sound “actually in use by the best speakers”. In terms of lengthening he says that in London, speakers also “give a slight prolongation to the vowel”, i.e. the middle sound, before *f*, *s*, or *n* (Smart 1836: v). The quality of this medium sound is described as near to his “a³”, “indeed so near that in theory they are considered identical; but it is not, practically, so broad” (Smart 1836: v). Therefore, his “middle” sound could perhaps be interpreted as a slightly less retracted vowel than [ɑ:]. His proposed system would be a three-way system with [æ], [ɑ:] and [ɑ:], where all except the second one are stigmatised in BATH words.

Some North American sources such as Worcester (1830: vii–viii; 1859: 11–12) also propose a three-way distinction where words like *fat*, *man*, and *carry* have a short sound, *far* and *father* the “Italian sound of *a*” and a sound intermediate between these two in words like *ask*, *cast*, *dance*, and essentially all possible BATH environments. This indicates either a quantitatively or qualitatively intermediate vowel. Worcester (1859: 11) quotes one of Smart’s comments on the intermediate sound in the respective section. Worcester himself does not however use the term

“broad(ness)” outside of this quote to describe the third vowel but sticks to the “Italian sound”. As concerns the distribution, Webster (1828) in contrast uses the “Italian sound” for words like *ask*, which forms one category with *bar*, *father*, *mask* under the section “Direction for the pronunciation of words”. Even Krapp (1919: 29–31) still notes considerable variation between distributions essentially resembling RP, present-day AmE pronunciation, or a three-way distinction with [æ] in TRAP, [a:] in BATH, and [ɑ:] in PALM words. However, he writes about the use of [a:] in words like *fast*, *calf*, *dance*, and *grass* that it is “widely current, especially in artificial speech in America, as a compromise vowel between [ɑ:] and [æ]”. Given the suggested overt prestige of the long retracted vowel, including its association with British speech (see also Paulsen 2022) and the typically American short realisation of the vowel, this “artificial speech in America” might have been an attempt by speakers to position themselves as aware of overtly prestigious forms, and yet solidified in their American identity.

These sources show that, alongside a twofold split, LModE scholars in North America and England proposed a threefold split, which is a tendency that is indeed also reflected in the CNG, at least for North America. Based on the sources so far discussed, the three-way distinction might have phonetically resembled [æ], [a: ~ ɑ:] and [ɑ:]. As we shall see, unfortunately the grammars in the CNG do not offer sufficient articulatory information to confirm whether these realisations are reflected in nineteenth-century grammars as well.

So far, the degree of lowering and backing and the phonetically gradual development of the vowel have only marginally been mentioned. The reason for that is that hard evidence on the phonetic realisations of BATH words throughout the LModE period is almost unattainable. This is simply due to the difficulty of determining exact vowel qualities in the low-mid, low-back spectrum. Hickey (2020: 558) and Trapateau (2020: 529) both note that determining the precise realisation and the degree of lowering and retraction is nearly impossible in eighteenth-century sources. MacMahon (1998: 455) also notes for LModE sources that ascertaining the quality of /æ/ and /a:/ “*with any precision is not straightforward*” (my emphasis). Paulsen (2022: 134) equally points to the following statement by Jones on the difficulty of deriving vowel qualities in historical sources due to only marginal differences in F2:

[v]owel quality identification in this area of the phonology is notoriously difficult, the low vowel space being relatively cluttered with segments distinguished by relatively small shifts in the Hz value of F2. [æ], [a], [ɐ], [ɑ] among unrounded variants, with rounded forms in [ɒ] and [œ]. Even for the trained modern observer, it can be difficult without instrumental analysis to

be certain about the precise phonetic values of segments like this, especially in connected allegro speech contexts, so that assessing their actual shape from written historical evidence is well-nigh impossible with any degree of certainty. (Jones 2006: 189–190)

Based on natural processes of sound change, a movement that looks somewhat like [æ] > [a] > [aː] > [ɑː] > [ɑ:] for BATH words is sensible. However, while this might look plausible and neat, reversals and phonetically abrupt changes in some words, based on analogy with words already containing a retracted variant, cannot be excluded as a possibility. Unfortunately, again evidence for this is similarly hard to obtain from the CNG. Therefore, my main focus in the next sections is the spread of variants that could potentially stand for long and/or retracted vowels through the lexicon and the role of spellings, phonological environments and certain lexemes in the categorisation in the grammars.

6.2 TRAP-BATH split in the CNG: Overview

In contrast to vowel quality, the quantitative difference of vowels, how many categories grammarians suggest for words we now collate under the PALM, START, TRAP and BATH sets, and the vowel's lexical incidence is easier to determine in the dictionaries of the ECEP. This equally applies to the grammars in the CNG. However, as Hickey (2020: 546) notes, it is evident that a full reconstruction of the chronology of the shift is impossible. My goal is to expand the knowledge of this change as best as possible with the data at hand.

In addition to the lexical sets discussed so far, the LOT, THOUGHT, and parts of the SQUARE, FACE and DRESS sets are also relevant in my analysis to a certain degree. The LOT and THOUGHT sets are relevant as some AmE speakers today have what is referred to as the COT-CAUGHT merger which may often be realised with the same vowel as START words, i.e. [ɑ(:)]. The FACE and SQUARE sets are relevant as Jones (2006: 309–318) points to other LModE sources that suggest a merger in what he calls the MAT, MET, and MATE sets in which monophthongal FACE variants and the front vowels in TRAP and DRESS are regarded as the same vowel category for some speakers. While the CNG does not exhibit traces of full mergers like this, we do find examples like *there*, *their* and *carry* listed in the same category as TRAP words. Moreover, as seen in Chapter 5, there is still a considerable overlap in the FACE and SQUARE sets in the description of nineteenth-century grammarians. The example of *carry* furthermore hints at another process relevant for the TRAP-BATH split, namely the *Marry-merry* merger (see Wells 1982:

480; Hickey 2014: 106–107). As these examples show, an all-encompassing analysis of the TRAP-BATH split would inevitably have to consider nearly the complete monophthong system of English. This is even more the case if we consider evidence of raising in the DRESS and TRAP sets (see Hickey 2020: 554–555). However, I did not conduct a systematic analysis of THOUGHT and LOT words, and only discuss them in so far as they appear to be listed in the same category as TRAP or BATH ones.

As seen with FACE and GOAT, generally grammars in the CNG do not give much detail on the realisation of vowels. This fact, on top of the difficulty of assessing the quality of low vowels mentioned above, means that I refrain from speculating on precise realisations of the sounds the grammarians propose. When they do provide information, I suggest likely realisations in IPA. Nevertheless, in the majority of cases the only information the grammars yield is what they call the sound in question, e.g. “Italian *a*”, or “grave *a*”. Based on these, we could hypothesise which research tradition they were working in, and which values they probably had in mind. Consulting Hickey’s analysis of the ECEP might hint at which phonetic qualities were likely meant by these terms by LModE grammarians. Nonetheless, proposing a quality simply based on the terminology grammarians employed, in a time where standardised phonetic terminology and transcription was still wanting, would certainly be a long shot. As I show in Chapter 7 for terms such as “rough” and “smooth” describing /r/, simply suggesting that grammarians had the same values in mind as eighteenth-century authors using the same terms is problematic for several reasons. They might each have had a specific idea as to what they meant by different terms, while the terminology itself could have simply been copied from earlier grammarians and dictionary authors. Many of them simply could not have known precisely which vowel quality grammarians and orthoëpists had in mind with certain terms.

For the present study my focus lies in the extent to which BATH words belong to the category of TRAP, PALM and START, or some intermediate category. Another goal is to trace the trajectory of vowel changes through different BATH words and see if there is a pattern, either in terms of phonological environment or word frequency. Regarding the succeeding sounds, I attempt to test the hypothesis that the vowel changed before nasals first. At the end of the eighteenth century there was still considerable variation in the number of words that had undergone lengthening and it is only in START words that the process had reached completion (Trapateau 2020: 528). It is reasonable to examine nineteenth-century sources to further corroborate these findings and see if patterns of change suggested by earlier sources continue. To measure word-frequency historically I employ ARCHER and the COHA.

In terms of evidence from the CNG, 41 grammars (25 North American, 16 British-Irish) provide sufficient detail on TRAP and BATH words to deduce whether a split was present or not. This is 25% of all grammars in the CNG that have been marked as containing enough information on pronunciation. The distribution of variants is illustrated in Table 6.3 and Figure 6.2. None of the grammars have a place of publication outside of Britain or the US. No Irish, Scottish or Canadian grammars provide any information on the presence or absence of the TRAP-BATH split.

Table 6.3: Quantitative distribution of perceived standard variants in TRAP and BATH in the CNG

	British-Irish	North American	all
pronunciation treated	100	66	166
evidence TRAP-BATH split	16 (16% of 100)	25 (38% of 66)	41 (25% of 166)
twofold distinction	11 (11% of 100)	10 (15% of 66)	21 (13% of 166)
threefold distinction	0	11 (17% of 66)	11 (7% of 166)
no distinction	1 (1% of 100)	2 (3% of 66)	3 (2% of 166)
others	4 (4% of 100)	2 (3% of 66)	6 (4% of 166)
insufficient information	84	41	125

Of the 41 grammars that give enough information, only three suggest that the split is absent (Fisk 1822; Hiley 1857; Caldwell 1859), while the remaining grammars show some form of a phoneme split. The first evidence of the split in the British-Irish grammars comes from Oliver (1825), while the earliest North American grammar that indicates the presence of a split is from 1821, namely Greenleaf (1821).

In the three grammars where the split is absent the only BATH words included in the category of “short *a*” are *glass* and *aunt*. That these three grammars are very conservative in this respect is unsurprising as they all admit in their prefaces or titles to being influenced by Murray. As regards the place of publication, Fisk (1822) and Caldwell (1859) are North American grammars, whereas Hiley (1857) was published in London.

Some grammars also contain prescriptions or identify variation in addition to their general categorisations of vowels (Oliver 1825; Kirkham 1834; Wells 1847; Clarke 1853; Fowler 1855; Nesfield 1900). These are discussed in more detail in Section 6.6 below. Six grammars were excluded from the quantitative analysis of example words, frequency effects and lexical diffusion. The reasons for this is that they either only provide descriptions of variation (Kelke 1885; Gow 1892;

6.2 TRAP-BATH split in the CNG: Overview

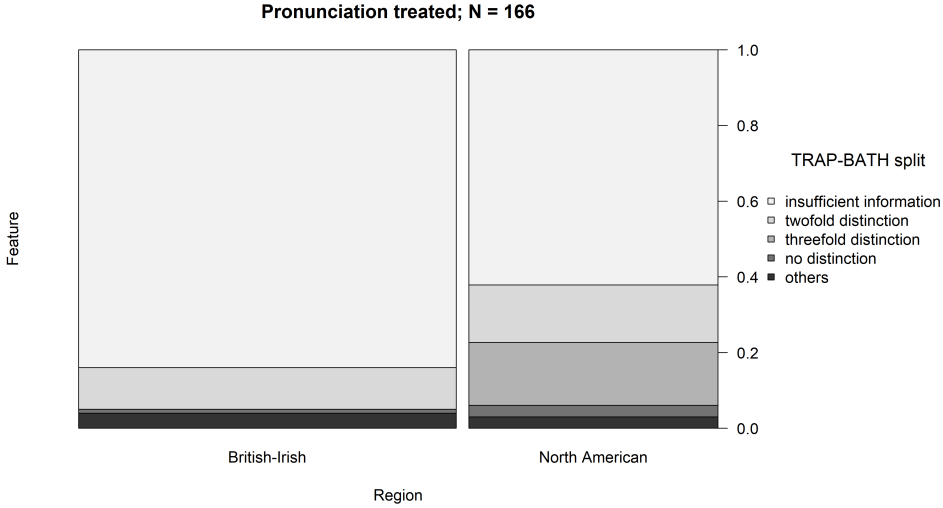


Figure 6.2: Evidence of perceived standard variants in TRAP and BATH in the CNG

Carpenter 1902), only include prescriptions (Leigh 1840), or provide contradictory evidence throughout their grammar (Brown 1849). They are labelled “others” in Table 6.3 and Figure 6.2. I return to these grammars in the qualitative discussion (Section 6.6) in order to complement the quantitative results.

I counted grammars as providing evidence for the absence of the split if no BATH words were listed in their category of START and PALM words, and if at least one BATH word was part of their category of “short *a*”. I marked those grammars that do not list any BATH words in either category as providing insufficient information for a split. This category also includes grammars where the word *father* was listed, but no BATH words. In fact, there are more grammars in the CNG that list TRAP or START words but not BATH words (91 grammars in total, 43 British-Irish, 48 North American). These grammars do not foster a discussion on the TRAP-BATH split and have thus been excluded from the analysis.

I only consider the example word *father* in the present analysis in relation to BATH words. That some grammars give insufficient example words could potentially be due to the fact that grammars often only give one example per vowel category and that TRAP words were still the most representative examples of “short *a*” for many of them.

The remaining 32 grammars show two different patterns: first, a twofold distinction (21 grammars: 10 North American, and 11 British-Irish), where some

BATH words pattern together with START and PALM words while others form a category with TRAP words, or second, a threefold distinction (11 grammars, exclusively North American), where BATH words are split across the short sound, some “middle” sound and a “long” sound of the letter *a*. In some sense this system is comparable to what Smart and Worcester (see above) suggested.

However, the categories are not clear cut when it comes to where BATH words belong. For Worcester, seemingly all BATH words had the intermediate sound between what is essentially the vowel for TRAP words and START and PALM. There are a number of grammars with a twofold split whose first vowel category does not contain any BATH words whatsoever (13 of 21 grammars). This could indicate a clear split. The remaining eight grammars with a two-way split include at least one BATH word in their short vowel category. In the grammars with a threefold distinction, it is only in Hyde (1895) that we still find a BATH word in the short vowel category. The rest is split across the other two categories.

In terms of regional distribution, there are three things that are surprising, as shown in Table 6.3 and Figure 6.2: first, the majority of North American grammars that include BATH words have a split, with the exception of two. Given that in present-day AmE, the majority of speakers do not have a clear phonemic split between TRAP and BATH words, I expected this to clearly show already throughout the nineteenth century. Second, more North American grammars provide evidence for the split both in relation to the number of grammars that treat pronunciation and the total number of grammars that show evidence of the TRAP-BATH split. Again, as AmE is specifically marked by the absence of this sound change, this is striking. Potential reasons might be that they oriented themselves towards New England speech, which was a highly prestigious variety until the end of WWII, or that they were influenced by British orthoëpists, or at least those who in part adhered more to British norms like Worcester. As we shall see below, the word *laugh* in fact enjoys special status in the lexical distribution of potentially retracted variants, which supports Stanford’s (2020: 262–263) observations on today’s situation in New England. Finally, those grammars with a threefold distinction are exclusively North American. This could be evidence that they were working in the research tradition of Worcester or at least heavily relied on his works for the pronunciation sections of their grammars. It could moreover signal that grammarians deliberately included an intermediate category to avoid either extremes, i.e. the complete absence of any split or what was in the process of becoming the British standard (see Smart’s 1836 and Krapp’s 1919 comments discussed above). Moreover, the phonological environment in which the second vowel category is most frequently used in the threefold-grammars, i.e. before /s/, could be a chronological intermediate stage in the development towards a split

in AmE prestige speech. This would mean that the vowel retracted last in /_s(C)/ environments. In regards to the North American grammars, it is furthermore worth noting that there is no evidence of a nasal short-*a* split.

In the following three sections I examine grammars with a twofold and threefold distinction separately. After that I consider the role of frequency effects and lead words in lexical diffusion and move on to discuss prescriptive commentary and variation in the final section. In all of these sections, I often omit words from the START set because, according to Trapateau (2020: 528), lengthening of the vowel had been completed in pre-/r/ contexts by the end of the eighteenth century. All other relevant phonological environments were however still variable. This is in fact mirrored in the CNG: There is not a single grammar in my data in which START words are collated under the short vowel of *a*. The only words subsumed under the grammarians' category of "short *a*" where the vowel in question occurs before /r/ are words belonging to Wells' (1982) SQUARE or TRAP sets, namely *marry*, *carry*, *carrying*, *sparrow*, *barrel*, *guarantee*, *Haerlem*, *parish*, *there*, *heir* and *sirrah*.² Moreover, no grammar provides evidence for *father* or any other PALM words having a short vowel. To be consistent with Trapateau's analysis and to ensure comparability, I however include the words *father* and *master*, as well as /l/-loss + /m/ environments from the PALM set in the following analysis (see Table 6.1).

6.3 Twofold split

Table 6.4 gives an overview of all grammars in the CNG with two categories for TRAP, BATH, START and PALM words, including the terminology they use and the example words they provide for the environments illustrated in Table 6.1 in Section 6.1, ordered chronologically. Asterisks are used to indicate North American grammars. The dash used in some cells also needs some explanation. It does not signal that no example words are given in the grammars, but that no words from the relevant sets are listed. I zoom in on specifically those grammars which list BATH words in both categories and consider their year of publication to determine if there is a pattern in example words over time.

Looking first, however, at the terminology shown in the table, what nearly all of these grammars have in common is that the first category is regarded mostly as a short sound of the letter *a*. Sometimes they state that it is the short version of their "Italian *a*", or of "ah". Two grammars also refer to it as the "French close" or "short *a*", a reference we can find in Walker (1791: xvi) too as he compares his short sound to the vowel in Fr. *fat* 'conceited', and *matin* 'morning'. The second category of the vowel, which includes START, PALM and BATH words, is mainly

²According to Fowler (1855: 212), the <i> in *sirrah* represents the vowel also found in *fat*.

6 The TRAP-BATH split

Table 6.4: Evidence of a twofold distinction in the CNG, including terminology and example words

grammar	category one		category two	
Greenleaf (1821)*	short Italian sound	—	long Italian sound, middle sound	<i>father, aunt</i>
Oliver (1825)	short quantity of a	<i>bath, lath, dance, glance, grant, plant, glass, last, fast, after, rafter, answer, basket, casket, command, demand, rather, gather, lather</i>	long quantity of a, long Italian sound of a	<i>father, draught, laugh, aunt, calf, half, calve, halve, psalm, calm, balm, psalmist, calmness, balmy</i>
Webber (1832)	short sound of a	—	acute sound of a	<i>father, aunt</i>
Kirkham (1834)*	short sound of a	<i>glass</i>	flat, Italian sound of a	<i>aunt</i>
Sanborn (1840)*	short sound of the Italian ä	—	long Italian ä	<i>aunt, laugh</i>
Doherty (1841)	short sound of ah	<i>laugh</i>	long sound of ah	<i>aunt</i>
Barnes (1842)	short open sound	<i>gather</i>	long open sound	<i>after, rather, laugh, father, calm</i>
Swett (1844)*	short sound of a	—	middle sound of a	<i>father, ask</i>
Smith (1846)	—	—	—	<i>fast</i>
Weld (1848)*	second sound of a	<i>draught</i>	third sound of a	<i>aunt</i>
Brown (1851)*	French, close, curt, short, or stopped a	—	Italian, broadish, grave, or middle a	<i>father, aunt, laugh, laughter</i>
Clarke (1853)	a short, short sound	<i>answer, cask, (glass, pass, ant, basrelief, plant)</i>	middle sound of ar	<i>father, rather, cast, glass, lass, bath, lath, haft, half, aunt, (ant, basrelief, plant)</i>

Barnes (1854)	short open sound	<i>gather</i>	long open sound	<i>after, rather, laugh, father, calm</i>
Brown (1857)*	French, close, or short a	—	Italian, or middle a	<i>father, aunt</i>
Covell (1861)*	short a	<i>grant</i>	Italian a	<i>ask, ant, laugh, aunt, calm, psalm</i>
Lowres (1863)	French or short a	—	Italian or middle a	<i>aunt</i>
Burt (1869)*	a short	—	a grave	<i>ask, calm</i>
Colegrove (1879)*	sound no. 31	—	sound no. 32	<i>aunt, calm</i>
White (1882)	—	—	—	<i>father, staff</i>
Hall & Sonnenschein (1889)	sound 1 ii.	—	sound 1 i.	<i>father, laugh</i>
Nesfield (1900)	ă, æ, no. 1	—	long sound of a, â, aa, no. 3	<i>father, palm, path, ask, aunt</i>

referred to as “Italian *a*”. The terms “broad”, “grave” or “middle” *a* are used as well. Most grammars, however, do not specify what they mean by these terms and presuppose knowledge on the part of the reader about which quality they refer to, or expect a demonstration by the teacher. This is furthermore complicated by the fact that grammars like Brown (1851) apply several terms to one and the same vowel category as “Italian, broadish, grave, or middle *a*”. The only grammar with a twofold distinction that provides some useful hints as to the quality of the different vowels is a very late grammar, namely Nesfield (1900: 278–279).

The vowel in the words *path* and *ask* has a long sound according to Nesfield (1900: 279). About this sound he writes that the “short sound that corresponded with this vowel is extinct in Modern English [...] and had the sound of *a* in A.S. *mann* or German *mann* (which is rather more open than the present sound of *a* in *man*)”. In OE, the vowel Nesfield is referring to would have been nasalised and potentially rounded (as evidenced by variant *monn* spellings) (Fulk 2020: 18). Taken together with the comparison to German and his claim about the openness of the vowel, his comments could suggest an open central or retracted vowel [ɐ̃: ~ ɑ:] with possible rounding.³

³High German has a vowel phonetically between an open front and back vowel, whereas Bavarian speakers generally have a more retracted realisation (Hickey 2020: 560). Anglo-Saxon *a* as in *dagas* ‘days’ or *hāt* ‘hot’ is usually given a low back realisations, i.e. [ɑ] and [ɑ:] (Fulk 2020: 10–11).

If we consider Hickey's (2020: 552) analysis of Walker's dictionary, the short sound of "Italian *a*" is phonemicised as /æ/, while the long "Italian *a*" is /a:/, and "broad *a*" represents /ɑ:, ɒ:/. The term "middle *a*" seems to be used synonymously with "Italian *a*" by Walker. This, according to Jones (2006: 218, 315), likely has a quality of [a ~ ɶ] and is employed as a synonym to "Italian *a*" still in Cooley (1861). The term "long open sound" of the letter *a*, which is found several times in the CNG, can for instance be found in Nares (1784), which Hickey (2020: 552) also gives the phoneme /ɑ:/. The term "*a* grave" is used interchangeably by Worcester (1830) with the "Italian *a*", the category to which words like *far*, *father*, and *part* belong. Thus, if, and only if, nineteenth-century grammarians used terminology in a similar fashion as earlier and contemporary dictionary authors, what the grammars in the CNG with a twofold distinction seem to suggest is a split between [æ] and [a: ~ ɶ:]. Examples like Brown (1851), who also uses the word "broadish" to refer to his second category, could be referring to a more retracted variant.

In terms of example words, the two most important grammars are Oliver (1825) and Clarke (1853), simply because they provide comparatively long lists. As shown in Table 6.4, in Oliver's grammar there seems to be a pattern: The only environments in which he suggests the "long Italian *a*" is before /l/, and in what Trapateau (2020) suggests were the lead words in the lengthening of /a/, namely *father* and ME /au/ words like *aunt*, *laugh*, and *draught*. The word *dance* (ME *dawnce*, *daunse*), nonetheless, has a short vowel. His short vowel category indeed still covers most of the phonological environments of BATH words. Interestingly, Oliver adds a negative social evaluation of short realisations in words like *aunt* in a footnote: "[w]e hear *au* sounded as short *a*; but this is, I think, a provincialism" (Oliver 1825: 293). It is evident that he wants speakers to give words like *laugh* and *aunt* as well as *flaunt*, *jaunt* and *laundry* the sound of his "long Italian sound of *a*". From Barnes (1842) onwards "Italian *a*" is also applied to other phonological environments in the grammars of the CNG, e.g. /_ft, _ðə(r), _sk/ in *after*, *rather*, and *ask*.

Clarke (1853: 37–38) lists "[t]he short sound" of *a* in words like *fat*, *fancy*, *had* and *answer* under the heading "SOUNDS OF THE LETTERS". To the words collated under this category he adds a footnote which reads: "[t]his sound is given before single sounds, not followed by *e* silent, except *h*, *r*, *w*, and *y*; thus *cab*, *cad*, [...] *cask*, *cat*. Before *nt*, *plant*; *nd*, *band*". His second category is "The middle sound of *ar*", which is the vowel found in START words and the following PALM and BATH words: *father*, *rather*, *cast*, *glass*, *lass*, *bath*, *lath*, *haft*, *half*, and *aunt*. He appends a footnote to this sound as well, which explains where his "middle" sound is used: "[t]his sound is given to roots ending with *sp*, *st*, *ss*, as [...] *ft*, as

[...] *r*, as [...] *th*". Thus, in his grammar the split is clearly present and pre-nasal environments (except ME /au/ word *aunt*) and /_sk/ are lagging behind. One page later however he notes variation between the short and "middle" sounds for the words *ant*, *basrelief*, *plant* without any value judgments. He furthermore remarks that because of Irish orthoëpist Thomas Sheridan some speakers may use a short vowel for the words *glass* and *pass*: "[t]here has been sometimes a fashion of saying, *glas* for *glahs*, *pas*, for *pahs*, & c., which was begun by Dr. Sheridan, an Irishman, writer of a pronouncing dictionary". This suggests a reversal of lengthening, albeit not before nasals (as described by Cooley 1861, see Section 6.1). However, clearly for Clarke, the words *glass* and *pass* belong to his "middle *ar*" category.

Table 6.5: Most frequent words favouring /a/ lengthening in grammars with a twofold distinction

examples of "short <i>a</i> "	freq.	examples of "Italian, long, middle, grave <i>a</i> "	freq.
<i>gather, glass</i>	3	<i>aunt</i>	14
<i>answer, grant, plant</i>	2	<i>father</i>	12
<i>after, ant, basket, basrelief</i>	1	<i>laugh</i>	7
<i>bath, cask, casket, command, dance, demand, draught, fast, glance, last, lath, lather, laugh, rafter</i>			
—	—	<i>calm</i>	6
—	—	<i>ask</i>	4

These grammars appear to show a development in the phonological and lexical distribution during the first half of the century. Apart from that, the relation between phonological environment and the year of publication of these grammars shows no clear pattern. For questions regarding the role of pre-nasal environments in the process of the change, the grammars are unfortunately not very helpful. Oliver (1825: 272–273) suggests many words have a short vowel before nasals, e.g. *dance, glance, grant, plant, answer, command, demand*. The word *aunt* generally seems to entertain special status as it can be found from 1821 and throughout the century with a long vowel. Again, strikingly, this is the case regardless of place of publication. The short vowel is suggested as late as Covell (1861), who nonetheless already lists *ant* and *aunt* as having the "Italian *a*". Doherty (1841) and Weld (1848) also have Trapateau's lead words in the short as

well as the long vowel category: *laugh* and *draught* in the former, *aunt* in the latter. *Answer* and *grant* are two more words with ME diphthongs that are equally listed with short vowels in the 1850s and 1860s in British-Irish as well as North American grammars (see Clarke 1853; Covell 1861). Nonetheless, ME /au/ words that have maintained the digraph <au> like *aunt* or *laugh* are clearly used more frequently for the second category, i.e. “Italian, long, middle, grave *a*”, of the vowel by grammarians, as illustrated in Table 6.5. However, very few grammars include BATH words in their “short *a*” category in the CNG in the first place. This could be due to the fact that this category contains many TRAP words and that some grammars only give few example words to illustrate the different sounds to begin with. Even some grammars like Swett (1844), which describe sounds for every letter and every attested combination of letters, usually give one to three examples per spelling. Since the vowels in TRAP and BATH are rarely represented by digraphs (ME /au/ and <ai> spellings in *plaister* ‘plaster’ aside), this automatically reduces the number of example words.

It is also striking that there does not seem to be any pattern depending on the place of publication of the grammars except that two more North American grammars use the example word *aunt* for the second category. Nonetheless, the word is equally prominent in the British-Irish grammars and this low difference in absolute numbers can be accounted for by the generally lower number of British-Irish grammars for this feature. This is surprising, again, as for several reasons already mentioned, we would certainly expect North American grammars to behave differently than British-Irish grammars. It is furthermore noticeable that Brown and Kirkham, despite their disputes (see Section 2.2), see eye to eye in terms of the twofold distinction and that for them *aunt* belongs to the category of “Italian *a*”. The only difference here is the terms they use to refer to this vowel. What is clear from Table 6.5, however, is that the most frequently used example words of “Italian *a*”, regardless of place of publication, overlap with Trapateau’s (2020) proposed lead words in the lengthening of the vowel. Yet, numbers are generally low, and many words are only mentioned in one grammar.

If we include START words in the analysis, it becomes clear that together with *aunt*, *laugh* and *father*, the words *heart*, *far*, *guard*, and *clerk* are frequently used as examples of the sound in the CNG, as shown in Figure 6.3, which is a word cloud of all examples used for the category of “Italian”, “long”, “middle”, and “grave” *a* in grammars with a twofold split. Moreover, words belonging to the lexical set THOUGHT like *flaunt* are at times mentioned in addition to *aunt* in both British-Irish and North American grammars. This categorisation could simply be an analogy based on the spelling of words like *aunt*. However, it is especially for the North American grammars this could indicate a merger of the



Figure 6.3: Word cloud showing the second category in grammars with a twofold distinction

THOUGHT, PALM, and LOT sets, which is attested in present-day varieties, albeit highly variable (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017: xx). Moreover, in the dictionaries in the ECEP there was also variation with respect to which transcription is given the word *laundry*. Only Spence's transcription is identified as a long rounded open-mid back vowel [ɔ:], while the others either have [æ] or more often [a:], e.g. Walker (1791). Indeed, for Walker words like *aunt*, *flaunt*, or *laundry* all have the "Italian sound of the *a*". These results could thus also point to the influence of eighteenth-century orthoëpists. Sanborn (1840: 11), for instance, writes that "[*a*]u before *n* or *gh* has the sound of *a* in far; as in aunt, flaunt, haunt, laugh, launch, laundress, taunt, jaunt, jaundice" (see also Oliver 1825; Brown 1851; Clarke 1853; Brown 1857; Lowres 1863). The frequency of these words can at least in part also be explained by the procedure many grammars follow, as previously noted. If a grammarian discusses sounds based on spelling in alphabetical order, including all orthographically possible combinations, it is unsurprising that comparatively many START words end up functioning as examples of this sound. START words can be represented by <a>, <e>, <ea>, and <ua> spellings, which can also be seen Figure 6.3, while many BATH words are represented simply by <a>, even some with earlier diphthongal values.

6.4 Threefold split

Regarding the threefold split, grammars usually suggest a short sound, an “intermediate”, “middle”, “medial”, or “slender” sound of the letter *a*, and another one they term “grave”, “long”, or “Italian”. Thus, in addition to the two categories of grammars discussed in the previous section, these grammars add a third sound which occupies an intermediate position between the two, as illustrated in Table 6.6. Similar to Table 6.4, this table shows all grammars with a threefold split, including their terminology and example words belonging to the BATH set as well as /_lm/ words and *father* and *master*. They are furthermore ordered chronologically, and in terms place of publication these are exclusively North American grammars, as shown by the asterisk. In grammars with a threefold distinction, BATH words are usually split between the second and third category, namely the intermediate and “grave *a*” or “Italian *a*” categories. The latter otherwise includes START and PALM words, while the former only contains BATH words. There is only one grammar which suggests that BATH words are split across all three categories, namely Hyde (1895). Her grammar does not feature a proper section on pronunciation but only pronunciation exercises. Based on these, *gather* patterns with TRAP words, while several BATH words are distributed across the other two categories.

As regards terminology and potential vowel quality, both of Harvey’s (1868, 1900) grammars are interesting cases because neither grammar shows uses of “middle *a*” which are synonymous with “Italian *a*”, in contrast to the grammars in the previous section. This perhaps suggests that “middle” in this case refers to the relation it has to short and “Italian”, and not to the relation between “short *a*” and “broad *a*”. In his 1868 grammar, this second category contains *ask* and the two SQUARE words *there* and *heir*. This is both shown in Figure 6.4. FACE and SQUARE words however are distinct, as are DRESS words. Technically, this could suggest a lowered quality of SQUARE words or a slightly raised quality of this “a middle”. It could also stand for a lengthened vowel. Unfortunately, Harvey does not provide any information on the presence or absence of post-vocalic /r/, which could have shed some light on the matter, but lowering before /r/ must have been very widespread. Similarly, raising of TRAP was also a common phenomenon (see Hickey 2017c; Purnell et al. 2017 and the discussion of Webber 1832 in Section 5.2). As noted in Section 6.2, there is LModE evidence of some potential overlap of the DRESS, TRAP, FACE and SQUARE categories.

Fowler (1855) is one of two grammarians in the CNG, together with Nesfield (1900), who provides sufficient articulatory information on the realisation of the vowel to deduce a potential quality. He describes the sound in the word *father*,

Table 6.6: Evidence of a threefold distinction in the CNG, including terminology and example words

grammar	category one		category two		category three	
Wells (1847)*	a short	—	intermediate between grave and short	<i>fast, ant, glass, plant, prance, glance, past, mast, grass, branch, advance</i>	a grave	<i>calm, father, balm</i>
Kenyon (1849)*	a short grave	—	a slender	<i>last</i>	a grave	—
Fowler (1855)*	The short sound (of Italian a)	—	slightly modified Italian sound	<i>pass, dance</i>	ancient or Italian sound of a	<i>father, aunt</i>
Harvey (1868)*	a short	—	a middle	<i>ask</i>	a Italian	—
Kerl (1868)*	(short vowel)	—	shade vowel	<i>ask</i>	(long vowel)	—
Holbrook (1869)*	a short	—	a medial	<i>ask</i>	a Italian	—
Raub (1880)*	Ä	—	Å	<i>ask</i>	ä	—
Ridpath (1881)*	ä short	—	à thin	<i>grass</i>	ä Italian	<i>father</i>
Metcalf & Metcalf (1894)*	short or explosive	—	short	<i>ask</i>	long	—
Hyde (1895)*	Ä	<i>gather</i>	à (interme- diate between ä and ä)	<i>past, last, fast, pass, mass, glass, class, grass, after, afternoon, pastor, master, ant, answer, chance, basket</i>	ä	<i>calf, half, laugh, father, balm, palm, psalm, calm, alms, aunt, can't, shan't, bath, path</i>
Harvey (1900)*	a short	—	a middle	<i>ask</i>	a Italian	—

TABLE OF ELEMENTARY SOUNDS.

4. Vowels.

a long, as in late.	i long, as in time.
a short, “ hat.	i short, “ tin.
a middle, “ ask.	o long, “ cold.
a Italian, “ arm.	o short, “ hot.
a broad, “ all.	oo long, “ ooze.
e long, “ eve.	oo short, “ book.
e short, “ ell.	u long, “ lute.
	u short, “ cup.

A Substitute represents a sound usually represented by another letter or combination of letters.

A long has four substitutes: *ê*, tête; *ei*, feint; *ey*, they; *ao*, gaol.

A middle has two substitutes: *e*, there; *ei*, heir.

A broad has two substitutes: *o*, cord; *ou*, sought.

Figure 6.4: “TABLE OF ELEMENTARY SOUNDS” and beginning of the section on “Substitutes”, taken from Harvey (1868: 9, 12), digitised by Google Books

and thus the one in *aunt*, in relation to the one in *fall*. The vowel he describes for *fall* is likely a low back vowel with slight lip rounding, [ɔ], as he describes the contraction of the tongue towards the tongue root as well as a “circular form” of the mouth: “[t]he fourth, that of *a* in *fall*, is produced by forcibly driving out the breath, modified in its passage by the tongue’s contracting itself to the root, the mouth being open in nearly a circular form” (Fowler 1855: 149). For the vowel in *father* he notes: “[t]he first, that of *a* in *father*, closes the mouth a little more than the fourth (see below), and, raising the lower jaw, widening the tongue, and advancing it a little nearer to the lips, its sound is less hollow and deep” (Fowler 1855: 149). This could indicate a quality like [ɛ], because based on his description it is raised and more front. That the sound is “less hollow and deep” could very well indicate the higher F2 frequency compared to his back vowel in *fall*. For the vowel in words like *pass* or *dance* he unfortunately only states: “[t]he ancient or

Table 6.7: Most frequent words favouring /a/ lengthening in grammars with a threefold distinction

“intermediate <i>a</i> ”	freq.	“Italian, long, grave <i>a</i> ”	freq.
<i>ask</i>	6	<i>father</i>	4
<i>grass</i>	3	<i>aunt, balm, calm</i>	2
<i>ant, fast, glass, last, pass, past</i>	2	<i>alms, bath, calf, can’t, half,</i> <i>laugh, palm, path, psalm,</i> <i>shan’t</i>	1

Italian sound, as in *father*, [...] is slightly modified in certain combinations, as in *pass, dance*” (Fowler 1855: 204).

With the exception of Harvey’s grammars, all words found under the intermediate category are BATH words. While *ask* is the most frequently employed example word of the middle category, Wells (1847) and Hyde (1895) provide evidence from the middle and the end of the century that undoubtedly shows that more phonological environments had this vowel. The most frequently mentioned example words in the “intermediate” and “Italian *a*” categories are illustrated in Table 6.7. Numbers are lower than for grammars with a twofold distinction, but *father* and *aunt* again seem to occupy a special position amongst grammarians. Moreover, the following /s/ seems to play a crucial role in the intermediate category as reflected in the most frequently used example words except *ant*. At first glance there is no apparent chronological pattern in Table 6.6, but considering the examples used in the intermediate category this changes. If we take the intermediate category to represent a chronological in-between stage, perhaps representing a lengthened but unretracted (or at least not fully retracted) vowel, we could make the cautious claim that /_s(C)/ environments were the final stage in the emerging split. Indeed, lengthened (and retracted) vowels did carry overt prestige way into twentieth-century America. The examples from the CNG could be interpreted as tentative evidence for a parallel development of retraction to the eighteenth-century trajectory of lengthening suggested by Hickey (2020: 559), where amongst others pre-/s/ environments changed last.

The distribution and relative frequency of all example words in these 11 grammars is illustrated in three treemaps, including TRAP, THOUGHT, BATH, START, PALM and SQUARE words. The size of the rectangles represents the frequency of the word. Thus, the more frequently an example word is mentioned the bigger the rectangle is in relation to the others. The different colours bear no specific

meaning but are used only to make differences between words more visible. As a complement to Table 6.4 and Table 6.6, the maps include all example words used in any of the grammars with a threefold split. Considering all lexical sets, they show some *START* words for the third category, with *arm* being the most frequent word of all (7 grammars). The intermediate category is clearly representative of *BATH* words and particularly of pre-/s/ environments. Table 6.7 and Figure 6.5 both show a great number of hapaxes in the CNG, meaning that many words are solely mentioned once as examples. This shows that the typical key words for the three categories are *hat* for the short vowel, *ask* for the intermediate vowel, and *arm* and *father* for the long vowel category. While this could point to the frequency of use, it could furthermore be part of the tradition of nineteenth-century grammarians to use exactly these words to refer to certain vowels in a similar fashion that nowadays many phonologists employ Wells' (1982) lexical sets (see Chapter 4). This equally applies to words like *aunt* and *father* in the previous section.

6.5 Frequency effects and lead words in the diffusion through *BATH* words

So far, we have seen that in the grammars with a twofold distinction, there seems to have been a shift in the first half of the century, while in those with a threefold split a chronological pattern can only be assumed if we consider the presence of an intermediate vowel category to mean an in-between stage in the gradual change towards a long and retracted vowel. The data reveal three important points with respect to the lexical and phonological distribution: The words *aunt*, *laugh* and *father* are ubiquitous in the grammarians' examples of what we could interpret as lengthened (and maybe slightly retracted) vowel, irrespective of place of publication. In grammars with a threefold distinction, which were all exclusively published in North America, *ask* is the prime example of the intermediate vowel category, while *father* and *aunt* also occur frequently in their third category. Furthermore, in the intermediate category examples mainly show the vowel in /_s(C)/ positions.

I have suggested that the frequent use of some example words could be due to the make-up of these grammars and the way they discuss sound-spelling correspondence, but that it could also represent the salience of these words. In any case, it is to be seen critically whether example words grammarians used to illustrate their vowel categories are representative of how far the change had progressed. As I have previously suggested, their use of certain words to show

6.5 Frequency effects and lead words in the diffusion through BATH words

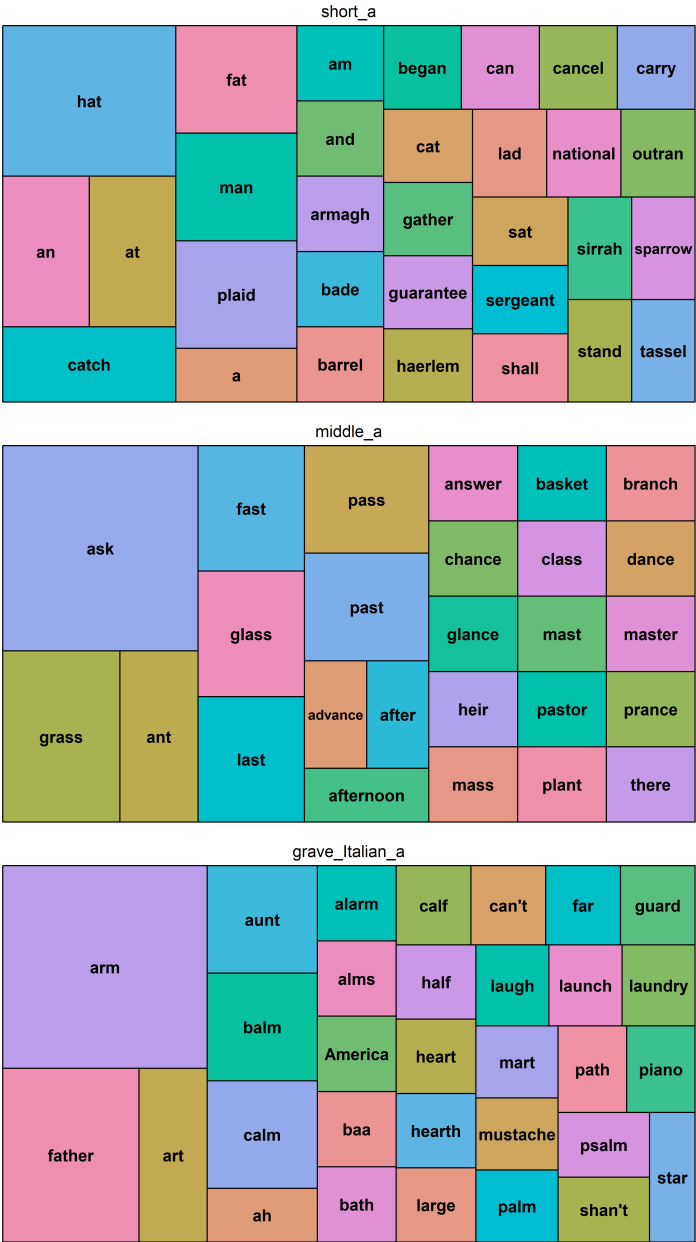


Figure 6.5: Treemaps of example words used for “short *a*”, “middle *a*” and “grave/Italian *a*” in 11 North American grammars

the number of different vowel sounds might have been similar to our use of Wells' (1982) lexical sets. Perhaps it was simply common to refer to a sound as the sound in *ask*, *aunt* or *father*. Another possibility is that grammarians simply copied passages from each other or from earlier authors, which would have led to some words occurring more frequently than others, and hence results for word frequencies would be less representative.

Of course, it is still possible that the most frequent example words in these grammars had become established as having the respective vowel because they were words affected early in the process or because they were indeed generally frequent words. Regardless of how reliable the grammars were, the use of example words can tell us something about the process of the change. What is also safe to say is that in the CNG *aunt*, *laugh*, *father* and *ask* take up a special status in terms of non-short vowels for BATH words. These overlap, with the exception of *ask*, with Trapateau's forerunners of the change to lengthened BATH words. This supports his claim that it was the type of word, namely those descended from ME /au/ and /ai/, rather than frequency effects that determined the early use of a lengthened vowel. As I have stated before, I refrain from hypothesising to what extent the vowel was retracted because other than Brown's (1851) use of the term "broadish" to refer to the sound, and Fowler's (1855) and Nesfield's (1900) descriptions of the vowel, there is no sufficient evidence to back up any discussion on retractedness of the vowel (see also my discussion on the difficulty of assessing vowel qualities above). However, what is worth testing are potential frequency effects and to determine if *aunt*, *laugh*, *father*, and *ask* were in general frequently used in the nineteenth century. I thus replicate part of Trapateau's approach and add data from AmE texts, which is necessary since neither the nineteenth century nor AmE are represented in his paper.

To measure frequency effects, I obtained normalised frequencies for the nineteenth century from ARCHER and the COHA for all example words where the vowel would occur in any of the phonological environments depicted in Table 6.1. I then compared how frequent the words which were employed as examples in the CNG were in the corpora. In both corpora I obtained frequencies per one million words of lemmata for the entire nineteenth century. The COHA however does not contain any texts from before 1820. Therefore, the data from the COHA represent frequencies of words covering texts from 1820 until 1899, while those obtained from ARCHER span the time from 1800 until 1899. In contrast to Trapateau (2020), I refrain from consulting texts from the eighteenth and twentieth centuries. The reason for that is that I want to clearly demarcate the time period that the CNG covers also in the frequency data. Despite the fact that the COHA (ca. 475 million words) is considerably bigger than ARCHER (ca. 4 million words),

the five most frequently represented words out of the examples in the CNG are *after*, *last*, *pass*, *father*, *ask* in both corpora.

In the grammars with a twofold distinction the most frequent example words are *aunt* (14 grammars), *father* (12 grammars) and *laugh* (7 grammars), with all START words excluded, as in Table 6.5. In nine grammars, *aunt* was in fact the only BATH word that was included under the example words of that vowel category (aside from *father*). In those with a threefold distinction it is also *aunt* and *father* that are the two most frequent examples of the potentially most retracted/lengthened variant. Of 66 example words *laugh* and *aunt* are only the fourteenth and twenty-ninth most frequent words in ARCHER but ninth and twenty-first in the COHA (see Tables A.3 and A.4 in the Appendix). They are thus still comparatively frequent but not part of the five most frequent words. The word *father* fits both the criteria of high frequency words and of Trapateau's lead words, whereas *aunt*, and *laugh* only fit the latter criterion. The word *laugh* may also be particularly susceptible to a non-short/front realisation, as Stanford (2020: 262–263) observed that the use of [a:] in present-day New England data is indeed most common in the word *laugh*. Four North American grammars give this in their second/third category, namely Sanborn (1840), Brown (1851), Covell (1861), and Hyde (1895). The word *ask* is not part of the lead words (as it comes from ME /a/) but is generally a high-frequency word. While general numbers are low, this seems to confirm Trapateau's suggestion. Yet, it may also point to a mixture of criteria affecting the diffusion of the vowel exemplified by the frequency of *father* and *ask*. This is especially the case since former diphthongal realisations are not visible in the orthography in *father*. As I have suggested earlier, this could have also influenced the grammarians' choice of example words as shown in the example of *dance*. Many of them were still highly influenced by the spelling as shown by them referring to the “sounds of the letter *a*” (see also Chapter 3).

6.6 Prescriptions and dialectal variation

As with FACE and GOAT, there are almost no prescriptive comments on this feature. Nonetheless, the CNG shows some prescriptions and proscriptions as well as some descriptions of variation. I discuss both under the same section since both types of grammars acknowledge some variant forms; some accept them, others condone or frown upon them. In the six grammars excluded from the previous quantitative analysis only variation (Kelke 1885; Gow 1892; Carpenter 1902), conflicting categorisations (Brown 1849), or prescriptions (Leigh 1840; Cobbin 1864) are given. They mention variation in BATH words without proposing a

categorisation of words themselves. Another six of those that have so far been discussed include variation (Clarke 1853; Fowler 1855; Nesfield 1900) or prescriptions (Oliver 1825; Kirkham 1834; Wells 1847) in addition to a description of vowel categories for the letter *a*.

Thus, out of these 12 grammars, five include prescriptions (Oliver 1825; Kirkham 1834; Leigh 1840; Wells 1847; Cobbin 1864) while the remaining grammars provide evidence for variation without any value judgments (Clarke 1853; Fowler 1855; Kelke 1885; Gow 1892; Nesfield 1900; Carpenter 1902). I have examined Oliver's negative evaluation of short vowels in *aunt* in Section 6.3. I begin this section with the four remaining grammars that show prescriptions.

Kirkham (1834: 21), whose grammar was published in Rochester, New York and is heavily influenced by Murray's grammar(s), generally only includes *aunt* out of all BATH words in his list of the "flat, Italian sound". Under his section of "PROVINCIALISMS, CONTRACTIONS, VULGARISMS, AND OTHER IMPROPRIETIES" he lists *father* with a short vowel (his *a*⁴ as in *fat*) as incorrect. According to Kirkham (1834: 201–207), the vowel has to be the same as in *far* (his *a*²). This echoes what we have seen in many other grammars but could furthermore point to the retention of short vowel realisation in some speakers. If there had not been any speakers that used this short realisation, he perhaps would not have felt the need to include this example. He moreover gives the "improper" realisations of *glass*, *mass*, *brass*, *pass* with the vowel in *far* as "COMMON IN NEW ENGLAND OR NEW YORK". Based on the criteria established in Chapter 4, this clearly constitutes a negative social evaluation of a specific region, and points to a negative attitude to the prestigious but also rural and conservative eastern pronunciation. Kirkham (1834: 205) prescribes the vowel in *fat* for /_s/ environments and the word-form *asked*. This is furthermore evidence of the special status of the words *aunt* and *father* as long realisations are accepted for these words but not in words like *glass* and *pass*.

Leigh (1840: 25–26) in his *Comic English Grammar*, published in London, gives evidence of long and potentially retracted vowels in the words *can't*, *shan't*, *tart* and *are* by means of parodying Cockneys and dandies. A Cockney is "[a] native of London, especially a working-class person from the East End of London" (OED: s.v. *cockney* 4.a); the word *dandy* refers to a person "who studies above everything to dress elegantly and fashionably" (OED: s.v. *dandy* n. I.1.a.). Cockneys are reported to say "I caun't. You shaun't. How's your Maw and Paw? Do you like taut (tart)?" (Leigh 1840: 25). This suggests the same vowel in START words and *can't* and *shan't*. An example of a dandy he adds after this also includes the respelling *au* 'are' (Leigh 1840: 26). The respellings could indicate an analogy to BATH words like *aunt* or *laugh* or THOUGHT words like *caught*, *taught*, or *laud*; the

latter of which are referred to as having “broad (German) *a*” in late eighteenth-century sources (e.g. Walker 1791: 11; Murray 1795: 4; see also Hickey 2020). In the same passage, he claims that “[w]e have heard young ladies remark,— [...] ‘I’m so fond of dayncing!’” (Leigh 1840: 25). This could suggest a long, raised vowel by using <ay> FACE spellings or diphthongisation. In a previous section, Leigh (1840: 16) similarly seems to indicate TRAP raising through respelling *James* as *jemes*. In terms of prescription, these are all social evaluations based on the speakers’ class background or gender. However, one of Leigh’s aims is to teach good English by means of parody: “as serious English Grammars have hitherto failed to effect the desired reformation, we are induced to attempt it by means of a Comic one” (Leigh 1840: ix). While this of course does not justify his treatment of proposedly non-standard speech, it is an explanation as to why we encounter Leigh again in many sections of the present work.

Wells (1847: 31) is one of the grammars with a threefold distinction and indeed he insists that words from the intermediate category are to be pronounced differently from the short and “grave” sounds of the letter *a*: “[i]ntermediate between the short and the grave; as in grass, pass, branch. Many persons pronounce this *a* incorrectly, giving it either the grave or the short sound”. In a footnote to this he specifies who some of these “many persons” are:

Perry, Jones, Nares, Webster, and Day, give to *a* in *grass* the grave sound, as in *father*; while Walker, Jameson, and Russell, give it the short sound, as in *man*. But good speakers generally pronounce *a* in *grass*, *plant*, etc., as a distinct element, intermediate between the grave and the short sound.

Wells does not shy away from criticising renowned dictionary authors like Nares, Webster, or Walker. This shows very well that there was no consensus as to how many categories for BATH words there should be. It illustrates the presence of a change in progress in the first half of the century with various words taking at least three different phonetic values, and that North American scholars like Wells seems to have been working in the tradition of Worcester (or Smart), rather than more nationalistic lexicographers like Webster. In Wells’ (1847: iii) references – he provides a “catalogue” with “those grammars to which special reference is made in the pages of the following work” – we can indeed find Worcester and Smart, but also Webster, in there (Wells 1847: iii–viii). While this does not explain why he apparently chose to follow Worcester or Smart, it certainly shows that he did know his sources.

Cobbin (1864: 82) identifies the use of the vowel from START words in BATH (and THOUGHT) words as a London feature, a change he evidently disapproves of

as his social evaluation of the speakers shows: “[t]he vulgar Londoners [...] say [...] *sarcepan* for *saucepan* [...] *plarnt*, for *plant*; *arnt* for *ant*, & c.; indeed several of the latter errors are committed by respectable persons, who do not attend to correct pronunciation, but still they are considered vulgar”. This suggests that a long (back) realisation was potentially used not only by speakers from the lower classes in London by the 1860s, but also by speakers of higher rank. However, according to Cobbin, these did not concern themselves with matters of pronunciation it seems. It is important that Cobbin’s grammar was published in London as his association was with a particular type of speakers in England, rather than the English as a whole.

The passages just discussed show that all grammars that include prescriptions concerning the BATH set proscribe long variants, except in *aunt* in Kirkham’s (1834) case. Oliver (1825) also only allows long realisations before /l/ and in /au/ words like *aunt*, where he explicitly proscribes short realisations. Wells (1847) on the other hand specifically calls for an intermediate pronunciation before /n(s)/ and /s(t)/. Kirkham’s comments, as a North American grammarian highly influenced by Murray, do not seem surprising. What is striking is that Kirkham proscribes a short vowel in *father* and lists a long vowel for *aunt* since Murray, at least in his first four editions, gives *father* and *aunt* a short vowel. Why he diverges from Murray here is not clear, but it could represent the genuine presence of long vowels in these two words in speakers he was in contact with. For Wells, however, we could assume either a reliance on Worcester or equally that this was simply the distribution that he considered most adequate due to the avoidance of either extremes (see Krapp’s comments above).

In all cases of value judgments, all the evaluations belong to category Social Evaluation, as expressions like “provincialism”, “vulgar”, or “improper” show. All grammars, except Oliver’s (1825), have furthermore been categorised as belonging to the category Mistake. Moreover, except Cobbin (1864), all grammars that proscribe long realisations of BATH words are from the first half of the century, whereas those that discuss variation, either solely or in addition to a general categorisation, are exclusively from the second half of the century. This could potentially indicate a more neutral attitude in grammars from the second half of the century, which is an argument I will come back to in later sections of the present study. It could furthermore be evidence of an acceptance of the change, especially in the British-Irish Isles. However, as we shall see below, just because a grammar is less prescriptive about one particular feature it does not in turn mean that there are no prescriptions or social evaluations in the grammar.

As regards grammars that mention or provide evidence for variation in a neutral fashion, I have already discussed Clarke’s reference to Sheridan as the rea-

son for short vowel pronunciations in *glass* and *pass* in Section 6.3. In the North American grammar by Brown (1849), we find conflicting categorisations and various differences in terminology. For instance, he identifies the sound in *arm* as “long rough vowel” and the one in *axe* as “short sharp vowel” (Brown 1849: 19). He lists the words *baa*, *heart*, *guard*, *Ah* as belonging to the same category as *arm*, whereas *aunt* is in the same category as *axe* (Brown 1849: 35–36). However, later in his grammar (Brown 1849: 45–49) the words *laundry*, *launch*, *aunt*, *heart*, *hearth*, *hearken*, *baa* all have the “shortish flat sound of *a*”, a term he did not use in any of the previous sections. In yet another section (Brown 1849: 50–53) the word *guard* receives the “shortish sharp *a* sound”, while *guarantee* receives the “short close *a* sound”. It is not clear from his grammar what these different terms refer to and why words like *aunt* are said to have a “short” sound and a few pages further in a “shortish” sound. The word *baa* equally receives his “long rough” sound in one section while in the next it is referred to as having a “shortish” sound. At no point, however, does he suggest that *aunt* has a long vowel. One reason for these differences in terminology and distribution of words could be that different parts of his grammar were influenced by or copied from other authors. Indeed, while he complains about others’ use of Murray in their grammars (like Kirkham, Greenleaf, or Gould Brown) in his preface, he does admit that the present book (which is Book II of three volumes) is a “*substitute* for the old theory” (Brown 1849: xix). His use of “shortish” could potentially indicate some intermediate form in length. Regardless, this makes him one of the grammarians in the CNG who does not clearly describe the word *aunt* as having a long vowel (together with Fisk 1822 and Hiley 1857 as discussed in Section 6.2).

Fowler (1855), whose grammar was published in North America, mentions the variants *cauf* and *hawpenny* for *calf* and *halfpenny* for the northern counties, which he defines as “the dialect of Northumberland, which resembles the Lowland Scotch of Cumberland, Durham, and Westmoreland. To these counties might be added York and Lancaster, Derbyshire and Cheshire”. The word *call* he claims is *caw* in this area. This illustrates on the one hand /l/-vocalisation in environments where it is a historical change typical of Scots (Stuart-Smith 2004: 63; Stuart-Smith et al. 2007: 232), as well as potentially a rounded and retracted vowel. However, the vowel that is likely represented here is rather uncommon for the area except that whenever the vowels in words like *master*, *plaster* or *disaster* do not have a short vowel, the vowel is indeed a long rounded realisation (Beal 2004a: 123). Other <a> spellings which would belong to the TRAP set in RP have retracted realisations in Scots (Stuart-Smith 2004: 55; Hughes et al. 2012: 159). Nonetheless, it is possible that these digraph spellings are simply meant to suggest /l/ vocalisation, see for instance Yorkshire and Scots spellings of the

word *old*: <owd>, <oud>, or <awd> (Cooper 2023: 473; for a detailed discussion of the history of the word in Scots see Maguire 2020b).

Kelke (1885: 35) describes variation that we would expect based on the present-day distribution in England, where a long vowel is used for BATH words in the South whereas in the North more frequently short realisations can be found: “[i]n many words educated Northerners and Southerners sound a differently. Thus, S. *grāss*, *dānce*, are Nor. *grāss*, *dānce*”. Directly after that he adds that “[t]he vowel-scales of ‘Cockneys’ and many Provincials are peculiar, mostly made up of diphthongs and double-vowels”. It is unclear to what extent this comment is supposed to refer to the vowel in words like *grass* or *dance* or if this is a general comment he feels the need to communicate to his readers. In any case, this interestingly shows that both variants seem equally accepted in “educated” speech, rather than a stigma attached towards the incoming or northern form.

While Gow’s (1892) grammar generally includes a vowel categorisation, the only examples he uses are *father*, *balmy* and *baa* which have the vowel “aa”, which he describes as a long vowel. He bases his transcriptions on Ellis, but slightly alters them (Gow 1892: 11–13). This vowel has the “mouth channel” “as wide as possible”, thus suggesting a long low vowel (Gow 1892: 8). In addition, Gow provides dialect and standard English transcriptions for various exercises and poems, based on his altered transcription system. From these we can gather that in the standard system the words *basket*, *laughter*, *can’t*, *commanding*, *fast*, and *past* have a long vowel (Gow 1892: 12–15). This seemingly shows a full split, while of course not all environments are covered by these words. Moreover, he includes transcriptions in a southern, northern Midlands and a Lowland Scots dialect (Gow 1892: 16–21). The southern dialect, which he defines as “spoken, with slight variations, in Wilts, Dorset, most of Somerset and Gloucester, and adjacent parts of other counties” (Gow 1892: 16) and therefore mainly the South-West. Here we find the word *passing* realised with the vowel in *father* and a short vowel as well as consonant metathesis in *asked* as it is transcribed “akst”, which is likely a lexicalised variant. Gow, as many other grammarians in the CNG, mixes lexical, grammatical and phonological features in his exercises. The distribution of the vowel in BATH words is a complicated one in the South-West and some regions have a split, e.g. Southampton (see Altendorf & Watt 2004: 198–199). In any case, this only provides little evidence of how the vowel was distributed in the area given the scarcity of examples in his transcription. In the north Midlands and Lowland Scots transcriptions there are no BATH words whatsoever. It is however worth noting that for the Midlands he lists TRAP words as well as words like *wantest*, *saw*, *all* as having the vowel of standard English *father*. In his Scots example we furthermore find examples of *take* (see the discussion in

Section 5.3 on “short FACE” in the North), *long*, and *caught* as well as several TRAP words. The pronunciation with an unrounded vowel in *wantest*, *saw*, and *all* are historical pronunciations which are also found in traditional dialects of the Midlands (Clark 2004: 150, 159), as are values like /a:/ in Scots, also for words like *long* (McColl Millar 2007: 40–41; Hughes et al. 2012: 159). Beal (2004a: 121) also lists /a:/ as one possible variant in THOUGHT words for the North of England. In general, Scottish varieties, including Scots, and dialects from the North and Midlands only have one phoneme for TRAP and BATH words. Indeed, one grammar in the CNG, namely Oliver (1825) discussed above, still provides evidence of variation indicating a categorisation with TRAP words or with THOUGHT words in *al-* words like *alternate* in his perceived standard. Gow (1892) gives evidence for variants typical of twentieth-century dialects, albeit in a sporadic fashion. I argue in Chapters 13 and 14 that his grammar, together with a few others, overall employs a comparatively neutral tone and provides converging evidence to previous studies for phonological variation in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century.

The only variation that Nesfield (1900: 457) seems to indicate is in the word *cart* when he discusses the sound of *ah*, *path* and *calm*. One line in this passage suggests that *cart* does not always have the same vowel as *path* and *calm*, but only does so in the South of England: “the name is sounded like the modern English *ah* (*a* in *path*, *al* in *calm*, and even (in many parts of Southern England) as *ar* in *cart*)”. What he could be referring to in this example is that the vowel is similar simply due to /r/-loss in the South as he essentially states in an earlier passage in his grammar that only the North of England is still rhotic (Nesfield 1900: 271).

Carpenter (1902: 223) provides a very thorough description of dialectal variation, including potential misunderstandings based on differing levels of vowel raising in regional varieties. In sum, he states that speakers of English all have the same vowel in *last* and *pass* as in *man*, with the exception of speakers from London and New England, where it takes the vowel from *far*. The vowel in New England he describes as located between the vowels in *far* and *man* and therefore presumably [ɛ: ~ a:]. He furthermore notes vowel raising in the same words for New York and northern England, with realisations which represent a quality between the vowel in *man* and *hen*, which likely indicates [æ ~ ɛ]. All this conforms to twenty and twenty-first century usage. The traditional New England quality has been noted above, although Johnson & Durian (2017: 277–283) show based on recordings from the 1930s that the historical situation must have been more complex there. In New York, the traditional realisation is an ingliding front vowel, represented phonemically by /ɛ̞/ (Newman 2014: 52). While the

closer quality seems uncommon for present-day northern British English, there is indeed evidence in recordings from the late 1920s to the late 1930s that raised variants [æ ~ ε ~ ɛ:] were in use in TRAP and BATH words in the North-East (Watt & Foulkes 2017: 154). While we would expect the presence of the split to be more widespread in England than simply London, this could come from an association with London as the standard. Furthermore, what he could be referring to is the difference between a split with [a:] or with [ɑ:] in BATH words. For instance, the SED data (see Figure 6.1 in Section 6.1) show for traditional dialects that [ɑ:] in the word *last* only occurs in London and the surrounding area and in the north-eastern part of East-Anglia (Orton et al. 1978).

6.7 TRAP-BATH split: Summary

As shown in Sections 6.3 and 6.4, the TRAP-BATH split seems to have reached its twentieth-century distribution by the time of Kelke (1885), Gow (1892), Nesfield (1900), and Carpenter (1902), as suggested by their categorisations of vowels as well as their statements concerning dialectal variation. Examining the temporal distribution more closely, a crucial development in the first half of the century can be found, at least based on those grammars with a twofold split. This is also evident in the pre- and proscriptions that occur mainly in the first half of the century (except Cobbin 1864), as summarised in Table 6.8. As in previous tables of this kind, British-Irish grammars are unmarked and asterisks indicate North American grammars.

Overall, however, hardly any grammar provides proper articulatory information on the vowels in words from the BATH set and evidence of more retracted vowels in the BATH set is wanting. In addition, this type of evidence is notoriously difficult to obtain from written sources like grammars. If we tried to derive a quality simply based on the terminology they used and how this has been interpreted, we could cautiously suggest a split between [æ] and [a: ~ ɑ:] for the twofold grammars. In twofold grammars like Brown (1851) and Nesfield (1900) [ɑ:] is also possible for the BATH category. In the grammars with a threefold split, the terminology implies a distinction between [æ], [a:], and [ɑ:]. Nonetheless, phonetic terminology and transcription were not yet standardised. As I have previously argued, there is a possibility that it was neither clear to the authors of the grammars nor to the teachers and students which exact phonetic values were meant with these terms. As for the authors, they could have simply copied the terms from other renowned orthoëpists. The students likely relied on their teachers' demonstration, who in turn might have consulted their own intuition.

Table 6.8: Summary of prescriptive comments, and grammars describing variation in BATH words

grammar	short and intermediate vowel	long vowel
Oliver (1825)	remaining BATH words are listed as short	prescribes long vowel in <i>aunt</i> <i>father</i> , /_IC/, ME /au/ are listed as long
Kirkham (1834)*	prescribes short vowel in BATH words	prescribes long vowel in <i>father</i> <i>aunt</i> is long
Leigh (1840)	prescribes short/non-retracted vowel in <i>can't</i> and <i>shan't</i>	—
Wells (1847)*	prescribes intermediate vowel in BATH words	<i>father</i> listed as long
Clarke (1853)	<i>glass</i> , <i>pass</i> , <i>ant</i> , <i>basrelief</i> , <i>plant</i> may be short	BATH words except <i>answer</i> , <i>cask</i> listed as long
Fowler (1855)*	—	(long/retracted vowel in <i>calf</i> and <i>halfpenny</i> in the North)
Cobbin (1864)	prescribes short vowel in <i>plant</i> and <i>ant</i>	
Kelke (1885)	short vowel used for BATH words used in the North of England	TRAP and BATH split only in the South of England
Gow (1892)	—	TRAP and BATH split in the standard
Nesfield (1900)	—	<i>father</i> , <i>palm</i> , <i>path</i> , <i>ask</i> , <i>aunt</i> listed as long
Carpenter (1902)*	short vowel used for BATH words everywhere else	TRAP and BATH split only in London and New England

Of course, it is also possible that some of the teachers and authors had a precise quality in mind, but without hard evidence in the form of articulatory descriptions this is impossible to verify. Moreover, I show in Chapter 7 that grammars that include the same terminology to refer to a sound do not necessarily always mean the same phonetic value by it as other grammarians. Therefore, accurate evidence on the gradualness of the change cannot be deduced from the comments in the CNG.

Regarding the regional distribution, it is striking that a threefold distinction between TRAP, BATH, and START and PALM, with the majority of words having the intermediate vowel, is exclusively found in North American grammars. I have suggested that this could mean that an intermediate pronunciation, regardless of what its exact phonetic realisation might have been, was used in order to avoid the typical American pronunciation, or sounding British or conceited. It could also be an intermediate stage in a phonetically gradual development towards a long and retracted vowel. Furthermore, this could indicate that these grammarians were working in the research tradition of Worcester (and Smart), rather than Webster. In total more North American grammars provide evidence for the split, which is an unexpected finding. In the phonological distribution of variants, the main difference is that there is no clear pattern in the British-Irish grammars whereas in the North American grammars the intermediate vowel is used primarily in pre-/s/ environments and most often in the word *ask*. Furthermore, no grammars in the CNG suggest any distribution that might resemble a nasal short-*a* split now common in the (North-)East of the US.

In terms of prescriptivism, negative comments are generally rare for the vowel in BATH words, which is surprising as Mugglestone (2007: 78) identifies questions about which vowels to use in words like *fast*, *bath* or *last* as “[o]ne of the most prominent topics for discussion” at the time. And the use of a fully retracted vowel in these words would have likely sparked comments of vulgarity and incorrectness, or lack of education (Mugglestone 2007: 79). Thus, the types of comments that we find in the CNG conform with what we would expect, namely mainly social evaluations marking other variants than a short vowel as a mistake. The low number of these comments is striking – especially since this change is said to have originated in the lower classes. This could either mean that the feature was not as stigmatised as previous research has suggested or that the genre of grammars plays a role here. I show in later sections that while for some features like post-vocalic /r/ absence and /h/-dropping there are more comments, in general prescriptive statements on pronunciation are comparatively rare in the CNG.

Concerning example words, what is noticeable is that the word *aunt* has a special position in most of these grammars as it is described with a long vowel very early on and almost categorically throughout the century even in those grammars that otherwise list or prescribe a short or intermediate vowel for BATH words, like Oliver (1825), Kirkham (1834), or Fowler (1855). This conforms with Trapateau's (2020) theory that it is certain lead words (ME /au, ai/ types) that were affected first in the process, while frequency effects play a less important role. The evidence from the CNG confirms that in part. The word *father* is also listed under his lead words, but it is at the same time also very frequent. Moreover, in grammars with a threefold distinction, *ask* is the prime example of a word having the intermediate vowel. This word is indeed a high frequency word. Therefore, my results on the spread and distribution are partially in line with Trapateau's (2020) analysis of eighteenth-century pronouncing dictionaries. The word *laugh* is also frequently listed in the CNG for the second/third sound and also in four North American grammars. It is similarly one of Trapateau's (2020) lead words and, according to Stanford (2020: 262–263), it is the most common word in which [a:] is used in present-day New England. It could be an example of a lexeme that acquired an innovative vowel first and in the present-day case is a strongly lexicalised variant at least in New England.

I have noted above that the frequency of example words could nonetheless also be explained in terms of their saliency or convention. It is not unlikely that amongst LModE grammarians and orthoëpists it was simply common to refer to a certain vowel as the vowel in *ask*, *father*, or *aunt*. They could have been precursors to Wells' (1982) lexical sets. Moreover, I have suggested that the make-up of grammars, most importantly the convention of going through every possible combination of letters from A to Z, could be responsible for the frequency of example words. For the twofold split the word *father* seems to have been representative of the vowel and therefore constitutes one of the typical examples under <a> spellings. *Aunt*, on the other hand, is often the example of <au> spellings. The similarity between my results and Trapateau's (2020) findings shows a certain conservatism that was present in grammars from the nineteenth century with respect to phonological variables. As concerns the spread of long variants before nasals, the low number of example words throughout the century do not permit any definite conclusions.

7 /r/: Post-vocalic /r/-absence and realisation

7.1 /r/: Historical background

Post-vocalic /r/-absence refers to the omission or vocalisation of /r/ after vowels in absolute final or pre-consonantal positions, e.g. *card* [kɑːɪd] > [kɑːd]. In RP, General New Zealand English (GNZE), and AusE today, post-vocalic /r/ is absent unless it occurs intervocalically as in [ˈkɑːɪəˈlɑːm] *car alarm* (Wells 1982: 218–228). Non-rhotic varieties can also be found in South and West Africa and the Caribbean (Hughes et al. 2012: 63–64). In North America, post-vocalic /r/ absence is only attested in parts of the South and eastern New England, and in AAVE today, although there is increasing evidence of rhoticity in these varieties as well (Labov et al. 2006: 47–48; Stanford 2020: 275–280). In contrast, Scottish, Irish, Canadian, and AmE standard pronunciations are fully rhotic. While recessive, rhoticity can also still be found in the South-West of England and central Lancashire (Hughes et al. 2012: 63–64). Furthermore, in Southland, New Zealand, rhoticity in *NURSE* words even increased in the twentieth century (see Villarreal et al. 2021).

This distribution looked very different in LModE. The pronunciation of /r/ was present, at least to some extent, in post-vocalic position in Britain, where the overtly prestigious variant now is characterised by post-vocalic /r/-absence. In twentieth-century dialects post-vocalic /r/ was still realised even in final unstressed position in words like *farmer* from the northern part of Kent all the way to the North-West of England and in some parts of the North-East and East Midlands, as illustrated in Figure 7.1.¹ The loss of /r/ in post-vocalic position started

¹This figure is recreated based on Orton et al. (1978). At the beginning of their atlas they explain that they employ the symbol [ɾ], which in present-day IPA denotes a retroflex flap, for retroflex frictionless continuants. I modernised the IPA used in these maps and use [ɹ] where they would use [ɾ]. Furthermore, they use [ɹ] for alveolar fricative realisations of rhotics, e.g. on their map depicting the distribution of /r/ variants in *rat*. I have replaced this with [ɹ] to more accurately represent the actual realisation (see Figure 7.2). The IPA did not differentiate between the frictionless continuant [ɹ] and the fricative [ɹ] until 1932 (see MacMahon 1996: 830 for the International Phonetic Alphabet from 1932), and even then it featured the same symbol for both, i.e. [ɹ].

in the fifteenth century, had become common by the end of the eighteenth century, but was still variable until the 1870s and potentially even longer (Lass 1999: 115; see also Trudgill 2004: 68; Hay & Sudbury 2005: 806; Trudgill & Gordon 2006: 239 for AusE and NZE). At the beginning of the twentieth century, Krapp (1919: 21–22) notes “that [ɹ] is regularly omitted by some speakers, especially in the East and South in America”.

If we look at what influential grammarians and dictionary authors proposed for /r/, we might conclude that post-vocalic /r/ was in its final stages of disappearance from prestige speech in Britain only in the second half of the nineteenth century. Beal (2004b: 154) states that “non-rhotic pronunciation continues to be stigmatized in England throughout most of the nineteenth century”. This is also evident in Walker (1791: 50) as he notices that in London /r/ “is pronounced so much in the throat as to be little more than the middle or Italian *a*” and that some speakers drop the sound of /r/ altogether. He instead proposes an allophony of “rough” and “smooth” variants. He advises speakers to “avoid a too forcible pronunciation of the *r*, when it ends a word, or is followed by a consonant in the same syllable”, but admits that “we may give as much force as we please to this letter at the beginning of a word, without producing harshness to the ear” (Walker 1791: 50). He concludes that “*Rome, river, rage*, may have the *r* as forcible as in Ireland; but *bar, bard, card, hard*, & c. must have it nearly as soft as in London”. In terms of the realisations of these two variants, he states the following:

[t]he rough *r* is formed by jarring the tip of the tongue against the roof of the mouth near the foreteeth: the smooth *r* is a vibration of the lower part of the tongue, near the root, against the inward region of the palate, near the entrance of the throat. (Walker 1791: 50)

From his articulatory description it looks like the “rough” variant is an alveolar trill, tap or even perhaps some form of fricated or assibilated variant as “jarring the tip of the tongue” (apical) and “against roof of the mouth near the foreteeth” (alveolar ridge) suggest. The meaning of his “smooth” variant is trickier to unfold. It has been proposed that it refers to an approximant [ɹ] (see Beal 2004b: 154). I argue that his remark on the “lower part of the tongue, near the root, against the inward region of the palate near the entrance of the throat” could indicate a bunched or velar realisation rather than a post-alveolar variant. It could furthermore refer to a secondary articulation which involves pharyngeal tension – especially given his comment on the tongue root and “the entrance of the throat”.² However, if we take the /r/ in England to be “little more than the

²I thank Prof Dr Margaret Zellers for pointing me towards this possibility.



Figure 7.1: Map showing the distribution of final unstressed /r/ in the word *farmer* in twentieth-century dialects in England, recreated based on Orton et al. (1978)

middle or Italian *a*” and the “smooth” /r/ to resemble the pronunciation of England, we cannot exclude the possibility of him referring to a vocalic realisation for “smooth” /r/s per se. In fact, Krapp (1925: 224) suggested that Walker’s “soft *r* was practically not a consonant at all”. Regardless of the exact phonetic quality, Walker’s non-prevocalic “smooth *r*” very likely represents an approximant or a vocalised variant and thus one of the final stages of a lenition process before complete /r/ loss.

Murray (1795: 11) also embraces a distinction of “rough” and “smooth” /r/s but does not provide any articulatory information: “*R* has a rough sound; as in Rome, river, rage: and a smooth one; as in bard, card, regard”. Smart (1836: x) argues for “a trill or trolling of the tongue against the upper gum” and “a smoother sound of the letter *r*, which it takes at the end of syllables when another *r* or a vowel does not follow in the next”.

Similar to Walker (1791: 50), Smart (1836: vii) and Ellis (1869b: 603) both observe the dropping of /r/ in London speech. Smart (1836: vii) writes that “[t]he extreme amongst the vulgar in London doubtless, is to omit the *r* altogether” and describes it as “an extreme which must be avoided”. Ellis (1869b: 603) notes that in London words like *farther* or *lord* are pronounced without /r/ “even in the mouths of educated speakers”. For south-eastern British English speech, Hickey (2025: 282) suggests the following lenition process, as depicted in Table 7.1.

Table 7.1: Lenition of /r/ in south-eastern British pronunciation, based on Hickey (2025: 282)

syllable-initial	syllable-coda	>	syllable-initial	syllable-coda
[r]	[ɹ]		[ɹ]	[∅]

Concerning syllable-initial trills, Hickey (2025: 276) mentions a recording with a speaker from London, born in 1868, who uses trills in words like *parallel*, *road*, and *story*.³ Trudgill (2004: 69–72) suggests two more intermediate stages between trills and (post-)alveolar approximants, i.e. flap and retroflex variants, as well as a more innovative late twentieth-century variant, i.e. a labio-dental approximant. He suggests the following lenition process: [r > ɾ > ɻ > ɹ > v].

As concerns the trilled realisation that was often mentioned in LModE sources, regardless of their place of publication, the use of *trill* cannot be directly translated into our understanding of the term without some caution as some might

³The speaker’s name is Florence Pannell and the recording can be accessed via YouTube: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e4FZkXvAY94> (see for instance 0:55, 1:15, 1:52 in the video for examples of trill realisations).

have employed the term to similarly apply to fricated variants. Ellis (1889: 84) for instance still adds that his notation (r) is the “‘true’ trill” which is used by Italian and Scottish speakers. Jones (1964 [1918]: 194) regards fricative pronunciations as “[t]he most usual English r” and so does Krapp (1919: 20–22), while both mention a trill as variable pronunciation.

Both Jones (1964 [1918]: 194–195) and Krapp (1919: 20–22) also note the possibility of realising /r/ as a frictionless continuant, i.e. an approximant. MacMahon’s (1998: 488) interpretation of Kenrick (1773) supports this as the possible phonetic variants he lists are: a post-alveolar or retroflex approximant or fricative, or an alveolar trill. Orton et al. (1978) also describe the alveolar fricative for all of England except the North-East, South-West and the Isle of Man, as illustrated in Figure 7.2. Hickey (2025: 276) mentions trills as well as slight assibilation of [r] in emphatic speech for RP and Cockney speakers. Thus, a fricative [ɹ] is at least in the realm of possibility for the emerging LModE standard and could potentially mark an intermediate stage of syllable-initial variants between trills and approximants in the lenition processes described by Hickey and Trudgill. Krapp (1919: 20–22) also suggests that /r/ is generally realised as a “voiced fricative [r]” in initial position and what is likely an approximant [ɹ] in final and pre-consonantal position. His description of the final/pre-consonantal /r/ suggests an approximant as he states: “friction accompanying the vocalic element is so slight that one might hesitate to group it with the fricatives”.

However, he also observes that “[a] trilled or rolled r, though not very common in American speech, is sometimes heard, especially for r between vowels, as in very, hurry, etc”. In some older RP speakers today, we may still hear remnants of the former trill in forms of taps intervocalically, either within words or as linking /r/. The use of this variant, however, decreased in the twentieth century (see Belando 2023 for a detailed sociophonetic account of this change).

For regional accents in mid-nineteenth-century England, Trudgill (2004: 69–71) shows only two non-rhotic areas: i) “from the North Riding of Yorkshire south through the Vale of York into north and central Lincolnshire, nearly all of Nottinghamshire, and adjacent areas of Derbyshire, Leicestershire and Staffordshire” and ii) “all of Norfolk, western Suffolk and Essex, eastern Cambridgeshire and Hertfordshire, Middlesex, and northern Surrey and Kent”. Thus, as regards regional varieties within England, the change was also very much in process in the nineteenth century, which is also evidenced by the maintenance of post-vocalic /r/ in traditional south-western varieties in England (Altendorf & Watt 2004: 200–201). However, realising /r/ after vowels is generally recessive in England (Hughes et al. 2012: 63; see also Barras 2018 on rhoticity and /r/-sandhi in Oxfordshire and Lancashire).

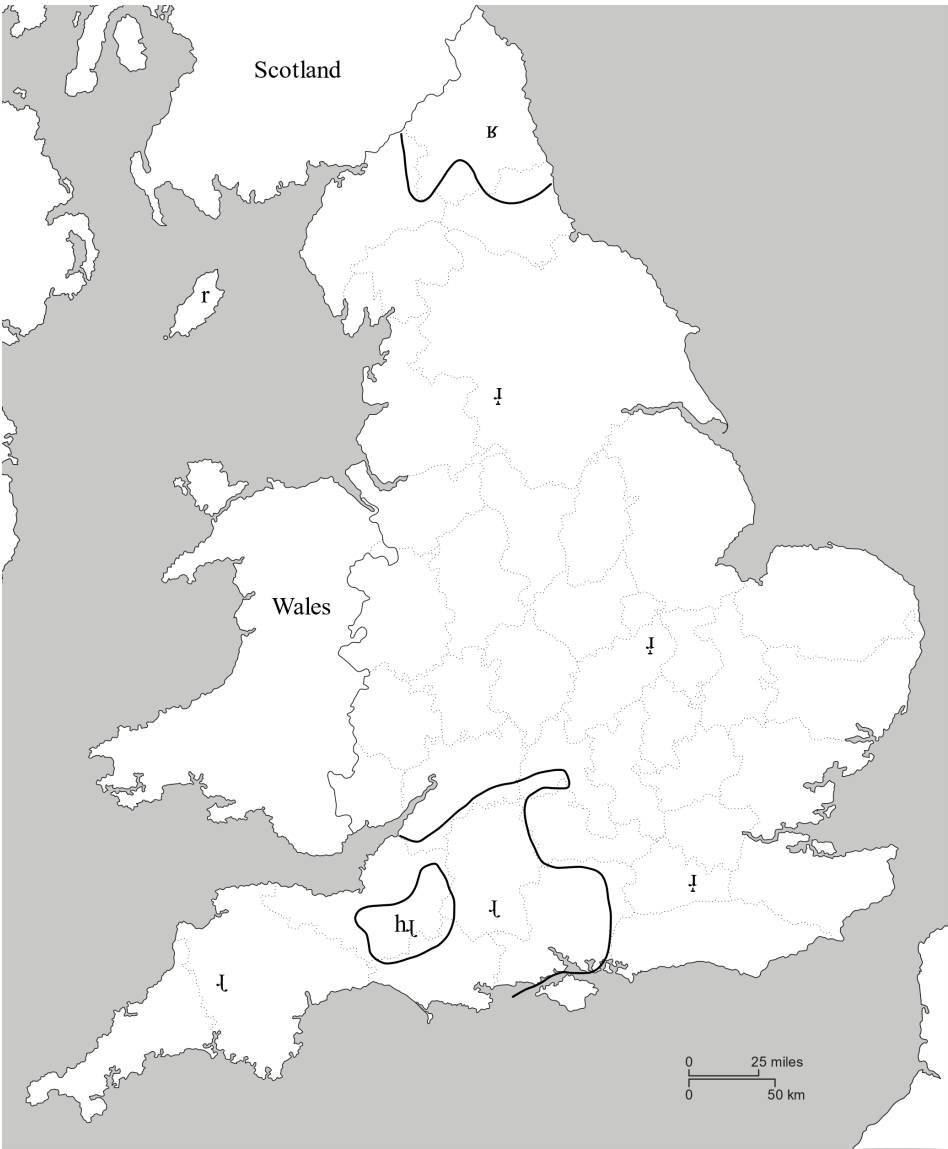


Figure 7.2: Map showing the distribution of /r/ realisations in the word *rat* in twentieth-century dialects in England, recreated based on Orton et al. (1978)

In eighteenth and nineteenth-century North America, Webster and Worcester diverge from the “rough”-“smooth” distinction of their British contemporaries. Webster (1783: 15) proposes that /r/ should be pronounced with the same sound, regardless of position. In Webster (1790: 15), he also states that /r/ “has always the same sound, as in *barrel* and is never silent”. Worcester (1859: 18) specifies this and writes that “the letter *r* has a jarring or trilling effect on the tongue, and it is never silent”. He nonetheless remarks that “[t]here is a difference of opinion among orthoëpists respecting the letter *r*”, which is that some authors propose only one sound for /r/, whereas others suggest a twofold distinction. His list of the former includes scholars like Johnson and Sheridan. Regarding the latter, Worcester (1859: 18) mentions Walker and Smart.

With respect to the reputation of /r/-less forms in North America, Paulsen (2022: 399), in her analysis of newspapers from the nineteenth century, suggests a positive evaluation of the feature in the Northeast, parts of the urban western regions, and along the southern coast. She argues that the “form must have been evaluated very positively as a sign of cultivation, education, upper-class membership and a close relation to European/British ancestry”. Nonetheless, speakers that used non-rhotic variants were also “depicted as Americans who lack authenticity by pretending to be English” (Paulsen 2022: 403). Moreover, /r/-lessness was associated with physical weakness and femininity and often connected to figures like the dude (Paulsen 2022: 388). Rhoticity and hyper-rhoticity, on the other hand, constituted an authentic American speaker by means of opposing British norms (Paulsen 2022: 386–388). However, speech, acting, and elocution schools in North America still taught the prestigious non-rhotic New England pronunciation until the end of WWII (Labov et al. 2006: 47). Non-rhoticity thus had conflicting connotations in both localities in the nineteenth century. In Britain, it was stigmatised and connected to the “vulgar” as well as “educated” Londoners but eventually became the standard. In North America, it was seen by some as a marker of good education and cultivation, while others evaluated it as pretentious, feminine, and un-American.

In the following sections, I discuss the proposed distribution of /r/ variants in the CNG and their intra-linguistic constraints as well as the role of extra-linguistic factors such as region. This serves to investigate the lenition process of /r/ sounds in what can be assumed to be the final stage of a long change from rhoticity to non-rhoticity in several varieties of English. To evaluate the extent to which prescriptions and references to regional speech were connected to this change, I furthermore consider the extent to which the absence or vocalisation of /r/ in post-vocalic position was stigmatised, and how exactly it was evaluated.

7.2 /r/ in the CNG: Overview

In the CNG, 57 grammars provide information on /r/ that exceeds a basic definition. However, not all of these grammars discuss post-vocalic /r/-absence or offer enough material to derive a clear distribution of variants. It is in 43 of the grammars that treat pronunciation (26%) that there is enough information to allow us to determine a distribution of /r/ variants.

26 of these are from North America and 17 are British-Irish. None of the grammars that were solely or additionally published in Ireland, Scotland or Canada contain sufficient information for deriving a distribution of /r/ variants. The majority of grammars, i.e. 31 grammars, propose a distribution of two different /r/ sounds. Suggesting only one sound for /r/ is the second most common strategy in the CNG (9 grammars). Grammarians that describe post-vocalic /r/-loss without any value judgements are the minority in the collection (3 grammars). In total 12 grammars provide evidence of non-rhoticity, nine of which present negative evaluations of the feature. The earliest mentions of the feature come from Kirkham (1834) and Leigh (1840). Table 7.2 and Figure 7.3 illustrate the distribution of proposed /r/ variants “one sound”, “two sounds” and “post-vocalic /r/ absent”. The negative evaluations have been excluded from both and the last category “post-voc. /r/ absent” only includes the neutral descriptions of /r/-lessness. Prescriptive comments are discussed separately as part of Section 7.5.

Table 7.2: Evidence of perceived standard variants of /r/ in the CNG

	British-Irish	North American	all
pronunciation treated	100	66	166
/r/ total	17 (17% of 100)	26 (39% of 66)	43 (26% of 166)
one sound	3 (3% of 100)	6 (9% of 66)	9 (5% of 166)
two sounds	12 (12% of 100)	19 (29% of 66)	31 (19% of 166)
post-vocalic /r/ absence	2 (2% of 100)	1 (2% of 66)	3 (2% of 166)
insufficient information	83	40	123

There is no noteworthy difference between British-Irish and North American grammars with respect to the distribution of /r/ variants. The only obvious difference is that North American grammars discuss /r/ more often, both in relation to the sum of grammars that mention /r/ and to the general number of grammars that treat pronunciation.



Figure 7.3: Quantitative distribution of perceived standard variants of /r/ in the CNG

7.3 One sound

Two grammars of the “one sound” category provide descriptions that allow for deducing articulatory features of /r/. These indicate an alveolar trill (Oliver 1825) and a bunched approximant (Kenyon 1849). Oliver (1825: 311) proposes that “[t]his letter [R] is always sounded” and elaborates that “it is termed the *jarring letter* because it has a jarring sound”. Moreover, he complains about what is likely to be a weakened variant: “the true sound of *r* is its sound in an Italian and in a Spanish mouth, which renders the jar perfectly perceptible, not degenerating into a semi-sound, the opprobrium of language” (Oliver 1825: 311). While the use of words like *jarring* might not have always referred to the obstruction of air (see MacMahon 1998: 488), Oliver’s praise of the Italian and Spanish realisations suggests an alveolar trill or tap as the ideal. Kenyon (1849: 252) suggests a bunched approximant as for him /r/ “is formed by articulating the sides of the middle part of the tongue with the upper back teeth”. Furthermore, the pointing down of the tongue tip common for bunched approximants is indicated by “and then rolling down the end and emitting the breath through the opening thus formed”. He moreover notes trilled realisations but claims that there are few speakers skilled enough to properly pronounce this sound: “though the *trilling* sounds very well, when done by a skillful speaker, yet the number who so manage it, are too few

to give authority to the practice” (Kenyon 1849: 247). If he is referring to a trill in our modern sense, his judgement may be evidence for trills becoming less common, although they were indeed still evaluated positively. Similar opinions on the apical trill [r] as aesthetically pleasing were widespread and can be found in late nineteenth-century works on German, e.g. in Trautmann (1880) and Siebs (1898), where this variant was preferred over uvular realisations (Hickey 2025: 277).⁴

The remaining grammarians are considerably more brief. Pinnock (1830: 19) contends that “R has one uniform, rough, vibrating sound, and is never silent”. His use of the word “uniform” and his claim that it “is never silent” reveal that he wants speakers to use one sound, irrespective of its position. This sound is identified as “rough” and “vibrating” and could indicate a tap, trill or fricative or perhaps even an approximant as he does not comment further on this. He evaluates its sound positively before what essentially appears to be front vowels as he adds that “[i]t produces a fine tone before the softer letters, as in *rather*, *red*, *read*, *rhyme*” (Pinnock 1830: 19), which might suggest that the sound he had in mind in fact was not “uniform”, but subject to phonetic constraints. However, he does not comment on this any further. Perhaps he had noticed weakened realisations in other contexts but was reluctant to acknowledge them. Weld (1848: 16) and Munsell Jr. (1851: 8) write: “[t]he following consonants have but one sound [...] *r* as in *rate*” and “*R*, has but one sound, as in *Rome*, and is never silent” respectively. Others are even less explicit and it is impossible to state with full certainty that they proposed only one /r/ sound in every position and every phonological environment, e.g. Goodenow (1839: 44), who simply states that “[t]he linguals are produced by the interruption of the tongue bent upwards, and are two in number, *l* and *r*, as heard in the words *lull* and *roar*”. He only provides us with an example which contains pre-vocalic and non-prevocalic contexts without further discussing the respective sounds. However, this itself could be evidence of him suggesting the same sound to be used in both positions. After criticising “even well-bred people” and the “vulgar” Londoners for omitting their /r/ in words like *father* or *mother*, Higginson (1864: 9) contends that “[t]he distinct but not excessive *trill* of the *r* is a great characteristic of good articulation”. Therefore, he argues against post-vocalic /r/ omission and for a distinct pronunciation and sanctions “excessive” variants. It is unclear what “trill” refers to because he does not explain the sound.

⁴To give one example, Trautmann’s (1880: 219) metaphorical use of language speaks for his preference of the alveolar variant (“zungen-*r*”) over uvular realisations (“zäpfchen-*r*”): According to him, the uvular variant had not yet won over (“gewonnen”) all towns, but in wider rural areas the realisation had already seized power (“herrschaft an sich gerissen hat”).

Other grammarians suggest one sound but note variation. Ridpath (1881: 27) claims that “[t]he consonant *r* has one sound, illustrated in the word *ruin*”. However, he adds a note, which reads “[s]ome orthoëpists maintain that *r* has two sounds: first, the *trilled r*, as in *rock*; second, the *smooth r*, as in *fair*”. Wells (1847: 38) very briefly states that “*R* has the sound heard in *rare*”, which implies that for him /r/ has just one sound, regardless of whether it occurs at the beginning of the word *rare* or at the end. To this line, however, he appends a footnote which says: “[t]he following quotations present a general view of the different opinions which exist among orthoëpists respecting this letter”. Following this, he simply lists quotes and names of a number of other scholars such as Sheridan (1780) and Webster (1790) that contend that /r/ has only one sound. Furthermore, he includes quotes by scholars such as Comstock (1868) and Smart (1841), who argue for twofold distinctions. Nevertheless, Wells (1847) does not comment any further on this.

7.4 Two sounds

The grammars that describe two sounds mostly utilise the terminology that we find in Walker, Murray, and Smart, namely a “rough” sound or a “trill” prevo-cally, and some form of “smooth(er)”, or “soft(er)” variant post-vocally.

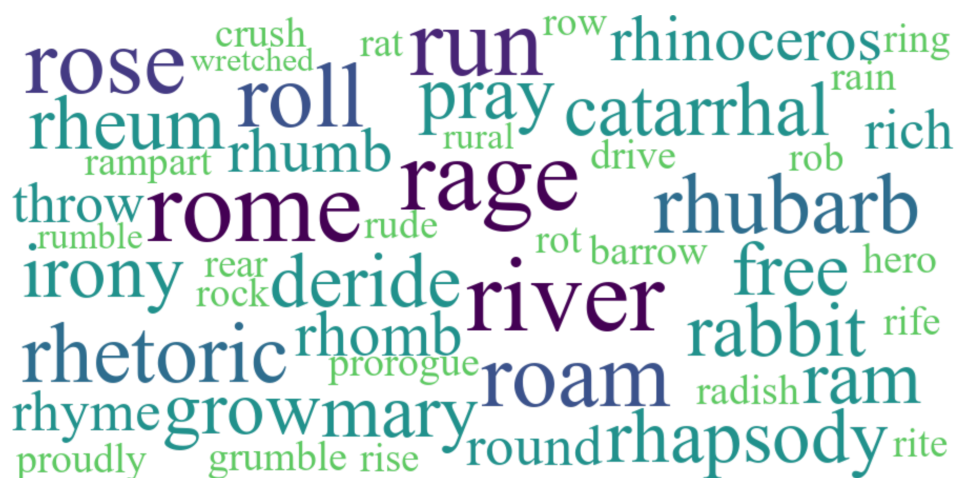


Figure 7.4: Word cloud showing example words used for the first sound of /r/ by grammars in the CNG with two different /r/ sounds

example words used by grammarians proposing two sounds, which are shown in Figures 7.4 and 7.5. As discussed above, the word *bar* is not used in Murray but only in Walker. These examples occur as early as in Picket (1815) and even as late as in Colegrove (1879) and Kelke (1885). However, based on the entire passage in Kelke (1885), it is unlikely that the example was taken directly from Walker or Murray. For the others this nonetheless seems to be the case. It should also be noted that not all of these 16 grammars use all of the example words. The only ones that do, with the exception of the word *bar*, are those that evidently copy directly from Murray.

As for articulatory properties of /r/ sounds, Table 7.3 provides a summary for those nine grammars that embrace a twofold distinction and give sufficient information. It is ordered chronologically and based on place of publication. Furthermore, asterisks indicate North American grammars. The first sound refers to prevocalic environments, while the second sound stands for final and sometimes medial position.

Of the British-Irish grammars, Clarke (1853), Lowres (1863) and Gostwick (1878) only provide implicit information on the place of articulation of /r/ as they categorise them together with other (post-)alveolar sounds. Of these, Gostwick is the only grammar from which a quality of the second sound can be derived. According to Gostwick (1878: 20–21), /r/ is a “dental”, i.e. a category which includes all alveolar sounds and “j”, in words like *rose* and sometimes a guttural as in *work*. Since his “gutturals” include [k], [g], [j], and [ŋ], I argue for a velar, bunched, or potentially uvular realisation. In contrast, Hort (1822: 20–21) provides more information on the quality and distribution of the “rough” and “softened” /r/: “R. This letter has a rough, rattling sound, which is formed by turning the tip of the tongue up towards the roof of the mouth, and breathing strongly, so as to shake the tongue, and make it vibrate [...] This is a little softened when the letter occurs in the end of words, before *d* and *t*”. His mentioning of the tip of the tongue, the description of the sound as “rattling” in addition to the shaking of the tongue caused by a strong breath suggests an apico-alveolar trill.

Kelke (1885: 29–31, 37) classes /r/ as well as /l/ as palato-lingual trills, the former as a central and the latter as a lateral trill. Palato-linguals also include his equivalents of [s], [z], [ʃ] and [ʒ] and thus (post-)alveolar sounds. He moreover notes that it “would be far more natural to class them with *y* and *w* as Semi-vowels” than “along with *n* and *m* as *Liquids*”. Both these statements suggest an understanding similar to that underlying our modern classification of [ɹ]. Hence, “trill” does not seem to mean [r] or [ʀ] but potentially an approximant. Furthermore, he classes /r/ with the glides: “[c]ertain consonants are so termed when final and almost imperceptible [...] as in *bar*” which implies a weakened vocalised

Table 7.3: Potential realisation of /r/ sounds in grammars with a twofold distinction

grammar	initial sound	possible interpretation		second sound	possible interpretation	
		place	manner		place	manner
Hort (1822)	rough, rattling	alveolar	trill	softened		—
Clarke (1853)	rough	(post-) alveolar	—	soft		—
Lowres (1863)	rough	(post-) alveolar	—	smoother		—
Gostwick (1878)	dental	(post-) alveolar	—	guttural	velar, bunched, uvular	—
Kelke (1885)	palato-lingual central trill	(post-) alveolar	approx- imant	glide	—	weakened, vowel, zero
Brown (1851)*	rough, pretty strong	(post-) alveolar	variable	smooth, soft	(post-) alveolar	variable
Fowler (1855)*	canine letter, palatal, gut-tural	(post-) alveolar	trill	vocal	voiced, rhotacised vowel	
		velar, bunched	approx- imant			
		uvular	trill, fricative			
York (1862)*	trilled R	alveolar	trill, tap, fricative	smooth	post-alveolar	approximant
Ramsey (1892)*	pure lingual	post-alveolar	approx- imant	—		—

or even zero variant. With respect to the realisation of the sound, he also seems to be influenced by the spelling as he claims the /r/ to be stronger in <rr> as in *barrow* than in *row* or *hero*.

Concerning North American grammars, Brown (1851: 1007) embraces a distinction between a “rough or pretty strong” and a “smooth” or “soft” /r/. He argues against one single sound for /r/ as he criticises Wells’ (1847) “indecision” (see the previous section above), which “forebears all recognition of this difference” between a “rough” and a “smooth” /r/. He further complains that Wells’ example *rare* is unlikely to “exhibit twice over the *rough snarl* of Johnson’s *r*”. His articulatory description suggests a sound produced with the tip of the tongue at the alveolar ridge or somewhere along the palate (Brown 1851: 1007):

The letter *R* turns the tip of the tongue up against or towards the roof of the mouth, where the sound may be lengthened, roughened, trilled or quavered. Consequently, this element may, at the will of the speaker, have more or less—little or nothing, or even very much—of that peculiar roughness, jar, or whur, which is commonly said to constitute the sound.

Since it may only be turned “towards the roof of the mouth”, it could very well be an approximant as friction would thus be avoided. His reference to the will of the speaker could indicate idiosyncratic variation. Brown further argues against both “the excessive *trilling*” and omission of the /r/. Roughness and softness therefore seem to be relational terms on a continuum with excessive trills and zero as the forbidden extremes.

Fowler’s (1855: 150) /r/ in *run* is “formed by placing the tongue at such a distance from the palate as to suffer it to jar against it, the breath being propelled from the throat to the mouth”. Allowing the tongue to be in a position to “jar” against the palate implies a (post-)alveolar trill, tap or fricative as for an approximant there would be no need to prepare the tongue for contact with the palate. The /r/ sound is also described as “canine letter, from the snarling of dogs” by Fowler (1855: 211), which has been interpreted as a (potentially uvular) trill in other descriptions that refer to /r/ as the sound of dogs (see Jones 2006: 110, 259–260). Similar references to the sound of dogs can also be found in other grammar traditions. Sen & Zair (2022: 438) for instance find comparable comments by Roman grammarians on the /r/ in Latin. With respect to these examples they argue against trill interpretations but suggest an approximant. In this context they also point out that in present-day British English an approximant is used for imitating the growling of a dog. Fowler (1855: 202) furthermore lists /r/ together with

“k, g, l, q, and c when equivalent to k” and terms these sounds “palatals” or “gutturals”. This could support a uvular interpretation or imply a velar or bunched realisation. The second sound he describes as “vocal” in words like *dare*, *her*, *bird*, *for*, *syrtis* and thus the SQUARE, NURSE and NORTH sets: “[t]he vocal sound of this letter, uniting with a preceding vowel sound, modifies it”. “Vocal” is not to be confused with “vowel” as “vocal” refers simply to voiced sounds in Fowler (1855: 144). This description of post-vocalic /r/ could either suggest a deliberate exclusion of devoiced variants or imply a more sonorous sound than the first. This would have to be a vowel or an approximant, depending on how we interpret the first sound of /r/. It could furthermore point to a rhotacised vowel, e.g. [hə] *her*. The complete omission of /r/ after vowels in words like *card* he however considers an “error” (Fowler 1855: 189).

York (1862: 68) embraces a distinction between a “trilled R” and a “smooth R”. The former can be interpreted as an alveolar trill or fricative as it “is formed by causing the tongue to vibrate against the gums of the upper incisory teeth while the breath is propelled through the mouth”. The “smooth” variant is used “when it follows a vowel: as in air, etc” and is “made with the tip of the tongue elevated towards the center of the roof of the mouth, and propelling the breath through the mouth”. This indicates a consonant articulated further back than the first one and could indicate post-alveolar approximant produced with the tip up.

The /r/ that Ramsey (1892: 130) proposes is a (post-)alveolar approximant. The sound is listed together with /j/, /l/, and /w/ in the category of semi-vowels and “the tongue is raised and made to vibrate with the passing vocal breath but does not touch the teeth or palate”. In initial positions it is “pronounced more distinctly than the medial or final” (Ramsey 1892: 168). Nonetheless, while he does not elaborate on this we can exclude complete absence of /r/ in final position because he is one of the fiercest opponents of non-rhoticity in the CNG, as I show later (see also Ramsey 1892: 139, 145, 148, 169).

7.5 Post-vocalic /r/ absence and prescriptive comments

Concerning the absence of /r/ after vowels, the CNG contains 12 grammars in which non-rhoticity is mentioned. However, the majority of those grammars (9 out of 12) display negative evaluations of non-rhoticity. Generally, these evaluations occur in British-Irish as well as North American grammars, and the feature is often identified as “vulgar”, “corrupted” or as typical of London. Nonetheless, there are three grammars that describe non-rhoticity in a neutral fashion, namely Gow (1892), Nesfield (1900), and Carpenter (1902). Although absolute numbers

are low, evaluations are slightly more frequent in North American grammars. However, this difference may be disregarded. The distribution of grammars that provide information on complete post-vocalic /r/ absence, including its evaluation, is summarised in Table 7.4.

Table 7.4: Distribution of grammars that treat post-vocalic /r/-absence in relation to region and attitude

region	pronunciation	post-vocalic /r/-absence		attitude
British-Irish	100	6	6%	4 negative 2 neutral
North American	66	6	9%	5 negative 1 neutral
All	166	12	7%	9 negative 3 neutral

With respect to the categorisation of the grammarians' arguments, providing a pejorative Social Evaluation of non-rhoticity (6 grammars) and identifying /r/-less forms as Mistakes (4 grammars) are the most common. Nature (2 grammars) or Aesthetic arguments (1 grammar) are more infrequent and furthermore more implicit than the others. There are no arguments based on Logic or on the Education of the speakers. Figure 7.6 illustrates evaluative terms used for or associated with post-vocalic /r/-absence in the CNG, grouped into the categories described in Chapter 4. I now discuss the grammars that treat post-vocalic /r/-absence based on region, starting with British-Irish sources.

If we zoom in on the category Social Evaluation, we can see that grammarians link their negative evaluations to different social groups. This applies to British-Irish as well as North American grammars. As shown in Section 6.6, Leigh (1840: 25) writes: "[a]fter this manner cockneys express themselves:— 'I sor (saw) him.' 'Dror (draw) it out.' 'Hold your jor (jaw).' 'I caun't. You shaun't. How's your Maw and Paw? Do you like taut (tart)?'". The first three examples that Leigh provides here are examples of non-historical /r/, a sandhi phenomenon of /r/-loss (Wells 1982: 222–227). The example which includes the respelling <taut> of the word *tart* indicates the absence of /r/. In a similar fashion, Leigh mocks dandies and writes: "[d]andies frequently exclaim,— 'I'm postively tiawed (tired).' 'What a sweet tempaw! (temper).' 'How daughty (dirty) the streets au!' And they also call, Literature, 'literetchah.' Perfectly, 'pawfacly.' [...]" (Leigh 1840: 25–26). The fact that his grammar is designed to teach correct English based on ridiculing wrong

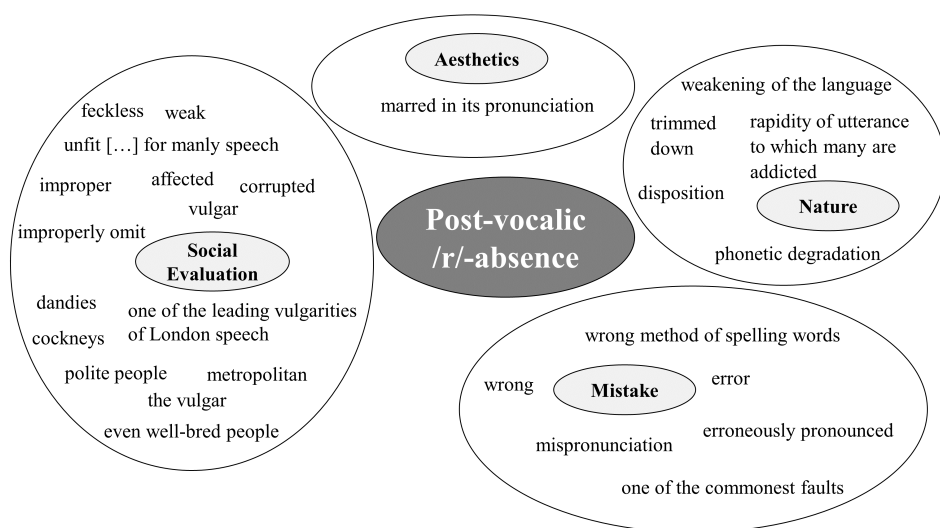


Figure 7.6: Evaluative terms used for post-vocalic /r/-absence in the CNG, sorted by category

English shows his negative evaluation of the /r/-less speech of non-standard speakers.

In Higginson's (1864) British-Irish grammar, the culprits are Londoners in general and non-rhoticity is evaluated as a metropolitan feature. Higginson (1864: 9) points out that "[t]he omission of the *r* sound is one of the commonest faults of even well-bred people, who say *fatháh*, *motháh*, *brotháh*, *sistáh*, and make them almost rhyme with *felláh* (for fellow), *umbrelláh*, & c". Thus, Higginson's (1864) main issue lies in syllable final /r/-loss in *-er* spellings (*father*, *mother*, *brother*, *sister*). He evaluates this omission as "one of the leading vulgarities of London speech, not the less vulgar for being metropolitan" (Higginson 1864: 9). "Well-bred" is categorised as Social Evaluation rather than Education as it often stands in as a synonym for *polite* rather than *educated* in the sense of having access to higher learning (OED: s.v. *well-bred* 1.b. "courteous, refined, decorous. Also in extended use.").

Fleay (1884: 86), published in London, states that "*Wh* and *Gh* are frequently corrupted into *w* and *y* in affected or vulgar pronunciation; *Ng* in unaccented syllables in like manner becomes *n*, and *R* after a vowel is dropped. Thus we often hear *wen*, *singin*, *fahther*, for *when*, *singing*, *farther*". Therefore, the absence of /r/ has the same status as realising the velar nasal as alveolar variant or the absence of /h/ in the *WHALE* set (see Yáñez-Bouza et al. 2018). According to Fleay,

this feature characterises a “corruption” of the language and moreover indexes affectation and vulgarity.

In the British-Irish grammar by King (1854: 63–64), we can find arguments that fit the categories Nature and Aesthetics. He argues that “[t]he English language is often marred in its pronunciation, by that rapidity of utterance to which many are addicted”, and hence proposes that a high speaking rate ruins the language. With that he ascribes some aesthetic superiority to a slower and more careful speaking style. The crucial part here is, however, that this “addiction”, as he calls it, is a “disposition [sc. that] frequently causes the suppression of letters which ought to be duly enunciated”. He provides some examples of the letters affected by this, as he writes: “[t]his is too often the case with regard to the letter *r*: thus, *park*, *lark*, *dark*, & c., are pronounced as if there were no *r* in the words”. If we take his passage literally, his argument thus runs as follows: some speakers of English have a natural tendency to speak too fast, which leads to the deterioration of English pronunciation. King’s (1854) argument is therefore based on the alleged disposition of some speakers and the aesthetic value of careful pronunciation. He implicitly prescribes /r/-full forms, or “letters which ought to be duly enunciated”. As is the case with several grammarians in the CNG, King’s comment shows the important role of orthography and the absence of a clear-cut distinction between spelling and pronunciation. For him, it is the *letter* that is to be “duly enunciated” and therefore evidently an argument based on the orthography.

As regards neutral evaluations of non-rhoticity in the British-Irish sample, there are two grammarians, namely Gow (1892) and Nesfield (1900), who essentially present descriptions of RP. As previously noted, Gow (1892: 11) bases his description on Ellis but states that the way he is using Ellis’ glossic is “slightly altered”. He discusses the weakening of Wells’ (1982) letter set to schwa and centring diphthongs in the South: “[t]he vowel-sound written ə (inverted e) is very common in southern English, especially before *r*”. He adds that “*r* is not heard unless a vowel follows, and the vowel ə is actually used as a substitute for *r* in such words as *hear*, *four*, which are pronounced *heeə*, *fauə*, if no vowel follows”. /r/-lessness with a long vowel in the NURSE set is also implied: “[t]he vowel ə is long in *bird*, *heard*, *earth*, which may be written *bəəd*, *həəd*, etc.”. Nesfield (1900: 271) adds a regional distribution and states that “except in the North, however, it [r] is never really heard as a consonant, unless it is followed by a vowel in the same or in the next word; cf. *far-ther* (sounded as *father*), *farr-ier*”. This statement aligns partially with the distribution of /r/ in traditional dialects, as parts of the North and South-West were still rhotic in the twentieth century (Orton et al. 1978), as illustrated in Figure 7.1.

Regarding North American grammars, Kirkham (1834: 201) has a section on “corrections in orthoepy”, which lists words “being often erroneously pronounced by polite people as well as by the vulgar”. He includes the wrong pronunciation of words and their proposed correction. His list contains several words with a post-vocalic /r/, of which two, namely *first* and *hearth*, are marked as often “improperly” realised as “fust” and “hurth” or “hath”. A superscript above the vowels in Kirkham’s (1834) section indicates that the only difference between the stigmatised and the proper pronunciation of *first* is the presence of /r/ in the latter. As regards *hearth*, he lists as “improper” pronunciations either those with the vowel in *tub* plus a post-vocalic /r/ or the absence of /r/ plus the vowel used in *far*. In terms of categories, the use of “erroneously pronounced” and “mispronunciation” identifies these pronunciations as mistakes, whereas the labels “improper” and “vulgar” convey a social evaluation. Thus, similar to Higginson’s (1864) line of argument, it is not only “the vulgar” but also “polite people” that make this mistake. Brown’s (1851: 1007) grammars states that “[s]ome readers very improperly omit the sound of *r* from many words to which it pertains; pronouncing *or* as *awe*, *nor* as *knaw*, *for* as *faugh* and *war* as the first syllable of *water*”. He thus does not target a specific group but marks the practice of dropping /r/ as “improper”.

Having been published in the same year as Gow’s (1892), Ramsey’s (1892) grammar, published in New York and London, establishes one of the highest contrasts to Gow’s neutral description. Ramsey (1892) targets the English as a whole with his criticism, as he writes:

This [sc. the absence of /r/] may be taken to be the present state of the case in England; and many in this country are entirely incapable of uttering the sound of *r* except after a pause or a consonant. [...] [I]ts disappearance [...] is a further weakening of the language much to be deplored. Of course, like all phonetic degradation [...] language may be trimmed down until it becomes weak and feckless, unfit for the work of strong, manly speech. (Ramsey 1892: 169)

His disapproval of this change and his fear of a decaying English language become apparent in this passage. I furthermore argue that his use of the expressions “weakening of the language” and “phonetic degradation” are depicted as a natural consequence of the linguistic behaviour of the English. Similarly, the English language is “trimmed down” – like a tree, for example – by the loss of /r/.

In addition to these arguments, which fall under the category Nature, he adds the dimension of gender and thus another social evaluation. The loss of /r/ is not only a “weakening of the language” per se but “weak” and “feckless”, hence less appropriate for men or, as he words it, “unfit for the work of strong, manly speech”. I categorised his use of “weak” and “feckless” as Social Evaluation because I interpret Ramsey’s (1892) use of these terms here as metaphorical. The fact that *feckless* is chiefly used as referring to persons in its later use supports this interpretation (OED: s.v. *feckless* adj.).

In Fowler’s (1855: 189) grammar, published in New York, post-vocalic /r/-absence is simply regarded as a mistake: “[o]ne error on this point in pronouncing a word is the *omission* of an element which belongs to it, as when one says *caad* for *card*”. Hyde’s (1895: 172) pronunciation exercises include the following: “[p]ronounce: — [do not omit the sound of r in these words.] dark, bark, garden, arms, car, hark, harm, warm, are, cart, lark, barn, carpet, far, card, large, star, market, jar, hard”. Therefore, Hyde does not provide any information on attitudes towards /r/ except that /r/-less forms are proscribed here. Similar to Gow (1892) and Nesfield (1900) in the British context, the only neutral North American grammar mentions a regional distribution, since Carpenter (1902: 221) states that /r/ “has already become silent in New York, as well as in other parts of America and England”, but that “it is still pronounced in our western states”.

Table 7.5 provides a summary of all grammars that treat post-vocalic /r/-absence, sorted by region and year. To show regional differences, asterisks were added to North American grammars, while British-Irish grammars are unmarked in the table. In addition to the quantitative similarity between British-Irish and North American grammars, they are very similar in the way they evaluate post-vocalic /r/-absence. In both regions, it is clearly stigmatised and judged in the speech of polite as well as “vulgar” speakers. The major difference is that among the British-Irish grammars, we find references to more specific groups like Cockneys, dandies, and London speech (Leigh 1840; Higginson 1864). In contrast, one North American grammar targets the English as a whole (Ramsey 1892). Moreover, aesthetic arguments are only used once and in a British-Irish grammar. Concerning the neutral descriptions, British-Irish grammars refer to the regional distribution in England: the far North traditionally maintaining /r/, while its absence is very common in the South. In the North American grammars, the traditionally non-rhotic area New York and less specifically other parts of America and England are mentioned.

Table 7.5: Summary of grammars that treat post-vocalic /r/-absence, sorted by region and year

grammar	region	attitude	evaluation of post-vocalic /r/-absence
Leigh (1840)	British-Irish	negative	cockneys, dandies
King (1854)	British-Irish	negative	disposition, marred in its pronunciation, rapidity of utterance to which many are addicted
Higginson (1864)	British-Irish	negative	one of the commonest faults of even well-bred people, not the less vulgar for being metropolitan, vulgarities of London speech, wrong
Fleay (1884)	British-Irish	negative	affected, corrupted, vulgar
Gow (1892)	British-Irish	neutral	common in southern English
Nesfield (1900)	British-Irish	neutral	except in the North
Kirkham (1834)*	North American	negative	erroneously pronounced, improper, mispronunciations, polite people, the vulgar
Brown (1851)*	North American	negative	improperly omit, should be avoided
Fowler (1855)*	North American	negative	error
Ramsey (1892)*	North American	negative	England, feckless, phonetic degradation, trimmed down, unfit for the work of strong and manly speech, weak, weakening of the language
Hyde (1895)*	North American	negative	do not omit
Carpenter (1902)*	North American	neutral	England, New York, other parts of America

7.6 /r/: Summary

As regards the distribution of /r/, having two sounds is by far the most frequent description in the CNG. The relevant passages almost exclusively contain the terms “rough” or “trill” for the prevocalic variant and “soft(er)” or “smooth(er)” for the post-vocalic variant. In four cases the post-vocalic “soft(er)”/“smooth” category also contains intervocalic examples or where /r/ occurs in syllable onsets after voiceless sounds as in *proud* (see Section 7.4). Assigning one specific variant to either of these terms is not possible due to insufficient data and also unlikely to have been the reality. The few grammars that offer some information on the articulation suggest (post-)alveolar and potentially bunched approximants as well as trills, taps or fricatives for initial /r/ and approximant, vocalic or rhotacised realisations for the second sound. In those grammars that only give one sound for /r/, regardless of position, one suggests a bunched approximant and one an alveolar trill. Clear and neutral descriptions indicating fully non-rhotic varieties only occur at the end of the century. Concerning the frequency of descriptions of /r/, more North American grammars provide sufficient information to derive a distribution of /r/ variants. Given the general frequency of a twofold distribution and the infrequency of proposing one sound, regardless of position, I argue that nineteenth-century speakers in Britain and North America at least displayed two different /r/ sounds. These sounds roughly confirm the trajectory of lenition that Hickey (2025: 281–282) suggests. This provides evidence for the continuation of a phonologically gradual change in /r/ in the nineteenth century. However, the closeness of example words and what appears to be almost verbatim copies from authors like Murray could also be evidence of a research tradition which involves copying or imitating renowned authors of the time, as previously suggested. Thus, it is also possible that a twofold distinction was proposed longer than it was actually used as the originality of many grammars should be seriously questioned.

The frequency of negative evaluations of /r/-lessness is balanced between Britain and North America and mostly confined to the second half of the century. Given the stigmatisation of non-rhoticity as a change led by the lower classes in Britain and as being characteristic of the former coloniser in North America, it is not surprising that the feature received negative responses from both localities. In terms of its stigmatisation, post-vocalic /r/ absence attracts more attention than the TRAP-BATH split and diphthongal FACE and GOAT vowels in the CNG. Yet, post-vocalic /r/-absence still received unexpectedly little attention in the CNG given its alleged stigmatisation. It is only discussed in 7% (12 of 166) of grammars that treat pronunciation. For a feature that is said to have been

stigmatised and with /r/-less forms having become the standard in England, this lack of attention is surprising.

As regards the types of comments that can be found, it is evaluated mainly on the social level or simply as an error. We can find terms like “vulgar”, “corrupt”, or “improper” in both localities for post-vocalic /r/-absence (Kirkham 1834; Higginson 1864; Fleay 1884). These have been reported frequently in eighteenth- and nineteenth-century sources, and thus conform to what we would expect from prescriptive discourses of the time (Sturiale 2016; Trapateau 2016; Anderwald 2017). In addition to these evaluations, /r/-lessness is associated with London in British-Irish grammars, e.g. the “vulgarities of London speech [...] not the less vulgar for being metropolitan” (Higginson 1864: 9), and references to Cockneys and dandies found in Leigh (1840). These negative evaluations thus conform to Walker’s statement on features typical of Londoners. Higginson’s (1864) reference to “even well-bred people” shows that a high degree of stigma was not exclusive to the working class. This conforms to the association with the “vulgar in London” (Smart 1836: vii) and “the mouths of educated speakers” (Ellis 1869b: 603). Despite being a North American grammar, we have also seen this reference to “polite people” and “the vulgar” in Kirkham (1834: 201). In contrast, Ramsey (1892) evaluates the feature as characteristic of the English as a whole, which supports the idea that for Americans the feature was clearly linked to Britishness. Ramsey’s (1892: 169) evaluation of the feature as “weak” and “unfit for the work of strong, manly speech” is in line with what Paulsen (2022) has found, i.e. that non-rhoticity is connected to effeminate characters such as the dude. Leigh’s (1840) evaluation of non-rhoticity as typical of the dandy could be interpreted in a similar fashion. The dandy in Britain can be regarded as the same figure as the dude in the sense that he is regarded as a cultured, well-dressed, and effeminate person.

The few neutral descriptions of post-vocalic /r/-absence could be explained by the feature having been more widespread and accepted in standard British speech towards the end of the century. Moreover, the advent of phonetics and the establishment of linguistics amongst the sciences could also explain a more neutral approach to discussing these features. As far as the striking difference in the approach towards non-rhoticity between late nineteenth-century grammarians like Ramsey (1892) and Gow (1892) is concerned, I argue that the former was likely an American grammarian, whereas the latter was British. Unfortunately, I have not been able to find more detailed biographical information on the grammarians collected in the CNG and we thus have to rely on the information that is available about the place of publication.

8 /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion

8.1 /h/: Historical background

The feature /h/-dropping refers to words which are spelled with initial <h> but pronounced without it. An example of this would be saying /aʊs/ for *house*. While it is often associated with traditional working-class speech from London, /h/-dropping is very widespread in England in informal speech and can be found in many traditional dialects (Ramisch 2010), as illustrated in Figure 8.1 where the only areas that retain /h/ in the word *hand* are the far North, a small part in the South-West and parts of the South-East (mainly East-Anglia).

/h/-insertion is the addition of initial /h/ to words that historically never had an /h/ in English in that position and do not suggest such a pronunciation based on their orthography, e.g. /heɪtʃ/ for *aitch*. The dropping and insertion of /h/ have a long history in the English language. Omission of initial /h/s occurs as early as OE, albeit still comparatively infrequently at that time. It is in the ME period that /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion become much more common through contact with French. This in turn likely accelerated the loss of /h/ in OE /hC/ clusters (Milroy 1992: 138–145; Hejná & Walkden 2022: 185–187). Today, /h/-dropping in the British-Irish Isles is common particularly in England, although there are cases of /h/ reinstatement, for instance in London (see Fox & Torgersen 2018). Varieties of Scotland, Ireland, North America, and Australia and New Zealand are characterised by maintaining /h/. There is however evidence for the historical presence of /h/-dropping in New Zealand as well (see Gordon 2010).

In terms of the social meaning of initial /h/, the /h/-full form is the one with overt prestige. According to Mugglestone (2007: 95), “[t]he use of /h/ in modern English has come to stand as one of the foremost signals of social identity”. Knowing where to put an /h/ and where to leave it out signals how well educated a person is and which class they belong to. The presence of /h/ in the correct words is “associated almost inevitably with the ‘educated’ and ‘polite’”, whereas “its loss commonly triggers popular connotations of the ‘vulgar’, the ‘ignorant’, and the ‘lower class’” (Mugglestone 2007: 95). Beal (2023: 463) points out that, as early as the eighteenth century, Sheridan (1762: 34) comments on /h/-dropping spreading amongst what he regarded as “the politer part of the world”. Beal moreover



Figure 8.1: Map showing the distribution of /h/-dropping in the word *hand* in twentieth-century dialects in England, recreated based on Orton et al. (1978)

notices that, while not regarded as “vulgar” in the ECEP, /h/-dropping was indeed stigmatised in the eighteenth-century dictionaries of the ECEP. Beal (2023: 463) moreover refers to the *The Language of the Labouring Poor in Late Modern English* (LALP) project, where it can clearly be identified as a lower-class feature (see Auer et al. 2023; Gardner 2023). Ellis (1869a: 223) also realised how pervasive the feature was becoming in the nineteenth century and that it was not only the lower classes who were omitting the /h/ in initial position (Jones 2006: 345).

As for its reputation in North America, Paulsen (2022: 382) finds that the English were parodied in American newspapers for dropping and inserting /h/. She observes that “Englishmen [...] were usually characterized as arrogant and as feeling superior to Americans, but their dropping and insertion of /h/ was used to depict them as being ‘in fact’ vulgar and ignorant”. While the terms “vulgar” and “ignorant” had been used by British authors to depict lower-class or illiterate speakers and to criticise their /h/-lessness, Paulsen (2022: 382) argues that these terms “were re-interpreted in America as applying to the majority of British people”. Therefore, from an American standpoint, /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion constituted Britishness and pronouncing /h/ in its “proper” position “functioned as a basis for American’s linguistic self-confidence” (Paulsen 2022: 410). British authors, on the other hand, used these features to delegitimise the speech of the lower classes and position themselves as linguistically superior.

Yet, as is the case today, some words are permitted, or rather expected, without initial /h/, e.g. *honour*, *heir*, *honest*, *hour*, *herb* (in AmE pronunciation), and words like *historical*, *him*, or *her* when unstressed. Indeed, in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries there was some debate as to whether some words which are /h/-full in RP and AmE pronunciation today are supposed to have an /h/. Based on 15 LModE sources, MacMahon (1998: 477–478) gives a list of words that were variable: *herb*, *herbaceous*, *herbage*, *herbal*, *herbalist*, *homage*, *hospital*, *hospitable*, *host*, *hostess*, *hostler*, *hotel*, *human*, *humble*, *humbly*, and *humour*. However, MacMahon’s sources are mainly from the eighteenth century (11 of 15 sources), and the most recent is Smart (1836). MacMahon states that the change in /h/-lessness in these words occurred between the late eighteenth and the middle of the nineteenth centuries.

To give an example of MacMahon’s sources, in Walker (1791: xiix, 46) the words *herb*, *hostler*, *hospital*, *humble* and *humour*, amongst others, are still listed as /h/-less, whereas words like *homage* and *herbal* have an /h/. That some of these pronunciations were controversial is well illustrated by Walker’s additional comment in his entry for *herb*, which reads: “I have differed from Mr. Sheridan by supressing the sound of the *h* in this word and its compound *herbage*; and have

Mr. Nares, Mr. Perry, and W. Johnson, on my side". Interestingly, the transcriptions for *herbal* and *herbalist* are /h/-full in Walker, which could be due to their different history. *Herb* is a borrowing from French, whereas *herbal* comes directly from Latin and *herbalist* is formed within English by means of an originally Latin/Greek suffix. As concerns a source not consulted by MacMahon, Murray (1795) does not mention any /h/-dropping whatsoever. In the third edition of his grammar, however, Murray adds a general comment on /h/-dropping but does not provide a list of words, perhaps to dodge taking a stance on the exact number of words which are to be used without /h/:

From the faintest of the sound of this letter, in many words, and its total silence in others, added to the negligence of tutors, and the inattention of pupils, it has happened that many persons have become almost incapable of acquiring its just and full pronunciation. It is therefore incumbent on teachers to be particularly careful to inculcate a clear and distinct utterance of this sound, on all proper occasions. (Murray 1797: 12)

This is nonetheless an important passage as we encounter this verbatim in some grammars of the CNG. There was also still variation in nineteenth-century North American sources: Worcester (1830), for instance, lists two possible pronunciations for *humble*, with or without /h/, while it appears from Webster (1828) that the word is to be /h/-full, thus reflecting a more modern realisation. As all of the words from MacMahon's list come from French and Latin, another interesting point to mention is that I have not been able to find any comments on the origin in /h/-less words in sources like Sheridan (1780), Walker (1791), Murray (1795, 1797) or Webster (1790). This in itself is astonishing because especially scholars like Walker include references to the origin of sounds and words as well as corresponding French sounds for all vowel features and several other consonants, but not in the section on /h/. This is the case in his preface and the dictionary entries and appears to be true of the whole of Sheridan's dictionary as well. In Webster (1828), however, at least the respective dictionary entries include information on the origin of the word, e.g. *hotel*, while in Worcester (1830) this information is only added for less frequent words still clearly marked as foreign, e.g. in the entry *hotel dieu* but not for *hotel*. According to the OED (s.v. *hôtel-Dieu* n.), this word is mainly used in French-speaking contexts.

However, in nearly all cases the /h/-full variant has won out over the /h/-less forms in the British-Irish Isles and North America, which, given the French origin of most words, at least at first glance seems surprising. The only exceptions from MacMahon's list are *herb*, *hostler*, and *humour*. The word *herb* is pronounced

without /h/ in the US today, while /h/-full forms exist there as well (see Wells 2008: 375; Upton & Kretzschmar 2017: 602; OED: s.v. *herb* n.). In the case of *hostler*, the realisation of /h/ is variable in the British-Irish Isles as well as North America today (see Upton & Kretzschmar 2017: 623; OED: s.v. *hostler* n.). In addition, *humour* is listed as variable or /h/-less only in AmE pronunciation (see Wells 2008: 391; Upton & Kretzschmar 2017: 627; OED: s.v. *humour* | *humor* n.).

As for the word *humble*, MacMahon (1998: 478) provides two additional sources (correspondence between Sweet and Storm from 1877, and Viëtor 1904) that show that the use of /ʌmbl/ becomes less common at the end of the nineteenth and beginning of the twentieth century. The variation of /h/-initial words can generally be explained by their complex etymology in English (MacMahon 1998: 477). Some words come directly from Latin (e.g. *herbal*), others are French borrowings (e.g. *humble*, *hospital*), words like *human* are of Latin and French origin, whereas words like *house*, *home*, *hound*, or the pronouns *he*, *him*, and *her* are originally Germanic (see the respective entries in the OED for more information on the history of the forms). In addition, words which are represented orthographically with <wh> today (e.g. *whale*, *what*) are part of a group of words inherited from Germanic that have in part maintained /h/ in emphatic pronunciation in some regions (see Chapter 9), whereas most OE /hC/ clusters have undergone lenition over time and show no traces of former /h/ even in their orthography (see for instance OE *hlāf* ‘loaf’).¹

The aim of this chapter is to determine to what extent words that are now pronounced with /h/ (e.g. *humble*) are still considered as correct without initial /h/ in the nineteenth century to find more evidence for the transitional period in prestige pronunciation. Given that most words from MacMahon’s list are indeed French borrowings, the etymology of the words and whether it is evoked as a criterion for the pronunciation of /h/ is considered as well. Furthermore, I scrutinise the extent to which /h/-dropping as well as /h/-insertion is stigmatised. Given Walker’s identification of the feature as typical of Londoners, I address the question of whether the features were regarded as characteristic of London in nineteenth-century grammars or whether there are other regional patterns that can be observed.

¹Words like *whole* and *whore* are an exception to this rule as the original form of these words only had <h> and <wh> spellings only started to be used in the fifteenth century (see also Chapter 9).

8.2 /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in the CNG: Overview

In total, 55 grammars in the CNG mention /h/-dropping or /h/-insertion (33% of grammars that contain information on pronunciation). This number, however, includes accepted as well as stigmatised forms of initial /h/-absence. There is no evidence on /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in any of the Irish or Canadian grammars. There are two Scottish grammars that contain some information on /h/, namely M'Culloch (1834) and Connon (1845). All data on these two features thus comes from grammars published in Britain or the US. The majority of those 55 grammars provide neutral descriptions of silent /h/ in their spoken standard, as in Turner (1840: 233): “*H* at the beginning of words is always sounded; except in *heir, herb, honest, honour, hospital, hostler, hour, humble, humour*, and their compounds”, which is almost word for word what we find in Walker (1791: 46). In fact, this is, with the exception of the use of “words” instead of “a word”, verbatim what is used in Brown (1857) and was likely copied from an earlier edition of Brown’s grammar. This is evident when we look at Turner’s (1840: iv) preface in which he acknowledges having used Brown’s grammar as the basis of his own grammar (see Sections 9.3 and 11.3 for other cases of plagiarism committed by Turner 1840 and taken from Brown):

the “Institutes of Grammar,” by Gould Brown, appeared to him [sc. Turner himself] so well suited to the purposes of instruction, that he has adopted it as the basis of the present work; and his own part of the task has been limited to such changes and modifications as, after much reflection, he judged necessary for the plan he had in view—the production of a practical Grammar for the use of English schools.

Similar wordings, yet with at times different examples, do also exist for /h/ in the CNG, for instance in Greenleaf (1821), Hallock (1849), or Meyrick (1873). While the structure of these comments on /h/ is to a certain extent alike, their use of different examples warrants a closer analysis. Moreover, compared to the similarity in structure in definitions of “improper diphthongs” and /r/-sounds discussed in previous sections, comments on /h/ are more heterogeneous in their wording. Nonetheless, the way of describing accepted /h/-less words is often identical and runs as follows: they state that /h/ in initial position is or should be sounded. Some then give examples, whereas others directly proceed to add a list of words where /h/-less pronunciations are permitted. In terms of potential plagiarism, it is possible that they copied from different sources or that they indeed added a list of words with words they deemed correct without initial /h/.

In total 43 grammars include similar information about what we could consider standard dropping in the sense that only those words are described that are required to have no /h/. In addition, four more grammars provide evidence for variation in the list of words that are /h/-less in the standard, equalling in total 47 grammars (30 British-Irish, 17 North American). Thus, 30% of British-Irish grammars (30 of 100) that treat pronunciation provide information on standard /h/-dropping, while for North American grammars it is 26% (17 of 66). This is only a small difference in quantity between both locations. The distribution of these grammars sorted by year and place of publication is shown in Figure 8.2. It shows that grammars that mention words with zero forms for /h/ occur throughout the century, albeit with overall more mentions in the period from 1830 until 1869. That there are only few comments before that time could be explained by the fact that overall the CNG contains fewer grammars from the beginning of the century. Perhaps, however, this is also due to the middle of the century marking the alleged point by which the change had occurred.

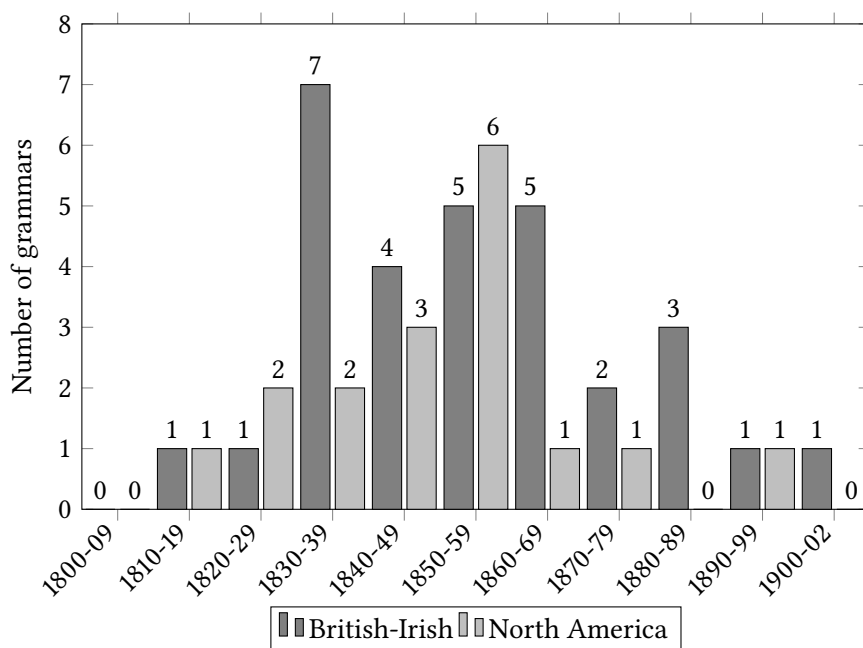


Figure 8.2: Grammars containing comments on standard /h/-dropping, sorted by decade and place of publication

By contrast, only 22 grammars reveal something about what we could consider non-standard /h/-dropping. In two of these grammars, the reference to /h/-

dropping is not very explicit and their evaluation of the feature is unclear. Hiley (1857: 15) notes that “words of similar *sound* but differing in respect of *aspiration* and import” like *harm* and *arm* or *hill* and *ill* are difficult words and may cause misspellings. He, however, does not evaluate the phonological feature as such but simply points to potential consequences for learners. Wells (1847: 36) only states that “*H* has the aspirate sound heard in *he*” and adds the following exercise, which could potentially imply mistakes on the side of students in the placement of initial /h/: “[e]xercise:—*Hat*, *h*; *home*, *h*; *hall*, *h*; *harm*, *h*; *behave*, *h*. *H* is sometimes silent; as in *heir*, *hour*, *honest*, *rhomb*”. If these cases are excluded, every form of non-standard /h/ is approached negatively in the remaining 20 grammars, except in Gow (1892: 16–19), where /h/-dropping is implicitly neutral as part of his dialect transcriptions for the South, and the northern Midlands. I return to this at the end of Section 8.4. In addition, 11 grammars provide information on /h/-insertion. While the majority of those grammars that mention /h/-insertion also mention /h/-dropping, two grammars only mention insertion and no non-standard dropping. All of these 11 grammars evaluate /h/-insertion as negative. Thus, in total there are 24 grammars which provide evidence for non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, of which two were excluded because their evaluation of the feature is unclear. In absolute terms, references to dropping and insertion can be found more often in British-Irish (13 grammars) than in North American (8 grammars) works. This is also true of /h/-insertion as seven instances occur in British-Irish grammars, but only four in North American grammars. However, as illustrated in Table 8.1, this is a minor difference in relation to the number of grammars that treat pronunciation from the respective regions: 13% of British-Irish and 12% of North American grammars treat non-standard /h/-dropping. The same applies to /h/-insertion, which is treated in 7% of British-Irish and 6% of North American grammars.

Table 8.1: Distribution of grammars that treat /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in relation to region

	British-Irish	North American	all
pronunciation treated	100	66	166
/h/-dropping	13 (13% of 100)	8 (12% of 66)	21 (13% of 166)
/h/-insertion	7 (7% of 100)	4 (6% of 66)	11 (7% of 166)

8.3 Accepted dropping and lexical distribution

Many grammars in the CNG indeed indicate the use of zero forms in words like *humble* and *hospital* in North America and Britain as shown in the quote by Turner in the previous section. Of 43 grammars that provide information on words in which /h/-dropping is accepted, four mention variation. All the grammars that specifically mention variation were published in London, namely Oliver (1825), Lowres (1863), Kirkus (1863), and Anonymous (1877). The words described as variable in these four grammars are *hospital*, *herb*, *hostler*, *humble*, *hotel*, and *inherit*.

According to Oliver (1825: 308), “usage is divided between the aspiration and nonaspiration” in the words *hospital* and *herb*. Lowres’ list of word in which /h/ is silent includes *hour*, *honest*, *hostler*, *heir*, *honour*, *hospital*, *herb*, *humour*, and *humble*. He adds the following comment to it: “it is doubted by some authors whether *hostler*, *hospital*, and *humble* should be pronounced without the aspirate” (Lowres 1863: 56). For Kirkus (1863: 4–5) the /h/ is “mute” in “*heir*, *hour*, *honest*, *honour*, and most of the words derived from these”. Kirkus continues by admitting that “[t]here are two or three other words beginning with *h*, in which the *h* is sometimes pronounced and sometimes mute”. The two examples he gives here are *humble* and *hospital*. He names the usage of well-educated speakers as the criterion for the correct pronunciation of these words. However, he notices that there is variation even in this particular group of speakers, which functions as a linguistic model for him. Yet, it is not specified whom exactly he means by well-educated: “[s]ome well-educated people pronounce the word *humble* as if the *h* were mute; others give the *h* its usual sound: This difference of usage is the reason why the pronunciation of the word *humble* is uncertain”. In one anonymous grammar it furthermore reads: “*H* is silent in *heir*, *heiress*; *hour*, *hourly*; *honour*, *honourable*; *honest*, *honesty*. Some insist upon dropping it also in *hotel*, *hostler*, *humble*, *herb*, *hospital*, and *inherit*” (Anonymous 1877: 7). The way these grammars mention variation, i.e. referring to doubt, uncertainty and insistence, points first and foremost to variation but also perhaps to insecurity and an ongoing discourse around correct norms of pronunciation. These four grammars seem to indicate that there was indeed still variation in words like *hotel*, *humble*, *hospital* as late as 1877, while MacMahon (1998: 477–478) suggests that the change to /h/-fullness happened in the first half of the century, which is mostly confirmed by the remaining 43 grammars (see Table 8.3). Moreover, the comment by Anonymous (1877: 7), whose grammar was published in London, suggests that the word *herb* was at least variable outside of North America until comparatively late in the century too.

Similar to Kirkus (1863: 4–5), several grammarians add statements like “and their derivatives” to their list of words which have no /h/. In Table 8.2 and Table 8.3 I ignored this comment because it is not clear, for instance, if derivatives of *herb* would comprise words like *herbal* and *herbalist*. In other words, grammarians do not usually comment on what they regard as a derived form and there might be subtle differences, as noted for Walker above, who regards *herbal* and *herbalist* as words with initial /h/ and *herb* and *herbage* without. I only added those words that were explicitly mentioned by the grammarians and refrained from adding a list of derived forms potentially anticipated by them. The next issue with the grammars in the CNG is that they usually only give a list of words that are not to be realised with an initial /h/, but do not specifically include those that should receive an /h/. In the following paragraphs, I have treated every derived form that was mentioned separately, also in terms of frequency numbers. To illustrate this, *humour* is not counted together with *humourist*, or *humoursome*. Spelling differences between <ou> and <o> in words like *humour* or *honour* have been disregarded because these are mere orthographical conventions and very unlikely to have an impact on the realisation of initial /h/ in the respective words. I consistently employ <ou> spellings in these cases unless I quote grammarians directly.

Table 8.2: Most frequent example words of /h/-less pronunciations in the CNG

no.	word	freq.
1	<i>hour</i>	31
2	<i>heir</i>	30
3	<i>honest</i>	25
3	<i>honour</i>	25
5	<i>herb</i>	16
6	<i>humour</i>	14
7	<i>hospital</i>	11
8	<i>hostler</i>	10
9	<i>humble</i>	8
10	<i>honesty</i>	5

If we consider the ten most frequently used example words for standard /h/-dropping from the other 43 grammars, we can see that the first six are words that would also be /h/-less, or at least variable, in present-day RP or AmE pronunciation, as shown in Table 8.2 (for a full list, see Table A.5 in the Appendix);

Table 8.3: Variable /h/-initial words under sections on pronunciation in the CNG, based on a list by MacMahon (1998: 477–478)

word	word origin (see OED)	years of publication of grammars listing respective word without /h/			
		British-Irish	freq.	North American	freq.
<i>herb</i>	French	1817, 1834, 1835, 1837, 1840, 1853, 1854, 1857, 1858, 1862	10	1821, 1849, 1851, 1857, 1859, 1892	6
<i>herbaceous</i>	Latin	—	—	—	—
<i>herbage</i>	French	1817, 1858	2	1821	1
<i>herbal</i>	Latin	—	—	—	—
<i>herbalist</i>	derived form	—	—	—	—
<i>homage</i>	French	—	—	—	—
<i>hospital</i>	French	1817, 1834, 1835, 1837, 1840, 1857, 1858	7	1821, 1834, 1851, 1857	4
<i>hospitable</i>	French	—	—	—	—
<i>host</i>	French	—	—	—	—
<i>hostess</i>	French	—	—	—	—
<i>hostler</i>	French	1817, 1835, 1837, 1840, 1858, 1900	6	1821, 1851, 1857, 1892	4
<i>hotel</i>	French	1900	1	—	—
<i>human</i>	French/Latin	—	—	—	—
<i>humble</i>	French	1817, 1834, 1835, 1837, 1857	5	1821, 1851, 1857	3
<i>humbly</i>	derived form	—	—	—	—
<i>humo(u)r</i>	French/Latin	1817, 1834, 1835, 1837, 1840, 1856, 1857, 1858, 1900	9	1821, 1851, 1857, 1873, 1892	5

Hour, *heir*, *honest*, *honour* are categorically pronounced without /h/ nowadays. *Honesty* and *hostler* may or may not be realised with initial /h/ today. Whereas *herb* is realised with /h/ in the British-Irish Isles, the pronunciation without /h/ is variable but quasi standard in present-day AmE pronunciation. As noted previously, there is variation in the /h/ of *humour* only in North America.

This leaves us with *hospital* and *humble*. It is noticeable that these words are comparatively infrequent in the grammars of the CNG. From 39 grammars only 11 and eight works respectively mention these words. It appears that words that nowadays still maintain an /h/-less pronunciation were perhaps regarded more typical of the category of words in which “dropped” /h/s are required. This could perhaps be due to the fact that there was variation in the others.

In terms of the developments of individual words and their regional distribution, Table 8.3 shows a few interesting points. The word *herb* is not listed with an /h/-less pronunciation in British-Irish grammars after 1862. In contrast, the last mention in North American grammars that indicates /h/-full realisations in this case is from 1892. This might be expected as realisations of *herb* still exhibit variation in North America today. The word *herbage* is generally infrequent, and no other related or derived forms of *herb* are mentioned in the grammars. *Hostler* is listed without /h/ throughout the century, which conforms with the fact that its realisation is still variable, regardless of locality. Furthermore, the words *humble* and *hospital* stop being listed as pronounced without /h/ after 1857/1858 in both regions. This appears to confirm that the process by which pronunciations with initial /h/ acquired the status of standard variants took roughly until the middle of the century, as suggested by MacMahon (1998: 477). The last mention of *hotel* can be found in Nesfield (1900: 276) and is surprisingly late for this word. The inclusion of *humour* without /h/ until comparatively late in both regions is also somewhat surprising as it is only used without /h/ in present-day AmE pronunciation.

Unfortunately, grammars rarely provide evidence of /h/-full forms for MacMahon’s list, except indirectly in the sense that grammars do not include them in the examples in which /h/ is silent. Gow (1892) is the only grammar that explicitly comments on the development in *humour*, *herb* and *hospital* and names them as /h/-full as opposed to *hour*, *heir* and *honest*. However, he even hypothesises that these words could acquire an /h/ in the future as well. He writes: “[t]hirty years ago it was usual to omit *h* in pronouncing *humour*, *herb*, *hospital*. It is now usual to pronounce *h* in these words, and perhaps it will become usual to do so in *hour*, *heir*, *honest*, etc.” (Gow 1892: 22). We know that to this day this has not happened. This is an important comment nonetheless as it shows that he regards /h/-less pronunciations in *humour*, *herb* and *hospital* as obsolete forms and dates them

back 30 years and thus roughly at the beginning of the 1860s, again conforming to MacMahon's dating of the change.

While reading through the grammars of the CNG, I noticed that some grammarians treat /h/ not only in the sections that concern pronunciation and spelling but also in other sections, mostly under the topic of indefinite articles. These grammars sometimes list words with permitted /h/-less realisations in these sections because whether /h/ is present or not determines the choice between the indefinite articles *a* and *an*. I have found those passages even in grammars that otherwise do not treat pronunciation. It is in 31 grammars that /h/-less variants are discussed in other sections than those on pronunciation. Therefore, I decided to discuss these separately at the end of the present section because ten of them are not part of the 166 grammars that were generally counted as containing information on pronunciation. In total, seven of these 31 grammars mention words from MacMahon's list and are thus relevant for the present analysis, namely Connon (1845), Crane (1843), Hiley (1857), Nicholson (1864), Norman (1875), Ridpath (1881), and Weedon (1848). They all discuss /h/-dropping in the context of indefinite articles.² Of these Norman (1875) and Weedon (1848) were counted as not treating pronunciation. Despite the fact that Crane (1843) and Nicholson (1864) are part of the category of grammars that treat pronunciation, they only comment on /h/-less variants under their sections on articles and not under the respective sections "LETTERS AND SYLLABLES" and "ORTHOGRAPHY", where we would normally expect comments on pronunciation in LModE grammars. The remaining three grammars Connon (1845), Hiley (1857), and Ridpath (1881) mention /h/-dropping more than once in their grammars³. Apart from Ridpath (1881), the grammars important for the present discussion are British-Irish grammars. Connon's (1845) grammar was published in Edinburgh. Some comments on /h/-dropping in the context of indefinite articles are more beneficial compared to all the other comments because they sometimes give examples of where /h/ is indeed still pronounced, as shown in Table 8.4.

Table 8.4 shows that the latest British-Irish grammar that mentions *herb* without and /h/ comes from 1864, namely Nicholson (1864), and not 1862. Moreover, in Norman (1875) it is already listed with /h/. For *hospital*, *hostler*, *humble*, and *humour* (including its derived form *humorous*) all dates in Table 8.4 are the same or earlier than those noted in Table 8.3.

²The terminology they use in these sections might differ as Connon (1845) and Norman (1875) consider *a* and *an* adjectives.

³The other passage by Hiley (1857) has already been discussed and Ridpath's (1881) comments are considered under prescriptions in the next section.

Table 8.4: Variable /h/-initial words under sections on articles in the CNG, based on a list by MacMahon (1998: 477–478)

word	realised without /h/		realised with /h/	
	British-Irish	North American	British-Irish	North American
<i>herb</i>	1857, 1864	—	1875	—
<i>herbage</i>	—	—	1875	—
<i>hospital</i>	1845, 1857	—	1875	—
<i>hostler</i>	1875	—	—	—
<i>hotel</i>	—	—	1875	—
<i>humble</i>	1848, 1857	—	1875	1881
<i>humbly</i>	—	—	1875	—
<i>humbleness</i>	—	—	1875	—
<i>humour</i>	1857, 1875	—	—	—
<i>humorous</i>	1875	—	—	1881

Regarding the etymology of the words, only three grammars make explicit mention of the French and Latin origins of the words and these are also from the end of the century: White (1882), Ramsey (1892), Nesfield (1900), with Ramsey's grammar being the only North American work of these three. White (1882: 66) for instance writes that “*h* is also silent in a few words of Latin origin, as *hour*”. However, according to the OED (*hour* n.), the word *hour* is a borrowing from French and had never been pronounced with /h/ in English (or in French for that matter). Yet, this constitutes at least an attempt at using the etymology of the word to describe its pronunciation. Given that White assumed the word to have come directly from Latin, he would have expected the /h/ to be realised. This shows that the origin of words could at least have been part of the reason behind the categorisation of words with and without /h/ in the grammars, as I suggested for Walker above. Ramsey (1892: 147) states “Seven words—*heir*, *herb*, *honest*, *honor*, *hostler*, *hour*, *humor*—that come to us through the French, begin with silent *h*”. Thus, Ramsey identifies the etymology of the words correctly, with the exception that some instances of *honour* and *humour* also come directly from Latin. The origin of the words seems to be the criterion here for categorising which words should take no initial /h/. The mention of *herb* and *humour* can be explained by this grammar being North American.

Concerning etymology, Nesfield (1900: 275–276) focusses more on the ME period, which through contact with French had many words in which /h/ was dropped. He writes that “[t]he aspirate in French was weak [...] Hence, in Mid.

8.4 Prescriptions and proscriptions: /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion

Eng., which contained many words of French origin, we have *abit* for *habit*, *eir* for *heir*, *ost* for *host*, *ostel* for *hostel*, *onest* for *honest*, *onour* for *honour*, *umble* for *humble*, *our* for *hour*". He moreover describes a few words which originally had /h/ in Latin but lost it in English through French influence. The examples he provides are however earlier developments and particularly those in which the modern form obscures the historical /h/, e.g. *able* (see classical Latin *habilis*), *arbour* (see classical Latin *herbarium*), but also *hostler*. In this section, he does not comment on which of these have /h/ in his day, but states that "*h* is almost or quite silent in English, unless its syllable is accented". He gives us information on the words *historical*, *hotel*, *harangue*, which take the indefinite article *an* rather than *a* as these words are not accented. Thus, he implies that /h/ is not realised in these three words. A lack of emphasis as in these cases is also the reason for the change of the third person singular pronoun from OE *hit* to ModE *it*. In a later section of his grammar, he lists *heir*, *hour*, *honour*, *humour*, *honest* as words where *h* is silent (Nesfield 1900: 297).

That etymological arguments are largely absent in the CNG could be explained by several factors. It could be due to the character of grammars and that generally less information was given on pronunciation than on morpho-syntactic features and compared to pronouncing dictionaries. Moreover, perhaps it was simply didactically irrelevant. While the origin of the word might have played a role in the general discussion and change in /h/-full words, for grammar books and teaching it might have been sufficient to tell students which words to memorise, especially given the complex history of /h/-initial words outlined above. However, this could furthermore be highly feature-dependent as for WHALE words there are several arguments based on the origins of <wh> words (see Section 9.4). Additionally, as it appears that grammarians tended to be influenced by earlier works their models might have simply lacked etymological information.

8.4 Prescriptions and proscriptions: /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion

In terms of prescriptions and proscriptions, the main categories in which evaluations of /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion can be summarised are Mistake (12 grammars) and Social Evaluation (10 grammars). References to the Education of speakers (4 grammars), arguments based on Aesthetics (2 grammars), and those concerning Nature (2 grammar) are less frequent. The latter two categories are exclusive to British-Irish grammars. Similar to the features previously discussed, grammarians in the CNG do not employ arguments based on Logic for /h/. Three

grammars do not make any specific evaluation but simply prescribe and proscribe certain forms. The evaluative terms used in the CNG are summarised in Figure 8.3. Norman (1875), whose grammar was discussed separately from the other grammars in the previous section as it was categorised as not treating pronunciation, will also be discussed in the present section. His grammar includes prescriptive statements belonging to the categories Social Evaluation and Nature. However, they were neither included in the numbers of different types of evaluation above nor in Figure 8.3. This decision was made for the sake of maintaining consistency throughout the present work as only grammars that have dedicated sections on pronunciation were otherwise considered in the quantitative analysis (see the criteria outlined in Chapter 3).

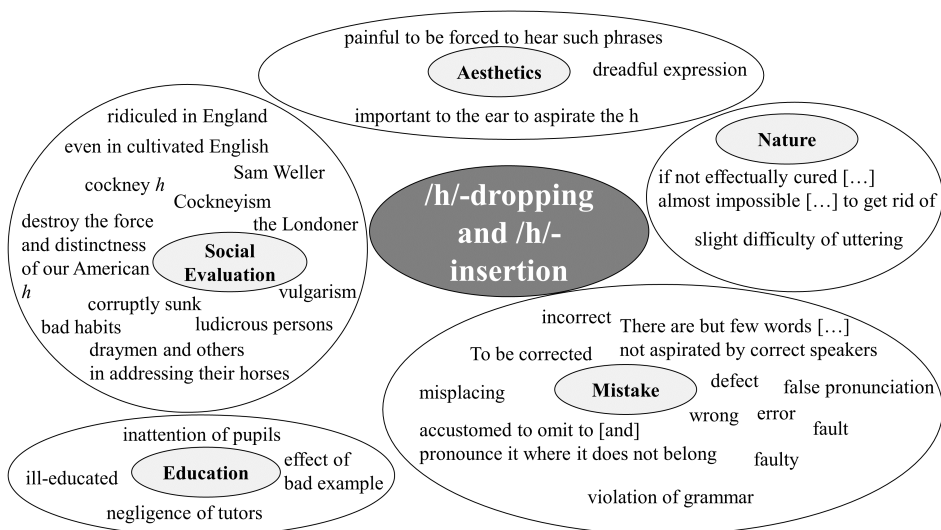


Figure 8.3: Evaluative terms used for /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in the CNG, sorted by category

As the number of evaluative comments is higher for /h/ than for any of the features previously discussed, this section only presents a selected number of examples in order to illustrate the categories and how they differ in terms of region, starting with British-Irish grammars.

The earliest grammar that mentions non-standard /h/ is Hodson (1806: 56–57), published in London. In this grammar, /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion are identified as mistakes and implicitly referred to as resulting from bad education. He contends that “faults in pronunciation are innumerable” and that some of them are “omitting the aspirate *h* where it should be used: as, *our* for *hour*; and

8.4 Prescriptions and proscriptions: /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion

using it where there should be none; as, *hegg* for *egg*". He claims that "fault[s] in articulation" are in fact "the effect of bad example, or inattention only" and not "a natural defect in some of the organs of speech". He thus disputes arguments pertaining to the category Nature and proposes that "faults" such as /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion are the result of imitation and faulty learning; hence implying criticism of the speakers' education.

Amongst the British-Irish sources is Lowres' (1863: 62–63) grammar, which contains a passage on /h/ that could be interpreted as belonging to the category Nature. In his section "Caution", he identifies /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion as mistakes. However, he remarks the following about the features listed under the section: "if not effectually cured of the habit in their young years, it is almost impossible for them to get rid of it when they grow older". His use of "cured" implicitly equates linguistic variants with an illness that has the potential to become chronic. The fact that he says "habit" in the same sentence suggests that he considers /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion to be learnt. In spite of "cured" being used in a figuratively extended meaning in this passage, the category Nature applies well as the whole sentence still conveys a sense of linguistic features needing healing. As previously noted, Norman's (1875) grammar contains a comparable comment under his section on articles. He writes:

Among the majority of our English elementary school children, at all events in the south, it would seem to be a waste of time to try to enforce rules about aitches; as their incapacity of aspirating, at all events in the proper place, appears to be radical and incurable. (Norman 1875: 10)

His use of the words "incapacity" and "incurable" implies a connection to a natural flaw and can thus be categorised under Nature. The reference to "our English elementary school children, at all events in the south" is clearly a Social Evaluation, which also depicts a typical association of /h/-dropping with southern British or London speakers. This passage not only reveals a strong aversion to the feature of /h/-dropping but also shows that Norman (1875) is more strict in his approach than Lowres (1863) as he claims that it would be a "waste of time" to try and teach the children.

In Leigh (1840) we can find strong negative attitudes to /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion based on a combination of aesthetics, his identification of the features as mistakes, and his evaluation of the speakers that use the feature. Leigh (1840: viii–ix) states in his preface that "[f]ew persons there are, whose ears are so extremely obtuse, as not to be frequently annoyed at the violations of Grammar by which they are so often assailed". He continues by claiming that "[i]t is really

painful to be forced, in walking along the streets, to hear such phrases as, ‘That *‘ere homnibus*.’ ‘Where’ve you *bin*.’ ‘Vot ’s the *hodds*?’ and the like”. Moreover, he compares speakers who use these features to the language of carters, as he contends that these “[v]ery dreadful expressions are also used by draymen and others in addressing their horses”. A few pages later he adds that “there is nothing in the office of a Parish Clerk that makes it desirable that he should be a ludicrous person. There is no reason why he should have [...] an inability to use, or a tendency to omit, the aspirate” (Leigh 1840: 7). In his section on the wrong spelling of words, the words *house*, *happiness*, *Higgins*’, and *has* furthermore appear without an /h/, while *one* appears with an /h/ (Leigh 1840: 16–17). His usage of words such as *violation*, *painful*, *dreadful* and his reference to *draymen* or *ludicrous persons* clearly shows his strongly negative attitude to the features and its link to working-class occupations.

Higginson (1864: 9) adds a regional distribution to his evaluation. He states that “[t]he omission or misplacing of this sound is one of the commonest vulgarisms throughout England, south of the Tyne or Tees”, while “[t]he Scotch and Northumbrians almost invariably use it correctly”. In a similar fashion to other grammar writers and dictionary authors of the time, he then gives his readers a list of words in which the pronunciation of /h/ is prohibited, hence proscribing /h/-less forms in a specific number of words, e.g. *hour*, *heir*, *honour*, and *honest*. From his passage, we can derive that Higginson (1864) regards insertion and dropping as incorrect, and as geographically restricted to the regions south of the rivers Tyne and Tees, which is still mirrored in twentieth-century dialects (Orton et al. 1978). By the use of “vulgarism”, he adds a social evaluation and at the end of the passage appends a proscription and a prescription, namely that in any other word that he has not listed /h/ should be pronounced.

Kelke’s (1885: 35) grammar, published in London at the close of the century, provides an explicit evaluation of the speakers’ educational status as he claims that “‘Poor letter H’ is badly treated by the ill-educated”. Kelke (1885) refers to the sixpenny manual *Poor Letter H*, which was “exclusively devoted to the pronunciation of [h] and its social importance” (Mugglestone 2007: 108). However, he continues that “[e]ven in cultivated English it has disappeared from the three words *heir*, *hour*, *honour*” (Kelke 1885: 35), which contrary to his statement is assumed to have never had /h/ in English. This comment also illustrates well that the line between what I have termed standard /h/-dropping and non-standard /h/-dropping may be blurry in nineteenth-century sources. This could at the same time also be an indication for the spread in non-lower-class speakers of /h/-less variants in words normally not allowed without /h/.

8.4 Prescriptions and proscriptions: /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion

Social evaluations of /h/ are generally more often found in British-Irish sources (6 grammars) than in North American ones (3 grammars). Whereas in the British-Irish sources we find terms such as “vulgarism” (Higginson 1864) or “corruptly sunk” (Oliver 1825) for /h/-dropping, all three North American grammars ascribe the feature to a specific group. These are “the Londoner” (Fowler 1855: 116), “Sam Weller” (Ridpath 1881: 304), a stereotypical Cockney character from Charles Dickens’ *The Pickwick Papers* (published in 1836) who makes his living by boot-blackening, and Cockneys, by naming the feature “Cockneyism” or “cockney *h*” (Ramsey 1892: 159–160, 176). Fowler (1855: 116) embraces an almost descriptive approach when he discusses /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in London speakers. According to him, “[t]he Londoner is also accustomed to omit the sound of *h* at the beginning of words, and to pronounce it where it does not belong; as, *art* for *heart*; *harm* for [sic!] *arm*”. Fowler (1855) implicitly identifies these features as mistakes but refrains from any further value judgments. In Ridpath (1881: 304), we can find the reference to Sam Weller and his father Mr. Weller in his paragraph on “Mimesis”, which he defines as “[t]he spelling of words in imitation of a false pronunciation”. His example of mimesis is the following: “‘*Vell*, I think it is *rayther* good,’ said Sam. 2. ‘*Wot* I like in that ‘ere writin’,’ said Mr. Weller, ‘is that there a’n’t no *Wenuses* in it’”. These lines appear exactly like this in Dickens’ *The Pickwick Papers* (1836–37). Ridpath (1881) thus evaluates the feature as wrong and connects it to Cockney speakers through Sam Weller. It is worth noting that the character of Sam Weller was known in North America not only through Dickens’ novel but furthermore through newspaper articles. Sam Weller’s valentine’s letter was frequently reprinted in nineteenth-century American newspapers, e.g. under title *Letter Writing* in the Berkshire County Whig 1845 or as *Sam Weller’s Valentine* in the Daily Columbus Enquirer 1860. These articles also include the lines that Ridpath quotes in his grammar almost verbatim. In Ridpath’s grammar we can find a second negative evaluation of /h/-dropping in his discussion on indefinite articles. His comment exhibits a sense of pride of the fact that /h/ is persevered in America but also shows a fear of /h/-dropping becoming widespread through British influence:

The opposite usage tends to destroy the force and distinctness of our American *h* and to bring about those very forms of speech which have been so much ridiculed In England, such as ‘*andsome*, for handsome; ‘*orse*, for horse; ‘*undred* for hundred; ‘*it ‘im on ‘is ‘ead* for hit him on his head. (Ridpath 1881: 101)

Ridpath’s mention of “the opposite usage” refers to either using *an* where *a* should be used or vice versa. In contrast to all the other evaluations in North

American grammars, this depicts an association with the feature and speakers in England as a whole rather than Cockneys or southern British speakers. Moreover, the American pronunciation is, although threatened, evidently regarded as the correct opposite to the dropping of /h/ in England. In terms of prescriptive categories, Ridpath's grammar can be classified under Social Evaluation and Mistake.

Ramsey (1892: 159–160) identifies expressions like “*a hass and an 'orse*” as Cockneyism; i.e. inserting /h/ in the word *ass* while dropping it in *horse*. In addition, the two North American grammars that contain references to the education of speakers, namely Fisk (1822: 39) and Swett (1844: 173), are in fact based on Murray (1797) and copy his wording verbatim, thus referring to the “negligence of tutors” and “inattention of pupils” with respect to /h/.

To these grammars can be added one comment on Gow's grammar. As previously noted, he does not specifically discuss non-standard /h/-dropping or displays any form of stigma towards the feature. However, the section of his grammar which includes dialect transcriptions (see Section 6.6) indeed shows transcriptions without initial /h/ for the southern, and northern Midlands dialects, but not for Lowland Scots. In fact, /h/ is categorically absent in his southern and northern transcriptions, which is surprising for his southern region as it includes “Wilts, Dorset, most of Somerset and Gloucester, and adjacent parts of other counties” (Gow 1892: 16), and thus mainly the Southwest. This area still had /h/ in traditional dialects of the twentieth century (see Ramisch 2010 for an analysis of the SED data). For the Midlands and Scots his transcriptions conform to what we could expect. In any case, what this perhaps illustrates best is that the feature had become associated with more than simply London in England of the nineteenth century.

All these excerpts show that the main difference lies in the social evaluation of the features and the absence of the categories Aesthetics and Nature in North American grammars. British-Irish grammars like Higginson (1864) and Kelke (1885) consider /h/-dropping, and in the case of the former also /h/-insertion, a “vulgar” and bad feature which occurs throughout England and amongst the higher as well as the lower social classes. Leigh (1840) specifically targets lower classes with his criticism. In North American grammars, however, it is clearly linked to Cockney speakers, perhaps mainly through literary figures such as Sam Weller rather than through actual contact with working-class speakers from London. The only exception to this is Ridpath's (1881) second comment where speakers in England are generally evaluated as dropping /h/.

8.5 /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion: Summary

In terms of /h/-dropping in the grammarians' perceived standard, more grammars provide commentary than on non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. The passages are usually short and appear reminiscent of what we can find in eighteenth-century authors like Walker. However, they occur throughout the nineteenth century. The most frequently used example words of standard /h/-dropping are also /h/-less in modern English and never had /h/ in the first place: *hour*, *heir*, *honest*, *honour*. Regarding words that according to MacMahon (1998: 477–478) were subject to change in the LModE period, the CNG confirms his results that the change was completed around the middle of the century. The words *hospital* and *humble* do not occur without /h/ after 1858 in any grammar, irrespective of the place of publication. The same applies to the word *herb* in British-Irish grammars with its last mention in 1864, which is to be expected given its present-day distribution. The word *hostler* appears without /h/ throughout and as late as 1900 (British-Irish) and 1892 (North American), which is in line with modern variation between /h/ and zero. The only surprise is the word *humour*, which appears in Nesfield (1900), a British-Irish grammar in which we would have expected /h/-full variants based on its present-day realisation. However, with the exception of Nesfield, the last mention of /h/-less *humour* in the British-Irish grammars is from 1858, which again conforms to what we would expect. Gow's (1892: 22) dating of the previously /h/-less realisations of *humour*, *herb*, *hospital* to thirty years ago, i.e. c. 1862, also aligns roughly with the middle of the century as the turning point, at least for British-Irish sources. One comment by an anonymous grammar (Anonymous 1877: 7) concerning the insistence of some scholars on the dropping in *hotel*, *hostler*, *humble*, *herb*, *hospital*, and *inherit* shows that there was likely still some reluctance to accept the new pronunciation late in the century.

Besides three grammars from the close of the century, there are no comments on the etymology of the words and their influence on the realisation of /h/. I have suggested that this could be the case because grammars overall contained less information on pronunciation than on grammatical phenomena and that the didactical value of etymological explanations was too small to include them. Nevertheless, the amount of etymological information given might be feature-dependent as for other connected features like the use of /hw/ in <wh> words like *what*, more grammars evoke arguments based on the origin of the words, as I discuss in Section 9.4. Moreover, as grammars were a product of copying renowned authors, there might have simply been a lack of explanations based on word origin in their sources.

As concerns the non-standard use of /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, the results are regionally balanced, albeit with qualitative differences in the evaluations by the grammarians. The two dominant categories into which evaluations fall are Mistake and Social Evaluation. The terms that the grammarians in the CNG utilise to evaluate /h/ like “vulgar”, “corrupt”, or “improper” can similarly be found for features like post-vocalic /r/ absence. The features of /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion are thus clearly regarded as mistakes by nineteenth-century grammarians. Whereas aesthetic arguments and those belonging to Nature only occur in British-Irish grammars, the category Education can be found in both locations, although only through verbatim copies from Murray (1797) in North America. With respect to further evaluations of the features, there is, however, a noticeable difference between British-Irish and North American grammars. In the former we find comments like “*H* [...] is corruptly sunk” (Oliver 1825: 308), “Poor letter *H*’ is badly treated by the ill-educated” (Kelke 1885: 35), or “one of the commonest vulgarisms throughout England” (Higginson 1864: 9). Leigh (1840) associates the features with working-class occupations. This represents its high degree of stigma and Sheridan’s (1762: 34) and Ellis’ (1869a: 223) observation that the feature was spreading through England.

In North American grammars, it is solely Cockneys and the Londoners who are associated with these features, apart from one comment by Ridpath (1881). This perception is likely reinforced by literary figures whose speech was frequently characterised by these features (Mugglestone 2007: 96). In Ridpath (1881), this is made explicit with Dickens’ character Sam Weller. Characters like Sam Weller could have represented stereotypical British working-class speakers for these North American grammarians and were thus used as a means of criticising and distancing themselves from British norms. While absolute numbers are generally low, it is noticeable that similar arguments to Walker’s identification of the features as typical of London and Cockneys can only be found in North American sources. This could be due to its spread in England and with an emerging AmE identity defined opposed to stereotypical British features.

9 WHICH-WITCH merger

9.1 WHICH-WITCH merger: Historical background

This section is concerned with a consonantal lexical set that Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018) have termed the *WHALE* set, analogous to Wells' (1982) standard lexical sets for vowels. The set comprises words going back to OE <hw> spellings such as *hwit* 'white', *hwæt* 'what', or *hwēol* 'wheel, circle', which used to have /hw/ in OE but have /w/ in the majority of standard English varieties today. This merger of /hw/ and /w/ has been labelled *WHICH-WITCH* merger (see Hickey 2023: 83–84). The pronunciations of both classes of words, i.e. those with modern <wh> and with <w> spellings, were historically distinct, but both have /w/ in many PDE accents. Some speakers in the far North of England, in Scotland, Ireland, New Zealand, and North America, however, still maintain the distinction between /hw/ and /w/ in these and similar words (Trudgill 2004: 77).¹ Nonetheless, some studies have shown evidence of a change to /w/ in these regions more recently (see for instance Stuart-Smith et al. 2007: 239–240 for Glasgow; Corrigan 2010: 46 for Northern Ireland). Indeed, Hickey (2023: 83) also points out that not many varieties of English still consistently distinguish between *which* and *witch* in the twenty-first century. The *WHALE* set further contains what Laing & Lass (2019: 108) refer to as the *WHO(M)* and *WHOSE* sets, i.e. words that are pronounced with simple /h/ today such as *who(m)* (OE *hwā(m)*) but etymologically had an /hw/ cluster. In these, /w/ was likely lost due to labial co-occurrence between /w/ and the following rounded high vowel (see Beal & Sen 2014: 47). Based on Dobson (1957: 980–981), Beal & Sen (2014: 42) suggest that this change took place between the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries although the older form was maintained into the seventeenth century in conservative registers. Moreover, PDE <wh> spellings that had simple <h> in OE like in *hāl* 'whole', *hōre* 'whore'

¹In Scotland <qu> type spellings, phonetically realised as [kw], are also historically attested. These have been interpreted as a fortition of OE [xw]. These are by far not the only orthographical forms for OE <hw> – Laing & Lass (2019) find 57 different spelling variants representing different periods and regional variation. For the Anglicisation of Scots <qu> types, see for instance van Eynhoven & Clark (2019). In the North-East of Scotland, realisations of /w/ like [f], [ɸ], or even zero are attested as well (McColl Millar 2007: 61–62; Hughes et al. 2012: 133).

are also included in the category of *who*(M) and *whose* sets. Polysyllabic words where the /hw/ cluster occurs in non-initial position like *somewhere*, *nowhere*, *overwhelm* are subsumed under the *whale* set.

The disappearance of the first segment in <hw> words has been interpreted as part of a lenition process: [xw] > [hw] > [ʰw] > [w] (see Laing & Lass 2019: 93), which eventually led to the WHICH-WITCH merger. The move from [x] to [h] in the first segment of /hw/ was under way already in OE. However, according to Laing & Lass (2019: 108), “[x] remained (at least variably) in the North-East Midlands, parts of North-West Midlands and the North well into the ME period”. /w/ variants occur as early as the twelfth century, at least in the South of England (Beal & Sen 2014: 42). However, given the sparsity of actual <w> spellings in the data from the fifteenth to the seventeenth centuries, Beal and Sen argue that /w/ had not become the regular pronunciation yet. They quote Johnston’s (1764: 9) comment that /h/ in these clusters was “very little heard” as evidence for the weakening of the aspiration in southern dialects, while they state that it was still fully realised in the North and in Scotland at Johnston’s time. In terms of the lenition process described above, this weakening can be interpreted as constituting the third stage, i.e. [ʰw]. Nevertheless, according to Beal & Sen (2014: 44), “most indirect sources of evidence suggest that /w/ was the norm in London” from the 1750s.

Yet, Yáñez-Bouza et al.’s (2018: 215–218) analysis of pronouncing dictionaries from the ECEP for the distribution of /hw ~ w ~ h/ in *whale* words yields the following results depicted in (1)–(3):

- (1) all London authors propose /hw/ (excluding *who*(M) and *whose*), except the earliest (Kenrick 1773)
- (2) two of the three Scottish dictionaries show a preference for /w/ (excluding *who*(M) and *whose*), except the earliest (Buchanan 1757)
- (3) Newcastle upon Tyne author Spence (1775) lists /hw/ almost categorically (even in *who*(M) and *whose*)

They moreover show that the aim of avoiding homophones plays a role in the choice between both variants, e.g. in Buchanan (1757), where *whoop* ‘a cry’ takes /hw/ but *whoop*, referring to a bird, has /w/.

Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018: 216) argue that the London data can be accounted for in terms of the rising degree of stigmatisation of /h/-dropping and its connection to the merger of /hw/ and /w/. They hypothesise that the absence of /hw/ in Kenrick (1773) is a result of stigmatisation not having taken effect by his time.

In other words, the /h/-less pronunciation in <wh> words only starts to attract stigma at the very end of the eighteenth century. Walker and Sheridan both regarded /h/-dropping and /hw/ > /w/ as the same process (Beal 2004b: 157). Additionally, while technically two different processes, Beal (2004b: 157) states that contact with French was likely an accelerator in the general loss of /h/, including /hw/ clusters. Walker (1791: 46) discusses the omission of /h/ in <wh> words in the same vein as /h/-dropping and shows an equal degree of stigma in his evaluation:

[t]his letter [sc. *H*] is often sunk after *w*, particularly in the capital, where we do not find the least distinction of sound between while and wile, whet and wet, where and wear [...] Trifling as this difference may appear at first sight, it tends greatly to weaken and empoverish the pronunciation, as well as sometimes to confound words of a very different meaning. The Saxons, as Dr. Lowth observes, placed the *h* before the *w*, as *hwat*; and this is certainly its true place [...] we shall avoid that feeble, cockney pronunciation, which is so disagreeable to a correct ear.

As previously noted, /w/ is also included in his list of faults of the Londoners earlier in his dictionary (Walker 1791: xii–xiii). For Walker this is equally as stigmatised as /h/-dropping and his arguments are based on several criteria such as avoiding ambiguity (Logic), etymology (Restorative prescriptivism), correctness (Mistake), agreeability to the ear (Aesthetics), and region and class (Social Evaluation).

The results from the Scottish dictionaries can be explained as an avoidance of particularly Scottish variants. Scottish dictionary authors were aware that in London /w/ had become common and was likely increasing in usage. In order to avoid regional pronunciations (e.g. Scottish /hw/ or /xw/) they prescribed what they thought to be the London standard. While the use of the voiced labio-velar approximant /w/ was seen as “vulgar” and a “Cockneyism” in England, Scots authors associated it with Englishness (Beal 1999: 104). Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018: 216) call this a “hypercorrect Anglicism” and suggest that Scottish authors were not yet aware of the association of /w/ with /h/-dropping and the resulting stigmatisation of the WHICH-WITCH merger.

Spence’s (1775) inclusion of /hw/ before rounded back vowels (except in *whore*, which historically always had /h/) is likely a regional north-eastern pronunciation (Beal 1999: 179–180; Beal & Sen 2014: 45). Based on Spence’s use of a separate symbol, rather than <hw>, Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018: 216, 218) argue that this could be seen as evidence for /ʍ/ and thus a voiceless opposition to /w/ rather

than /hw/. On the phonetic level, it is not unlikely that both realisations were used and are used today by speakers who still preserve the contrast. Jones (1928: xx) records both variants on a realisational level and points to the fact that the difference between the two is difficult to perceive auditorily: “‘hw’ is to be taken to mean either the group ‘h’ + ‘w’, or the single sound ‘ɸ’ (unvoiced ‘w’). Both pronunciations occur, and they are difficult to distinguish”. As both notations involve a labial and velar element as well as aspiration, the actual realisation of these different representations do not necessarily differ (Beal & Sen 2014: 42). Hickey (2023: 83–84) argues for analysing the variant as a sequence, i.e. /hw/, due its conformity with rising sonority towards the nucleus of the syllable and as English does not generally have voiceless sonorants or glides. Moreover, varieties of English with /h/-dropping do not usually have /ɸ/. This would speak against a /ɸ/ vs. /w/ opposition in the variety’s phoneme inventory (see also Hickey 2007: 319–320). I use /hw/ in this chapter for phonemic transcriptions, also as my data do not warrant detailed articulatory analyses and since /hw/ indeed reflects many of the nineteenth-century grammarians’ descriptions.

Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018) additionally point to stress placement in polysyllabic examples in Perry (1775), as well as sound symbolism in Kenrick (1773) and Perry (1775) as factors that influence that the choice of variants. Stressed syllables generally favour /hw/ while /w/ is used in unstressed syllables, e.g. <wh> in *overwhelm* has /hw/ whereas *somewhere* takes /w/. Concerning sound-symbolism, they find that front vowels and succeeding /s/ in coda-initial position favour word-initial /hw/ as in *whelm*, *whisk*, or *whisper*.

To give an example from eighteenth-century grammars, in Murray (1795: 13) we can find only one sentence which indicates /hw/: “W before h is pronounced as if it were after the h; as, hwy, why; hwen, when; hwat, what”. This kind of argument reflects closely what many nineteenth-century grammarians wrote, as we shall see later. As for the early nineteenth century, MacMahon (1998: 467–468) shows that /hw/ was still regarded as weakly realised by some authors. He observes comments in Hornsey (1809: 168) stating that /h/ in *wheat* *while* and *where* “though not quite mute, sinks” (cited in MacMahon 1998: 468).² However, /hw/ was still used by Sweet until 1908 in words like *which* or *what* although Sweet himself observed that /hw/ was giving way to /w/, and that /w/ was becoming the common variant in the South of England (MacMahon 1998: 468; see also Sweet 1877: 112; 1888: 278). MacMahon further cites Ellis (1874), who contends that the majority of educated speakers in London use /w/ rather than /hw/ in the

²MacMahon gives 1807 as year of publication but lists the source as published in 1809 in his references. Based on my own searches for the source, 1809 should be the correct year.

word *wheat*. This does not mean that /w/ had stopped causing furore amongst some people at the end of the century. MacMahon (1998: 468) quotes 72-years-old philosopher Francis Newman (1878: 692) as identifying the use of /w/ as an “especial disgrace of Southern England”. MacMahon (1998: 467) suggests that the contrast between <wh> and <w> “is retained, apparently by most speakers of educated Southern English, until at least the second half of the nineteenth century; thereafter its use becomes more infrequent”. Beal (2004b: 135) claims that the change from [ʰw] to [w] (and thus the final stage of the lenition process) was still in progress in 1937 in RP. Thus, even in twentieth-century England, maintaining a difference between /hw/ and /w/ pronunciations was still considered as correct by some speakers. Jones (1964 [1918]: 208) observes that [hw] and [ʌ] variants are “regularly used in Scotland, Ireland, the North of England and in America”, whereas “[i]n the South the more usual pronunciation of these word [*what, which*] is wɒt, wɪtʃ, etc”. Nonetheless, he adds that “the use of ʌ or hw is sometimes taught as being more ‘correct’”. The SED data show that even traditional dialects in the middle of the twentieth century had nearly completely lost /hw/ (Orton et al. 1978). The area preserving /hw/ spans most of Northumberland, parts of the historic counties of Cumberland, Durham and Westmorland, and for the word *wheel* also the Isle of Man, as shown in Figure 9.1. Based on Ellis’ works, the nineteenth-century shibboleth of /hw/ still stretches slightly further south (see Trudgill 2004: 78).

The perception of /h/-less <wh> variants also appears to shift in the twentieth century to some extent and it is indeed the /h/-full variant that attracts a higher degree of stigma for some. Jespersen (1909: 374) contends that “[i]t [i.e. the /h/-less variant in *WHALE* words] is not, however, nowadays regarded as nearly so ‘bad’ or ‘vulgar’ as the omission of [h], and is, indeed, scarcely noticed by most people. In fact, a great many ‘good speakers’ always pronounce [w] and look upon [hw] as harsh or dialectal”. Thus, there seems to have been a development from /w/ as a stigmatised London dialect feature to /hw/ being negatively associated with dialectal speech. Still, while he points to a decrease in the level of the negative connotations with /w/, “not [...] as nearly so ‘bad’ or ‘vulgar’” implies that /w/ may still be avoided by some speakers.

Some sources observe a gender difference, or at least suggest that /hw/ survived longer in female speakers. MacMahon (1998: 468) mentions Montgomery (1910: 13–14) in that respect, who contends that maintaining the /h/-full variant was restricted to the speech of women. Jespersen (1909: 374) makes a similar observation: “[i]n some schools, however, especially girls’ schools, [hw] is latterly insisted on”. As for the CNG, I have not been able to find any comments on gender differences in *WHALE* variants. Generally, Jespersen’s and Montgomery’s



Figure 9.1: Map showing the distribution of /hw/ and /w/ in the word *wheel* in twentieth-century dialects in England, recreated based on Orton et al. (1978)

comments seem to suggest that /hw/ > /w/ is a recent change for both of them as they show, first of all, that there are still some speakers that may shun the use of /w/, that /hw/ was still prescribed in some schools, and that /hw/ might have still been in frequent use by women.

In North America, /hw/ is reported to have been maintained longer than in England (MacMahon 1998: 468). Webster's (1828) "directions for the pronunciation of words" and Worcester's (1830: vii) "key to the sounds of the marked letters" both list /hw/ for <wh> spellings. In Worcester (1860: xi), /hw/ is still the unmarked form as well. According to Jespersen (1909: 374–375), "Scotch and Irish people, as well as most Americans, generally retain [hw], yet with the modification that many have [hw] in a strongly stressed syllable only". For Krapp (1919: 142), /hw/, realised as [ʍ], was still the standard in the early twentieth century, although he mentions the use of [w] in some speakers: "[ʍ] [...]. This sound is the voiceless equivalent of [w], and in America it is generally pronounced wherever written wh, as in *what*". He adds that "[s]ome speakers, however, pronounce all these voiceless sounds voiced, as in *whit* [wɪt] not distinguished from *wit*, *white* [waɪt] not distinguished from *wight*" (my emphasis). Despite the fact that he does not evaluate /h/-less or voiced realisations negatively, he informs his readers about potential social sanctions: "[t]hough not vulgarisms, such pronunciations are usually discountenanced by careful speakers and in formal instruction. In standard British speech of the Southern type w and wh are generally both pronounced as [w]". Therefore, there were evidently differences in the regional distribution and evaluation of /hw/ well into the twentieth century.

In the following sections, I scrutinise to what extent /hw/ was still proposed in the nineteenth century. I furthermore focus on regional differences between the grammars as well as evaluations of the feature as dialectal, either as typical of London or of dialects in the far North of England. Given Walker's comments on /h/ and a revitalisation in prescriptions of /hw/ in the late eighteenth century due to associations with /h/-dropping, I analyse to what extent /w/ is discussed in the same vein as /h/-dropping in the grammars of the CNG.

9.2 WHICH-WITCH in the CNG: Overview

The crucial factor behind the WHICH-WITCH merger is the phonetic realisation of WHALE words. I have found comments on WHALE words in 53 grammars (20 British-Irish, 33 North American), which is roughly one third of grammars marked as treating pronunciation.

Concerning the distribution of variants in the grammarians' perceived standard, or rather the suggested majority variant, more than half of the British-Irish

grammars propose /hw/, and, perhaps unsurprisingly, all American grammars give /hw/. Two Scottish grammars mention WHALE words, namely Connell (1843) and Connon (1845). Connell (1843: 3), published in Glasgow, states: “*Wh* sounds like *hw*, and *qu* like *kw*; as in *when*, *while*; *quite*, *quell*”, and thus describes /hw/. This is contrary to what Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018) find in the ECEP for most Scottish authors, but represents what we would expect Scottish grammarians to write based on the variants that were likely widespread in most speakers at the time. However, it could also represent an imitation of other nineteenth-century grammars because this is exactly what most of them propose. In the case of Connon (1845) the variant is unfortunately unclear and was excluded. He only gives a list of (near-)homophones and writes that

[t]he pupil should be careful to observe the use of such words as *there* and *their*; *his* and *is*; *was* and *as*; *principal* and *principle*; *air*, *hair*, and *heir*; *to*, *too*, and *two*; *were* and *where*; *they*, *the*, and *thee*; *of* and *off*; and generally words that are differently spelled but pronounced the same or nearly so. (Connon 1845: 13)

While this points to a potential similarity in form between *where* and *were*, his focus is the correct spelling in this section, and it is not evident if pronouncing *where* with /w/ constitutes a problem for him. The comment “pronounced the same or nearly so” could of course indicate several phonetic variants like [ʰw], [ʌ], [w], or even [hw], depending on how we interpret “nearly so”. Therefore, I marked his grammar as unclear. Other than that, none of the Irish, Scottish or Canadian grammars mention WHALE words. The British-Irish grammars contain one more grammar in which the variant is unclear and was hence not included in the analysis, namely Scotson (1876). His statement concerns WHO(M) words amongst other features, and he simply writes that “[s]ome double consonants have a peculiar sound of their own; as, *ch* in *church*, *sh* in *she*, *ng* in *sing*, *th* in *this*, and *wh* in *who*” (Scotson 1876: 60). Unfortunately, this sentence does not reveal anything about the alleged peculiarity of the sound he claims <wh> to have in the word *who*.

Of the remaining 20 British-Irish grammars, 13 propose /hw/, one suggests a weakened variant, and six give /w/. There is one North American grammar, namely Carpenter, which mentions variation only between America and England, with Americans using /hw/ and British speakers /w/. This has been counted as /hw/ as majority variant for North America. The regional distribution is illustrated in Table 9.1 and Figure 9.2.

Table 9.1: Quantitative distribution of perceived standard variants in WHALE words

	British-Irish	North American	all
pronunciation treated	100	66	166
WHALE majority variant			
discernible	20 (20% of 100)	33 (50% of 66)	53 (32% of 166)
/hw/	13 (13% of 100)	33 (50% of 66)	46 (28% of 166)
weakened	1 (1% of 100)	0	1 (0.6% of 166)
/w/	6 (6% of 100)	0	6 (4% of 166)
insufficient information	80	33	113



Figure 9.2: Evidence of perceived standard variants in WHALE words

What is noticeable is that in only 20% of British-Irish grammars a preferred variant for *WHALE* words is discernible, or rather mentioned at all, whereas of the North American grammars it is 50%. This is perhaps due to the fact that /hw/ evolved to be the marked regional variant and that /w/ was widespread and did not trigger too much commentary in England.

It could however also be a general trend as North American grammars give information relatively more frequently in the case of every variable discussed so far, with the exception of /h/-dropping. In addition to the perceived standard of these grammars, some of them contain prescriptions, comments on regional variation and interesting etymological arguments in the context of *WHALE* words. In fact, regardless of their perceived standard, there are in total 15 grammars provide evidence for /w/ or weakened variants but 7 evaluate the form negatively. 12 were published in the British-Irish Isles and the first British-Irish grammar that provides evidence of the presence of /w/ is Pinnock (1830). Only three North American grammars mention the use of /w/ in the context of *WHALE* words, the earliest being Goodenow (1839). Those who do not suggest /w/ as their standard variant but mention it in the context of prescriptions or variation are discussed in Section 9.4.

9.3 /hw/ or /w/ as the nineteenth-century standard

Most grammars argue, similar to Murray, that in <wh> words the <w> should be pronounced after <h>. This is an argument based on spelling, and in some fewer cases also etymology (see below), which clearly indicates /hw/. This can be seen for instance in Hiley (1857: 8), whose grammar was published in London and reads: “*W*, before *h*, is pronounced as if it were after the *h*, as *why*, *hwy*; *when*, *hwen*”. Hallock (1849: 19) is a North American example: “*W* before *h* is pronounced as if it succeeded it; as in *when*, *why*, *what*”. As with previous features, Turner (1840: 237) appears to copy from an early edition of Brown’s grammar on this feature: “*W* before *h* is pronounced as if it followed the *h*; as in *what*, *when*”. Brown (1857: 318) writes: “*W* before *h*, is pronounced as if it followed the *h*; as in *what*, *when*”. Other grammars that stick close to Murray’s (1795) and Brown’s (1857) wording are the North American grammars Greenleaf (1821), Fisk (1822), Swett (1844), Fowler (1855). Two other North American grammars, namely Sanborn (1840) and Caldwell (1859), seem to be based on Kirkham (1834: 22) who writes “[b]efore *h* it [sc. <w>] is pronounced as if written after the *h*; as in *why*, *when*, *what*;—*hwy*, *hwen*, *hwat*”. They make use of almost the exact same wording and the same example words. Caldwell (1859) acknowledges his use of Murray

and Kirkham in his preface and Sanborn (1840) at least quotes Kirkham on other matters of grammar. Thus, he must have at least been familiar with Kirkham's work. Whereas these are almost exclusively North American examples, save for Hiley (1857) and Turner (1840), similar arguments, with less identical wordings, occur in British-Irish grammars as well, e.g. Oliver (1825), or Lowres (1863).

Table 9.2 illustrates the example words used for /hw/ in the CNG ordered by frequency of mention. The words *when*, *what*, *why*, *where* and *which* are the five most frequently employed words. In terms of Yáñez-Bouza et al.'s (2018: 218) comments on stress, the CNG does not reveal much simply due to the fact that only one polysyllabic word where <wh> is in initial position of the second syllable is listed in the grammars, namely *overwhelm*. The use of /hw/ here conforms to their suggestion as it receives primary stress on the second syllable. Regarding sound-symbolism, there are several instances of /hw/ before front vowels in the examples of the CNG. However, I argue that these are unlikely examples of phonological conditioning and neither influenced necessarily by sound-symbolism, but simply represent high frequency words, e.g. *when*, *where*, or *which*. There is only one instances where the coda of the respective syllable starts with /s/, i.e. in *whist*. What is most likely is that these words are the most frequent example words simply because these are precisely the example words that Murray (1795) and Brown (1857) employ, as shown above.

Table 9.2: Examples of /hw/ in WHALE words, taken from the CNG

no.	word	freq.
1	<i>when</i>	35
2	<i>what</i>	27
3	<i>why</i>	14
4	<i>where</i>	10
5	<i>which</i>	8
6	<i>while</i>	7
7	<i>whether</i>	4
8	<i>whale, wheat, who</i>	3
11	<i>whet</i>	2
12	<i>overwhelm, wharf, whelp, whence, whiffletree, whip, whist, white, whither, whole, whurt</i>	1

Moreover, the grammars these words are taken from categorically describe /hw/ for all of the words they list. This is of course a general difference between

the make-up of grammars and pronouncing dictionaries, meaning that with the exception of those few grammars that mention variation they only ever provide words that take the perceived standard variant. In pronouncing dictionaries variation is evidently more accessible even if it escapes explicit commentary.

As previously stated, North American grammars categorically suggest /hw/ as the standard variant. This aligns with the position that the /h/-full variant was maintained much longer in the US than in most other locations. I now turn to one example of a weakened variant (Higginson 1864) and six examples of standard /w/ in British-Irish grammars (Pinnock 1830; Lewis 1869; Tancock 1878; Kelke 1885; Gow 1892; Nesfield 1900). These were, perhaps unsurprisingly, all published in England. Eight more grammars mention /w/, but either describe it as a variant form in competition with /hw/ or evaluate it negatively (see Section 9.4). Regardless, /hw/ is clearly also the majority form in grammars published in England. This seems to confirm that the trend Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018) observe in eighteenth-century dictionaries indeed continues in nineteenth-century grammar books.

Higginson (1864: 10) is the only grammar which suggests a weakened variant where aspiration is not described as entirely present but less strong. Moreover, he states that the letter *w* in *WHO(M)* words is still present, albeit not fully realised. He writes: “[w]hen *w* is followed by *h*, the two letters are not (for they cannot be) both sounded strongly. Thus in *who*, the *w* is scarcely heard, and in *when*, *what*, *why*, & c., the *h* is sounded very gently”. In terms of *WHO(M)* words, however, it is worth considering that he regards the realisation of the letter <*w*> as a vowel, and to be more precise the vowel usually represented by the graphemes <oo>. In fact, this is a description of <*w*> that we can find in most grammars in the CNG. This vowel is thus likely [u:]. Therefore, the fact that <*w*> is said to be realised does not necessarily tell us that there was supposed to be a glide but could simply point to a slightly laxer or weakened vowel realisation.

From the six grammars in the CNG that clearly suggest /w/ as their standard, Pinnock (1830: 20) is the earliest. He gives one sentence on *WHALE* words: “*W* is sometimes silent before *h*, as in *whole*, *whom*, & c.; but in general *h* is silent after *w*, as in *wharf*, *wheel*, *while*, *whale*, & c.”. He thus describes the present-day distribution found in most of England, i.e. /h/ before non-low back vowels and /w/ in all other <wh> contexts.

Lewis (1869: 8), like Walker and other LModE authors (see Section 9.5), discusses *WHALE* words under the letter <*h*> in the section “Remarks on Particular Letters”. Here he writes that *h* “is aspirated, although not written as the initial letter, in the words *who*, *whose*, *whom*; but has ceased to be so in the words *which*, *what*, *when*, etc. These words were formerly written *hwo*, *hwich*, *hwat*,

etc.”. Again, we can gather from this that /h/ is present in WHO(M)/WHOSE words. Although it is unclear from his comment if /w/ also still is, it is unlikely given the dating of the change from /hw/ to /h/ (see Section 9.1). However, words like *which*, *what*, and *when* are said to no longer be aspirated. Lewis moreover makes a reference to the history of the form and what is essentially its OE orthographical representation. In fact, he is not the only grammarian in the CNG who does that, as I show in Section 9.4.

Tancock (1878: 25) similarly invokes the history of WHALE words: “[t]he aspirated interrogative or relative forms, *hwa*, *hwæt*, *hwelc*, *hwæther*, *hwile*, became softened into *who*, *what*, *which*, *whether*, *while*, and the words *hlaf*, *hlaford*, *hlædere*, *hræthe*, became *loaf*, *lord*, *ladder*, *rathe*”. He is correct in his assessment of Germanic clusters of words like *hlaf* or *hræthe*. The original /xl, xr, xn ~ hl, hr, hn/ variants where ModE spellings maintain no traces of former /x/ or /h/ had lost the first segment of the onset by late ME (Lass 1999: 122). Still, as I have described in Section 9.1, several dialects retained /hw/ in Tancock’s time in words with historical /xw ~ hw/ clusters such as *which*, *while*, or *what*. It is especially this comparison to words like OE *hlāf* and *hlāford* becoming *loaf* and *lord* that very likely indicates that for him “became softened into *who*, *what*, *which* [...]” is supposed to mean the simplification of initial consonant clusters in WHALE words. Like in Lewis, it is not clear to what extent WHO(M) words differ from other WHALE words. In the sentences preceding this passage, Tancock (1878: 25) identifies French influence as a reason for the simplification of clusters, which is correct, at least if regarded as one of the factors that sped up the loss of /h/-initial words and clusters: “[l]etters and sounds which did not exist in French, or could not be easily pronounced by the French were lost. The strong English aspirates and gutturals almost disappeared”. The remaining three grammars in which /w/ is considered the standard variant are discussed in the following section as they provide evidence for regional variation. Additional arguments based on the etymology of WHALE words are further discussed in the following section.

9.4 Dialectal variation, etymological arguments, and prescriptions

In total, six of 55 grammars mention regional uses of either /hw/ or /w/ (Booth 1837; Kelke 1885; Gow 1892; West 1898; Nesfield 1900; Carpenter 1902). Except Booth (1837), all their descriptions align with the SED recordings and the distribution described in Ellis’, Jespersen’s, Krapp’s works or other late nineteenth and early twentieth-century sources, as summarised in Table 9.3. It is mostly /hw/

that is regarded as the marked regional variant in the CNG, albeit in a neutral fashion. This might be less surprising if we consider that, save one, they were all published after 1884. Of these grammars, Carpenter is the only North American grammar in Table 9.3, as indicated by the asterisk. /w/ is the unmarked variant in most of the cases and Kelke, Gow, West and Nesfield have been counted as suggesting /w/ as the majority variant.

Table 9.3: Summary of /hw/ and /w/ as regional features in the CNG

grammar	/hw/	/w/
Booth (1837)	—	Cockney, the capital (London)
Kelke (1885)	Scotch, Irish, Northumbrians, some Southerners	—
Gow (1892)	Scotchmen, Northcountrymen	—
West (1898)	Scotchmen, Irishmen	—
Nesfield (1900)	Scotland, North of England	—
Carpenter (1902)*	Americans	The English

Booth (1837: 20) simply quotes Walker's passage (see above) directly and therefore seems to similarly contend that /w/ is a "feeble Cockney pronunciation" which is to be avoided. Booth moreover copies the reference to Lowth and to the Saxons from Walker: "[t]he Saxons, as Dr. Lowth observes, placed *h* before the *w*, as *hwat*; and this is certainly its true place".

For Kelke (1885: 30–31) /hw/ is the marked variant as opposed to what he perceives of as the standard variant. This is shown by the addition of brackets in his classification of sounds and the corresponding explanation: "[t]hree are here inserted in parentheses: *ch*, as in Scotch *loch*; *gh*, as in Irish *lough*; and *wh*, the sound used by the Scotch, Irish, Northumbrians, and some Southerners, in pronouncing *what* as *hwat*". In the section on consonantal changes, and more specifically in the context of "gutturals" that disappeared in English, he mentions the feature again as a change from Anglo-Saxon *hwæt* to modern *what*. He states that this is a minority form in the South but adds that the "sign *h* is here a Guttural, not Faucaal, and is sounded in Scotland and Northumberland, rarely in the South, while in *who* the *h*, on the contrary, is sounded and the *w* silent" (Kelke 1885: 36). His category of "faucals" only contains *h*, whereas gutturals refer to velar sounds, and

his sound “wh” is categorised as “labio-vocal” alongside the sound of *w*. What he is referring to here is thus likely [xw] and not [hw]. This consequently implies variation between three variants. Since this section concerns historical changes and as he provides the original OE spelling variant as well, it is likely that he is referring to an historically older pronunciation, in which case [xw] would make sense. This is also confirmed by the statement concerning the same sound represented by <gh> in *high* and *knight*: “[t]he Guttural, though still written, is now not sounded, or (more rarely) has been turned into a Labio-dental, as in the final sound of *laugh*, *enough*”. As <gh> used to represent dorsal fricatives, and since this explanation is given right after his discussion of OE *hwæt* ‘what’, it seems plausible to assume that his reference to a guttural pronunciation is a historical reference only, at least outside of Scotland, Northumberland and parts of the South. That [xw] is still used in his day is true of Scotland and Northumberland. However, I am not aware of any southern British dialects that maintained dorsal variants until that late. Compared to the passage earlier in his grammar, he also leaves out the Irish here. In sum, I interpret his comments in the following way. Generally, WHALE words have [w], many Irish, Scottish, Northumbrian and some southern British speakers maintain [hw], while realisations representing a historical retention of [xw] do also exist in all these regions except Ireland. For WHO(M) words the case is clear: they are realised only with /h/. Under “Phonetic Spelling—Objections”, Kelke (1885: 42) gives another historical account, which suggests /w/ in *what* and /h/ in *who*: “[s]till more evident is it that we should obscure the connection of *who* and *what*, if we wrote the first as *hū*, and the second as *wot*, as we have already obscured by our spelling the connection of *how* with *who*”. He makes a case for a more phonetic spelling and likely refers to ME spelling variants <how> representing *who*. In any case, he is the only grammarian mentioning regional variation that still identifies the South as a region where /hw/ can be found, although much less frequently. As previously noted, it was still used by educated southern speakers at the end of the nineteenth and beginning of the twentieth centuries. Perhaps Kelke was aware of this, while the other grammars in the CNG discussing regional distribution regarded /hw/ as already having made its way out of the system. This does, however, not explain the use of what is likely [xw] in the South.

Gow (1892: 9, 20) writes: “[w]e do not ordinarily, in English, aspirate any consonant, but Northcountrymen aspirate a breathed *w* (spelt *wh*)” and identifies “*wh* for the breathed *w* as pronounced by Scotchmen”. Thus, the typical English pronunciation for Gow is clearly /w/, as opposed to the pronunciation in the (unspecified) North of England (see OED: s.v. *north country* n. & adj.) and in Scotland.

The exact phonetic quality remains uncertain, except that it entails some form of aspiration.

West (1898: 48) states the following about how <wh> is supposed to be realised phonetically: “[w]ith regard to this sound, it should be noticed that when the aspirate is sounded, as it is by Scotchmen and Irishmen, and as it ought to be by everybody, the aspirate comes before the *w* and not after it, and in this order the letters used to be written in Old English, *hwat* and not *what*”. What is striking in this passage is that /hw/ is evidently regarded as the marked regional form but at the same time identified as the correct pronunciation by West, as the prescription “as it ought to be by everybody” shows. He is also one of 11 grammarians in the CNG who make explicit reference to earlier stages of the language (see below). While this is not as clear an example of restorative prescriptivism as comments discussed in Section 5.3 on FACE diphthongs, it appears that this argument is based on the history of the form and its spelling.

In a footnote, Nesfield (1900: 269) remarks that “[t]he sound of *wh* is seldom heard except in the North of England and in Scotland. Thus, *while* is usually pronounced the same as *wile*”. Again, here the /h/-less pronunciation is identified as the majority pronunciation. In Nesfield we can also find an articulatory description from which it seems as if this difference is one of voicing and therefore implies a monosegmental variant, as noted by Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018) for Spence. Unfortunately, grammars in the CNG rarely provide enough information on whether we are dealing with a cluster or monosegmental forms. Nonetheless, most arguments suggest /hw/, also for the reason that they are mainly explained with a focus on the spelling of the respective words. While the usual pronunciation for Nesfield seems to be /w/, he still considers /hw/ as the correct pronunciation as a passage from his section on “Further Changes in Middle English” shows: “*Hw*, which gave and still gives correctly the sound of the first letters in *which* and similar words, was changed to *wh*” (Nesfield 1900: 293). Under “Consonantal Sounds and Spellings” he again remarks that <wh> is “often sounded as *w*, except in the North” (Nesfield 1900: 297). He points to the fact that an historically older spelling reflects the pronunciation found in some speakers of his day correctly. Nevertheless, he does not invoke this as an argument against /w/, but neutrally observes this.

Carpenter (1902: 222) recognises that “[t]he English generally make no distinction between *w* and *wh*,— pronouncing, for instance, *witch* and *which* exactly alike, — though the Americans generally do”. Interestingly, he is the only grammarian that mentions American pronunciation in the context of this feature. While this observation is only based on a very small number of grammars, it is noticeable that the only North American grammar identifies the English as

a whole as speakers who use /w/ rather than /hw/. This in part conforms with the reality of late nineteenth and early twentieth-century England. It also shows that the regional evaluations of phonological features differ between places of publication. Similar to comments about non-rhoticity, it is the North American grammar that suggests the dichotomy American versus English, while in British-Irish grammars we find references to more specific regions in the British-Irish Isles. The situation for /hw/ is thus slightly different to features like /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion in the CNG, as discussed above.

In contrast to comments on /h/-dropping in words like *humble*, the CNG features several etymological arguments and references to the history of either the orthography or pronunciation of <wh>. In total, there are 11 grammars in which these can be found, namely Oliver (1825), Booth (1837), Wells (1847), Mulligan (1868), Lewis (1869), Tancock (1878), Colegrove (1879), Kelke (1885), Ramsey (1892), West (1898) and Nesfield (1900). We can therefore find these types of arguments throughout the century from 1825 until 1900. Most of these grammars were published in England, except Wells (1847), Colegrove (1879) and Ramsey (1892), which are North American grammars. There is one more grammar we could perhaps add to this list, namely Tidmarsh (1882: 163), published in London, whose comment “[i]n modern English the wh of the relatives is sounded hw” can be found in the section on the declension of Anglo-Saxon pronouns. However, he does not make a direct connection between the history of the form and the modern pronunciation besides adding this sentence under the section of Anglo-Saxon pronouns.

Booth (1837), whose grammar has already been discussed in the present section, copies directly from Walker. Lewis (1869) and Tancock (1878) have also already been mentioned in the context of /w/ as the standard variant. Kelke’s (1885) historical accounts and Nesfield’s (1900) comment on historical <hw> reflecting the correct pronunciation of words like *which* have also already been mentioned above.

In terms of additional etymological arguments, Oliver (1825: 316) traces the form back more generally to Germanic dialects as he writes: “W initial is sounded before *h* followed by any vowel but *o*, as in *what*, *when*, *whip*, *whurt*, in which words *w* is pronounced as if preceded by *h*, as it really is in the Gothick dialects, from which words of this form are derived”. Oliver’s use of “Gothick” meaning ‘Germanic’ is now obsolete but was still common in the nineteenth century (see OED: s.v. *Gothic* adj. 2.).

In Wells (1847: 39), we can find the following sentence: “*Wh* is pronounced as if written *hw*. Thus, the words *where*, *while*, *when*, are pronounced *hwere*, *hwile*, *hwen*”. In a footnote, he refers to the same passage we find in Booth, referencing

Lowth by means of quoting directly from Walker (1791). He adds another quote by Murdoch & Russell (1845: 33) who refer to James Rush: “*Wh*, which Dr. Rush has recognized as a distinct element, are but apparently such. They differ, in no respect, from the separate elements, *w* and *h*, —only that, in the *modern orthography* of words, they are inverted, as to their order. The *ancient orthography* of the language placed them as they stand in *orthoëpy*, —*hw*; thus *hwheat*, *hwen*, etc.”. Thus, here again we have a reference to a historically older spelling variant as reflection of the pronunciation of WHALE words. Although all this suggests that the pronunciation of WHALE words is a cluster /hw/, a few pages later in his grammar we can find a comment that suggests a monosegmental realisation: “[t]wo consonants forming but one sound, as [...] *wh*, are never separated” (Wells 1847: 45). Nonetheless, as with all the grammars in CNG concerning <wh> spellings, they do not provide sufficient information that would warrant a detailed articulatory description based on modern standards.

Mulligan (1868) is perhaps the most comprehensive (and accurate) historical account of WHALE words in the CNG. The sentence that is relevant in the context of the present section is the following: “[w]e have a numerous family of these *interrogative* words commencing in modern written English with the letters *wh* (in Anglo-Saxon with *hw*, which letters still represent more exactly the present pronunciation)” (Mulligan 1868: 534). He also in fact mentions Scottish <quh> spellings in the same passage, but it is evident that he regards /hw/ as the correct variant. His argument runs similar to others we have encountered so far, i.e. the old spelling reflects the current pronunciation better than the present orthography.

Colegrove (1879: 24) first mentions <wh> words under the heading “ANOMALOUS COMBINATIONS” where he writes “*wh* equals ‘*hw*’, as in ‘*while*’, equal to ‘*hwile*’”. In his appendix, he discusses a potential spelling reformation and it is in this context that he states: “[i]n the fifth place, there are about two hundred words in which, besides the foregoing, it would be necessary to change the order of the letters ‘*wh*’, so as to write ‘*hwen*’ instead of ‘*when*’ & c.; but as these words *were formerly written in this way*, the effect would be not to obscure, but to make evident their relations to their primitives” (Colegrove 1879: 322). The part “relations to their primitives” refers to the etymology of the words in question. Thus, in the scenario of a spelling reform he argues that in some cases, as in WHALE words, a restoration of a historical spelling would be sufficient to establish sound-spelling correspondence. This on the one hand tells us that his perceived standard pronunciation is /hw/, and that he makes a case for restoring earlier orthography. Ramsey (1892) and West (1898) comment on the pronunciation and spelling of WHALE words as in (4) and (5).

- (4) Our ancestors wrote *hw* where we absurdly write *wh*—*hwá*, who; *hwæt*, what; *hwæther*, whether. [...] Wh has been subject of much dispute. In my judgment it is (hw). (Ramsey 1892: 142, 175)
- (5) On the other hand, we have left out the sound of *wh* in *what*. With regard to this sound, it should be noticed that when the aspirate is sounded, as it is by Scotchmen and Irishmen, and as it ought to be by everybody, the aspirate comes before the *w* and not after it, and in this order the letters used to be written in Old English, *hwat* and not *what*. (West 1898: 39)

Neither Ramsey nor West argue for restoring Old English spellings here, but both bring up these extinct spelling variants and point out that they would more sensibly reflect the pronunciation that they are prescribing. Yet, I treat comments like West's in (5) as a form of restorative prescriptivism because an older stage of the language is evoked on one level of linguistic analysis to justify, at least partially, the use of a specific variant in this case. A summary of etymological remarks can be found in Table 9.4. The three North American grammars that provide such arguments are marked by an asterisk, namely Wells (1847), Colegrove (1879) and Ramsey (1892). Moreover, from the grammars in this table, both Booth (1837) and Wells (1847) copied their comments on etymology verbatim from Walker's dictionary, which is itself based on Lowth with regard to <wh>.

In terms of the name of the variety, nineteenth-century scholars referred mainly to (Anglo-)Saxons, while there is one example of Old English and also one reference to Germanic languages more generally through the term "Gothick". Other than that there are references to an unspecified "ancient orthography" and "our ancestors". Of the grammars that include etymological remarks, all those in which the standard variant is /hw/, regardless of place of publication, use the OE spelling or pronunciation as evidence for the correctness of their perceived standard variant. Surprisingly, we even find a comment indicating a similar argument in Nesfield (1900), who otherwise clearly suggests /w/ as majority variant. Lewis (1869) and Tancock (1878) simply add etymological information to give more detail on the form they are discussing, and Kelke (1885) appears to mention it also in the context of the regional variation observable in his day.

However, as has become apparent, the majority of etymological arguments in the CNG cannot be regarded as restorative prescriptivism in a narrower sense as found in Curzan (2014), simply because their comments are not always prescriptive. Moreover, while /w/ is said to have been very widespread in the England of the nineteenth century, both variants coexisted and still continue to do so to this day. Therefore, we should be cautious about terming these comments attempts

Table 9.4: Overview of etymological remarks on /hw/ in the CNG

grammar	standard variant	historical group/variety	judgement
Oliver (1825)	/hw/	Gothick dialects	w is pronounced as if preceded by <i>h</i> , as it really is in the Gothick dialects
Booth (1837)	/hw/	the Saxons	<i>h</i> before the <i>w</i> , as <i>hwat</i> ; and this is certainly its true place
Wells (1847)*	/hw/	the Saxons, ancient orthography	<i>h</i> before the <i>w</i> , as <i>hwat</i> ; and this is certainly its true place, <i>ancient orthography</i> of the language placed them as they stand in <i>orthoëpy</i> , — <i>hw</i> ; thus <i>hwæt</i> , <i>hwen</i> , etc
Mulligan (1868)	/hw/	Anglo-Saxon	<i>hw</i> , which letters still represent more exactly the present pronunciation
Lewis (1869)	/w/	—	These words were formerly written <i>hwo</i> , <i>hwich</i> , <i>hwat</i> , etc.
Tancock (1878)	/w/	—	<i>hwa</i> , <i>hwæt</i> , <i>hwelc</i> , <i>hwæther</i> , <i>hwile</i> , became softened into <i>who</i> , <i>what</i> , <i>which</i> , <i>whether</i> , <i>while</i>
Colegrove (1879)*	/hw/	—	but as these words were formerly written in this way, the effect would be not to obscure, but to make evident their relations to their primitives
Kelke (1885)	/w/	Anglo-Saxon (A.S.)	The sign <i>h</i> is here a Guttural, not Faucal, and is sounded in Scotland and Northumberland, rarely in the South
Ramsey (1892)*	/hw/	Anglo-Saxon (A.S.), our ancestors	Our ancestors wrote <i>hw</i> where we absurdly write <i>wh</i> — <i>hwá</i> , <i>who</i> ; <i>hwæt</i> , <i>what</i> , <i>hwæther</i> , <i>whether</i>
West (1898)	/hw/	Old English	it ought to be by everybody, the aspirate comes before the <i>w</i> and not after it, and in this order the letters used to be written in Old English, <i>hwat</i> and not <i>what</i> .
Nesfield (1900)	/w/	Anglo-Saxon (A.S.)	<i>Hw</i> , which gave and still gives correctly the sound of the first letters in <i>which</i> and similar words, was changed to <i>wh</i>

at restoring extinct pronunciations. However, Beal & Sen (2014: 44) do in fact hypothesise that the near-categorical transcription of <wh> words with /hw/ in eighteenth-century dictionaries from London “reflect[s] a prescriptive attempt to revitalise this contrast under the influence of spelling, on the basis that the simplification of /hw/ to /w/ could be considered a form of ‘h-dropping’”. Authors like Lewis (1869) and Tancock (1878) evidently regarded /hw/ as a historical form no longer in use. Yet, while not explicitly prescriptive in the majority of cases, the other grammars use these historical variants to justify their perceived standard. Thus, in a broader sense these remarks are forms of attempts at restoring an historically older pronunciation. It seems true more generally that Beal & Sen’s (2014) observation in the ECEP can equally be applied to the CNG for the reason that grammars proposed near categorical /hw/ and at least implicitly attempt to revitalise historical variants. This is reflected in explicit comments on the etymology of *WHALE* words.

This can perhaps also be seen in value judgements on /w/ that go beyond cases of restorative prescriptivism. Of the grammars that give information on *WHALE* words, I counted seven as including clearly negative evaluations of /w/ and therefore the *WHICH*-*WITCH* merger. These are summarised in Table 9.5 together with all neutral evaluations, ordered chronologically and based on region (North American grammars are indicated by the use of asterisks).

As we have previously seen, Booth (1837) simply copies Walker’s prescription. In Leigh (1840: 16–17, 29–30) we find /w/ in his passages on “Comic Orthography” and “Comic spelling”, which “teaches us the oddity and absurdities of letters, and the wrong method of spelling words” and “is usually the work of imagination. The chief rule to be observed in this kind of spelling, is, to spell every word as it is pronounced”. The focus here is of course more on mistakes in spelling caused by pronunciation. The entire make-up of the grammar as well as some other features suggested by spellings indicate a negative evaluation. However, in Leigh’s grammar we can also observe variation concerning the realisation of *WHALE* words. The words *when* and *which* are spelled only with <w> in “Comic Orthography” (Leigh 1840: 16–17), while under “Comic spelling” *when* is spelled with <wh> while *which* receives <w>. (Leigh 1840: 29–30). It furthermore contains a form which could be considered a hypercorrect variant, namely <whet> ‘wet’. Whereas in ME <whet> was attested as a spelling variant of *wet* (see OED: s.v. *wet* adj.), Leigh surely does not refer to a historical orthographical variant here. It is hard to interpret this variation but it could simply mean that Leigh was used to variation and that, perhaps subconsciously, he included variation in his “Comic spelling”. The example of <whet> ‘wet’ might have also been influenced by the potential ambiguity between *wet* ‘(to make) humid’ and *whet*

Table 9.5: Overview of evaluations of /w/ sorted by grammar, according to place and year of publication

grammar	attitude	categories	evaluation
Pinnock (1830)	neutral	—	in general <i>h</i> is silent after <i>w</i> , as in <i>wharf, wheel, while, whale</i>
Booth (1837)	negative	Logic, Mistake, Prescription, Social Evaluation	weaken, impoverish, confound words, feeble, Cockney, disagreeable to a correct ear, ought to breathe forcibly
Leigh (1840)	negative	Mistake	wrong
Lowres (1863)	negative	Prescription, Proscription	the aspiration of the <i>h</i> should precede the <i>w</i> [...] What is sounded as if written <i>hwat</i> , not <i>wat</i>
Lewis (1869)	neutral	—	has ceased to be [aspirated]
Tancock (1878)	neutral	—	The aspirated [...] forms [...] became softened
Fleay (1884)	negative	Social Evaluation	frequently corrupted [...] in affected and vulgar pronunciation
Kelke (1885)	neutral	—	[sc. <i>h</i> in <i>what</i>] is sounded in Scotland and Northumberland, rarely in the South
Gow (1892)	neutral	—	We do not ordinarily, in English, aspirate any consonant, but Northcountrymen aspirate a breathed <i>w</i> (spelt <i>wh</i>)
West (1898)	negative	Prescription	when the aspirate is sounded, as it is by Scotchmen and Irishmen, and as it ought to be by everybody [...]
Nesfield (1900)	neutral	—	The sound of <i>wh</i> is seldom heard except in the North of England and in Scotland. Thus <i>while</i> is usually pronounced the same as <i>wile</i> .
Goodenow (1839)*	negative	Mistake	defects of articulation, neglect to sound consonants plainly
Hyde (1895)*	negative	Proscription	do not omit
Carpenter (1902)*	neutral	—	English generally make no distinction [...] the Americans generally do

‘to sharpen’. However, the only evaluative category that applies here is Mistake. Leigh’s grammar is also the only grammar in which an example of hypercorrect variants can be found for WHALE words.

Lowres (1863: 56) only provides a simple prescription and proscription but no further value judgements: “[i]n words beginning with *wh*, the aspiration of the *h* should precede the *w*; thus— What is sounded as if written *hwat*, not *wat* [...]”. In a pronunciation exercise further on in his grammar we also find a list of words to be pronounced: “[n]o. 4. Pronounce the following words. [...] high, eye, arrow, harrow, am, ham, honest, humour, whet, wet, when, wen, hen, wether, ether, whether [...]” (Lowres 1863: 65). While not explicit, by providing low frequency words like *wat* ‘a hare’, *whet* ‘to sharpen’, *wether* ‘a male sheep’ and *wen* ‘a tumour, lump’, this suggests that Lowres wants speakers to avoid potential ambiguity caused by homophony. In practice, this is of course unlikely as the context would usually disambiguate and what Lowres might be implying can be regarded as a theoretical ambiguity. Moreover, examples of /hw/ and /w/ are listed directly after pairs like *high-eye*, which suggests a perceived connection between /hw/ > /w/ in WHALE words and /h/-dropping.

The relevant passage from Fleay (1884: 86) has already been mentioned in the context of post-vocalic /r/ loss as he evaluates several features together in one paragraph. A shortened version reads: “*Wh* and *Gh* are frequently corrupted into *w* and *y* in affected or vulgar pronunciation; [...] Thus we often hear *wen*, [...] for *when*”. Together with Booth’s copy from Walker and Goodenow below this is the strongest negative attitude we can find expressed towards /w/ in the CNG. This can clearly be classed as Social Evaluation as “corrupt”, “affected”, and “vulgar” show. This is another example of a high degree of stigma in a British-Irish grammars towards a form that would have been very frequent in England. West (1898: 48) has already been discussed in the context of regional variation. As noted above, he also simply includes a prescription of the aspirated variant used by Scottish and Irish speakers as the aspirate “ought to be [sounded] by everybody”.

As regards North American grammars, the earliest example is Goodenow (1839: 58), who states the following under “Defects of Articulation”: “[n]eglect to sound consonants plainly, especially at the close of words; as, *an’* for and, *inspec’* for *inspect*, *w’en* for *when*”. Interestingly, he mentions the feature in the context of word-final CCR (consonant cluster reduction), which in his examples is a typical feature of spoken language. He regards this as a mistake as is indicated by the word “defect”. It makes sense that this stigmatisation occurs this early in an American grammar if /hw/ was regarded as the standard longer in North America. The second North American grammar, namely Hyde (1895), includes a

pronunciation exercise in which the use of /w/ seems to be regarded as a form of /h/-dropping. She writes: “PRONOUNCING EXERCISE. Pronounce: - [...] [Do not omit the sound of h in these words.] which, when, white, what, while, where, wheat, whether” (Hyde 1895: 160).

The grammars marked as neutral have already been discussed. Tancock’s (1878: 25) passage requires some further comment. It was treated as a neutral evaluation because no value judgements per se can be found in the respective passage and he does not present a flat-out rejection of the change from /hw/ > /w/ either. The only indicator that he might not have approved of some changes, or rather the factors that led to the changes, is that the chapter under which the discussion on WHALE words can be found is titled “Influence of French on the English language” and starts with the sentence “[t]he English language was changed much in this long struggle and mingling of races” (Tancock 1878: 20). However, while it is not clear what exactly is regarded as “the struggle”, it could mean a struggle for dominance or refer to several wars in the history of the English language.

In sum, only few grammars discuss /w/ and even fewer actually exhibit negative evaluations of the feature. Furthermore, as concerns the types of evaluations that are present in the CNG, the use of /w/ is not as strongly evaluated if compared to features such as post-vocalic /r/ loss or /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. We can mainly find prescriptions, proscriptions and evaluations belonging to the category Mistake. Moreover, despite comments such as those by Jespersen that some speakers might consider /hw/ harsh, this variant is not stigmatised but clearly identified as a marked regional variant in the CNG.

9.5 /w/, /hw/ and their relation to /h/-dropping

As regards the relation between /w/ realisations and /h/-dropping, only three grammars suggest a connection between the two features, namely Booth (1837), Lowres (1863), and Lewis (1869), which were all published in London. Hyde’s (1895: 160) grammar, published in Boston, may be added to this list because of her pronunciation exercise (see above). This general absence of a relation is striking given that the stigmatisation of /w/ as well as the revitalisation of /hw/ in publications from England has been hypothesised to be due to its association with /h/-dropping. This we find in Booth (1837), but he quotes directly from Walker (1791). Lowres (1863: 56) seems to regard /h/-dropping and /w/ in <wh> words as related phenomena and he comments on how not to sound words like *what* in a note directly after listing words with zero realisations of /h/ in his standard, e.g. *hospital*. Lewis (1869: 8) indeed treats WHALE words under “Remarks on Particular Letters [...] h”. This paragraph is nonetheless based on orthography and

the disappearance of dorsal fricatives in words like *right* is also discussed in the same passage.

This lack of connection between /h/-dropping and /w/ in the CNG can be explained by several factors. Nearly all grammarians regard /hw/ as the correct realisation of initial <wh>. There are only few grammars that mention /w/ as a possible (or rejected) variant in the first place (only 14 of 55 grammars). Moreover, not all grammars that mention /w/ for WHALE words also provide information on /h/-dropping and vice versa. Furthermore, in many grammars in the CNG the correct realisation is considered a consonant cluster consisting of /h/ and /w/. This is likely the case because many argue based on spelling. Therefore, they mostly discuss WHALE words under the letter <w> and not <h>, and argue that <w> comes after <h> in pronunciation, as shown in Section 9.3. The consonants /h/ and /w/ are thus rarely mentioned in the same vein as many grammars go through the sounds of letters alphabetically and based on orthography. Since WHALE words begin with <w>, they are normally mentioned at the very end of the respective sections. While they do not discuss /h/ in the same place as the pronunciation of WHALE words, they follow Walker's (1791: 46) principle that a letter present in the orthography ought to be realised in speech.

9.6 WHO(M)/WHOSE and other examples

Concerning mentions of WHO(M)/WHOSE words, the distribution of variants is illustrated in Table 9.6. Generally, grammars that mention words belonging to these sets are rare. Those that suggest /hw/ are only three in total, namely Covell (1861), Kirkham (1834), and Higginson (1864), of which the last is the only British-Irish grammar and was published in London. There are furthermore three unclear cases, namely Lewis (1869), Scotson (1876), and Tancock (1878).

Table 9.6: Distribution of WHO(M)/WHOSE variants in the CNG

region	WHO(M)/WHOSE mentioned	/hw/	/h/	unclear
British-Irish	5	1	1	3
North America	7	2	5	—
total	12	3	6	3

All unclear cases in which WHO(M)/WHOSE words are mentioned have already been discussed. Lewis and Tancock were mentioned in regard to etymological

remarks and both claim /h/ to be present in words like *who* but it is unclear if /w/ is as well. The third unclear case is Scotson, according to whom “[s]ome double consonants have a peculiar sound of their own; as [...] *wh* in *who*”. As previously noted, he does not provide any information on what makes this sound “peculiar”. If we excluded these unclear cases, the majority of grammar that mention *WHO(M)* words would be North American.

As concerns those grammars that could suggest /hw/, Covell (1861), published in New York, gives the same sound in words like *where* and *who*. Yet, the word *whole* takes /h/ as indicated under “OF ASPIRATES”: “*wh*—*where*, *while*, *when*, *why*, *who*, *whist*, *overwhelm*. *h*—*hate*, *harm*, *hall*, *hat*, *hem*, *uphold*, *whole*” (Covell 1861: 15). That *whole* is listed under /h/, while *who* is not is likely due to their different etymologies as *whole* only acquired <wh> in late ME. In some regional varieties /w/ and /hw/ did exist even in *whole* (OED: s.v. *whole* adj., n., & adv.). Unfortunately, Covell does not reveal any articulatory information on the realisation of the consonant cluster or the vowel in *who*.

For Kirkham (1834: 22) <wh> spellings generally take /hw/ as he states: “[b]efore *h* it [sc. *w*] is pronounced as if written after the *h*; as in *why*, *when*, *what*; *hwy*, *hwen*, *hwat*”. However, for *whole* he lists a pronunciation with only /h/ and the vowel in STRUT words (his *u*²) as “improper” and “COMMON IN NEW-ENGLAND AND NEW-YORK” (Kirkham 1834: 205). According to him, the correct pronunciation has /hw/ plus his “*o*¹”, which is the sound found in GOAT words. The criticised variant *hull* actually reflects a form typically found in dialect literature or dialect depictions in newspapers. Paulsen (2022: 291) for instance finds *hull* ‘whole’ in representations of the speech of mountaineers. This characterological figure does not correspond to Kirkham’s portrayal of the feature as common in New England and New York. As regards this pronunciation orthographically represented as *hull* ‘whole’, it appears to be a historical New England feature. The description of the vowel in the word would match the “New England short-*o*”, e.g. [rød] in *road* (Stanford 2020: 55). This was historically present but has been reported to be recessive from the 1960s and is not attested in Stanford’s data. Moreover, Krapp (1925: 133) mentions realisations with [ʌ] and [ɔ]. He also notices the occurrence of *hull* for *whole* in regions beyond New England but retraces them to former migration from New England to these areas:

Forms like *hum* for *home*, *hull* for *whole*, *unly* for *only* are occasionally met with in regions outside New England, but only in dialect speech, and apparently always in the wake of New England migration. For the word *shone*, however, both [ʃɔn] and [ʃʌn] are still to be met with in cultivated speech, though [ʃo:n] is much the more common form. (Krapp 1925: 133)

Potential migration could also explain its association with mountaineers in Paulsen's (2022) study of US-American newspapers. The OED also lists variants like *holl* or *hull* as generally "U.S. regional" (OED: s.v. *whole* adj., n., & adv.). According to the *Dictionary of American Regional English* (DARE), /hʌl/ is used mainly in New England, the South, and the South Midland. In New England /həl/ and less frequently /hɔl/ are attested as well. Pronunciation spellings of these variants include *holl*, *hull*, and *whull* (DARE: s.v. *whole* adj. & n.).

In terms of the last grammar, namely Higginson (1864: 10), it has already been mentioned that he claims that "in *who*, the *w* is scarcely heard". I have suggested that, since <w> was regarded also as a vowel by most nineteenth-century grammarians, this could simply point to a laxer realisation. However, as with many cases it is impossible to tell for certain given the lack of information provided by Higginson.

The remaining grammars give WHO(M) words /h/ as we would expect. Ramsey (1892) is part of these grammars and states that <w> is "silent before *h* in *who*, *whole*, *whoop*, and *whore*", but also explicitly proscribes /hw/ in *whole*. Ramsey (1892: 176) notes that "[t]here is a pronunciation remarked on in England as peculiarly American, which culminates in, but is not confined to, the word *whole*". This pronunciation he identifies as a short vowel so that the "word then insensibly becomes *hull*". Thus, the vowel realisation could be regarded as similar to the pronunciation given by Kirkham as typical of New England and New York. Ramsey continues and identifies realisations of *whole* with /hw/ as even "worse" and retraceable to the spelling of the word. He furthermore draws a comparison to /h/-insertion in Cockney speech:

A still worse pronunciation is appearing among some of those who insist on speaking as they spell, in trying to make the *w* audible. This produces a most uncouth and barbarous vocable for sake of a written letter that is no part of the original word. In all the equivalents except the English the *w* is wanting. It appears to have crept in from some local dialect about the year 1500, and attached itself to a number of words in the manner of the cockney *h*. In some words, as *whole*, *whore*, and *whoop*, it has been retained in the written but not in the spoken language. (Ramsey 1892: 176)

Ramsey is correct in his assessment that these words originally did not have <w> and that it entered the language at the end of the ME period. He shows a strong aversion to the /hw/ variant in the form of social evaluations as the use of "uncouth" and "barbarous" show. While this does not show an association with

/h/-dropping, he does compare the variant with an additional /w/ to Cockney /h/-insertion. I have not been able to find any information of the /hw/ pronunciations mentioned by Kirkham and Ramsey, either in present-day AmE or historically aside from the comments in the OED. In Worcester (1830) and Worcester (1859) the transcription “hōl” is given for *whole*. There is no evidence in Krapp (1919) or Krapp (1925) for /hw/ in *whole* either. Neither Newman (2014) nor Stanford (2020) mention this variant for New York and New England respectively.

Thus, the use of /hw/, or at least a variant in which both <w> and <h> have a phonetic realisation, is mentioned in the CNG for the words *whole* and *who*, albeit very infrequently. In *whole* it is regarded as correct by Kirkham (1834: 205) but as “uncouth” and “barbarous” American pronunciation by Ramsey (1892: 176). In *who* it does not receive any value judgments or is tied to a specific region. The variant realisation of *whole* as *hull* is criticised in both grammars and correctly identified as typical of New England in Kirkham although Krapp (1925), and the OED and DARE also provide evidence for the form outside of New England.

9.7 WHICH-WITCH merger: Summary

In sum, significantly more North American grammars mention WHALE words (50% North American versus 20% British-Irish grammars). They exclusively propose /hw/ and therefore suggest a complete absence of the WHICH-WITCH merger. The only evidence of /w/ and weakened variants comes from British-Irish grammars throughout the century. Only one of the Scottish, Irish or Canadian grammars gives information on the distribution of /hw/ and /w/, namely Connell (1843). Similar to most other British-Irish grammars, he proposes /hw/. Most grammars argue based on spelling and thus in favour of /hw/ and are descriptive. The grammarians in the CNG implicitly and at times explicitly, e.g. Ramsey (1892: 142, 175) or West (1898: 39), adhere to the idea that good pronunciation is the result of perfect sound-spelling correspondence, i.e. if there is a letter in writing it should also be realised in actual speech (see also my discussion of Walker 1791: 46 in Section 9.1).

I have suggested that the difference in frequency could be explained by the maintenance of /hw/ in North American speakers. In other words, it might have been more important to them to highlight a contrast they maintained, were keen on maintaining, and that was seen as more correct. In general, the high frequency of /hw/ also in British-Irish grammars can have several reasons. First, it could indeed be the continuation of a revitalisation of /hw/ due to the stigmatisation of /h/-dropping. Given the little evidence of the connection between /h/-dropping

and /w/ in the CNG, this is however unlikely. Second, they could have simply copied from authors like Murray and others, which would also explain the closeness in wording in earlier grammars and the frequency of example words like *when*, *what* and *why*. Finally, the orthography of the words (and their history) is likely to promote arguments for /hw/. The absence of comments in grammars from Scotland, Ireland or Canada, is striking but could be because of how little they are represented in the CNG in the first place, or perhaps because there was no variation.

In terms of dialectal variation, evidence mainly comes from the end of the century and almost exclusively from British-Irish grammars. Despite the statements we find in Walker at the end of the eighteenth century, there is no explicit mention of /w/ as a feature typical of London. In contrast, in those grammars that discuss dialectal variation it is /hw/ that is the marked regional variant. Except in one case, the results align with the traditional dialect distribution found in Ellis and the SED materials. The one exception is Kelke (1885), who identifies what is likely a variant with a velar fricative in Northumberland, Scotland and parts of the South. To my knowledge variants like [xw] had long been lost in the South at the time he was writing. Therefore, it is unclear which variety he refers to exactly. One example from North America, namely Carpenter (1902), identifies /hw/ as American and /w/ as the pronunciation of the English, again supporting the idea that the /h/-full variant was maintained longer in North America than in England.

In contrast to other features, 11 grammars make use of the etymology of *WHALE* words, i.e. OE <hw> words such as *hwæt*, to justify their perceived standard. I have argued that these cases cannot be regarded as restorative prescriptivism in a strict sense based on Curzan (2014) but certainly have elements of it. Therefore, I treat them as a form of restorative prescriptivism in a broader sense. This is supported by Beal & Sen's (2014) idea of a revitalisation of /hw/ in England, where /w/ is said to have been very widespread in the late eighteenth-century. These etymological arguments are very likely also caused by the orthography and the perception that OE spelling variants more accurately represent the modern English phonetic values. Grammarians simply regarded <hw> as the more logical spelling. However, there are no direct calls for restoring historical spellings as I have found for *FACE* diphthongs (see Section 5.3).

As regards words like *who* or *whole*, only three grammars propose some form of consonant cluster, whereas one grammar, namely Ramsey (1892), explicitly proscribes /hw/ in *whole*. Realising *whole* as *hull* is criticised as New England, New York (Kirkham 1834), or generally American pronunciation in the CNG (Ramsey 1892). According to Krapp (1925: 133), the OED, and DARE, it is a typical

New England feature but not restricted to this area. In terms of /hw/ in *who*, the vowel realisation as well as the finer phonetics of the sounds remain unclear in the respective grammars.

In this chapter I have thus shown that /hw/ is clearly the dominant variant in the WHALE set in nineteenth-century grammars of English. It is categorically proposed in North American grammars and the only grammars in which /w/ can be found are those published in Britain. Furthermore, it is only in works from 1885 or later that /hw/ becomes the marked regional variant. The high frequency of /hw/ in the grammarians' descriptions could be seen as a revitalisation effort of older forms and a counter-measure to a change that had been ongoing for centuries at their time of writing. The change towards a full WHICH-WITCH merger had already progressed very far in the nineteenth century and despite efforts by LModE elocutionists and grammarians, who often strived for sound-spelling correspondence, it has reached completion in virtually all varieties of English today. In terms of articulatory descriptions, the grammars in the CNG generally do not allow for a systematic study of phonetic differences between [hw], [ʰw], and [ʌ]. Therefore, the exact quality or a phonetically gradual development in the nineteenth century cannot be argued for.

10 /v/-/w/-interchange

10.1 /v/ and /w/: Historical background

The next consonantal feature, i.e. /v/-/w/-interchange, refers to the pronunciation of words like *very* with [w] or *well* with [v]. It was strongly associated with Cockney speakers in the nineteenth century (see Gerwin 2023), while it was indeed also attested more widely in the South of England in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. Trudgill (2021: 84) however cites instances as early as the fifteenth century, e.g. in the Paston letters. There is furthermore evidence for former use in New England, Boston, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, and Georgia (Krapp 1925: 241–244; Trudgill 2021: 85–86). Based on Trudgill’s (2021: 85–86) assessment of SED materials and conversations with older speakers from Norfolk, he suggests that it disappeared last in Norfolk and was widespread there up until the 1920s. In contrast to all the other consonantal features discussed in my analysis so far, the interchange of /v/ and /w/ is neither part of modern London English nor many present-day dialects. Some exceptions are areas in North America with German heritage speakers, e.g. Pennsylvania (Huffines 1980: 360; Raith 1981: 42–43), traditional Irish English dialects (Kallen 2013: 49–50, 214–215, 221), and varieties of English spoken in India (Sharma 2012: 2086). Trudgill et al. (2003: 26–27) also provide a list of less-widely spoken Englishes such as Tristan da Cunha and Pitcairn English where /v/ and /w/ merged.

Historically, it is another one of the features that Walker identifies as “faults of the Londoners” (Walker 1791: xii–xiii). According to him, it is common “among the inhabitants of London, and those not always of the lower order” (Walker 1791: xii–xiii). While Walker was evidently very influential, his comments were not free of criticism and parody in the nineteenth-century, as the following excerpt from *Punch* magazine as well as Figure 10.1 show. An anonymous philologist utilises exactly this feature to make fun of Walker’s rules as they write the following in the issue from 22 April, 1843: “[T]here is no truth [...] in the rules for teaching my fellow-citizens to speak English, laid down in the introduction to the pronouncing dictionary of *Walker*” (cited in Crystal 2017: 76, my emphasis).

However, Walker is not the only LModE scholar that mentions and frowns up the feature. In guides like *The Vulgarities of Speech Corrected* (1826: 257) speakers

ON THE COCKNEY PRONUNCIATION.

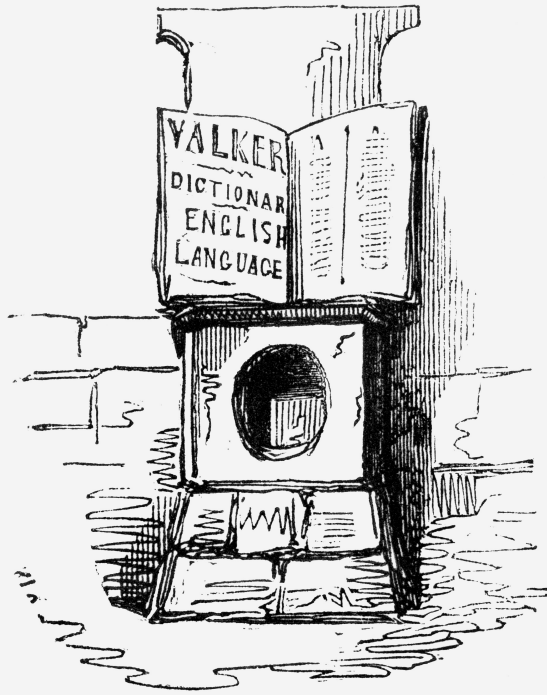


Figure 10.1: ON THE COCKNEY PRONUNCIATION., taken from *Punch Magazine* (22 April, 1843: 169) and reproduced with permission from Punch Cartoon Library/TopFoto.

from London are said to “make the greatest mistakes with regard to the sounds *v* and *w*, and in sounding or not sounding the letter *h* properly”. However, in the same source the interchange is said to occur throughout England: “yet these mistakes are by no means confined to London, but may be met with in every part of England” (cited in Jones 2006: 343). Smart (1836: xl) refers to it as “extreme vulgarity” but at the same time provides evidence for its disappearance: “[f]ew persons under forty years of age [...] can be in much danger of saying, that they like ‘Weal and winegar wery well;’ or that they are going to ‘Vest Vickham in a po shay’”. Mugglestone (2012: 358–359) argues that correspondence of William Darwin and his use of “Villie Darvin” to refer to himself “gives incontrovertible

evidence of the continued alternation of [v] and [w]”. She, however, also notes that it was used by authors like Dickens to depict lower-class speakers and for comic effect. Ellis (1889: 132) writes about the interchange that it “is disappearing under the influence of education”. According to him, this feature is also not exclusive to the Southeast or London, but a general eastern feature which is used from Kent to Norfolk. Concerning the direction of the interchange he states: “I have never yet heard (v) used for (w) in good faith, though I have much wanted to do so, but (w) for (v) I have known all my life in Ke[nt]” (Ellis 1889: 132). Several pages later he notes “though I have for many years been on the look out for it, have never heard (v) used for (w) in *earnest* London” but provides a list of words he has been able to find representing exactly this direction in the character of Sam Weller from Dickens’ *The Pickwick Papers* (Ellis 1889: 229). If Ellis is correct in his assessment, this would be evidence of either unidirectional variation, i.e. /w/ for /v/ in actual speech, or at least an overshoot of the opposite direction of the interchange in literary dialect. Trudgill et al. (2003: 34–41) provide a detailed discussion on this feature in eighteenth and nineteenth-century southern English dialects and less-widely spoken Englishes. They argue that /v/ and /w/ had merged on a phonetically intermediate variant in England, namely [β] or [β̥]. This intermediate variant caused speakers who did not share this merger (Dickens, amongst others) to perceive [w] as [v] but also the other way around. This then accounts for the two-way interchange. They argue that this merger was exported to some colonies, where it is still attested today, but reversed in England through contact with middle class speakers and other regional varieties. Before the reversal was complete, they argue, there must have been an intermediate stage where there was still one phoneme with the allophones [w] and [v].

Concerning North American sources, Krapp (1919) does not provide any comments on the feature, but in his *The English Language in America* he devotes four pages to it (Krapp 1925: 241–244). He says that “Americans nowadays are familiar with the pronunciation of v as [w], and the reverse of w as [v], only as examples of British humor in Dickens and similar writers”. He adds: “Nowhere in America does the exchange between [v] and [w] persist as a general native dialect survival”. This would support the claim I made above about /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, i.e. that features typically associated with Cockney speakers are unlikely to have been familiar to most North American ears first hand. It is likely that they were mainly known to them through literary works by authors like Dickens, who utilise literary dialect in their characters. However, Krapp (1925: 241–244) points out that historically /v/-/w/-interchange seems to have been used in America and provides evidence from Benezet (1779), Johnston (1888), and Webster (1789) for the feature in Boston, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, and

Georgia. Based on migration from areas like London to North America, Krapp (1925: 243–244) furthermore hypothesises that it is likely to have been present in the US, especially in New England. Additionally, based on Webster (1789) he argues that we could regard it as an urban feature. In any case, it was clearly stigmatised and referred to as an “impropriety” and a “vulgarism” (Krapp 1925: 241–244). Krapp (1925: 243) himself notes that “[t]he pronunciation in England seems never to have been a refined or elegant pronunciation”. Thus, irrespective of whether they were in the British-Irish Isles or North America, LModE scholars not only regarded /v/-/w/-interchange as wrong but “vulgar” and further as a characteristic trait of working class speech.

Given Walker’s identification of this feature with London, and its historical role in the enregisterment of Cockney (see Gerwin 2023), one of the goals of this chapter is to assess differences in the extent to which nineteenth-century grammarians regarded /v/-/w/-interchange as a London, or at least a southern British, dialect feature. As the results for /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion have shown that North American grammarians primarily regard these as British features, I examine to what extent this is the case for /v/-/w/-interchange as well. I also scrutinise whether the feature is mentioned as working both ways, i.e. [w] used for <v> and [v] used for <w>, especially in light of Ellis’ (1889) claims that he has never encountered the latter type and Trudgill et al.’s (2003) suggestion of a reversed merger.

10.2 /v/-/w/-interchange in the CNG: Overview

In the CNG, 11 grammars (7% of 166) mention /v/-/w/-interchange, all of which exhibit a high degree of stigma and exclusively negative evaluations. The earliest of these is Hodson (1806) and the latest Ramsey (1892), and comments on this feature occur throughout the century from the first decade onwards. Six of those grammars were published in England (exclusively in London), while the remaining five are North American. Therefore, none of the grammars that mention the interchange were published in Scotland, Ireland or Canada. This quantitative difference can be disregarded as roughly 6% of British-Irish and 8% of North American grammars mention the feature. This furthermore shows that the feature is generally rarely mentioned in the grammars in the CNG.

In terms of the direction of the substitution, all grammars, except Kirkham (1834), suggest that the interchange works both ways. However, regarding the number of example words grammarians give of this feature, the use of /w/ for /v/ is more frequently represented. We could interpret this frequency-imbalance

as in part confirming Ellis' observations, despite the mentioning of /v/ for /w/ in the CNG. However, it is generally questionable in most cases if these comments are caused by actual first-hand contact with speakers who have this feature in their speech. I return to this point in the next section. As one of the goals of this chapter is to assess differences in the extent to which nineteenth-century grammarians regarded /v/-/w/-interchange as London dialect feature, I start by discussing those grammars that claim it to be a southern English feature.

10.3 Stigmatisation of /v/-/w/-interchange

Concerning evaluations of /v/-/w/-interchange, there are six cases where grammarians refer to it as a Cockney, London or Kent feature: half of these grammars were published in London (Leigh 1840; Cobbin 1864; Kelke 1885), and the remaining three are North American grammars (Fowler 1855; Ridpath 1881; Ramsey 1892). Kelke, Ridpath as well as Ramsey provide references to Dickens' *Pickwick Papers* or his character Sam Weller in connection to this feature.

In addition to explicitly ascribing the feature to a specific region (7 times), grammarians identify /v/-/w/-interchange as Mistake (8 times), provide other Social Evaluations (6 times), including references to the speakers' Education (once), and utilise arguments belonging to the category Aesthetics to argue against it (twice). Moreover, the argument in one grammar, namely Lowres (1863), has been categorised as Nature. Identifying it simply as wrong is the most frequent evaluation. References to the feature are summarised in Figure 10.2, ordered by evaluative category.

As regards the terms used to identify /v/-/w/-interchange as a London dialect feature in the three grammars published in England, Leigh's (1840: 21) section on "The Alphabet" displays a reference to Cockney speakers: "V was hop-a-kick Vulcan, that limping old codger; *Wenus* — Venus I mean — with a W begins, (*Vell*, if I *ham* a Cockney, *wot* need of your grins?). In Leigh's (1840) grammar, another negative evaluation can be found in a passage already discussed with respect to /h/-dropping:

Few persons there are, whose ears are so extremely obtuse, as not to be frequently annoyed at the violations of Grammar by which they are so often assailed. It is really painful to be forced, in walking along the streets, to hear such phrases as, "That 'ere homnibus". "Where've you *bin*". "*Vot's* the *hodds*?" and the like. Very dreadful expressions are also used by draymen and others in addressing their horses. (Leigh 1840: xi)

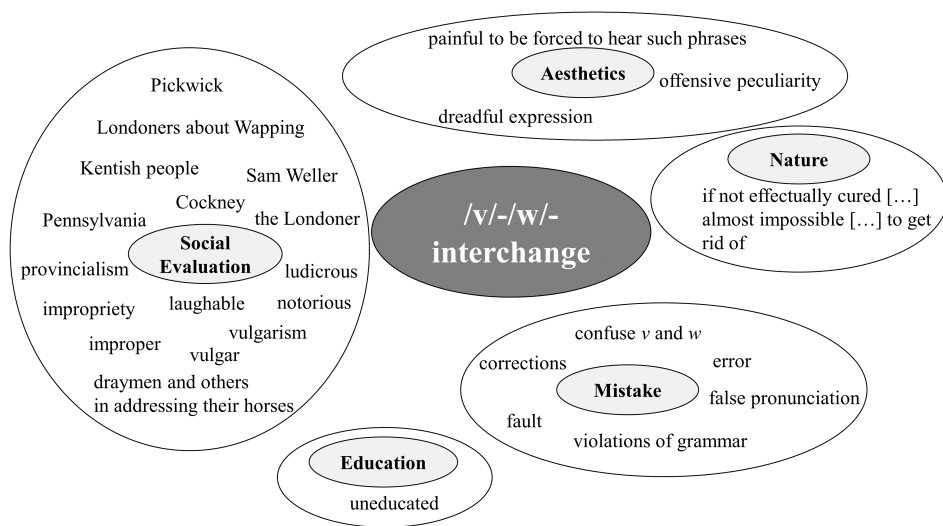


Figure 10.2: Evaluative terms used for /v/-/w/-interchange in the CNG, sorted by category

Expressions such as “violations of Grammar” show that Leigh regards these features as mistakes. Leigh (1840) lists /v/-/w/-interchange in the same sentence together with features such as /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion and a short front monophthong in *been*. His evaluation is of an aesthetic and social kind as words like “dreadful” and his ascription to working-class occupations such as draymen show. For Cobbin (1864: 82), it is the “Kentish people” and “Londoners about Wapping” who “are notorious for substituting the *v* for *w*, and the *w* for the *v*, in pronouncing words”. Cobbin provides an example of this fault in nursery rhymes as he continues: “as humorously described in the well-known phrase, ‘Weal and winegar are wery good wictuals, I wow;’ and in ‘Vill, vare’s my vice vig?’”. He describes both ways of interchange, i.e. from /v/ to /w/ as in the first example and from /w/ to /v/ in the second. The words “notorious” shows that the feature is stigmatised as does “as humorously described”. Cobbin (1864: 82) moreover adds a footnote to this passage, in which he admits that /v/-/w/-interchange can be found in the bible, but that he deliberately refrained from including any biblical examples:

I had, agreeably to my plan, given Scripture illustrations of this fault; but as it is so ludicrous, I thought it better to substitute others, than to associate laughable ideas in the minds of children which might haunt them their lives.

He identifies the interchange of /v/ and /w/ as a “fault”, calls it “ludicrous”, and regards it as so problematic that it might “haunt” children forever. Furthermore, Cobbin (1864: 82) states that including religious examples of the feature would lead to children associating these mistakes (or “laughable ideas”) with holy texts. While it is neither clear which words and which translation of the bible he had in mind, he could be referring to variation in words like *wine*, *vine*, and *vinegar*. Despite the apparent importance of the Scripture for him, the degree of stigma attached to interchanging /v/ and /w/ outweighs the significance of biblical language. Kelke’s (1885: 37) comment is considerably shorter as it reads: “(5) Dento-labials and Labials. [...] (N.B. ‘Cockney,’ Kentish, etc., confuse v and w, as ‘wery’ for ‘very’)”. To this he adds a footnote which makes a reference to Dickens’ *The Pickwick Papers*, i.e. “[p]ut it down a *We* (*Pickwick*)”. This is in fact a characteristic feature of the character in the book as spellings such as <wery> *very* occur throughout Dickens’ novel in Sam Weller’s speech. Kelke is the only one of the grammars published in England that makes a reference to Dickens.

Concerning North American grammars that explicitly refer to the connection between London and /v/-/w/-interchange, Fowler (1855: 116) states “The LONDONER or COCKNEY pronounces *w* for *v*, and *v* for *w*; *weal* for *veal*; *vicked* for *wicked*”. Fowler (1855: 116) provides an alleged explanation of the distribution of /v/ and /w/ and hypothesises (perhaps jokingly) the Cockney “not to have understood why the consonant *u* of the Latins, which was not distinguished in writing from the vowel *u*, should be pronounced *v* (= *bh*), while the consonant *u* of the Anglo-Saxons, which had a distinct character from the vowel *u*, was pronounced *w*”. Fowler (1855: 117) further claims that Cockney speakers realise words such as *prevent* as “perwent”; hence “transposing letters” and changing /v/ to /w/. If he is referring to classical Latin in this paragraph, which I would have assumed, his explanation is inaccurate. At least in classical Latin both <v> and <u> existed although only <v> was used for stone engravings. Moreover, they both represented the labial forms /w/ and /u/. However, in later and church Latin, only /v/ and /u/ were used and were expressed simply by one graph (Salmon 1999: 39). Thus, for church Latin his observation would indeed be correct. So would his comment on <u> representing [w] in Anglo-Saxon, with the addition that there were several ways of representing [w] in OE depending on the region and age of the manuscript, namely <u>, <uu>, <p>, and <pp> (Hogg 1992b: 74–76; Hejná & Walkden 2022: 250).¹ From the fourteenth century onwards <w> is the standard way of representing /w/ (Lass 1992: 36). Fowler (1855: 116) acknowledges that this

¹In modern editions of OE manuscripts we normally find <w> to represent [w] as <p> may be confounded with <p> by modern readers.

is not easy to grasp: “[a]nd it must be confessed that the rule is somewhat arbitrary”. Despite his fuzzy explanation, it is very unlikely, to say the least, that any Cockney speaker had knowledge of Latin, if they were sufficiently literate, let alone the history of its pronunciation. Moreover, it is questionable how this is relevant to the interchange of /v/ and /w/ in his day in the first place even if we assume that speakers had an awareness of the history of the relevant graphemes. Therefore, we should read this as a rather parodying statement and as an evaluation of the education and status of the speakers he is criticising here. This is also evident in his statement “[t]his interchange of w and v is the most offensive peculiarity of the Cockney dialect” (Fowler 1855: 116), which we could furthermore categorise as an aesthetic or social argument, depending how we interpret “most offensive peculiarity”.

The second North American grammar, namely Ridpath (1881: 304), has a section which has previously been mentioned, namely “mimesis”. It is part of “Figures of Orthography” and treats “[t]he spelling of words in imitation of a false pronunciation”. His examples are close to verbatim quotes from chapter 33 of *The Pickwick Papers*: “1. ‘Vell, I think it is *rayther* good,’ said Sam. 2. ‘Wot I like in that ‘ere writin’, said Mr. Weller, ‘is that there a’n’t no *Wenuses* in it’”. The feature is therefore evidently regarded as a mistake and is part of a reference to Dickens (as in Kelke 1885).

Ramsey (1892: 174) also presents Dickens’ character Sam Weller as a typical speaker in whom we can find this feature. Ramsey attributes /v/-/w/-interchange to working-class speakers from London when he suggests that “Sam Weller is a type of a class who find it difficult to pronounce an initial v”. This line is, somewhat similar to Fowler, preceded by an explanation of the history of <u> and <v> and the observation that both essentially functioned as allographs of the same grapheme even still in the King James bible (which is indeed true of the authorised version from 1611). Again, as with Fowler, the relevance of this in the context of /v/-/w/-interchange is not evident from his grammar. Ramsey continues with an anecdote: “[w]hen I was young, there was in the neighborhood a man of that class from the old country whom the boys used to banter to say rapidly, ‘Veal, wine, vinegar, very good victuals, I vow.’ When thoroughly roused, the old man would run off in a string: Yes, I can say ‘*weal, wine, winegar, wery good wittles, I wow*, as fas’ as any of ye’”. This anecdote seems to be constructed and serves the purpose of exposing the alleged lack linguistic awareness of speakers that use this feature. His use of “a man of that class from the old country” could indeed refer to a working-class speaker from England and therefore be a further illustration of his Sam Weller example, and an association with Britishness.

There are no stark differences between grammars published in England and North America in the evaluations of /v/-/w/-interchange as a London feature. We can find references to Sam Weller in two North American and one British-Irish grammar, which seems to confirm that this was, similar to /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, a feature that was familiar to American speakers through Dickens rather than first-hand knowledge of Londoners who would use the feature.

In terms of grammars that do not refer to London, Cockney or the South of England, but were published in England, Hodson (1806: 57) provides the earliest example of /v/-/w/-interchange as he includes it as part of a list of wrong pronunciations: “[f]aults in pronunciation are innumerable. Some of them are the following: [...] confounding and interchanging *v* and *w*”. While his use of the word “interchanging” suggests that the “mistake” goes both ways, Hodson (1806) does not provide any example words or sentences for this “fault”. Andrew (1817: 124) simply writes that “[i]t is vulgar to confound the letters *v* and *w* [...] as by saying *weal* instead of *veal*, *vine* for *wine*”, thus providing a social evaluation of the feature.

Lowres’ (1863: 62–63) grammar includes one section titled “Cautions”, which includes “errors” in the speech of children “that if not effectually cured of the habit in their young years, it is almost impossible for them to get rid of it when they grow older”. As has been noted for Lowres in the context of /h/ (see Section 8.4), he thus equates linguistic variants with potentially chronic illnesses; hence, features listed under this section can be considered to belong to the category Nature. In addition to /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, Lowres (1863: 62–63) discusses /v/-/w/-interchange in his section: “[b]e careful not to sound *v* like *w*, nor *w* like *v*, a practice so common in many localities among the uneducated. Examples. Very should not be pronounced wery. Vinegar [should not be pronounced] winegar. Well [should not be pronounced] vell”. Lowres thus identifies these variants as part of the speech of uneducated speakers and adds three proscriptions. These comprise /w/ words which are realised with [v] and vice versa.

The remaining two North American grammars identify /v/-/w/-interchange as a Pennsylvanian feature, and implicitly as French and Irish. In Kirkham (1834: 205), the feature can be found under the section “PROVINCIALISMS. CONTRACTIONS, VULGARISMS, AND OTHER IMPROPRIETIES”. This section is divided into different sub-sections ordered by different regions. Kirkham proposes that speakers in Pennsylvania use /w/ for /v/. His example of the “improper” Pennsylvanian pronunciation reads “in wain” whereas the correct one is “in vain”. Given German migration to Pennsylvania in the seventeenth, eighteenth and nineteenth

centuries, Kirkham's evaluation of this feature as Pennsylvanian could be explained by the English spoken in areas with Pennsylvania Dutch-English contact. In fact, while this is not a categorical feature, twentieth-century English of Pennsylvania Germans still exhibited three different variants for /v/, namely [v], [β], [w] (Huffines 1980: 360). Furthermore, exchanging /v/ for /w/ in words like *very* as well as /w/ for /v/ as in *want* was also attested (Raith 1981: 42–43). However, Kirkham is the only grammar where, based on the information given, the substitution only works one way, i.e. [v] > [w], which conforms with Ellis' observation for London. Kirkham thus clearly provides a social evaluation and regards the feature as wrong and as a regionalism.

In his chapter on “ORAL EXERCISES. EXAMPLES FOR PARSING”, Brown (1857: 266) includes as first lesson “LESSON I.—FIGURES OF ORTHOGRAPHY. MIMESIS AND ARCHAIISM”, where he provides the following quotes amongst others:

- (1) “*Fery goot*: I will make a *prief* of it in my note book ; and we will afterwards *'ork* upon the cause with as great discreetly as we can”. —Shak.
- (2) “*Vat* is you sing? I do not like *dese* toys. Pray you, go and *vetch* me in my closet *un boitier verd*; a box, a *green-a* box. Do *intend vat* I speak? a *green-a* box”. —Id.
- (3) “I *ax'd* you what you had to sell. I am fitting out a *wessel* for *Wenice*, loading her with *various keinds of prowisions*, and *wittualling* her for a long *woyage*; and I want several *undred* weight or *weal*, *wenison*, & c., with plenty of *inyons* and *winegar*, for the *preserwation of ealth*”. —Columbian Orator, p. 292. (Brown 1857: 266)

This lesson however does not contain any instructions for the student but merely serves the aim of exemplification. If we consider Ridpath's (1881) description of mimesis this could constitute a negative approach to the features in the passages quoted and could exemplify to the student how not to spell and pronounce specific words outside of acting. I have found that the Shakespeare examples, i.e. (1) and (2) abbreviated by Brown as “Shak.”, and “Id.” (Lat. *ibidem*), are from *The Merry Wives of Windsor*. The example in (1) is a line by Sir Hugh Evans, who is a Welsh character, whereas the one in (2) is spoken by Doctor Caius, a French physician. The third example depicted in (3) is taken from the *Columbian Orator*, from “A DIALOGUE BETWEEN A CITY GENTLEMAN OF THE TON, AND A COUNTRY FARMER”, in which a farmer, who uses a higher register than all the characters and constantly has misunderstandings with his interlocutors, claims

to have had a conversation with an Irishman (Bingham 1817: 292). Brown's quote includes what the Irishman has supposedly said. In the examples taken from Shakespeare, we can only find the interchange in the French character, who uses *vat* instead of *what*. The passage from the *Columbian Orator* is slightly more complicated because the character whom the farmer identifies as Irish himself states that he does not speak Irish but that "[i]t is enough for me that I am able to speak good English" (Bingham 1817: 292). However, not all of the features depicted here by semi-phonetic spelling are attested in Irish English. /h/-dropping in *hundred* and *health* and a front realisation of the first vowel in *onions*, which are all implied here, are not attested in historical or contemporary Irish English. According to Kallen (2013: 221), Bliss (1979) gives examples of spellings implying /v/ for /w/, and less frequently so /w/ for /v/, for seventeenth and eighteenth-century Irish English. The use of [ɸ] and [β] for /f/ and /v/ (as well as sometimes /w/) is also attested in traditional Irish English dialects and is likely a transfer from Irish Gaelic, and is "at least a partial point of continuity [...] between early Irish English and traditional dialect of the modern era" (Kallen 2013: 215). The linguistic variant represented by *inyons* depicted in this passage is a stereotypical Yankee, i.e. New England, form. Still, similar spellings and pronunciations like [ɪ(n)jɪm] that are suggested by this semi-phonetic spelling are also attested in other regions such as South Carolina (DARE: s.v. *onion* n.). Nevertheless, Brown (1857) does not provide his readers with the information that this quote represents an Irishman or a Yankee. The feature might be implicitly evaluated as wrong, old-fashioned, and foreign (in the lines quoted from Shakespeare), although the passage in (3) does not reveal that per se.

As for these five grammars that do not link /v/-/w/-interchange with London, it is hard to pinpoint any systematic qualitative difference between British-Irish and North American grammars that are relevant to the present analysis, except the explicit reference to Pennsylvania and implicit association with French and Irish speakers.

10.4 /v/-/w/-interchange: Summary

With only 11 mentions, /v/-/w/-interchange is generally an infrequent feature, although it attracts almost as many comments as post-vocalic /r/ absence and diphthongal variants of GOAT words in the CNG. Similar to non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, but different to all other features, it receives exclusively negative evaluations. The categories in which these can be summarised are: Mistake (8 times), Social Evaluation (6 times), Aesthetics (twice) Education

(once), and Nature (once). The main categories are thus Mistake and Social Evaluation, which is in line with features such as /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. In addition, grammars in the CNG associate it with different regions seven times, of which six are associations with London, Cockney or the South of England and one with Pennsylvania. Half of the references to the South of England make use of Dickens' novel *The Pickwick Papers* (1836), whose character Sam Weller uses /v/-/w/-interchange repeatedly throughout the novel. Two of these can be found in North American grammars and one in a grammar from England. This is in line with Krapp's (1925: 241–244) observation that most speakers in North America know this feature from British novels. It also conforms with my findings for non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. I suggest that the stigmatisation of /v/-/w/-interchange in the CNG is very unlikely to have come from actual contact with speakers whose speech was characterised by features like this. The grammars presumably largely reproduce what they know from dialect depictions from authors like Dickens, which is supported by the fact that we find it twice under the section on “mimesis”. These depictions do not necessarily align with the actual structural variety spoken by speakers represented by his characters. Gerwin (2023: 42–43) also provides a discussion of several scholars who are very sceptical of Dickens' fidelity to actual spoken Cockney. Thus, while still regarded as a fault of southern speakers, somewhat similar to Walker's (1791: xii–xiii) comments, the faithfulness to actual speech is doubtful. There is thus conflicting historical evidence. On the one hand, Mugglestone (2012: 358–359) suggests that, while utilised by authors like Dickens, /v/-/w/-interchange was still used in the middle of the nineteenth century. Trudgill (2021: 86) also claims it was used in Norfolk up until the 1920s and Ellis writes only in 1889 that the feature is disappearing. On the other hand, Smart's (1836: xl) comments that only speakers older than forty still use this feature indicates that it was already recessive in the 1830s. To this we may add further sceptical accounts of Dickens' faithfulness from the nineteenth century, e.g. Ellis' (1889: 229) comments on the absence of [v] for [w] in actual speech and its presence in Sam Weller.

In the example of Kirkham (1834), however, his criticism of /v/-/w/-interchange as a Pennsylvanian feature does seem to reflect the speech of nineteenth-century Pennsylvanian English speakers, if we consider Krapp's (1925) comments and studies of traditional Pennsylvania-Dutch-English bilingual speakers (Huffines 1980: 360; Raith 1981: 42–43). As regards the direction of interchange in the CNG, [w] for <v> is used more often in the examples of the CNG than vice versa. Nonetheless, with the exception of Kirkham's (1834) grammar, they all provide examples of both ways of interchange. While the higher frequency of [w] for <v> is in line with Ellis' (1889) observation that he has never properly heard

[v] for <w>, the fact that all grammars provide examples of both cases seems to contradict this statement. The presence of a two-way interchange supports Trudgill et al.'s (2003) theory about the history of the change discussed above. However, I argue that, similar to the references to Cockney, the examples stem from a reproduction of enregistered forms rather than an actual observation of real data. This can also be seen in the repeated reference to Sam Weller, nursery rhymes and the recurring use of the same example words, e.g. *veal*, *vinegar*, *victuals*, and *wine*.

11 Realisations of *-ing*

11.1 *-ing*: Historical background

The sound used in final *-ing* endings in English standard varieties today is the velar nasal /ŋ/. While in PDE it has phoneme status and differentiates words such as *sin* and *sing*, it used to be an allophone of /n/ in OE and ME. Then it only occurred before the velar plosives /k/ and /g/, e.g. *mancynn* ‘mankind’ or *lang* ‘long’. During the late sixteenth, and seventeenth centuries, /g/ disappeared after /ŋ/ (see Lass 1999: 119–120). Today, the only environments in which /g/ is maintained in standard English varieties are in comparative and superlative forms of adjectives such as *stronger* and *strongest* and in “words that are not obviously morphemically complex” such as *finger* (Lass 1999: 120).

In the suffix *-ing* in gerunds and present participles, e.g. *writing*, the dominant pronunciation in every standard variety of English today is [ɪŋ]. However, [ɪn], a variant nowadays clearly marked as dialectal and non-standard, is attested as early as the fourteenth century and emerged due to early loss of /g/ (see Lass 1999: 120). The alveolar variant became increasingly more frequent in the following centuries. Lass (1999: 120) quotes Queen Elizabeth I as using [ɪn] and notes that “[b]y the end of the seventeenth century [the use of the alveolar variant] no longer needs comment”. Hickey (2023: 79) calls this process by which a final velar nasal becomes alveolar ING-fronting and remarks that this may happen not only in verbs but also nouns, e.g. *morning* and *evening*, where the morphological complexity of the form is not particularly apparent to a modern speaker. In addition, we have to bear in mind that the emergence of the alveolar variant was a complex historical process and that there were important differences between present participles and gerunds. ModE gerunds essentially emerge from OE verbal nouns. In fact, present participles were formally distinct from them until early ME. The OE form for verbal nouns was *-ing/-ung*; present participles had *-and* in the North, *-ende* in the Midlands and *-inde* in the South. Thus, the OE participle of ModE *to write* was not *writing* but *writende*, while its verbal noun was *writing*. It only happens during the ME period that these two forms merge to the formally similar but functionally distinct form *-ing* for present participles and verbal nouns/gerunds; a process which was complete by about the end of the

fifteenth century (see Lass 1992: 144–146). Not all present participle forms were affected by early /g/-loss as the *-nd(e)* forms coexisted with *-ing(e)* throughout ME, as illustrated in Figure 11.1.

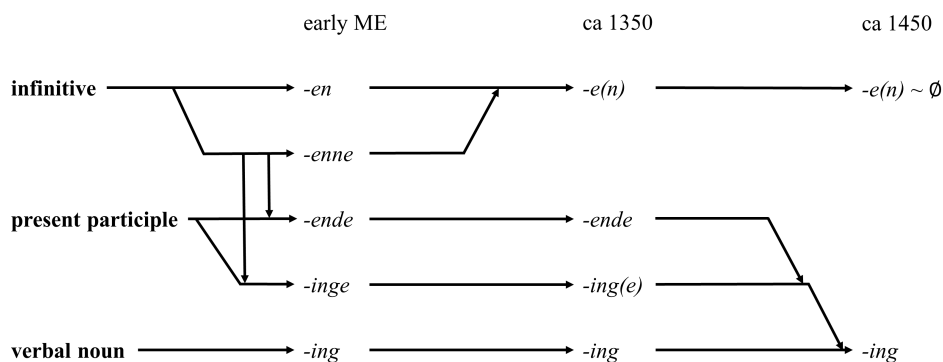


Figure 11.1: Historical development of infinitive, present participle and verbal noun endings, recreated based on Lass (1992: 146)

According to Mugglestone (2007: 128), it is not until the mid-eighteenth century that an awareness of the social stratification between the variants [ɪn] and [ɪŋ] arose. Stigmatisation of the alveolar nasal first occurs in the second half of the eighteenth century. With respect to the realisation of the velar nasal and the suffix *-ing* in LModE, I differentiate between five cases of variation which I elaborate on further below:

- [ɪn] as an upper-class and aristocratic variant
- [ɪn] as educated pronunciation only in post-[ɪŋ] environments as in *singing*
- [ɪn] as non-standard and lower-class variant
- hypercorrect variants, e.g. [ˈrɪbɪŋ] *ribbon*, [ˈkæptɪŋ] *captain*
- [ɪŋk ~ ɪŋg] as dialectal, lower-class, and non-native variant in words like *nothing*

What I have called “[ɪn] as an upper-class and aristocratic variant” deserves some further comment here. While several sociolinguistic studies have shown that in present-day varieties of English the presence of [ɪn] correlates with lower socio-economic classes and more casual speech styles (Evans Wagner 2012: 183), in the first half of the eighteenth century [ɪn] was still very common in the speech

of the upper class and the aristocracy. It continued to exist throughout the nineteenth and early twentieth century in the speech of the aristocracy. According to Beal (2004b: 161), this aristocratic usage of [ɪn] starts to attract stigma towards the end of the nineteenth century and had become stereotyped and chiefly employed for humoristic purposes in the early twentieth century. Jespersen (1909: 356), although aware of [ɪn] being taught at schools, however still describes the use of [ɪn] in educated speech like that of Ellis and Arthur Sampson Napier, the Merton Professor of English Language and Literature at Oxford from 1885 until 1916. Nevertheless, Jespersen also remarks that this pronunciation is characteristic of the aristocracy and “horsy people”, i.e. wealthy and prominent people, while it is said to be less often employed by female speakers:

In our own days [ɪn] is certainly heard pretty often in all verbs in spite of the influence of schools. Professor Napier, of Oxford, once told me it was to him the only natural way of pronouncing the ending; and A. J. Ellis very frequently had the same sound. The aristocracy, and ‘horsy’ people generally, are said to favour [ɪn], which is certainly less frequent among the ladies. (Jespersen 1909: 356)

Around the same time as Jespersen, the American Krapp (1919: 114) describes [ɪn] as a dialectal variant and a realisation heard in educated speech: “[i]n dialect speech and sometimes also in colloquial cultivated speech, final unstressed [ŋ] becomes [n], especially in present participles, as in singing [ˈsɪŋn], doing [ˈdʌm], saying [ˈseɪn], etc.”. However, he suggests that “[t]his pronunciation is more generally heard in cultivated speech in England than in America”. Krapp moreover points out that there was a discrepancy between prescriptivists and the use of the variant by educated speakers: “[i]n both countries, however, the authority of academic opinion is strongly against it” (Krapp 1919: 114). According to Beal (2004b: 161), by the mid-twentieth century at the latest, even in England stigmatisation of the alveolar realisation had reached a degree so “that even the supposed rulers of the country could not escape censure for using this”. Thus, we can make the cautious claim that stigmatisation of [ɪn] started around 1750 and by 1950, at the very latest, had led to the variant having disappeared from upper-class and aristocratic speech. As noted in Section 2.1, it is important to differentiate between upper-class and aristocratic speech and what authors like Sheridan and Walker regarded as educated and best speakers. The audience of LModE orthoëpists was not the aristocracy, and neither were it the lower classes, who simply could not afford their works and struggled with survival rather than improving their pronunciation. It is the middle class who was willing to pay

for pronunciation advice to improve their position in society and become one of these “good” and “elegant” speakers mentioned in Walker and others (see Ranson 2012 for the rhetoric in Walker; Beal 2020 for a discussion on eighteenth-century orthoëpists’ readership and their role in codifying pronunciation; Beal 2023 for their relation to the lower classes).

Nonetheless, the alveolar variant has continued to be used sporadically to the present day by middle and upper-middle-class speakers in casual speech styles, as shown in Labov (1966) (see Meyerhoff 2019: 189–190 for an overview of twentieth-century studies on different varieties showing that the alveolar variant is stratified by class and formality). Labov et al. (2011) show that it is considered the marked variant in formal speech, as opposed to the unmarked standard [ŋ].¹

The second case listed above concerns statements we can find in the work of late eighteenth-century scholars like Walker (1791) and Murray (1795). Both generally contend that “the ringing sound”, i.e. [ŋ], is to be used in the present participle ending *-ing*. They only allow for the alveolar variant [n] if the stem of the word already has the phonological sequence /ɪŋ/, as in words like *singing* and *bringing*. Walker provides an aesthetic argument for this: “a repetition of the ringing sound in successive syllables would have a very bad effect on the ear; and therefore, instead of *singing*, *bringing*, and *flinging*, our best speakers are heard to pronounce *sing in*, *bring-in*, and *fling-in*” (Walker 1791: 49). For him the fact that “our best speakers” use [n] appears to follow logically from the allegedly auditorily displeasing succession of two similar syllables he perceives in this sequence. That it might be the other way around does not occur to him, or at least he does not admit that his perception could stem from actual general use of alveolar variants in the “best speakers”. Walker’s third and fourth editions (1798, 1806) maintain the same distinction. The latter was the last London edition published before his death in 1807. It is curious however that all of his examples have *-ing* plus *-ing*. Despite the fact that he claims the repetition of the “ringing sound” to be the main issue, it appears that it is the repetition of the entire syllable that is the problem. He does not give any examples like *hanging* or *bang-ing*, where [ŋ] would also precede [ɪŋ]. In contrast to Walker, Murray does not provide an aesthetic argument in favour of [n] but he agrees with Walker’s proposed distribution of [n] and [ŋ] in *-ing*, at least in the first edition of his *English Grammar*. Murray (1795: 9) prescribes the alveolar variant in post-/ɪŋ/ environments and the velar variant in all other cases: “[t]he participial *ing* must always

¹Recent sociolinguistic studies have focussed mostly on other factors than formality such as the social meaning and perception of [ɪŋ] or the acquisition of variation (see for instance Campbell-Kibler 2011a, 2011b; Schlee et al. 2011; Levon & Fox 2014; Forrest & Wolfram 2019).

have its ringing sound; as, writing, reading, speaking; except it be preceded by *ing*; as, singing, bringing, swinging; when it must be pronounced *in*; as, singin, bringin, swingin". Evidence that the term "ringing sound" meant [ŋ] can be found in rhymes. Walker (1791: 49) suggests: "I can assert, that our best speakers do not invariably pronounce the participle *ing*, so as to rhyme with *sing*, *king* and *wing*". Furthermore, Walker's and Murray's respellings, e.g. *sing in* or *singin* indicate an alveolar variant (see also Beal 2004b: 160–161; Yáñez-Bouza & Nieves-Fernández 2023: 64–66). Unfortunately for us, Walker does not list participle forms in his dictionary but he does include the word *singingmaster*. This we should expect to have [n] in the coda of the second syllable following his logic. Nonetheless, it is transcribed with "ng", i.e. his "dento-guttural or nasal ng" (Walker 1791: 5), in both syllables; hence, he seems to contradict his earlier claims. This transcription of *singingmaster* he also employs in the second, third and fourth editions of his dictionary.

Walker (1791, 1797, 1798, 1806) and Murray (1795) both seem to propose a *horror æqui* argument here. On the grammatical level English has a double *-ing* constraint and cases where verbs ending in *-ing* are immediately followed by another *-ing* form are rare (see Vosberg 2003). An example of this would be a sentence like *They're attempting riding the horses*, where *ride* would usually occur in the infinitive rather than as a gerund. In Walker's dictionary, and Murray's first edition, a similar constraint is suggested for the pronunciation of the ending. This has, to my knowledge, never existed on the phonological level for *-ing*. The only comparable example in English is perhaps that a word like *friendlily* (also sometimes spelt *friendlyly*, OED: s.v. *friendlyly* adv.), where the sequence *-ly* is immediately followed by the same syllable through derivation, is less frequent than its counterpart *in a friendly manner*.² Still, it appears to me that the *-ing* rule in Walker (1791, 1797, 1798, 1806) and Murray (1795) is likely made-up in order to condone alveolar uses in speakers other than the lower classes and thus escape the dilemma that some of his model speakers were using variants he himself as well as other elocutionists disapproved of. The other option is that it was a way to simply make a feature orthoëpists and grammarians were familiar with but which was stigmatised seem rule-governed on aesthetic grounds. Creating this compromise distribution might as well have been an attempt at reallocating variation between alveolar and velar variants to a very specific phonological environment. De Vos & van der Meulen (2024: 302) regard this as a different way

²I did a sample search in the COHA and the *Corpus of Contemporary American English* (COCA; Davies 2008–) and in both *in a friendly manner* was considerably more frequent than *friendlily*. In the COHA *friendlily* occurs 20 times and *in a friendly manner* 69 times. The COCA returns one hit for the former and 45 for the latter.

of evaluating variation to efforts of suppressing it altogether. Inventing rules, or even entire forms, is also attested in codifying works of other languages. For instance, de Vos (2022) finds artificial forms of third person pronouns for Early Modern Dutch which do not correspond to actual language use but were created by grammarians.

However, interestingly, with Murray there is a change in his later editions. In the third edition of his grammar he observes that “[s]ome writers [sc. including himself, two years earlier] have supposed that when *ing* is preceded by *in*, it should be pronounced *in*; as, singing, bringing, should be sounded *singin*, *bringin*” (Murray 1797: 13). He then argues against this realisations based on the goal of maintaining sound-spelling correspondence: “but as it is a good rule, with respect to pronunciation, to adhere to the written words, unless custom has clearly decided otherwise, it does not seem proper to adopt this innovation” (Murray 1797: 13).

By 1797 the variant had thus attracted the criticism of influential scholars like Murray. In fact, Mugglestone (2007: 130) suggests that “from its beginnings in the polite usage of the mid-eighteenth century, the use of [m] and, in turn, <in’> had, a century later, emerged as a well-attested linguistic stereotype of the ‘vulgar’ and the lower echelons of society”. This I take to represent the third case outlined above. Bearing in mind what we saw earlier, this means that [m] coexisted in the speech of the upper class and aristocracy and lower social classes throughout the nineteenth century. The major difference however in this case is the evaluation of its use. Figure 11.2 from *Punch Magazine* shows this nicely. While this is a caricature, it illustrates that the alveolar nasal was associated with working-class occupations such as “stable-boy” and “laundry-maid” as well as dukes and duchesses. We should nonetheless be cautious not to interpret this coexistence as a deterministic distribution. The [m] variant and its graphemic representation <in’> was also frequently employed to depict working-class speakers in literary works in the nineteenth century. Mugglestone (2007: 130) lists Dickens, Gissing, Gaskell, Thackeray, Eliot, Reade, and others that use <in’> spellings to negatively depict characters that deviate from linguistic norms. This was often referred to as “g-dropping” or “dropping the g” in LModE sources (see Beal 2004b: 160–161; Mugglestone 2007: 129), and this term can still be heard by non-linguists today to refer to alveolar realisations of *-ing*. Respellings indicating alveolar *-ing* realisations can equally be found in US-American sources to depict different types characterological figures such as Black speakers or mountaineers (see Paulsen 2022: 290).

The next case concerns hypercorrect variants such as [ˈrɪbɪŋ] for *ribbon*, graphemically represented as *ribbing*, or the like. Similar to [m] and /h/-insertion,



“EVIL COMMUNICATIONS,” &c.

Lord Reginald. “AIN’T YER GOIN’ TO HAVE SOME PUDDIN’, MISS RICHARDS? IT’S SO JOLLY!”

The Governess. “THERE AGAIN, REGINALD! ‘PUDDIN’—‘GOIN’—‘AIN’T YER’!!! THAT’S THE WAY JIM BATES AND DOLLY MAPLE SPEAK—AND JIM’S A STABLE-BOY, AND DOLLY’S A LAUNDRY-MAID!”

Lord Reginald. “AH! BUT THAT’S THE WAY FATHER AND MOTHER SPEAK, TOO—AND FATHER’S A DUKE, AND MOTHER’S A DUCHESS!! SO THERE!”

Figure 11.2: “Evil communications,” & c., taken from *Punch Magazine* (6 September, 1873: 99) and reproduced with permission from Punch Cartoon Library/TopFoto.

hypercorrect variants of words not containing *-ing* were used to mark literary characters as belonging to the lower classes. One of Mugglestone's (2007: 131) examples is the character of Thomas Bilder in Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), who is a zoo-keeper and uses forms such as *garding* 'garden', or *certing* 'certain'. Krapp (1919: 114) also lists these variants for the US but describes them as dialectal uses: "[a] final unstressed [n] is sometimes pronounced [ŋ] in dialect speech, as in kitchen ['kɪtʃɪŋ], chicken ['tʃɪkɪŋ], garden ['gɑːdn̩], etc., so also facetiously in heavens ['heɪvɪnz] [...]".

The fifth and final case is what has been referred to as "velar-nasal plus" (see Wells 1982: 365), i.e. a velar nasal to which a voiceless or voiced velar plosive is added. This can be differentiated further into the historical variant [ŋɡ] and unetymological [ŋk].³ There was, and still is, regional variation with respect to both types. Historically, the [ŋɡ] variant used to be present in the termination *-ing* especially in gerunds (see the discussion on the different etymologies of the present participle and gerunds above). Lass (1999: 120) points to reports of words like *hanging* and *singing* maintaining /g/ well into the eighteenth century but only in the coda of the base not in word-final position, e.g. in Elphinston (1765). In the first half of the nineteenth century, Smart (1836: xxxii) writes that "it is only in the north-western counties [...] there the *g* is articulated and added to the element described, (*ring-g*, *long-g*, & c.,) but this is not the general usage". In PDE, it has also been reported in the North-West and western Midlands of England in areas such as Birmingham, Manchester and Liverpool in mono-morphemic words like *king* and *wrong* and participle endings (see Hughes et al. 2012: 68; Bailey 2019).

As concerns [ŋk], this is regarded as a typical Cockney form. This is mainly a lexicalised variant in words like *anything*. For England Jones (1964 [1918]: 172) still evaluates this Cockney pronunciation of *-thing* words negatively as "the substitution of ŋk for ŋ in *nothing*, *something*, *anything* [...] found in London dialect (Cockney) [...] is not considered a desirable pronunciation". In Cockney speakers words like *nothing* or *anything* may still contain the voiceless plosive [k] in addition to the velar nasal today (Hughes et al. 2012: 68, 77). Furthermore, Schleef et al. (2011: 215) found that adolescents born in London generally still use [ŋk] for *-ing*, albeit very infrequently. Jones (1964 [1918]: 172) furthermore observes the velar nasal plus with a devoiced final consonant in German speakers of English, who he observes to confuse words such as *sing* and *sink*.

³Velar nasal plus realisations in final position are also common beyond English, e.g. in dialects of northern Germany, where words like *Ahnung* 'hunch, idea' or *entlang* 'along' may be realised with final [ŋk] (see Kleiner 2011– under "Velare Verschlusslösung bei <ng> im Auslaut und vor /l/").

Regarding North America, Krapp (1919: 114) notes the presence of the feature with a voiceless plosive in American dialects: “[a] final [ŋ] sometimes becomes [k] in dialect speech, as nothing [ˈnʌθɪŋk], singing [ˈsɪŋɪŋk] anything [ˈɛniːθɪŋk] [...] pronunciations like [ˈkɪŋk] for king may even be heard”. However, he further remarks that this variant occurs in America “chiefly in the larger cities and in speakers of foreign birth or tradition”. Therefore, the variant [ŋg] was the typical north-western and West Midland variant, whereas [ɪŋk] was used by non-native speakers in the British-Irish Isles and North America alike and in London (more specifically Cockney) speech but mainly in *-thing* words.

In the following sections I analyse to what extent alveolar nasals as the final sound in *-ing* endings, as well as other non-standard variants, are stigmatised. For those grammars that clearly show negative evaluations, I further discuss the likelihood of aristocratic usage of alveolar variants in the nineteenth century. I furthermore examine if any of the grammars in the CNG contain comments on (potentially made-up) distributions like those suggested by Walker. If so, I am interested in whether they argue in favour or against it and whether they do so by means of copying verbatim from Walker, Murray or other eighteenth-century orthoëpists and grammarians.

11.2 *-ing* in the CNG: Overview

In total, my data show 21 mentions (13% of grammars that contain sufficient information on pronunciation) of any of the five different cases explained above. Which feature can be found in which grammar is illustrated in Table 11.1. Grammars are ordered chronologically and based on region (North American grammars are given an asterisk in the table). The two earliest comments on the alveolar nasal come from Morgan (1814) and Andrew (1817). Differences in the social class ascribed to speakers’ use of the alveolar variant are not specifically differentiated in the table for the simple reason that there are no explicit evaluations of [ɪn] as an aristocratic or upper-class variant. One grammar, namely Gow (1892), implicitly hints at this connection through a comment on the use of the variant in the West End of London (see Section 11.3). There are two more neutral description of the feature without any evaluation of its socio-economic distribution, namely Morgan (1814) and Tancock (1878). With the exception of these three grammars, the remaining grammars that mention [ɪn] demonstrate the high degree of stigma attached to the variant by means of prescriptions and proscriptions (10 times), Social Evaluations (8 times), including examples of dialectal use (4 times), and its identification as a Mistake (4 times). Evaluative terms used for alveolar realisations of *-ing* are summarised in Figure 11.3.

11 Realisations of *-ing*

Table 11.1: Variants mentioned for *-ing* in the CNG, ordered chronologically and by place of publication

grammar	region	alveolar nasal	post-/ɪŋ/ environment	hypercorrect variants	velar nasal plus
Andrew (1817)	British-Irish	✓	✓	—	—
Leigh (1840)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	—
Turner (1840)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	—
Turner (1843)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	—
M'Mullen (1860)	British-Irish	—	—	—	✓
Lowres (1863)	British-Irish	✓	—	✓	✓
Cobbin (1864)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	✓
Higginson (1864)	British-Irish	—	—	—	✓
Tancock (1878)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	—
Fleay (1884)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	—
Gow (1892)	British-Irish	✓	—	—	—
Morgan (1814)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Fisk (1822)*	North American	✓	✓	—	—
Kirkham (1834)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Sanborn (1840)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Swett (1844)*	North American	✓	✓	—	—
Brown (1851)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Fowler (1855)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Brown (1857)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Ridpath (1881)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
Hyde (1895)*	North American	✓	—	—	—
total:	—	19	3	1	4

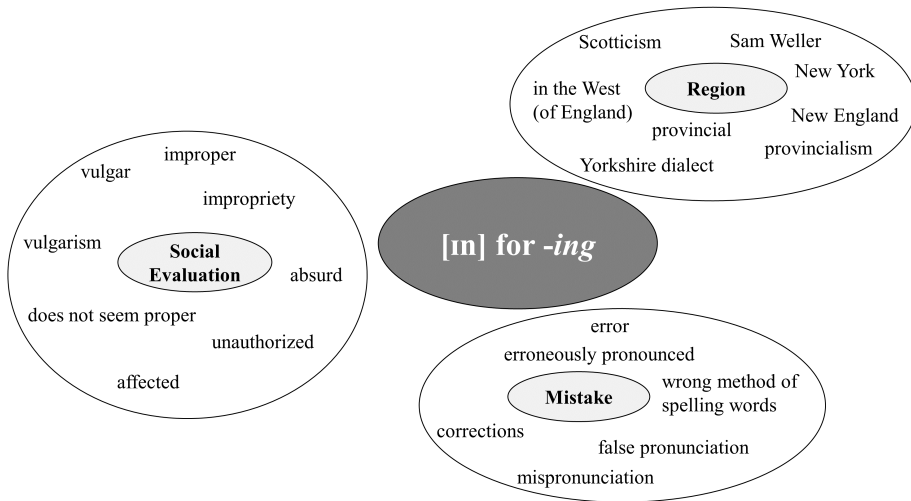


Figure 11.3: Evaluative terms used for [ɪn] for *-ing* in the CNG, sorted by category

A potential difference between post-/ɪn/ and other environments is discussed in three grammars, namely Andrew (1817), Fisk (1822) and Swett (1844). The first follows Walker's (1791) argument while the latter two are heavily based on Murray's (1797) third (or later) edition and thus argue against making a difference between post-/ɪn/ environments and other cases. Lowres (1863) is the only grammar that mentions hypercorrect forms and unsurprisingly criticises its use. Four grammars contain remarks on velar nasal plus variants, of which all were published in London. This is also unsurprising as this is a characteristically British feature, although in North America the variant with final [k] existed but was mainly associated with non-native speakers of English. Based on absolute numbers, there is no obvious difference between places of publication (11 British-Irish, 10 North American). Furthermore, even relatively speaking the differences can be disregarded as 15% of North American and 11% of British-Irish grammars mention the feature. None of the Scottish, Irish, or Canadian grammars in the CNG mention any of the cases discussed above. M'Mullen (1860) is the only example that was, in addition to England, also published in Scotland, and Ireland.

As concerns its chronology, discussions concerning [ɪn] occur throughout the century. Post-/ɪn/ environments are mentioned only in the first half of the century, which could be explained in terms of chronological closeness to Murray and Walker. Velar nasal plus and hypercorrect variants are treated only in grammars from the 1860s. However, given the low absolute numbers for all variants

except the alveolar nasal, the distribution does not warrant any sophisticated conclusions.

11.3 Alveolar realisations

As previously mentioned, passages in which [m] is specifically identified as an upper-class variant or is stigmatised as specifically aristocratic in use are absent in the CNG. There is one grammar in which this connection is potentially made, albeit implicitly, namely Gow (1892: 22). His grammar comes close to a modern scholarly work, as passages from his grammar discussed in previous sections have already shown. Regarding the sound-spelling correspondence of English, Gow (1892: 22) observes: “[t]he spelling of English has been almost fixed for the last 200 years, while the pronunciation of the language has been gradually changing”. According to him, “[i]t is easy to watch such changes. For instance— (1) It is now common in the West End of London to pronounce *ng* as *n* at the end of words, e.g. to say *somethin*, *askin*, for *something*, *asking*”. He even hypothesises about the future distribution of this variant and suggests that “[t]his change may become general”. The fact that he ascribes this feature to speakers in the West of London could signal an association with upper-class speakers given the affluent status of parts of the West End. St. James’ palace as well as many gentlemen’s clubs are located in the area. While the West End is and was the theatre district and working class actors also resided there, the West is stereotypically associated with upper-class speakers through, for instance, the gentlemen’s clubs. It is very likely that comments like this are not about the actual socio-economic make-up of the area but rather about cultural associations, where the West End was clearly one of upper-class gentlemen. According to the OED, the West End denoted “The fashionable or wealthy quarter of a town or other place” already in the nineteenth century, while it could also refer to “the theatres and entertainment industry of the West End considered collectively” (OED: s.v. *west end* n. 2.b.ii & 2.c). Yet, if Gow had wanted to invoke working-class associations, the East End would have been more appropriate to achieve that effect. Therefore, Gow (1892) likely connects the alveolar nasal with upper-class and aristocratic circles although this is not made explicit. The grammars in the CNG therefore only provide implicit evidence for aristocratic and upper-class usage of [n] in *-ing*.

There are two more neutral accounts of the [n] variant, in which, however, there is no information on its social stratification. Morgan (1814: 20), published in North America, observes alveolar realisations for *-ing* but discards this feature as unlikely to become widespread: “[i]n the termination *ing*, in the participles,

some reject the *g*, in sound. But this custom has not, and probably will not, gain sufficient ground, to require further notice". While there is no overt negative evaluation of the feature as such, Morgan easily discards it as not worthy of his attention. In Tancock (1878: 2), published in Britain, we find evidence of the variant, but it does not appear to play an important role. The section in which the variant is used is intended to demonstrate that different dialects of English mainly differ in pronunciation and still exhibit enough similarities to regard them as the same language. The alveolar nasal is portrayed as part of the Sussex dialect in the following example sentence: "Stay me wud drinkin pots, comfort me wud appuls, for I be sick wud love. (Sussex.) [...]". However, it solely serves illustrative purposes and no evaluation or description is added to this line.

Moreover, there are six grammars in which either [ɱ] is prescribed or [m] is proscribed without any further value judgments or exceptions such as post-/ɱ/ environments. British-Irish sources are illustrated in (1)–(3) and North American grammars in (4)–(6). With respect to the social status of the speakers using the alveolar variant, it is possible that these grammarians either had upper- or lower-class speakers in mind.

- (1) The latter sound [sc. the ringing sound of *ng*] should be carefully preserved in all words ending in *ing*, and in such others as require it. (Turner 1840: 235)
- (2) USEFUL HINTS. 1. Be careful to give all words, ending in *ing* the ringing sound, as, *reading*, not readin; *pudding*, not puddin; *parsing*, not parsin; *writing*, not writin; *morning*, not mornin. (Turner 1843: 84)
- (3) CAUTIONS [...] 6. Be careful that the participial termination *ing* be not sounded in [...] EXAMPLES. Speaking should not be pronounced speakin. Writing [sc. should not be pronounced] writin. (Lowres 1863: 63–64)
- (4) 82. *Ing* should always have its ringing sound; as, in running, walking. (Sanborn 1840: 13)
- (5) The latter sound [sc. the ringing sound of *ng*] should be carefully preserved in all words ending in *ing*; and in such others as require it. (Brown 1857: 315)
- (6) PRONOUNCING EXERCISE. *Pronounce*: — [Do not omit the sound of final *g*.] *reading*, *stopping*, *going*, *smoking*, *singing*, *touching*, *coming*, *being*, *talking*, *seeing*, *wishing*, *doing*, *walking*, *hearing*, *burning*, *trying*, *calling*, *looking*, *standing*, *spelling*. (Hyde 1895: 118)

In addition to prescriptions, proscriptions, the absence of differences between places of publication, and no further value judgements, two things are noticeable here. When looking at these examples it becomes clear that Turner (1840) and Brown (1857) clearly copied from the same source. Brown's grammar was first published in 1823 and I have not been able to find any earlier grammar or pronouncing dictionary that contains this exact wording. Thus, it likely goes back to earlier editions of Brown and Turner probably copied from any of Brown's grammars, as I have also shown in previous sections for other features.

Moreover, except Hyde (1895) and Lowres (1863), all of the grammars in (1)-(6) refer to [ŋ] as "the ringing sound", a term that we can find in eighteenth-century dictionary and grammar writers. It is not entirely clear in Hyde whether omitting "the sound of final g" refers to not pronouncing a plosive after the velar nasal or to replacing [ŋ] with [n]. As previously stated, the latter process was and is still sometimes referred to as "dropping the g". I argue that it is more likely to be a proscription of [n] rather than a categorical prescription of a velar nasal plus.

Cases in which the lexeme to which *-ing* is attached already has *-ing* are treated in three grammars. Two of these were published in North America and one in England. The first of these is Andrew (1817), published in London, who proscribes the ending *-in* as a general rule: "[t]he participial termination *ing* ought never to be read *in*" but follows Walker's argument by adding "unless it be preceded by another *ing*; thus we say, *speaking*, *writing*, not *speakin'*, *writin'*; and *bringin'*, *singin'*, not *bringing*, *singing*". The other two examples, namely Fisk (1822: 40) and Swett (1844: 173), are based on Murray and copy verbatim from his 1797 (or later) edition: "[t]he participial *ing* must always have its ringing sound; as writing, reading, speaking. Some writers have supposed that when *ing* is preceded by *ing* it should be pronounced *in*; as singing, bringing, should be sounded *singin*, *bringin*". The only difference between the two is that Fisk continues his passage by sticking to Murray's wording: "but, as it is a good rule with respect to pronunciation, to adhere to the written words, unless custom has clearly decided otherwise, it does not seem seem [sic!] proper to adopt this innovation" (Fisk 1822: 40). In contrast, Swett (1844: 173) simply states "but this practice is unauthorized and absurd". As they are based on Murray, Swett's and Fisk's grammars include prescriptions, i.e. "must always have its ringing sound" and a social evaluation of [m], i.e. "not [...] proper" and "unauthorized and absurd". Therefore, it is only in the earliest of these three grammars and in the only British-Irish grammar that Walker's phonological *horror aequi* argument is used.

As concerns negative social evaluations in the context of alveolar variants in the CNG, more North American grammars provide evidence (2 British-Irish, 6 North American). These include the two North American grammars by Fisk

(1822) and Swett (1844), which have been discussed in the context of copies from Murray's grammar.

The two British-Irish grammars are by Cobbin (1864) and Fleay (1884) and were both published in London. Cobbin (1864: 83) mentions the use of an alveolar nasal variant in the West of England, and it, at least at first glance, does not appear to be decidedly stigmatised: "In the West, people often cut off the *g* from *nothing*, & *c*". However, the use of *cut off* could imply a negative evaluation because of the register difference to the rest of the passage, or its meaning of removing something from its main part. However, the entire passage is listed under "General Caution [...] V. Beware of vulgar provincial pronunciation". He furthermore writes that "the *ing* should have a ringing sound". While he does not explicitly say that he means the West of England by his statement, it is very likely as he immediately after that adds "in London, they add a *k* [...] *nothink*" and also discusses Yorkshire and Lancashire realisations. If he had wanted to distinguish different parts of London he would not have simply mentioned London and other parts of England. As using [m] for *-ing* is a widespread feature, occurrences in the West of England as a whole (potentially alongside velar nasal plus variants in some regions) are very likely.

In Fleay (1884: 86) too, similar to Andrew (1817), Murray (1795), and Walker (1791), the use of [m] in the second syllable of words like *singing* is stigmatised. However, despite the fact that *singing* is the example he uses, his passage does not only concern post-/ɪŋ/ environments. His criticism is generally directed at the use of [m] in unaccented syllables. According to Fleay (1884: 86), changing the final sound of *-ing* to [n] is considered a "corruption" and occurs in "affected" or "vulgar" pronunciation. For him it is equally as problematic as not pronouncing a post-vocalic /r/ and the WHICH-WITCH merger as shown in the following passage, which we have already encountered in previous sections:

Wh and *Gh* are frequently corrupted into *w* and *y* in affected or vulgar pronunciation; *Ng* in unaccented syllables in like manner becomes *n*, and *R* after a vowel is dropped. Thus we often hear *wen*, *singin*, *fahther*, for *when*, *singing*, *farther*.

"Affected" could also mean pretending to be of a different class and thus Fleay could be frowning upon what he perceives as an exaggerated pronunciation employed by speakers in an effort to climb socially. It is noteworthy however that, with the exception of [n] in *-ing*, all the other features he mentions indeed became the standard in England and comments like this could constitute an attempt to

slow down or stop variants rising in overt prestige from becoming the dominant variant.

Regarding social evaluations found in North American grammars, in Kirkham (1834: 206), [n] for [ŋ] can be found in the sections “Corrections in Orthoepey” as well as “Provincialisms”. In the former of the two sections Kirkham mentions *gone* as well as *goin* as “improper” pronunciations of *going*. Following his vowel overview, these “improper” forms are realised as [go:n] and [go:m]. Furthermore, the word *jesting* can be found in this section, the “wrong” pronunciation of the last syllable being [ɪn]. The section on provincialisms with the subtitle “contractions, vulgarisms, and other improprieties” includes the dialect spellings <goin>, <geestin>, and <jokin> as incorrect New England and New York variants. Kirkham mixes grammatical as well as phonological features in this section as the syntactic environment in which these graphemes are used are “I be goin”, “I mer goin” and “nither geestin nor jokin”. However, the corrected versions he proposes all include final <g>, except *jokin*, which is omitted altogether in the “correct” column of the section. Thus, [n] in *-ing* is not only considered wrong by Kirkham but furthermore “vulgar” and dialectal.

Brown (1851: 1006) also prescribes [ŋ]: “[t]he latter sound [sc. the ringing sound of *ng*] should be carefully preserved in all words ending in *ing*, and in such others as require it”. The wording is similar to that of his later grammar from 1857 (Brown 1857: 315). However, in his 1851 grammar he still adds value judgements. The alveolar variant is criticised as “vulgar” in spoken language and evaluated as dialectal, in this case Scottish, in written language: “The sounding of the syllable *ing* as if it were *in*, is a vulgarism in utterance; and the writing of it so, is, as it would seem by the usage of Burns, a Scotticism” (Brown 1851: 1006). Bann & Corbett (2015: 25) indeed note that especially in earlier Older Scots, i.e. the period up to 1700, *-ing* would have largely been used for verbal nouns (as used to be the case in English) and often represented /m/ phonologically. They cite the example *singin* from *Peblis to the Play*. While Robert Burns, who is referred to here by Brown, was born in 1759 and thus after the Older Scots period, Jones (1997: 328) also notes [n] in *-ing* for eighteenth-century Scots.

In Fowler (1855: 112) [n] is used under the heading “SPECIMEN OF THE YORKSHIRE DIALECT” in the chapter “DIALECTS AND PROVINCIALISMS”. He writes: “[h]ere we have *Ah* for *I*; *sudn’t* for *should not*; *bud* for *but*; *foak* for *folk*; *o’* for *of*; *startin’* for *starting* [...]”. However, this is the only dialect for which he mentions this variant. Further on in his grammar he discusses potential mistakes under the heading “ORTHOEPY IN RESPECT TO THE PHONETIC ELEMENTS”. One mistake he mentions is substituting the velar nasal with an alveolar nasal: “[a] third error is the substitution of one element for another, as *think-in* for *think-ing*, *sinks*

for *shrinks*” (Fowler 1855: 189). He therefore considers the feature provincial and dialectal and evidently as a mistake.

In Ridpath (1881: 304) we can find information on pronunciations that are regarded as wrong under “Figures of Orthography” and more specifically “mimesis” which he describes as “[t]he spelling of words in imitation of a false pronunciation”. We have already seen this example in the previous section. Ridpath references Dickens’ famous Cockney character Sam Weller and his father from *The Pinwick Papers*: “1. ‘Vell, I think it is *rayther* good,’ said Sam. 2. ‘Wot I like in that *’ere writin*,” said Mr. Weller, ‘is that there *a’n’t* no *Wenuses* in it’”. The alveolar variant is identified as typically used by working-class speakers through association with Mr Weller, Sam Weller’s father, and regarded as an error. As previously noted, it could very well be the case that Ridpath does not have any first-hand knowledge of or experience with a Cockney accent and simply reproduces this stigma due to associations with literary characters. This illustrates Mugglestone’s (2007: 131) observation that this variant, together with other stigmatised features, was often employed in literary works. Moreover, it shows that this was easily taken up by grammarians and thus further perpetuated.

The only grammarian who has not been discussed and whose comments on *-ing* can also be added to the category Mistake is Leigh (1840). In his grammar we can find graphemic representations of the alveolar variant in his sections on comic orthography and comic spelling which we have come across in several of the previous sections and are clearly designed to teach students by means of bad example. While Leigh’s sections contain constructed examples, they are supposed to represent what he considers wrong variants. The two passages shown in (7) and (8) contain <in> spellings in the following words: *sitting*, *falling*, *getting*, *nothing*, *making*, *being*, *popping*.

- (7) Comic Orthography:- [...] we was *sittin* by the window and we was wery Neer *fallin* Out [...] and am *gettin* wus and wus witch i Think yu ort to pittty Mee. i am Tolloed every Day that ime *Gettin* Thinner and a Jipsy sed that *nothin* wood Cure me But a Ring. i was a Long time *makin* my Mind Up to right to You for of Coarse i Says jemes will think me too forrad but this *bein* Leep yere i thout ide Make a Plunge speshially as her grashius madjesty as Set the Exampel of *Popin* the queshton [...] (Leigh 1840: 17, my emphasis)
- (8) Comic spelling [...] i was in the habbet of *Gettin* whet feet Every Night by pumping water out of a Celler [...] i have Bin in the habbet of Getting wet when traviling (Leigh 1840: 29–30, my emphasis)

However, in (8) *getting* appears with as well as without <g>, and the words *travelling* and *pumping* are both represented with <g>. This could indicate variation but could at the same time be employed to represent inconsistency in the realisation of -ing in speakers he is ridiculing. Yet, in the same *traviling* he also uses eye dialect for the vowels.

Qualitatively, there is no systematic difference between North American and British-Irish grammars in negative social evaluations of alveolar nasals, also given the fact that only two British-Irish grammars provide social evaluations in the first place. References to dialectal use as well as terms like “vulgar” appear in grammars from both regions. However, except in Kirkham’s example where it is identified as a New York and New England feature, the dialectal references in North American grammars are to dialects from the British-Irish Isles, i.e. Yorkshire, Cockney, and Scottish, rather than to the British in general or to other North American dialects. This is different to the case of /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion where it is only considered to be typical of Londoners and Cockneys. Given the low number of examples, the reference to British dialects in North American grammars is unlikely to represent a general association of the feature with Britishness. Another reason why the results from the CNG are unlikely to represent a connection solely to Britishness is that many Americans were familiar with the feature also in American dialects and dialect representations of non-standard American speakers in novels and newspapers.

11.4 Hypercorrect variants and velar nasal plus

Reference to hypercorrect forms can only be found once in the CNG. Lowres (1863: 63–64) advises his readers to “[b]e careful that the participial termination *ing* be not sounded *in*, nor the termination *en* as *ing*”. He gives the following examples: “Speaking should not be pronounced speakin[.] Writing [sc. should not be pronounced] writin. Nor Garden as if it were written garding[.] Warden [sc. as if it were written] warding”. In Lowres’ grammar we furthermore find one of four references to the velar nasal plus in the CNG. In the same section in which he treats *garding* and *warding*, he cautions his readers: “[b]e careful to avoid pronouncing words ending in *ing* as if they ended in *k*. EXAMPLES. Nothing should not be pronounced nothink[.] Anything [sc. should not be pronounced] anythink”. Therefore, according to Lowres, the only possible variant for the suffix -ing is the velar nasal. However, he solely mentions variants ending in [k] and only gives *nothing* and *anything* as examples. A voiceless plosive in final position of words like *nothing*, *anything*, or *something* are typical realisations of

Cockney speakers. Nevertheless, he does not add any further value judgments or references to the regional and social distributions of the feature. His grammar thus differs from the other three examples of velar nasal plus variants in the CNG, which all contain social evaluations and identify the feature as particular of a specific region or dialect. Yet, all the four grammars that treat the velar nasal plus advise against using this variant. Moreover, they are from the 1860s and are all British-Irish grammars. One grammar, namely M'Mullen (1860), was published in England, Ireland, and Scotland. He remarks under the section on nouns that "[t]he word *thing* is by some supposed to be another form of *think*. It appears in that shape in the vulgar pronunciation of something, nothing—'somethink,' 'nothink'" (M'Mullen 1860: 3).

In Cobbin's (1864: 83) grammar the velar nasal plus variants are identified as dialectal usage in London, Yorkshire and Lancashire. For London Cobbin mentions the variant [ɪŋk] and evaluates it as "barbarous" and a "defect". In the case of Yorkshire and Lancashire it is likely [ɪŋg], which is seemingly regarded as less bad but still presented as a form that should be avoided: "in London, they add a *k*: the former [sc. people in the West] say, *nothin*, and the latter *nothink* the latter specimen is barbarous. The Yorkshire and Lancashire dialects have also nearly the latter defect". His use of the word "nearly" to refer to the Yorkshire and Lancashire variant could be interpreted as lacking devoicing characteristically present in the London variant; hence [nʌθɪŋg]. He ends the passage with a prescription of the velar nasal: "the *ing* should have a ringing sound". As previously noted, *-in* at the beginning of the passage does not specifically receive an evaluation. Yet, it is clear from the prescription at the end that a velar nasal is the preferred variant out of all possible variants for Cobbin.

Higginson (1864: 10) explains the velar pronunciation of *-ng* as follows: "Ng combined, have only part of the sound of *n* and part of the sound of hard *g*; sing, sang, sung, ring, & c". However, he adds "[i]t is a vulgar provincialism of the midland counties to pronounce the *g* strongly in this combination". He implies pronunciations such as [sɪŋg], [rɪŋg] for *sing* and *ring* and classifies them as "vulgar", "provincial" and occurring in the Midlands, where we would still find these pronunciations today. It is also worth noting that the examples that these grammarians employ are, with the exception of Higginson, lexically restricted to words like *nothing*, *anything*, *something*, regardless of whether they are generally criticised or not and irrespective of which region they refer to. There are no examples in the CNG where velar nasal plus variants of *-ing* are identified in participle or nominalised forms. The regional distribution these grammars suggest, i.e. [ɪŋk] for London and [ɪŋg] in the Midlands and the North, corresponds to traditional dialects (see Wells 1982: 365).

11.5 *-ing*: Summary

In sum, North American grammars mention any of the non-[ɪŋ] cases outlined above more frequently than British-Irish grammars. None of the grammars counted as Irish, Scottish, or Canadian provide evidence for any of the variants. Furthermore, there is no grammar in the CNG that provides any proper evidence on aristocratic uses of [ɪŋ]. The only grammar which could potentially be read as referring to upper-class speakers in the West End of London is Gow (1892), who generally gives a neutral evaluation of the variant. If we interpret Fleay's (1884) use of "affected" as pretending to be of a higher class, this could at least be evidence for an association with the upper class. The absence of references to the aristocracy in the context of *-ing* can have multiple reasons. Grammarians potentially included more general evaluations and prescriptions because they shunned the feature, regardless of who used it, potentially also because they themselves were middle-class speakers. Aristocratic and upper-class uses might simply not have been relevant to the grammarians and their readership as mentioned in Section 11.1. This then seems to reflect the rising degree of stigma attached to this variant in the nineteenth century.

A phonotactic restriction resulting from a phonological *horror aequi* argument, which is retractable to Walker, is mentioned in three grammars, namely Andrew (1817) published in London and the two North American grammars Fisk (1822) and Swett (1844). Nonetheless, it is only regarded as correct in Andrew's (1817) grammar. Fisk (1822) and Swett (1844) both argue against it, albeit through verbatim copies from Murray's third or later edition. I have argued that this rule suggested by Walker (1791) and Andrew (1817) is a made-up rule and can be interpreted not as a flat-out suppression of variation but as a reallocation. Apart from these two grammars, I have not found any evidence that suggests word-for-word copying from Walker or other eighteenth-century orthoëpists or grammarians.

Concerning evaluations of alveolar realisations, regardless of phonological context, relatively more North American grammars contain any comments. There are two neutral accounts, namely Morgan (1814) and Tancock (1878). Except these two and Gow (1892), all other comments on any of the different variants outlined in Section 11.1 evidently show its stigmatisation. These negative evaluations mostly come in simple prescriptions and proscriptions and social evaluations. There are, however, only two British-Irish grammars that provide social evaluations. Furthermore, alveolar nasals are regarded as dialect features in both regions. Nonetheless, in North American grammars, the feature is identified mainly as a British feature, i.e. as Yorkshire, Cockney or Scottish, and only once as a New York or New England feature. Irrespective of the place

of publication, alveolar nasals in *-ing* are criticised as “vulgar”, “provincial”, “improper” or simply as mistakes. Despite the fact that most dialectal references in North American grammars are to British varieties, I have argued that this hardly constitutes evidence for associations between alveolar nasals and Britishness in nineteenth-century North America.

It is in only four grammars (Cobbin 1864; Lowres 1863; Higginson 1864; M’Mullen 1860) that comments on velar nasal plus variants can be found, of which one, namely Lowres (1863) also mentions hypercorrect forms, which he evaluates negatively. Velar nasal plus variants are clearly stigmatised and are only mentioned in the British-Irish grammars, which makes sense as this is a characteristically British feature. Cobbin (1864) and Higginson (1864) regard them as a dialectal feature and describe the distribution of the devoiced and voiced variants [ɪŋk] and [ɪŋg] similarly to what we would expect based on evidence from traditional dialects: voiceless variants occur in London, while voiced variants are used in the Midlands, Yorkshire, and Lancashire. Except in Higginson’s grammar, only examples like *anything* or *nothing* are given, which is at least typical of the feature in traditional London dialects but not the North-West. The increasing degree of stigmatisation of [ɪn], and in fact of all non-standard variants, is thus clearly visible in the grammars of the CNG, whereas explicit references to aristocratic use and phonotactically restricted distributions are largely absent.

Part III

Global summary, discussion, and conclusions

12 Research questions recapped

After I have discussed my findings on changes and variation in a number of different phonological variables based on comments in nineteenth-century grammars of English, I now return to my research questions outlined in Section 2.4, which I have for convenience summarised again below. The present and final part of this book is therefore structured as follows: Chapter 13 concerns research questions i–iii and is feature-oriented in its approach. Each research question is discussed separately and receives a dedicated section. In each section I provide a short summary of my results for the respective research question and then move on to discuss the overall trends and their implications. I depart from the order allocated to the phonological features in Part II and instead move from the most frequently mentioned to the least in Section 13.1, start with the most surprising results in Section 13.2 and commence with the most stigmatised variants in Section 13.3.

In Chapter 14, I zoom out and evaluate general observations in terminology, approaches, structure, and genre across grammars to judge their potential as future research material (research questions iv and v). Again, every question is discussed in a separate section (Sections 14.1 and 14.2). Finally, I summarise the significance of my findings for my overarching question which concerns the extent to which nineteenth-century grammars can be taken as historical evidence for sound changes and sociolinguistic variation (Section 14.3). As I have suggested in Section 2.3, analysing prescriptive comments has significance beyond the study of the historical period under scrutiny. I evaluate this relevance with respect to my analysis at the end of Chapter 14 and use it as a transition to concluding remarks and opportunities for further research in Chapter 15.

- i To what extent are the features mentioned in Table 2.1 discussed by the grammarians?
- ii To what extent do comments in the CNG align with the current state of research on phonological variation in the nineteenth century? Do the grammars in the CNG diverge from the established timeline or realisation for certain variants?

12 Research questions recapped

- iii Are certain phonological variants stigmatised in the grammars? If so, how prescriptive are the grammarians and does the degree of stigmatisation depend on the feature in question?
- iv To what extent do grammars contain verbatim copies from other LModE codifying works?
- v To what extent can grammars in the nineteenth century be regarded as a homogenous genre?

Overarching research question:

To what extent can nineteenth-century grammars be taken as historical evidence for sound changes and sociolinguistic variation?

13 Phonological features and prescriptivism

13.1 Research question i: Frequency of phonological variables

When it comes to the features described in Section 2.4, comments on all of them can be found in the CNG, albeit in varying degrees and depending on the variable. Table 13.1 shows the quantity of evidence for all features and variables analysed in the present study, meaning all grammars that contain information on variation or innovative variants are listed, irrespective of whether the respective grammarians accept the change. The numbers thus represent the general number of grammars that provide sufficient information on the variables to allow an analysis on their variation.

The most frequently mentioned sounds are found in the FACE and GOAT sets. However, as explained before, these include monophthongal as well as diphthongal descriptions. All the remaining features are commented on in at most one third of the grammars that treat pronunciation. This could also be due to the fact that the prime example in the definitions of “improper diphthongs” in the CNG is *boat* and that a distinction between “improper” and “proper” diphthongs was made by the majority of grammarians. Furthermore, the choice of features accounts for some of the differences in numbers. We can of course expect a quantitative difference between, for example, /v/-/w/-interchange and realisations of WHALE words, simply because the former is a very specific “non-standard” feature while the latter is a phonological variable which occurs in many high-frequency words. Moreover, comments on /hw/ are likely to occur in most grammars that simply treat the letter <w> or the digraph <wh>. It is especially those grammars that follow a more traditional approach and systematically go through every possible combination of letters where we would find WHALE words.

The results show that the mentions of most phonological variables are surprisingly low, except GOAT and FACE. Moreover, innovative variants are comparatively infrequent. Yet, it is possible to utilise those grammars that discuss

phonological variables to show variation in pronunciation and in the acceptance of innovative variants in the nineteenth century.

Table 13.1: Quantitative overview of evidence for all variables discussed

		total	British-Irish		North American	
pronunciation treated	166		100		66	
evidence GOAT	101	61%	51	51%	50	76%
diphthongs	13	8%	7	7%	6	9%
evidence FACE	80	48%	43	43%	37	56%
diphthongs	20	12%	13	13%	7	11%
/h/-dropping and /h/-insertion	55	33%	35	35%	20	30%
non-standard variants	24	14%	14	14%	10	15%
evidence WHALE	55	33%	22	22%	33	50%
/w/ and weakened	15	10%	12	12%	3	5%
evidence /r/-distribution	43	26%	17	17%	26	39%
post-vocalic /r/ absence	12	8%	6	6%	6	9%
evidence TRAP-BATH split	41	25%	16	16%	25	38%
split present	38	23%	15	15%	23	35%
split absent	3	2%	1	1%	2	3%
evidence non-standard <i>-ing</i> total	21	13%	11	11%	10	15%
evidence /v/-/w/-interchange	11	7%	6	6%	5	8%

13.2 Research question ii: The state of research and the CNG

My analyses of comments on FACE and GOAT words, TRAP and BATH words, post-vocalic /r/ absence as well as in part the WHALE set have yielded some surprising results. For variables like FACE and GOAT, /r/, and the initial sound(s) in WHALE words, the innovative variants, i.e. the diphthongs [eɪ] and [oʊ], an [ɪ]-[Ø] distribution (for Britain), and /w/ respectively, are by far the minority in the grammars of the CNG, both in terms of the commentary they receive as well as the grammarians' acceptance of these variants. The absence of differences between British-Irish and North American grammars is furthermore striking for the consonant /r/. The absence of the WHICH-WITCH merger in most grammars is unexpected considering the historical development of the variable in the nineteenth

and twentieth century but conforms to Beal & Sen's (2014) and Yáñez-Bouza et al.'s (2018) findings. Late observations on the regional distribution of /hw/ and /w/ align with previous research on the development of the variable. The presence of a threefold split of the TRAP-BATH-START/PALM sets in all North American grammars is also unanticipated given the existence of one characteristically unsplit phoneme for both TRAP and BATH in present-day AmE, at least outside of decidedly regional accents.

In terms of grammars that were published outside of England or the US, there are only few examples in the CNG and these can be found in the sections on /h/, and the lexical sets of FACE, GOAT and WHALE. Most importantly, apart from Speers (1880) on diphthongs in GOAT words (Section 5.5), all of these are linguistically conservative in what variants they suggest. This is not surprising as even present-day varieties of Scottish and Irish English mainly maintain historically older forms in these lexical sets. One of the Scottish grammars, namely Connon (1845), was also marked as unclear in the WHICH-WITCH merger section. The one Canadian grammar, namely Davies (1869), only provides evidence for the vowel in GOAT words, where he suggests a monophthong. This low number of comments in this subset of grammars could be explained by the absence of variation in these regions or simply by the underrepresentation of these grammars in the CNG.

For the GOAT and FACE sets the suggested variants are predominantly monophthongs. Diphthongal descriptions from before 1845 are, judging from the use of exclusively FACE_b and GOAT_b spellings in example words, likely cases of historical retentions, restorative prescriptivism or influenced by orthography. The history of the variant also plays a role for the lexical set of FACE, as shown in Morgan (1814), Cramp (1838), Tancock (1878), and Kelke (1885). Grammars that could indicate a complete shift to diphthongs across all lexical subsets of FACE or GOAT are from 1889 or later (Hall & Sonnenschein 1889; Gow 1892; Ramsey 1892; Nesfield 1900; Carpenter 1902). Even in these works the use of terminology and comments like "slight diphthong" (Gow 1892: 11) "partly diphthongal", "slight after sound" (Nesfield 1900: 282), "fade away into (uu)" (Ramsey 1892: 164), or the like to refer to the vowel in these sets suggests a hesitancy to accept fully diphthongised values. Nesfield (1900) also still describes, albeit inconsistently, what looks like an allophonic distribution with diphthongs in closed syllables and monophthongs in open syllables. Based on these comments, I suggest that the diphthongal variants had not yet reached phonemic status by the end of the nineteenth century and that for most the underlying form was a monophthong with some slightly diphthongised realisational variants.

My analysis confirms a timeline corresponding to the dating of the change by Jones (2006) and furthermore suggests a phonetically gradual change from long monophthongs to diphthongs. There are some small quantitative differences between British-Irish and North American grammars in the number of FACE diphthongs mentioned, where both in absolute and relative terms British-Irish grammars contain more comments. With respect to GOAT, the difference is much smaller as the number of grammars providing diphthongal evidence is higher only by one British-Irish grammar compared to the North American grammars. Concerning the relative differences, North American grammars still treat GOAT diphthongs slightly more frequently than British-Irish grammars (2 percentage points). However, this minor difference may be disregarded, also given the low absolute numbers. Furthermore, North American grammarians tend to reference (and criticise in the case of Brown 1851) their American contemporaries Rush (1827) and Comstock (1843), who both propose diphthongs. While all the other changes discussed in the present study were already under way before the nineteenth century, *Long Mid Diphthonging* is a very recent process, with the first reliable evidence outside of the CNG coming from 1809 for FACE and 1795 for GOAT (see Section 5.1). Therefore, it is less likely to constitute a change in progress that was exported to North America from Britain, but that it was indeed an independent development, which is also confirmed by my results. Moreover, save for very few instances, diphthongs largely escape any prescriptive judgments, which could be exactly because full diphthongs were not established or at least were still being used under the level of conscious awareness. This lack of negative evaluations and associations with different regions would furthermore support the idea that diphthongs emerged independently in Britain and North America.

Post-vocalic /r/ absence, which became the standard in England in the course of the nineteenth century, is mentioned in less than one third of the grammars that allow for deducing any /r/-distribution and is, with the exception of three grammars from the close of the century, highly criticised. The first (albeit negative) comments on post-vocalic /r/ absence in the CNG are Kirkham (1834) in North America and Leigh (1840) in the British-Irish Isles. The three grammars in which neutral attitudes are shown towards /r/ are from the close of the century, namely the British-Irish grammars by Gow (1892) and Nesfield (1900) and the North American Carpenter (1902). The high percentage of negative evaluations is unsurprising and aligns with claims made by Beal (2004b: 154). However, the comparatively low frequency of comments on non-rhoticity in general, coupled with the high frequency of a twofold distinction of /r/ sounds in both the British-Irish Isles and North America, may be unexpected. Nevertheless, it is not

impossible that a twofold distinction as well as the use of one single /r/ realisation regardless of position was in part still the reality as it can be backed up with other historical evidence, as Trudgill's (2004: 69–71) analyses of Ellis (1889) and Orton et al.'s (1978) SED data have shown. This is evidenced also by Scottish, Irish and North American varieties that have maintained post-vocalic /r/ to this day and thus much longer than the majority of areas in England. It also aligns with Lass' (1999: 115) statement that rhoticity must have been variable until 1870 or even longer.

The quality of the sounds in those grammars that propose a twofold distinction between “rough” and “smooth” variants is difficult to assess. Few grammars offer articulatory information and those that do potentially indicate (post-)alveolar or bunched approximants, assibilated or alveolar fricatives for “rough” variants. “Smooth” variants could represent rhotacisation, vocalisation or simply approximants. In those grammars that only suggest one sound for /r/, a bunched approximant and an alveolar trill are possible interpretations. They could all represent different stages of the lenition process of /r/ in south-eastern British pronunciation or other non-rhotic areas (see Trudgill 2004: 69–72; Hickey 2025: 281–282). My results conform with a phonetically gradual loss of post-vocalic /r/.

However, I argue below that terminological and structural similarities to authors like Murray and Walker, which can be found in many cases, likely also indicate genre conventions of plagiarism rather than actual observations on the part of some of the grammarians. This could be an explanation for the linguistic conservatism in /r/ and other variables. As the consonant /r/ developed differently in several regions, it is furthermore surprising that there is no significant regional difference in the distribution or evaluation of non-rhoticity, with the exception of the case discussed for the two late nineteenth-century grammars Gow (1892) and Ramsey (1892). Gow (1892) neutrally describes essentially RP, whereas Ramsey (1892) opposes non-rhotic pronunciations strongly.

Concerning WHALE words, grammars in the CNG almost exclusively propose /hw/ as realisation for <wh>. In North American grammars, I have found /hw/ categorically, while in the British-Irish grammars there is one case of a weakened variant and six examples of /w/, which make up roughly one third of British-Irish grammars. Eight more grammars mention /w/ but either proscribe it and in one case identify it as a regional variant. The first evidence in the CNG comes from 1830, namely Pinnock (1830). However, with the exception of Booth (1837), who directly quotes Walker, regional descriptions are only used in late nineteenth-century grammars (Kelke 1885; Gow 1892; West 1898; Nesfield 1900; Carpenter 1902). In these late grammars /hw/ is clearly the marked variant, whereas /w/ is unmarked. Late nineteenth-century comments on variation in WHALE words

further reflect the traditional dialect distribution we find in the SED (Orton et al. 1978) and in Ellis' works. Therefore, the CNG authors are very conservative in terms of realisations of <wh> which they suggest as the correct standard variant. The fact that /hw/ is the only variant that North American grammars allow is perhaps unsurprising as other historical and present-day sources have shown that /hw/ has been maintained longer there than, for instance, in England. A crucial factor in the choice of variants for WHALE words is furthermore the spelling as well as the history of the form. Nearly all arguments suggest that <w> should be pronounced after <h> and are thus undoubtedly claims based on the presence of both letters in the orthography. This is further reinforced by comments on the etymology of words, e.g. references to the OE or generally Germanic spellings with <hw>. I have thus shown that grammars in the CNG are overwhelmingly conservative with respect to the four variables of FACE, GOAT, /r/, and WHALE.

As for the lexical sets TRAP and BATH, the situation is slightly more complicated. The first evidence for a split in the CNG comes from Greenleaf (1821) for North America and from Oliver (1825) for the British-Irish Isles. However, we can observe a phoneme split in the majority of grammars, even those published in North America, where we would assume the absence of a clear split based on the present-day distribution in most regions. Yet, what I have termed a threefold split occurs exclusively in North American works. The split in those grammars mostly corresponds to words from the TRAP, BATH, and START and PALM sets. The first category usually has a short vowel, the second some form of "middle" vowel, whereas the last is said to have a "grave", "long", or "Italian" sound of *a*. Fowler (1855) and Hyde (1895) are the only examples from the CNG in which the third category contains some BATH words as well. Unfortunately, as I have frequently pointed out throughout my analysis, the problem is that articulatory descriptions for these vowels are wanting in nearly all grammars. It is hard to derive any qualities of these sounds, or even find out whether what is meant are actually qualitative rather than length differences. In any case, the presence of any split in North America is indeed surprising as present-day AmE pronunciation is marked exactly by the absence of this phoneme split. There are several possible explanations for this. It could perhaps represent an influence from Smart or Worcester or continuing prestige of a non-short/front vowel. The presence of a middle category could constitute a compromise pronunciation between the overtly prestigious back variant and the short front variant characteristic of American speakers, as I have suggested in Chapter 6 based on Krapp (1919) and Paulsen (2022). The majority of example words used in the middle category have the vowel in /_s(C)/ environments. Another interpretation could be that

this constitutes a phonetic intermediate stage in the development towards a full split, which would mean that the vowel retracted last before /s/. The similarity of important example words, i.e. *aunt*, *father* and *laugh*, with Trapateau's (2020) analysis of eighteenth-century dictionaries implies conservatism in the CNG also with respect to the variants in TRAP and BATH words. Moreover, the special position of *laugh* confirms Stanford's (2020: 262–263) statements about present-day New England, where a long variant [a:] has been maintained longest in the word *laugh*. There is no evidence for any system that represents the present-day nasal short-*a* split found in the (North-)East of the US.

Non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion are expectedly criticised categorically and, especially in North American grammars, associated with Cockneys and literary characters like Sam Weller. This, I have hypothesised, stems from literary works rather than first-hand knowledge of Cockney speakers (see also Mugglestone 2007: 96). One exception to this can be found in Ridpath's (1881) grammar. Despite his evaluation of the feature as typical of Cockney through its association with Sam Weller, a second comment in his grammar suggests a connection with British speakers as a whole.

Furthermore, the timeline of words in which /h/-dropping is permitted and in fact required conforms largely with what has been suggested by MacMahon (1998: 477–478). From the middle of the century (after 1864), there are rarely comments suggesting /h/-less realisations for words that are /h/-full in either the British-Irish Isles or North America today. In other words, words that were variable before, e.g. *hospital*, *hotel*, *human*, *humble*, seem to have reached their present-day /h/-full pronunciation by the 1860s. Variation that can still be observed today, as in *herb*, *hostler*, or *humour*, is also attested in the CNG throughout the century. The only surprise is that *hotel* and *humour* are described as /h/-less in one British-Irish grammar from 1900, namely Nesfield (1900). In *hotel* we would clearly expect an /h/-full pronunciation by 1900, irrespective of region, and in the British-Irish Isles *humour* would similarly have an /h/. Interestingly, in contrast to WHALE words, etymology does not play any role in the arguments at all. Before the middle of the century, we could have expected prescriptions of /h/-less variants based on the French origin of words like *hospital*, *hotel*, or *humble*, but no such prescriptions based on the etymology of the different /h/-initial words can be found in the grammars of the CNG.

As we would expect for a feature such as /v/-/w/-interchange, which was largely associated with working-class speakers from London and the South, it is exclusively evaluated negatively. Indeed, more than half of the comments on this non-standard feature contain references to Cockney, London or Kent, even from North American grammars. These are dialects where the feature would

have been found historically but also those with which it is stereotypically associated (especially London). Questions about whether the interchange worked both ways are hard to answer satisfactorily due to the low number of mentions in the CNG. The evidence gathered from the grammars suggests that /w/ for /v/ and /v/ for /w/ were both used as all grammars include both ways of substitution, save for Kirkham (1834). This is in line with Trudgill et al.'s (2003) analysis who argue for a merger on a phonetically intermediate variant that caused speakers without the merger to interpret the feature as working both ways. The merger and later reversal thereof in England would have caused occasional hypercorrections as well. Example words where /w/ is used for /v/ as in *wery* for *very* occur more frequently in the CNG, seemingly also confirming Ellis' (1889: 132) statements that indicate that this is the common type of substitution. However, the adequacy of the potential distribution derived from the grammars in the CNG is hard to gauge. This is simply because it is likely that their comments stem from literary works by, for instance, Dickens and from widespread stereotypes rather than from actual first-hand exposure to speakers who use this feature, as has been similarly noted for /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. The high degree of stigmatisation, the regional characterisations and the direction of interchange as well as a close connection to literary figures from the time thus align with what has been published on the feature.

Comments on the realisation of *-ing* in the CNG are as expected and align with previous research. Perhaps the only exception is that there are no mentions of any aristocratic or upper-class speakers in the context of alveolar realisations of *-ing*, except one neutral comment on its use in the West End of London by Gow (1892). Whereas in previous research it has been argued that alveolar nasals were still used by the aristocracy in the nineteenth century and continued to be used at the beginning of the twentieth century (see the beginning of Section 11.1), there is no proper evidence for this in the CNG. All alveolar uses as well as velar nasal plus and hypercorrect variants are stigmatised and it is clearly a velar nasal which is regarded as the correct standard variant. Many negative evaluations of [ɱ] in the CNG could equally be applied to working class and non-working class speakers as grammarians do not always include explicit references to the group of speakers who use this variant.

A phonotactically restricted distribution which permits alveolar variants after [ɱ], as suggested by Walker (1791) and Murray (1795) in his first edition, is only mentioned in three cases (Andrew 1817; Fisk 1822; Swett 1844), the latter two of which argue against it by means of verbatim copies from Murray (1797) or later editions. I have however argued that this distribution was likely made up and never attested in actual speech.

In summary and in regards to those variants that eventually became the standard in England, evidence in the CNG which could suggest categorical shift to diphthongs in FACE and GOAT only comes from the end of the 1880s or later. Even in these late works, grammarians still show a hesitancy to accept lexically categorical and fully diphthongised qualities. Together with the development in /h/-full words permitted in the standard and the reduction of initial /hw/ in WHALE words, it is a change that took place in the emerging standard in both British and in AmE pronunciation. For /h/ and WHALE, evidence in part suggest a difference between both regions in the nineteenth century that still reflects today's distribution. In contrast, the CNG exhibits only minor differences between grammars published in the British-Irish Isles and those from North America on GOAT and FACE. This could indicate that diphthongs developed independently but simultaneously in both regions.

Whereas Ellis (1869a: 23) notices the emergence of a supra-regional "received" pronunciation (see Section 2.1) in the 1860s, some of the features typical of twentieth-century RP must have still been in the process of changing at his time of writing. They at least had not reached phonemic status and conscious awareness in many speakers as shown, for instance, for diphthongal realisations in FACE and GOAT. This process is also visible in the CNG in the comparatively late acceptance of some features like non-rhoticity and the WHICH-WITCH merger. For North America, we can also still see examples of meta-linguistic negotiation of newer variants between authors in the middle of the century, e.g. Brown's (1851) critique of Rush (1827) and Wells (1847) on diphthongal FACE and GOAT vowels and the number of /r/ variants.

As I have only considered the publication dates of the grammars in the CNG for determining the timeline of phonological changes, which I did simply for the reason that biographical information was rarely available, dating the spread of innovative variants slightly earlier could perhaps generally be considered. The reason for that is that the publication date of a grammar does not necessarily reveal the age of the grammarian who wrote it. If we assumed that the grammarians' prescriptions and descriptions were affected by their own usage, then we could presume that the phonological variants they give as the standard were used when they themselves acquired the language (see Beal 1999: 104–105; Trapeau 2020: 539). However, as we mostly do not have this information and as other factors such as ideology motivated prescriptions and plagiarism are relevant as well, an earlier dating of the changes described would be hypothetical. Furthermore, while a potential time lag, from the widespread use to acceptance of variants in the grammarians' description could also generally be assumed (as noted in Sections 2.3 and 5.1) this is equally hard to operationalise. Therefore,

I argue that it is sufficient to bear in mind that the timelines for changes suggested by comments in the CNG do not represent exactly the earliest points of widespread use of innovative variants but an indication as to when or if the variants had come to be generally accepted in the nineteenth century. This in and of itself is extremely valuable information about the phonology of LModE.

13.3 Research question iii: Stigmatisation of variants

As concerns the questions of whether certain phonological variants are stigmatised, grammars indeed vary dependent on the feature in question and with respect to the degree of criticism the variants receive. Table 13.2 provides an overview of negative evaluations of innovative (and non-standard) variants for all variables in relation to overall evidence, ordered from most to least stigmatised. The column on non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion excludes unclear cases and Norman (1875) whose grammars was categorised as not treating pronunciation but includes value judgements on /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. Non-standard *-ing* includes velar nasal plus and hypercorrect variants. Furthermore, the one weakened variant discussed with respect to the WHICH-WITCH merger was not counted in this table. Table 13.2 shows that, surprisingly, many of the grammars in the CNG are descriptive with respect to innovative (and non-standard) variants in the vowel variables if compared to consonants.

All grammars that mention /v/-/w/-interchange exhibit stigma towards the feature. Similarly, all statements on non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, except one, are negative evaluations. For final *-ing* endings, it is in 16 of 19 (84%) grammars that negative attitudes towards [ɪŋ] can be found. Velar nasal plus and hypercorrect variants are categorically criticised, which results in a total of 18 of 21 (86%) cases which show negative evaluations of non-standard variants of *-ing* endings.

Post-vocalic /r/ absence is also one of the features where negative evaluations clearly outweigh neutral observations, as nine of 12 (75%) grammars that mention it provide prescriptions or value judgements, irrespective of their places of publication. It receives negative evaluations in the grammars published in England as well as those from North America, which aligns with our expectations. In the case of grammars from England, it is a feature that emerges first in the lower classes and in North America it is increasingly associated with the former coloniser.

The WHICH-WITCH merger is evaluated in a negative fashion seven times of 14 (50%) mentions but receives unexpectedly little connection to /h/-dropping.

13.3 Research question iii: Stigmatisation of variants

Table 13.2: Negative evaluations of innovative (and non-standard) variants for all variables in relation to overall evidence

	total		British-Irish		North American	
pronunciation treated	166		100		66	
/v/-/w/-interchange	11		6		5	
negative evaluations	11	100% of 11	6	100% of 6	5	100% of 5
non-standard	22		13		9	
/h/-dropping and /h/-insertion						
negative evaluations	21	95% of 22	12	92% of 13	9	100% of 9
non-standard <i>-ing</i> total	21		11		10	
negative evaluations	18	86% of 21	9	82% of 11	9	90% of 10
post-vocalic /r/ absence	12		6		6	
negative evaluations	9	75% of 12	4	67% of 6	5	83% of 6
WHICH-WITCH merger	14		11		3	
negative evaluations	7	50% of 14	5	45% of 11	2	67% of 3
FACE diphthongs	20		13		7	
negative evaluations	2	10% of 20	1	8% of 13	1	14% of 7
TRAP-BATH split	41		16		25	
negative evaluations	4	10% of 41	2	12.5% of 16	2	8% of 25
GOAT diphthongs	13		7		6	
negative evaluations	1	8% of 13	—	—	1	17% of 6

The evaluations that are present however are less strong than those for, for example, post-vocalic /r/ absence or /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion. Etymological arguments also play a considerable role to justify /hw/ as the perceived standard in several grammars. This is why I regarded these instances as variant forms of restorative prescriptivism in a broader sense, although they are not proper cases of restorative prescriptivism in Curzan's (2014) sense because they are not all prescriptive. Still, they highlight the importance of the history of words in the arguments presented by grammarians.

For FACE words, four of 20 grammars that contain evidence for diphthongal pronunciations provide prescriptive arguments but in two cases monophthongs are evaluated negatively (10%), i.e. in the North American grammar by Morgan (1814), and in Cramp (1838), published in London. They do not however criticise monophthongs because they are in favour of the innovative diphthongal variant,

but because they favour historical pronunciations of FACE_b words or in Cramp's case argue based on the orthography. I have suggested that both cases can be regarded as restorative prescriptivism in Curzan's (2014) sense as they intend to restore former diphthongal variants in <ai> digraphs. Diphthongs are proscribed in one more case, namely in Gostwick (1878). Furthermore, Brown (1851) criticises the use of diphthongs in FACE_b in the work of his contemporary Rush. Therefore, there are only two grammars which potentially show the stigmatisation of innovative variants, which illustrates the striking absence of prescriptive commentary. For diphthongs in GOAT words, it is only one of 13 (8%) grammars that critiques diphthongal variants, namely Brown (1851), who disapproves not only of Rush's use of diphthongs in FACE_b but also GOAT_b words.

Realisations of the vowel in BATH words only receive negative evaluations in five out of 41 (12%) grammars that provide evidence of the presence or absence of a TRAP-BATH split. There are, however, differences as to which variants and whose usage is evaluated negatively, as only three (10%) criticise what appears to be long or retracted variants, and in one case both long and short variants are evaluated negatively. In the grammars published in England, we have one instance where indeed a short vowel is criticised, suggesting perhaps that a long variant was firmly established. Contrary to that, there are two instances in which what seem to be low and backed variants are stigmatised. For Oliver (1825: 292–293) it is a short sound in <au> spellings which is regarded as a “provincialism”. Leigh (1840: 25–26) frowns upon what appears to be low back vowels in the speech of Cockneys and dandies as well as raised or diphthongised variants in the speech of young female speakers. In Cobbin (1864: 82–83) the “vulgar Londoners” but also “respectable persons, who do not attend to correct pronunciation, but still [...] are considered vulgar” use what could be a long back vowel in words like *plant* and *ant*. In the North American grammars, Kirkham (1834: 23, 205) criticises the New York and New England uses of the same vowel variant as in *far* in words like *glass* or *pass*, but gives *aunt* his “flat, Italian sound”. Wells (1847: 31) prescribes the use of a vowel intermediate between the one heard in *man* and *father* for “good speakers”. Thus, there is evidence that the conservative as well as the more recent variant receive negative evaluations in the nineteenth century.

In sum, FACE and GOAT diphthongs and the TRAP-BATH split almost exclusively escape any prescriptive commentary. For the WHICH-WITCH merger neutral and negative evaluations keep the balance and both occur equally often. Moreover, there is particularly little connection established between this variant and the highly stigmatised feature of /h/-dropping as shown in Walker (1791) and suggested by Beal & Sen (2014) and Yáñez-Bouza et al. (2018).

Features like post-vocalic /r/ absence, non-standard /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, /v/-/w/-interchange, alveolar, velar nasal plus and hypercorrect realisations of *-ing* are expectedly strongly criticised, both in terms of how and how often they are negatively evaluated. This suggests that the level of prescription is indeed dependent on the variants and it is especially those features that are said to have been stigmatised in previous research that receive mainly negative evaluations, with the exception of the WHICH-WITCH merger. Therefore, the commentary on these features mostly aligns with the state of research on LModE writing and prescriptivism in both qualitative and quantitative terms. Yet, there is a stark difference between vowel and consonant features. I have suggested that for diphthongs in the sets of GOAT and FACE this could be due to the change taking place below the level of conscious awareness for many. This is supported by statements from the early twentieth-century scholars Krapp (1919: 67) and Jones (1964 [1918]: 102), and by Batchelor (1809: 53) and Ellis (1869a: 294) in the nineteenth century (see Section 5.1).

While it is certainly possible that the absence of negative evaluations of the TRAP-BATH split could indicate a lesser degree of stigma than previous research like Mugglestone (2007: 79) has suggested for fully retracted long vowels, this is hard to back up with the data from the CNG. It is not even possible to derive with certainty that fully retracted forms are meant by the descriptions in the CNG in the first place. While the issue of vowel quality in BATH words remains, it is safe to say that some form of phoneme split affecting words from the TRAP and BATH sets, whatever the exact qualities, was accepted by nineteenth-century grammarians. Of the consonant features, all are non-standard features and it is only non-rhoticity which became the standard in England and other Englishes like AusE or NZE. Therefore, the high percentage of negative comments is to be expected, at least in relation to number of mentions of the features.

In terms of consonantal features that Walker (1791) identifies as typical of London, there are differences in the associations in nineteenth-century grammars. Regarding post-vocalic /r/ absence, there is indeed support for an association of the feature with speakers from London in the British-Irish grammars. This cannot be said of North American grammars. Interestingly, for /h/-dropping it is only North American grammars where this connection is made but absolute numbers of these comments are low. There is no evidence for any connection between /w/ and London, at least in the evaluations presented by grammarians. Of course, as we have seen, this is a variant which is exclusively mentioned in British-Irish grammars but not evaluated as particularly specific to London. For /v/-/w/-interchange both British-Irish as well as North American grammars put the feature in relation to southern British and London speech.

Table 13.3 summarises the evaluative categories and their frequency in comments on the phonological features. Simple prescriptions and proscriptions in the sense of “should/must (not) be used” as well as examples of restorative prescriptivism have been excluded from this table. Often comments in grammars fit into more than one category. Therefore, the sum of all categories per feature may exceed the number of grammars in which the feature is criticised. Social Evaluation and Mistake are undeniably the most frequent categories into which comments by grammarians on phonological features can be grouped. Aesthetic arguments and references to the Education of the speakers and those belonging to the category Nature are decidedly less frequent. Finally, there is only one instance that fits the category Logic/Avoiding ambiguity.

Table 13.3: Quantitative overview of evaluative categories in the CNG

	Social	Mistake	Aesthetics	Education	Nature	Logic
/h/-dropping and /h/-insertion	10	12	2	4	2	—
[ɪn] for <i>-ing</i>	8	4	—	—	—	—
/v/-/w/- interchange	7	8	2	1	—	—
post-vocalic /r/ absence	6	4	1	—	2	—
long vowel in BATH	4	4	—	—	—	—
WHICH-WITCH merger	2	3	—	—	—	1
short vowel in BATH	2	1	—	—	—	—
FACE monophthongs	2	1	1	—	—	—
[ɪŋg ~ ɪŋk] for <i>-ing</i>	2	—	—	—	—	—
hypercorrect [ŋ]	—	—	—	—	—	—
FACE diphthongs	—	—	—	—	—	—
GOAT diphthongs	—	—	—	—	—	—
total	43	37	6	5	4	1

The vocabulary employed by the grammarians in the CNG for displaying negative attitudes towards the variants in question in the form of social evaluations is similar to what other studies on eighteenth- and nineteenth-century grammars and dictionaries have reported: evaluative terms like “vulgar(ism)”, “improper”, “impropriety”, “affected”, “corrupt(ion)”, or “Cockney(ism)” are widely used. Thus, grammars in the CNG very much reflect the discourse of the time (see Sturiale 2016; Trapateau 2016; Anderwald 2017; Beal 2023).

With the exception of two cases of restorative prescriptivism in the context of FACE monophthongs and some comments on the etymology of WHALE words, statements regarding the phonological features in the present analysis can clearly be categorised as standardising prescriptivism (Curzan 2014). With respect to phonological variants, prescriptive grammarians do not make a difference between formality and various speaking styles. They clearly have one variant in mind which they consider the correct standard; they do not, however, employ the word *standard* itself. In Curzan’s (2014) terms, there is no evidence of stylistic prescriptivism with respect to the variables I analysed.

Regarding the overall picture, the number of mentions of innovative variants are comparatively rare given the general frequency of evidence for distributions in these variables, as previously shown in Table 13.1. Thus, while the quantitative relation between neutral and negative evaluations tend to the negative side where we would expect this, for stigmatised features we would generally have expected a higher number of overall comments. The features *-ing* and /v/ and /w/ are an exception because here we are dealing with explicitly non-standard features which I have specifically searched for. Furthermore, while strong social evaluations are indeed the majority in the CNG, there are also grammars that contain only simple pre- or proscriptions without any value judgments, e.g. several remarks on alveolar realisations of *-ing* (Section 11.3), Gostwick’s (1878) comments on diphthongs in FACE_b and GOAT_b words (Sections 5.3 and 5.6), or Lowres’ (1863) proscriptions of /hw/ in WHALE words (Section 9.4) and velar nasal plus variants for *-ing* (Section 11.4). If ranked on a continuum, these cases would be examples of less prescriptive commentary. In sum, there are passages lacking any value judgements than mere pre- or proscriptions and there is a lower number of comments on innovative variants than expected. Therefore, the grammars in the CNG can be placed more on the descriptive side of a prescriptive-descriptive continuum rather than be considered fully normative works.

Thus, the CNG is not only very conservative but also strikingly descriptive, at least in quantitative terms and with respect to some of the features discussed. For those with verbatim copies from Murray, this is due to the fact that Murray’s

(1795: 4–15) section on pronunciation (GENERAL OBSERVATIONS ON THE SOUNDS OF THE LETTERS under OF ORTHOGRAPHY) is in general descriptive. This observation is in line with Anderwald's (2016a: 238) findings in the CNG. She illustrates that "much grammar writing of the nineteenth century was indeed prescriptive in character and intention", but "at least with respect to verbal paradigms, [it] was often not very prescriptive at all". If we consider the genre of grammars as a whole in relation to this, it becomes even more apparent that a clear differentiation between descriptive and prescriptive grammars is often impossible to uphold. As the degree of stigmatisation represented by comments in the grammars depends on the variant in question and as there is variation in the degree of criticism and the use of terminology even within one work, it is difficult to place any grammar purely on either end of a descriptive-prescriptive continuum, let alone an entire genre.

14 Grammars as sources for historical phonology

14.1 Research question iv: Verbatim copies

The first question to be addressed in this chapter is concerned with verbatim copies from other LModE grammars or dictionaries. I have shown for several phonological variables that verbatim and close-to-verbatim copies of terminology and entire passages from eighteenth-century authors like Murray and Walker as well as nineteenth-century grammarians like Brown or Kirkham are common in nineteenth-century grammars. This is the case for instance for monophthongs, which are almost exclusively referred to as “improper diphthongs” and are illustrated by means of the word *boat*. Several examples have exactly Murray’s wording and others have wordings which are strikingly close, as shown in Section 5.4. This is moreover evident in comments on the consonant /r/ where we do not only find a “rough-smooth” distinction but also the same example words and wordings as in Murray. In the case of /r/, it is not always possible to determine who the respective grammarians copied from, as even Murray uses the same examples as Walker. A lot of what looks like Walker to someone familiar with his dictionary might have come into nineteenth-century grammars through Murray. While Murray does not seem to have copied entire passages from Walker verbatim, he appears to have been influenced by him in terms of variants and example words. This is only transparent from his fourth edition onwards (Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1996a: 88; Mugglestone 1996: 146), where he writes “It is, however, proper to acknowledge in general terms, that the authors to whom the grammatical part of this compilation is principally indebted for its materials, are Harris, Johnson, Lowth, Priestly, Beattie, Sheridan, and Walker” (Murray 1798: 7). I have moreover observed similarities like these for standard /h/-dropping and WHALE words. Thus, although Murray had already been criticised for his unacknowledged copies of others and despite the changes in attitude towards plagiarism at the end of the eighteenth century (see Tieken-Boon van Ostade 1996a), it was still very common in nineteenth-century grammars to copy other sources word-for-word.

Some grammarians that plagiarised others did so for several variables in the present analysis, e.g. Greenleaf (1821), Fisk (1822), Kirkham (1834), Turner (1840), Swett (1844), Hiley (1857) and Caldwell (1859). In fact, Anderwald (2016a: 43–44) shows for many of these grammars (near-)verbatim copies from Murray concerning the definition of tense. She further points to plagiarism of Murray and other grammarians in several cases in her analyses. As previously noted, it is not always clear that nineteenth-century grammarians copied from Walker, Murray, Sheridan or other eighteenth-century orthoëpists. However, in some cases we can indeed retrace their plagiarism. This is shown in the example of Turner's grammar in multiple sections above, who very likely copied from one of Brown's early editions. Anderwald (2016a: 179) also finds a verbatim overlap in Brown and Turner regarding the progressive, which would support this observation. I have furthermore hypothesised strong influence from Smart and Worcester in grammars with a threefold TRAP-BATH-PALM/START distinction.

Verbatim copies occur at least until the end of the 1850s if not longer, as shown in Caldwell's (1859: 18–19) definition of "improper diphthongs" and Hiley's (1857: 8) description of /r/. Descriptions that were clearly influenced by Walker and Murray such as the use of "rough" and "smooth" to refer to /r/ sounds or the selection of the same example words, albeit with slightly altered wordings, can even be found into the 1870s. Examples of this are Colegrove (1879: 22–24) on /r/ or Irving & Mann's (1876: 5) and Edwardes' (1877: 3–4) comments on "improper diphthongs".

It is certainly worth asking whether the pervasive overlap in terminology, e.g. the use of "improper diphthong" for digraph, "rough" and "smooth(er)/soft(er)" to refer to /r/ sounds, or "Italian sound of *a*" for vowels in the BATH set, is in fact surprising or whether we should regard this simply as a convention of the time. After all, present-day introductory works to English linguistics and to English phonetics and phonology also use the same terminology as well as similar examples because these are universally agreed upon. Whereas the IPA was not officially established until 1888 (Passy 1888) and while there were still considerable notational differences in LModE sources in how sounds are represented in the late eighteenth-century (Beal 2023: 450), I argue that the terminology used is in fact at least partially conventionalised in the nineteenth century. It seems that the act of copying directly from other grammarians and orthoëpists as well as using similar or the same terminology were both part of LModE conventions, and it is exactly this fact that seems to account for the noticeable overlap in some of the grammars in the CNG. Of course, the comparison with twenty- and twenty-first century works is an anachronistic one, and indeed verbatim copies are rightfully unacceptable nowadays. The major difference is that today the same terminology

is employed to ensure universal comprehension across different (sub-)branches of linguistics. It is not possible to prove the contrary was the case in some of the nineteenth-century grammars in the CNG but word-for-word copies might suggest different motivations such as economic interests or simply saving time in the creation of teaching material. The use of the same examples might have also served didactic purposes or a similar function to Wells' (1982) standard lexical sets, as I have suggested, for instance, in Chapter 6 for example words employed for words from the TRAP, START, and BATH sets. The importance of examples like *aunt* could thus either indicate conservatism in the grammars, as it is similar to what Trapateau (2020) finds for eighteenth-century dictionaries, plagiarism, or convention. Comments on the phonological variable /h/ are more heterogeneous but I show for grammars like Fisk (1822) and Swett (1844) that they even copy verbatim from Murray in this case. For the variable *-ing*, it is also only in Fisk (1822) and Swett (1844) that we find copies from Murray, but from the third or later editions of his grammar. This again clearly shows that grammarians in the CNG did not copy other authors for all features and that there was generally variation as to how much and what was copied.

Similar to eighteenth-century dictionaries, as shown by Beal (2009: 172), some grammarians also make their sources transparent either in the title or preface of their work. Examples of this are Fisk (1822) and Swett (1844), whose grammars have the titles *Murray's English Grammar Simplified [...]* and *An English Grammar, Comprehending the Principles and Rules of the Language, Illustrated by Appropriate Exercises: On the Basis of Murray* respectively. Fowler (1855: xv) writes in his preface: "[t]he older grammarians, such as Wallis, Greenwood, and Lowth, I have consulted, as well as some of the modern, such as Murray, Crombie, and Arnold". Examples like this conform with my observations on individual variables and with Busse et al.'s (2019: 55) systematic study of British grammar books who find that the most frequently referenced grammarians were Murray and Lowth. Moreover, they find that almost half of these references are in fact quotations, whereas less frequent types of references in descending order include opinion, comparisons, acknowledgments, mentions and application (Busse et al. 2021: 148). Several grammars in the CNG indeed also make explicit reference to North American lexicographers Webster and Worcester, e.g. Greenleaf (1821), Frazee (1845), Wells (1847), Fowler (1855), Adams (1868), Holbrook (1869), and Ramsey (1892) reference Webster, and Fowler (1855), or Holbrook (1869) contain references to Worcester. In North America, the scholars Rush and Comstock also appear to have played an important role from the middle of the century as references and critical comments in for instance Brown (1857), Fowler (1855), and York (1862) show (see also Chapter 5).

Considering the relevance of late eighteenth-century pronouncing dictionaries, various grammars refer to Walker or Sheridan, either for further information, or as a source for their observations on pronunciation, e.g. Greenleaf (1821), Nutting (1823), Oliver (1825), Comly (1834), Cramp (1838), Leigh (1840), Sanborn (1840), Murray (1847), King (1854), or Brown (1857). They clearly show the importance of and the frequency of intertextual references to earlier orthoëpists. As noted at the beginning, even the early Ellis worked to some extent in Walker's tradition (see Section 2.1 and Kelly 1981).

If we add (near-)verbatim copies, as shown by Anderwald (2016a) and in the present study, to this list, it is certainly unsurprising that many grammars are conservative in terms of which variants they want readers to use, and which variants and features are stigmatised. Lists of sources as the one quoted from Fowler can be found in multiple grammars. For instance, Greenleaf (1821: iii) writes:

[i]n selecting materials for the work, I have consulted Harris, Lowth, Priestley, Johnson, Sheridan, Horne Tooke, Webster, and Murray; and, in constructing it, have endeavoured to render it plain and intelligible to the lowest capacity; and to obviate every difficulty or obscurity that might tend, in the least degree, to embarrass or perplex the mind of the learner.

These and similar statements suggest that we should interpret writing these grammars as making use of a toolkit of other works. For different parts (levels of linguistic analysis, features), grammarians had to utilise different tools (other grammars and dictionaries) to assemble their own creations.

This supports a continuation of what Chapman (2008: 31–32) notes for late eighteenth-century grammars, which is that many grammarians made use of what was already there in other works. They often saw themselves as teachers rather than innovators. Many grammarians in the CNG should indeed be regarded as compilers and not as original authors. This is certainly the case with grammars like Kirkham (1834) as noted by Finegan (1980: 13), and as can be seen for instance in Kirkham's comments on /r/, /hw/ and the vowel in *boat*. This further aligns with McLelland's (2021: 270–271) list of features typical of grammar books and dictionaries in the European tradition. Making use of other sources word-for-word enabled grammarians to create a grammar book in a few days, as noted by Michael (1997: 39) and Anderwald (2016a: 249–250).

As I have shown with examples like Bingham (1867: 3–5) in Chapter 3, some grammarians were indeed aware of the massive production of grammar books, and still, they decided to publish yet another grammar. Reasons for this may be

manifold and range from regarding themselves as a better judge in the realm of English grammar to economic or didactic interests. For example, Bingham (1867: 5) suggests improvement of teaching as well as learning as one of his goals: “[w]ith much distrust of his own ability to achieve success in an undertaking in which so many have failed, the author sends forth the following pages, in the hope that he has accomplished *some good*, both for teachers and learners”. The convention of copying other authors and the consequent ease with which a grammar might have been compiled could explain the stark increase of grammar books in the nineteenth century, together with other factors such as increasing industrialisation and innovation, e.g. steam-powered printing, as well as moves towards mandatory primary education.

14.2 Research question v: Grammars, a homogenous genre?

As concerns the question of the extent to which grammars in the nineteenth century can be regarded as a homogenous genre, the simple answer is not to a great extent, even though there is considerable overlap in many grammars. As I have previously described, there are several conventions and (near-)verbatim copies that evidently suggest homogeneity rather than heterogeneity. However, who the grammarians copy from, whose terminology they use and to what extent they stick to certain variants may differ, as the phonological analyses in the present study have shown. Moreover, there are certain distinctive strands of grammars; those that are compilers, e.g. Fisk (1822), Kirkham (1834) or Swett (1844). Then there are those grammarians who are much more likely to have been proper authors and direct witnesses of language variation and change; hence precursors of modern linguists, e.g. Kelke (1885), Hall & Sonnenschein (1889), Gow (1892), Nesfield (1900), or Carpenter (1902). Furthermore, there are some of the late nineteenth-century grammars which are distinctly modern in their descriptions but are strongly prescriptive when it comes to certain features, e.g. Ramsey (1892). Grammars like Ramsey’s, I argue, could be regarded as counter-evidence to Busse et al.’s (2021: 147) hypothesis that the nineteenth century marks a shift to a more descriptive tradition and indeed seems to suggest that parallel to a more objective and descriptive tradition, prescriptive tendencies persisted as suggested by Chapman (2008).

Yet, the nineteenth century seems to mark a shift in tradition to more focus on morpho-syntax as suggested by Jones (2006: 273), based on Bailey (1992)

and Görlach (1998). While many nineteenth-century grammars stick to the traditional structure of previous grammars (preface, orthography, etymology, syntax, prosody), some indeed break with it. This is evidenced also by the fact that not all grammars treat pronunciation and that comments on the deliberate exclusion of sections like orthography and orthoëpy occur as early as 1807. These comments can be found throughout the century and show several different motivations for this exclusion of traditionally common parts of a grammar book, as shown in Chapter 3 (see also Table A.1 in the Appendix). It is noticeable that, at least in the CNG, the number of grammars that do not treat pronunciation as well as those that explicitly comment on its deliberate omission mainly come from North America. This could indicate that nineteenth-century North American grammars were more progressive in terms of their structure and which sections they included.

For late eighteenth-century grammars, Beal (2013: 176) points out that the inclusion of pronunciation, which might seem strange to twenty-first-century readers, was part of the *zeitgeist*. Still, grammars were not in competition with dictionaries and this *zeitgeist* was also evidently in the process of changing in the nineteenth century. This can be seen even in those grammars that touch on pronunciation as some barely exceed one page, e.g. Adams (1838), while others feature lengthy discussions spanning several pages, e.g. Gow (1892) or Ramsey (1892).

In the second half of the century, grammars start making references also to phoneticians like Ellis, e.g. Fleay (1884), Gow (1892), and Ramsey (1892), which could in part be regarded as evidence for the increasing scientification and relevance of phonetics and for a change of authority in questions of pronunciation.

Despite the establishment of the IPA in 1888, even grammars from the 1890s, e.g. Gow (1892), do not make use of the IPA, but use other alphabets such as some altered version of Ellis' notational system. This could point to a lag in the adoption of the IPA in works by non-phoneticians or simply be due to the genre of grammar writing.

Works like West (1898: 40) show that what we would nowadays consider phonetics and phonology was by some regarded as physiology rather than grammar. In spite of the fact that no linguist today would use the word *physiology* in this case, West's grammar illustrates a move towards a more modern understanding of articulatory phonetics. Another fact that suggests a shift in the genre and its conventions is the usage of the terms *phonetic(s)* and *phonology*. In English, these only emerge in the nineteenth century (see Chapter 3). My observations of the CNG suggests that in grammars these terms only start to be used in 1849, while

they still occur alongside more traditional terminology like *orthography* and *orthoëpy*. For instance, for Brown (1849) *orthography* consists of *phonology* and “alphaology”, and for Carpenter (1902) *phonology* is a branch of *orthoëpy*.

To name only a few examples, *phonetic(s)* is employed in Fowler (1855), Covell (1861), Burt (1869), Holbrook (1869), Cruttenden (1870), Colegrove (1879), and Gow (1892). The term *phonology* can be found in various grammars like Brown (1849), Kenyon (1849), Colegrove (1879), West (1898), and Carpenter (1902). For a full list of grammarians that use the terms *phonetics* and *phonology* in their grammars, see Table A.2 in the Appendix. These examples illustrate a transitional period from traditional structure and terminology to more modern ones. Downey’s (1991: 30) comment that “mid-century America was too progressive to let the works of Murray, Brown and other traditional grammarians control the field” seems to apply to the development of grammar books with respect to pronunciation and related terminology. Despite the existence of references to grammars like Murray (1795) after 1850 and terms and phrases which suggest at least a partial continuation of his and Walker’s influence, Busse et al. (2021: 150) also find that references to grammarians like Lowth (1762) and Murray (1795) are abruptly declining in the second half of the nineteenth century.

While investigating the readership, sales numbers, and actual use of the grammars of the CNG exceeds the scope of my analysis, these are important factors that should be considered in the interpretation of the present data. Görlach (1999: 16) points out that not all grammars were in equally widespread use, which is a fact that is echoed in Bingham’s (1867) preface as he comments on grammars that were not sold a single time. Differences in popularity between locations and within one location can moreover be seen in the use of well-established works by Murray, Lowth, Brown and Kirkham in New York and Harvard (see Section 2.2). However, generally many of these grammars did not have to be in widespread use if we consider them simply as compilations created for teaching in one small school rather than commodities on the book market. This alone makes them a heterogeneous genre.

Knowing about the exact background and motivations and regarding nineteenth-century grammarians as a discourse community is hard to argue because of the lack of biographical information. Still, I have clearly shown a maintenance of structural similarities in these grammars. At the same time there is also a shift in their structures, an expansion of terminology, and an increasing exclusion of pronunciation in many. I thus argue that we can regard nineteenth-century grammars as a discourse tradition, as defined by McLelland (2021: 268) as a “diachronic series of works in a particular *genre* where [...] genre-typical features

are expected and inherited, but are also adapted over time, and where new ones may arise”, rather than a discourse community.

14.3 Overarching question: Grammars and phonology

In terms of the overall research question, which concerns the extent to which nineteenth-century grammars can be taken as historical evidence for sound changes and sociolinguistic variation, it is indeed possible to fruitfully employ them, as I have shown in my analysis for several phonological features. Many grammars were surprisingly descriptive but even those that contain prescriptions, only very brief commentary, or orthography-oriented descriptions can be used for analysing historical sound changes and variation. They can frequently yield valuable information on sounds, even if they are less explicitly described than in the works by scholars like Ellis. In addition, there are several grammars which constitute an exception to the conservative standard “copy-paste” grammars of the time. Some of the late grammars that continued to include pronunciation increasingly employ more modern terminology and embrace more objective approaches.

Nevertheless, caution is still required when interpreting their comments because of a great number of verbatim copies in some of the grammars in the CNG. What MacMahon (1998: 376) states about the use of LModE sources for historical phonology seems to be true for the grammars in the CNG: “[c]onsiderable caution is needed, nevertheless, when interpreting the pronunciations given for the period from the mid-eighteenth century until the time of Alexander Ellis in the 1860s”. In grammar books this is even more true given their character of teaching materials rather than extensive treatises on pronunciation. Nonetheless, it is especially due to their heterogeneity that some grammars are important sources. They provide relevant information on the stigmatisation of phonological variation, which has in many cases continued into the present day. If a feature is mentioned, even if it is evaluated negatively, it might also reveal its part in the enregisterment of different varieties, its general associations and the timeline of changes. We should further remind ourselves of what Beal (2004b: 130) states about Walker, i.e. that even works that from a modern perspective are considered prescriptive often still had the intention of providing detailed information on the language of the time and are thus invaluable for researchers. Ramsey (1892) and Fowler (1855), for instance, show a negative attitude to /v/-/w/-interchange and Ramsey is furthermore one of the fiercest critics of non-rhoticity in the CNG. Yet, both also provide valuable information on other linguistic features. Fowler’s

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(1855) grammar gives information on dialectal realisations of the vowel in FACE words, engages with the works by Rush much more neutrally than Brown does, and is one of the only ones that provides any articulatory information on the vowel in words like *father*. Ramsey (1892) is also comparatively detailed, provides evidence for GOAT diphthongisation and also discusses Ellis' works. Thus, the grammars in the CNG can indeed be used as evidence for historical phonology, if the context and type of the grammar is considered in the analysis.

15 Conclusion and outlook

In the present study I have shown by example of several phonological features that nineteenth-century grammars are viable sources for studying the history of English phonology. Many grammars provide information which is highly relevant to the historical study of pronunciation if we take the evidence as it is, i.e. not in accordance with modern linguistic guidelines and terminology, often not politically correct, and at times imprecise. With the aid of early recordings as well as studies of more thorough treatises such as Ellis' works, scrutinising these grammars is worthwhile for complementing the evidence and zoom in on the processes of change throughout the nineteenth century.

Due to plagiarism from other LModE authors and the rarity of detailed articulatory descriptions, some caution is required, especially when dealing with the earlier works in the CNG. I have shown that the focus on spelling when discussing pronunciation may also complicate but certainly not hinder the suitability of nineteenth-century grammars for phonological analysis. Whereas the high frequency of (close-to) verbatim copies might at first glance suggest a homogeneity in these works, there are in fact considerable differences either in whom they copy from, which variants they regard as proper, and in the terminology they use.

My study has furthermore shown a development in the genre of grammars towards a more modern understanding of what these books represent and contain. On the one hand, orthography and orthoëpy lose their place in grammars, especially in North American grammars, and extensive treatments of pronunciation are increasingly to be searched for in other works, which is commented on by the grammarians themselves. On the other hand, some late grammars do certainly include more detail on pronunciation than the majority of earlier books. I have suggested that this is due to the scientification of linguistics and that these grammars constitute a more neutral and more detailed current emerging parallel to traditional and continuing prescriptive works. Nineteenth-century grammars are therefore also beneficial for examining the history of linguistics itself. I have furthermore found a relatively low number of comments on features that were stigmatised and in the process of changing in the nineteenth century. There is a

great deal of variation in the frequency with which certain variants are criticised, suggesting that the prescriptive traits of grammars are indeed feature-dependent.

As for the limits of this book, given the number of grammars I analysed, I had to focus on a restricted number of features and examined these in detail. Other important LModE features that could be analysed in the CNG in the future are, for example, the development of unstressed vowels, the contrast between the BEAT/BIT sets, happy-tensing, raising of CATCH, central onsets in PRICE diphthongs, fronting of MOUTH, YOD-coalescence and YOD-dropping, /t/-glottalisation, or /l/-vocalisation. In terms of method, it would certainly be beneficial to turn the CNG into an online database or a corpus to enable analyses that are less time consuming than manually reading through 258 grammar books that range from very short to over 1,000 pages each, and this would furthermore enable other researcher to use this resource. The reasons why this has not been done are mainly a want of human and financial resources. With increasing technological advancements, including but not restricted to improvements in AI and LLMs, perhaps this could be done more easily in the near future with fewer resources. This would allow for quantitative analyses that go beyond what I did in this book, also from researchers outside of Kiel. As the number of grammars that were published in the nineteenth century far exceeds the size of CNG with a total of 1,936 works, LLMs could provide help with more automated analyses of the remaining grammars. Some larger-scale quantitative methods have already been employed by Busse et al. (2016, 2019, 2021) with their network analyses, but similar approaches have not been taken with respect to individual linguistic variables although this would be a desirable.

Combining comments in the CNG with other data could also be a fruitful enterprise to take. Direct evidence, i.e. explicit comments on pronunciation, and early recordings were the most obvious and sensible way of finding converging evidence in historical phonology for the LModE period and in this area all sources known to me have been exhausted in this book. As noted in Chapter 2, complementing results from the grammars with corpus data is not possible in the way that Anderwald did in several studies for morpho-syntactic features. In Chapter 6, I tried to enrich my analysis with corpus data from ARCHER and the COHA in order to assess frequency effects in phonological change. Other ways in which corpora could be productively employed are to study historical trends in the use of terminology like *orthography*, *orthoëpy*, *phonetics*, or *phonology* or evaluative terms such as *improper* and *vulgar* and compare them with developments in the grammars of the CNG and orthoëpic works.

I considered general statements by grammarians in some of their prefaces as well as the use of their terminology to describe sounds and to negatively evaluate

phonological variants. Yet, studies of individual grammars and grammarians are still needed to get to a more complete picture of LModE grammar writing and prescriptivism. Examining the readership, their reach in schools as well as individual differences in their motivations to determine potential influence on actual language change better would be a helpful contribution not only to the study of grammar writing but to the history of education in the British-Irish Isles and North America. Downey (1982, 1991) makes some contribution to these subjects for North America. Görlach (1999: 16), for instance, already notes in the 1990s that Murray's grammar was more influential than most other grammars. Whereas for the eighteenth century there are several excellent contributions on the reception of grammars and on individual grammarians in Tieken-Boon van Ostade (1996b, 2008a), to my knowledge, no comparable studies have been done to this date for the nineteenth century.

Questions of market dominance, ideologies, motivations and relationships between grammarians and the potential of a discourse community are also of great relevance and could be tackled by examining in more depth the prefaces, biographical background and correspondence of and between grammarians, where these are available (as discussed by Watts 2008 for the eighteenth century, and as done by Finegan 1980). A closer look could furthermore be taken at the transitional period from the nineteenth to the twentieth century. As Curzan (2014) suggests, examining the history of a language always entails studying attitudes to the language. Considering prescriptivism to be as important as studying historical dialects and looking at the actual impact on speakers who were and continue to be stigmatised simply for pronouncing words the way they do, historical prescriptivism has to be part of any history of the English language. I have shown that scrutinising LModE grammars can indeed also help in this endeavour.

Appendix

Table A.1: Grammars that deliberately excluded/briefly treated sounds, orthography or orthoëpy, ordered by year of publication

author and year	abridged title
Webster (1807)*	<i>A Philosophical and Practical Grammar</i>
Cobbett (1818)*	<i>A Grammar of the English Language, in a Series of Letters</i>
Lynde (1821)*	<i>A Key to English Grammar</i>
M'Chesney (1822)*	<i>An English Grammar, Compendiously Compiled for the Use of Schools</i>
Nutting (1823)*	<i>A Practical Grammar of the English Language</i>
Hull (1828)*	<i>English Grammar by Lectures</i>
Putnam (1828)*	<i>English Grammar, with an Improved Syntax</i>
Emmons (1832)*	<i>The Grammatical Instructor</i>
Parker & Fox (1835)*	<i>Progressive Exercises in English Grammar.</i>
Pue (1841)*	<i>A Grammar of the English Language</i>
Goldsbury (1842)*	<i>A Sequel to the Common School Grammar</i>
Felton (1843)*	<i>The Analytic and Practical Grammar</i>
Fowle (1847)*	<i>The Common School Grammar</i>
Barrett Jr. (1848)*	<i>The Principles of Grammar</i>
Weedon (1848)	<i>A Practical English Grammar of the English Language</i>
Goldthwait (1850)*	<i>A Treatise upon some Topics of English Grammar</i>
Spencer (1851)*	<i>An English Grammar</i>
Pinneo (1854)*	<i>Pinneo's Primary Grammar of the English Language, for Beginners</i>
Morris (1858)*	<i>A Philosophical and Practical Grammar of the English Language</i>
Sill (1863)*	<i>Synthesis of the English Sentence, or an Elementary Grammar on the Synthetic Method</i>
Burns (1864)*	<i>Principles of English Grammar, Defined and Illustrated</i>
Tower & Tweed (1867)*	<i>First Lessons in Language; or, Elements of English Grammar</i>
Tidmarsh (1882)	<i>A Practical English Grammar for Schools and Colleges and for Students Preparing for Examinations</i>
Swinton (1884)*	<i>A Grammar Containing the Etymology and Syntax of the English Language</i>
Rigdon (1903)*	<i>English Grammar for the Common School</i>

Table A.2: Grammars that contain the terms *phonetic(s)* and *phonology/phonological* ordered by year of publication

grammar	<i>Phonetic(s)</i> additional comment
Balch (1841)*	only with reference to Egyptian and Indian signs
Brown (1851)*	only in two direct quotes
Bullen & Heycock (1853)	only in the context of a potential reformation of spelling
Clarke (1853)	only with reference to Egyptian writing
Barnes (1854)	—
Fowler (1855)*	—
Mason (1858)	only in a list of words derived from Greek in the appendix
Covell (1861)*	—
Latham (1861)	—
York (1862)*	—
Bain (1863)	only once but to refer to his alphabet
Lowres (1863)	only under <i>derivation/etymology</i>
Nicholson (1864)	only under <i>derivation</i>
Mulligan (1868)*	only in a quote with reference to the Manchu language
Harvey (1868)	only in an example sentence in a syntax exercise
Kerl (1868)*	—
Lewis (1869)	only once to describe allomorphy of plural <i>-(e)s</i>
Burt (1869)*	—
Cruttenden (1870)*	only twice to explain the phonetic alphabet in use
Yates (1884)	only once to define orthography
Davidson & Alcock (1876)	only in a list of Greek derivatives
Gostwick (1878)	only once and with respect to changes in/differences between High German and English
Burton (1878)	only once and with reference to spelling
Colegrove (1879)*	—
White (1882)	—
Swinton (1884)*	only in an example sentence
Kelke (1885)	—

grammar	<i>Phonetic(s)</i> additional comment
Welsh (1889)*	—
Gow (1892)	—
Steel (1894)	only in a list of Greek derivatives
Baskervill & Sewell (1895)*	only in the context of the phonetic spelling of past tense forms
West (1898)	—
Powell & Connolly (1899)*	only in a list of foreign stems in English
Nesfield (1900)	—
Milne (1900)*	only in a list of Greek roots
Whitney & Lockwood (1901)*	only in a list of stems given in the appendix
Carpenter (1902)*	—
Rigdon (1903)*	only in a quote by Whitney, in his argument to exclude it from the grammar
<i>Phonology/phonological</i>	
Kenyon (1849)*	—
Brown (1849)*	—
Brown (1851)*	only in the title of Comstock that he lists under a catalogue of grammars and grammarians
Fowler (1855)*	—
Nicholson (1864)	only under <i>derivation</i>
Colegrove (1879)*	—
West (1898)	—
Carpenter (1902)*	—
Rigdon (1903)*	—

Table A.3: Frequencies pmw of BATH example words, retrieved from ARCHER

no.	example	occurrence pmw	no.	example	occurrence pmw
1	<i>after</i>	1082	34	<i>basket</i>	24
2	<i>last</i>	739	35	<i>laughter</i>	18
3	<i>pass</i>	549	36	<i>haunt</i>	16
4	<i>father</i>	522	37	<i>plaster</i>	16
5	<i>ask</i>	378	38	<i>pastor</i>	15
6	<i>rather</i>	278	39	<i>lass</i>	14
7	<i>answer</i>	262	40	<i>shan't</i>	12
8	<i>master</i>	189	41	<i>draught</i>	11
9	<i>afternoon</i>	168	42	<i>palm</i>	10
10	<i>ah</i>	167	43	<i>calf</i>	8
11	<i>can't</i>	159	44	<i>mast</i>	7
12	<i>glass</i>	151	45	<i>psalmist</i>	7
13	<i>past</i>	150	46	<i>launch</i>	6
14	<i>laugh</i>	146	47	<i>psalm</i>	6
15	<i>advance</i>	138	48	<i>calmness</i>	5
16	<i>grant</i>	136	49	<i>laundry</i>	4
17	<i>class</i>	123	50	<i>balm</i>	2
18	<i>demand</i>	105	51	<i>casket</i>	2
19	<i>command</i>	101	52	<i>gaunt</i>	2
20	<i>chance</i>	99	53	<i>lather</i>	2
21	<i>mass</i>	97	54	<i>prance</i>	2
22	<i>branch</i>	86	55	<i>rafter</i>	2
23	<i>fast</i>	77	56	<i>ant</i>	2
24	<i>dance</i>	74	57	<i>clat</i>	2
25	<i>glance</i>	67	58	<i>flaunt</i>	1
26	<i>plant</i>	64	59	<i>gauntlet</i>	1
27	<i>grass</i>	57	60	<i>haft</i>	1
28	<i>path</i>	55	61	<i>jaunt</i>	1
29	<i>aunt</i>	50	62	<i>lath</i>	1
30	<i>gather</i>	46	63	<i>balmy</i>	0
31	<i>bath</i>	41	64	<i>calve</i>	0
32	<i>calm</i>	38	65	<i>halve</i>	0
33	<i>staff</i>	30	66	<i>plaister</i>	0

Table A.4: Frequencies pmw of BATH example words, retrieved from the COHA

no.	example	occurrence pmw	no.	example	occurrence pmw
1	<i>after</i>	1260	34	<i>basket</i>	37
2	<i>last</i>	823	35	<i>palm</i>	25
3	<i>father</i>	663	36	<i>staff</i>	25
4	<i>pass</i>	660	37	<i>bath</i>	23
5	<i>ask</i>	653	38	<i>pastor</i>	22
6	<i>answer</i>	462	39	<i>draught</i>	17
7	<i>rather</i>	368	40	<i>launch</i>	15
8	<i>master</i>	256	41	<i>mast</i>	14
9	<i>laugh</i>	247	42	<i>calf</i>	12
10	<i>class</i>	233	43	<i>calmness</i>	12
11	<i>past</i>	203	44	<i>psalm</i>	11
12	<i>demand</i>	192	45	<i>ant</i>	11
13	<i>command</i>	183	46	<i>shan't</i>	10
14	<i>advance</i>	178	47	<i>plaster</i>	9
15	<i>can't</i>	174	48	<i>balm</i>	8
16	<i>glance</i>	168	49	<i>gaunt</i>	7
17	<i>ah</i>	163	50	<i>lass</i>	7
18	<i>chance</i>	155	51	<i>balmy</i>	7
19	<i>grant</i>	149	52	<i>casket</i>	5
20	<i>gather</i>	137	53	<i>rafter</i>	5
21	<i>aunt</i>	133	54	<i>flaunt</i>	4
22	<i>plant</i>	129	55	<i>gauntlet</i>	4
23	<i>mass</i>	128	56	<i>halve</i>	3
24	<i>branch</i>	127	57	<i>prance</i>	3
25	<i>path</i>	114	58	<i>laundry</i>	2
26	<i>fast</i>	110	59	<i>psalmist</i>	2
27	<i>calm</i>	101	60	<i>lath</i>	1
28	<i>afternoon</i>	100	61	<i>lather</i>	1
29	<i>glass</i>	94	62	<i>jaunt</i>	1
30	<i>dance</i>	82	63	<i>haft</i>	0
31	<i>grass</i>	69	64	<i>clat</i>	0
32	<i>haunt</i>	42	65	<i>calve</i>	0
33	<i>laughter</i>	37	66	<i>plaister</i>	0

Table A.5: Frequency of example words of /h/-less realisations in the grammarians' perceived standard

no.	word	freq.	no.	word	freq.
1	<i>hour</i>	31	21	<i>Clapham</i>	1
2	<i>heir</i>	30	21	<i>Hibernian</i>	1
3	<i>honest</i>	25	21	<i>Hungarian</i>	1
3	<i>honour</i>	25	21	<i>Nottingham</i>	1
5	<i>herb</i>	16	21	<i>Petersham</i>	1
6	<i>humour</i>	14	21	<i>Shoreham</i>	1
7	<i>hospital</i>	11	21	<i>exhaust</i>	1
8	<i>hostler</i>	10	21	<i>exhibitor</i>	1
9	<i>humble</i>	8	21	<i>exhort</i>	1
10	<i>honesty</i>	5	21	<i>forehead</i>	1
11	<i>honourable</i>	4	21	<i>hair (?)</i>	1
11	<i>humorous</i>	4	21	<i>harangue</i>	1
13	<i>heiress</i>	3	21	<i>her</i>	1
13	<i>herbage</i>	3	21	<i>hibernal</i>	1
13	<i>hourly</i>	3	21	<i>hidalgo</i>	1
13	<i>humoursome</i>	3	21	<i>him</i>	1
17	<i>historical</i>	2	21	<i>his</i>	1
17	<i>honourably</i>	2	21	<i>honestly</i>	1
17	<i>humourist</i>	2	21	<i>hornito</i>	1
17	<i>humorously</i>	2	21	<i>hotel</i>	1
21	<i>Birmingham</i>	1	21	<i>humbles</i>	1

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Tracing the history of pronunciation in nineteenth-century English

A key challenge of studying the historical phonology of any language is how to reconstruct the pronunciation of periods before the availability of sound recording. Many studies of pre-twentieth-century pronunciation rely on sources that comment on how people spoke, or infer pronunciation from spelling variation or rhymes. This book is the first to investigate the phonology of nineteenth-century English based on a new kind of written source material: it examines pronunciation evidence provided by contemporary grammar books, and offers quantitative and qualitative analyses of the phonological commentary found in a collection of 258 English grammars published in Britain, Ireland, and North America during the nineteenth century.

The nineteenth century has been described as the century of prescriptivism, and this book examines the tensions between prescriptive and descriptive approaches in the grammars. Individual case studies detail several linguistic features which were undergoing change and which were reportedly stigmatised at the time. Consonantal features include non-rhoticity, /h/-dropping and /h/-insertion, the WHICH-WITCH merger, /v/-/w/-interchange, and the pronunciation of *-ing*. Further studies chart variation in the vowel of BATH words, and in the diphthongs of words such as FACE and GOAT, which are characteristic of both RP and American English pronunciation. In exploring the potential of this understudied source material as evidence of historical pronunciation, this book contributes to the fields of historical phonology, grammaticography, the study of prescriptivism, and historical sociolinguistics.